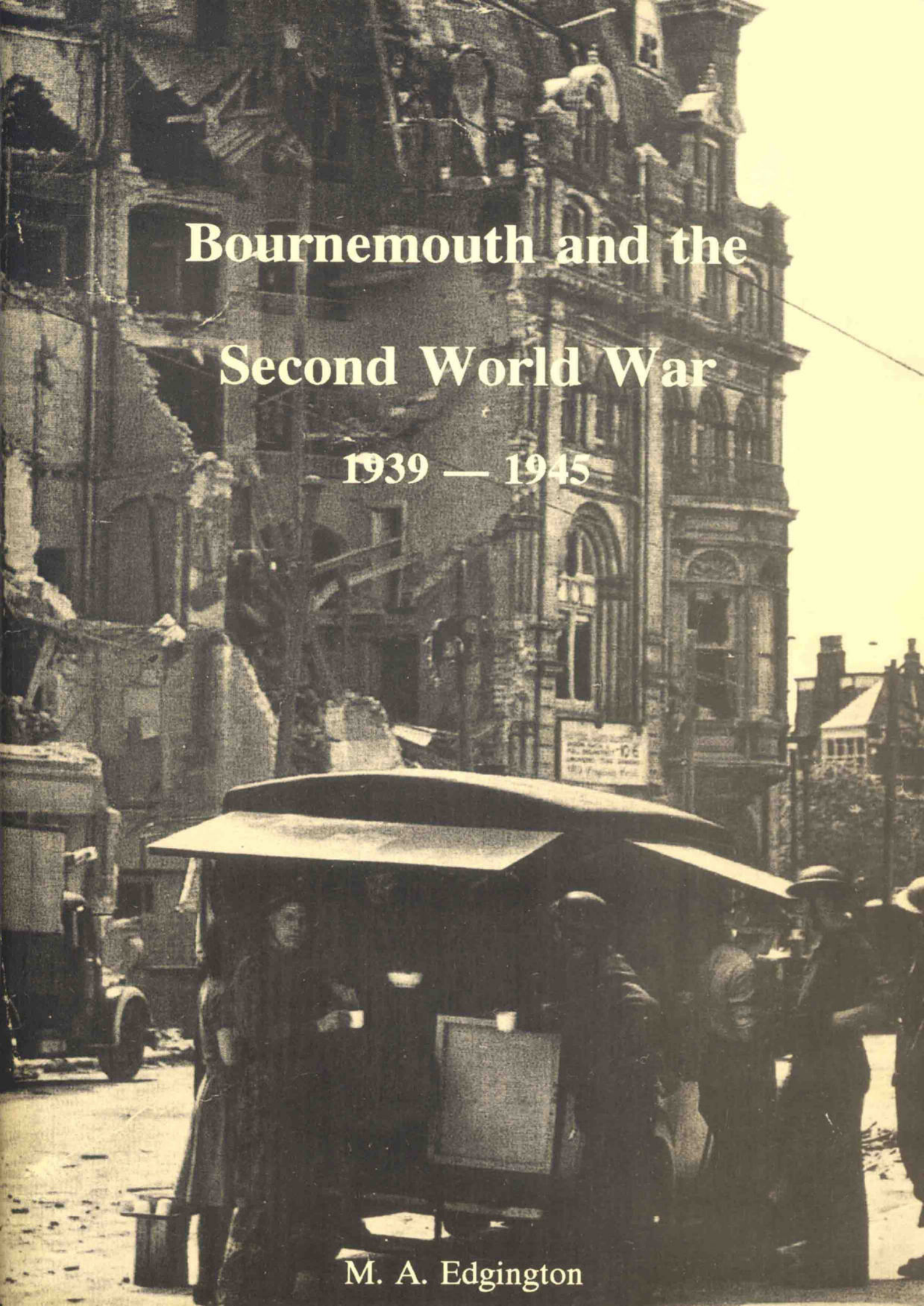


Bournemouth and the Second World War

1939 — 1945

M. A. Edgington

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Bournemouth Local Studies Publications
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The Author

M.A. Edgington was born in Bournemouth and educated at the Collegiate and Bournemouth Schools. He qualified as an Associate of the Library Association having started his career as a Librarian with Bournemouth Library Service. He also worked in the Municipal College Library then moved to Hampshire County Library's Ringwood branch. In 1973 he returned to Bournemouth taking up the post of Reference Librarian at the Lansdowne Library, retiring in 1991. Bournemouth local history has always been one of his interests and he has written two other pamphlets, both published by the Bournemouth Local Studies Publications, entitled "Bournemouth and the First World War" (1985) and "Citizen-soldiers" (1988).

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Where errors in the original text have been identified, these have been corrected. No attempt has been made to update any references to the function or naming of individual locations. These remain as they were presented in the original publication.

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Introduction

This brief history attempts to show how the town coped with the raids, restriction, rationing, plus the influx of Servicemen from other countries, and all the other circumstances forced upon it by the hostilities.

Such a short account cannot give due recognition to the many people and organisations who kept going through those dark days and whose efforts helped to win the war.

Although not a military history it does record military events and mentions some of the units which were stationed locally.

The author would be pleased to receive information, photographs and reminiscences regarding this period of Bournemouth's history.

Chapter One

1939

At 11.15 am on Sunday, 3rd September 1939, just ten weeks before the twenty-first anniversary of the Armistice in 1918, which marked the end of "The War to end all Wars" the Prime Minister, Neville Chamberlain, made his fateful broadcast stating that Britain was at war with Germany. Congregations in several Bournemouth churches, such as St. Peter's, were told during morning service, the news having been brought by church members who, like others, had heard it over the radio and then hastened to give the Minister the information. It was not completely unexpected since the threat of war had been on the horizon for some time. ln fact preparations in case of war had already been taken.

The experience of air raids during the First World War had caused the Government to look to future needs against such attacks. So in 1924 a Committee was set up to determine what defence measures were necessary. Sir John Anderson, Parliamentary Under Secretary of State at the Home Office, was appointed Chairman, and under his guidance the Committee, working in secret called for advice from expert organisations and many individuals. In 1935 the secrecy was abandoned and the Government sent a letter to all local authorities telling them of the setting up of the Air Raid Precautions Department of the Home Office. The letter also warned that precautionary measures were needed to safeguard civilians against attacks from the air. However the object of the ARP was not only to make everybody safe but to "make possible an efficient resistance to an aggressor".

Although the Government did not say that war was coming Parliament passed the Air Raid Precautions Act in 1937, which came into force on 1st January 1938. This Act laid down the duties of local authorities in preparing and putting into force ARP schemes. Grants were then made available to enable these schemes to be commenced. Thus although the protection of civilians was primarily the duty of the Home Secretary he delegated this responsibility to local government, who could claim back the major part of their expenditure on air raid precautions.

Under this legislation the country was divided into six regions, each under a Regional Commissioner, Bournemouth coming under Region 6 with Regional HQ at Reading. Initially the Home Office suggested that Bournemouth Corporation co-operated with Poole and Christchurch Councils. So a Joint Committee for ARP was set up consisting of Councillors from the three Boroughs, chaired by the Mayor of Bournemouth. This "linking" was almost unique so far as ARP was concerned. The only other such partnership had been Torquay and Paignton but this was dissolved fairly quickly. An Area ARP Officer, Mr. H.G. Barrett was appointed by the Committee in 1938. He was to act as Executive Officer assisted by three ARP Officers, one in each town. The Bournemouth Poole and Christchurch Committee met for the first time in August 1938. The following were asked to provide representatives at that meeting: Police, Fire Services, Red Cross, St. John Ambulance, Hospitals, Gas, Water and Electricity Services.

Each Borough had its own Committee administrating the ARP organisation within its own boundaries with its own ARP Office. These Committees had to make their own arrangements, especially in the training of Wardens and rescue services. In Bournemouth the main control room was

built in the basement of the Town Hall with telephone links to the Central Fire Station, the Police Station and the ARP Offices in the three towns. Bournemouth was divided into three areas for management purposes. They were the Central, Eastern and Northern Divisions, with Divisional Offices at Fairlight Glen, Shelley Park and the Embassy Club, Brassey Road. Fairlight Glen, Avenue Road (the site is now occupied by "Hobson's Choice"), was also used for the Area ARP Office.

There were one hundred and fourteen Wardens Posts situated at strategic positions all over the town. Some were in private garages rented for the purpose, church halls, schools and empty shops. A number of huts removed from the beach because of the defence works were also used. The following are a few examples of the places used as Wardens Posts:

East Howe Congregational Church Hall
Redhill Bowls Pavilion
Shop, 67 Barnes Road
Hut in Hambledon Road
Garage at 18 Wimborne Road
Bus body at Sandbourne Road
70 Gladstone Road
Talbot Village School
Broadway Garage
Eventide Homes
Throop School
Five Ways Hotel Garage

These were protected with sandbags and blast walls and all had telephones and anti-gas clothing available. In Carlyle Road at Iford the single storey building used originally as the Iford Housing Office became a Wardens Post and the blast wall protecting its entrance still remains. They were manned by a skeleton staff for the majority of the time, others arriving when the siren sounded or bombs were dropped. By the end of November the Borough Engineer's Department had filled and placed over 250,000 sandbags as protection at Hospitals, the Town Hall, Police Stations, the Sewage Works and ARP Posts.

The number of Wardens in the Bournemouth establishment was 2,180, made up of both full and part time volunteers. Each Warden was supposed to do 48 hours duty a month, however the majority put in many more than this. One of the duties of an ARP Warden was to patrol the streets in his section watching out for unobscured lights and calling the occupants' attention to them using that well known phrase, "Put that light out". He also advised the householders on precautions in their homes, fitted, checked and distributed gas masks and encouraged them to join the ARP or other organisations, i.e. First Aid Parties, Rescue Parties, Messengers and the Gas Decontamination Squad. Wardens were to man their posts at the Alert. This could mean making a dash two or sometimes three times a night. Fortunately the local policy was to allocate a post as near as possible to their home. Wardens, especially as the war progressed, tended to be middle aged or elderly.

They patrolled their area after the raid warning had been sounded and when necessary reporting incidents and details of casualties. They were to give name, address, sex and, if under 16, the age. Some householders, to help the rescue services, placed a note on the front gate giving the number of people resident in that property. Where there was an unexploded bomb the Wardens were to clear an area of 500 yards around the bomb, reporting to the control room at the Town Hall at once. The Controller would then alert the Bomb Disposal Squad at Christchurch. The Wardens remained at the spot to keep people away, and waited for the Bomb disposal Team, but keeping well clear in case of an explosion.

The basic uniform at the beginning was a card of appointment, armlet, steel helmet with ARP on it and a civilian duty respirator. Later on a uniform of dark blue cloth was provided. Some Wardens received them during the summer of 1940 but the remainder had to wait. One of their first jobs was to distribute gas masks from various centres on 16 December 1938. A Census of the number of gas

masks required had been carried out earlier with some difficulty because of the shortage of Wardens. The public were very apathetic about Civil Defence. Many did not believe that there would be a conflict, so volunteer were not forthcoming. Also those who did take up Civil Defence work were often despised as seeking "soft jobs".

Cllr. (later Alderman) H.P.E. Mears was appointed the Chairman of the Joint ARP Committee at the beginning of December. As these criticisms of the ARP had been voiced by many people, especially that young men were joining it and the AFS to avoid call up into the Forces, he made an enquiry into the allegations and found that these criticisms were unwarranted and without substance.

On 24th March 1939 the sirens installed at the Town Hall, Southbourne Water Tower, Gas Show Rooms, Christchurch Road, Boscombe (now Motabitz), Kingsleigh School and on the tower of the Chapel in the North Cemetery (with the control room in the Crematorium underground) were tested for the first time. The warning of a raid, or an Alert, was a warbling or fluctuating note which sounded for two minutes, whilst the All Clear was a continuous note for two minutes. These times were reduced to one minute each in June 1940.

The official classifications of warning sent over the telephone system were:

Yellow	Preliminary Caution (discontinued in October 1941)
Red	Action Warning (Alert)
Green	Raiders Passed (AIl Clear)
White	Cancel Caution

On the receipt of the Yellow through the National Warning Network, which was sent when enemy aircraft were within twenty-two minutes flying time, all key personnel including Head Wardens, were contacted from the control room. This could be done in eight minutes and in twenty, Wardens could be on patrol throughout the Borough. The Alert meant that enemy aircraft were expected in twelve minutes and everybody must take cover until the All Clear had sounded. The sirens were tested again on Saturday, 2nd December, and the result showed that in certain parts they were not heard clearly. Westbourne only heard a faint warning because the wind carried the sound from the Town Hall out to sea. This criticism was to be heard again during 1940, especially over the All Clear. People complained that they had remained in the shelters after the Alert was over because the siren sounding the All Clear was not heard. The ARP Officer for Bournemouth in a lecture in March 1940 stated that the sirens were to clear the streets and it was not the intention that people should be able to hear them indoors!

By November 1939 there were seven sirens manned by 150 volunteers twenty-four hours a day. The siren in the North Cemetery had been moved to Bournemouth School for Boys in East Way, which was less harrowing for the operators, whilst others had been installed at the Corporation East Yard, Holdenhurst Road, and the Winton Fire Station, Wimborne Road. Two more were erected in 1942. One at the Wardens Post in Richmond Park Crescent and the other at the junction of Headswell Avenue with Redhill Drive.

In July 1940 the sirens were converted to remote control through the telephone lines, so that the volunteers were no longer needed day and night. From the beginning of 1940 there was a regular test held on the first Monday of each month at 2 pm which was a steady blast of 30 seconds duration (the All Clear), followed by 25 seconds duration of the Alert and ended with a one minute steady blast. Later on when the raids started it became the rule to test the sirens only if there had not been an actual Alert during the previous month.

Public shelters had been constructed in basements all over the town for those people caught in the streets by an air raid. The ARP Committee, 17th October 1939, gave instructions that "at all shelters doors shall be fitted, such doors to have a panel of very light glass which will have to be broken in order to lift the latch and obtain entrance". By the end of the year nearly 3000 places were available in shelters housed in buildings such as Maples (200), Grand Parade Basement, Westbourne (220), Springbourne Library (40), Five Ways Hotel (30), and the Odeon Cinema, Lansdowne (300) now the Bingo Club. Later surface shelters were constructed. Communal shelters were also erected in

residential areas for residents who didn't have their own. A list of the majority of public shelters is given in Appendix B.

The Pier Approach and Stokewood Road Baths were taken over by the ARP on September 3rd and all sections were closed. The Turkish and Private Baths were reopened on September 7th at the Pier Approach and the Private Baths at Stokewood Road on 8th September. Twice a week the Private Baths were used by soldiers stationed locally, approximately one hundred visiting each time. Parts of the buildings were adapted as gas decontamination and first aid posts for the ARP in early October. Air lock doors were fitted and buttresses of sandbags were constructed to protect the buildings from bomb blast. The Pier Approach pool was not re-opened until Easter Sunday, 24th March 1940, and the Stokewood Road one on 27th June.

The Auxiliary Fire Service had come into being under the Air Raid Precautions Act 1937 to supplement the Fire Brigades for it was recognised that the existing Brigades would be inadequate against the expected air attacks. The first professional Chief Fire Officer for Bournemouth, Mr. W.H. Barker from Dagenham, was appointed in April 1938 on the retirement of the Volunteer Fire Captain, Mr. Harry Wall. He found that one of his first tasks was to recruit and train volunteers for the AFS. He also had to set up emergency stations, to obtain appliances and equipment, then plan and prepare supplementary water supplies. Large steel static water tanks, each holding 5000 gallons were erected in key positions all over the town to aid fire fighting. Sites included the forecourt of the Imperial Hotel at the Lansdowne (demolished postwar and redeveloped as the Forte Posthouse), Horseshoe Common, Avenue Road car park and Hendy's Garage, Palmerston Road. Later reservoirs were sunk in the Upper Pleasure Gardens and the Bourne Stream was dammed. More tanks of concrete and brick were constructed all over the town. All had the letters SWS on the side to indicate that they were Static Water Supplies for fighting fires. The AFS also had two single deck Corporation buses which had been converted to be mobile water units, each carrying two 500 gallon canvas tanks.

The following are a few of the sites used for the SWS tanks:
Meyrick Road next to the Municipal College: 100,000 gallons
Corner of Glenferness Avenue and Talbot Road
Redhill Park by Bowls Pavilion
Junction of Knyveton and Derby Roads
Junction of St. Peter's and Firvale Roads
Land at rear of Springbourne Library Junction of Southbourne Road and Southbourne Grove: 100,000 gallons
Wimborne Road next to Winton Library: 84,000 gallons
Eldon Place: 5,000 gallons
R.L. Stevenson Avenue: 100,000 gallons
West Hill Place
Stafford Road
West Cliff near Beacon Road
Strouden Avenue near entrance to North Cemetery

On the outbreak of war the professional Fire Brigade was expanded by the AFS becoming full-time, the personnel required being recruited from the trained volunteers. However not all the volunteers transferred, some remained as part-timers. The Chief Officer, Mr. W.H. Barker, wrote in the "Firebucket: the official organ of the Bournemouth AFS", that "the effectiveness of the AFS relies, more than it is perhaps fully realised, to the greatest extent on its part-time personnel. Auxiliary firemen engaged on a whole-time basis are necessary for immediate action. The part-time establishment is as necessary and important to maintain an efficient service, both to complete the manning of all available pumps, and as reliefs for crews...".

Bournemouth was divided into eleven Zones, each having its own Fire Station:
Zone 1 Central Fire Station, Holdenhurst Road

Zone 2	San Remo Towers, Sea Road
Zone 3	Pokesdown Fire Station
Zone 4	West Hill Fire Station
Zone 5	Maxwell Road Corporation Depot
Zone 6	Carbery Garage, Southbourne Grove
Zone 7	Nortoft Road Disused Chapel
Zone 8	Pelham, Kinson
Zone 9	Meyrick Park Corporation Depot
Zone 10	Strouden Park Hotel, Castle Lane
Zone 11	Lee Motors, Wimborne Road (Caffyns until 1992)

The hated blackout had its first test locally during the night of 7th/8th July 1939 when all the street light were switched off at midnight until 4 am. During this period RAF planes flew overhead to check on its efficiency. Another blackout test was held from midnight to 4 am on 11th August together with a Civil Defence exercise. The real blackout came into force on 1st September and lasted until 17th September 1944. All street lighting and illuminated signs were switched off and windows had to be completely curtained or shuttered so that no light could be seen outside. Blackout material became scarce and expensive even though the shops had had the foresight to obtain large stocks. The first cases of breaching the blackout were soon being heard in the Magistrates Courts, the fine for conviction ranging from £1 to £5. Car headlights were fitted with masks and side lights were dimmed by putting two sheets of paper over the glass. The rear red tail light had not to exceed two inches in diameter, and the front and rear bumpers, plus the edges of the running boards and wings, had to be painted white.

All over the country road deaths during the blackout rose horrifically. In December 1939 in Bournemouth there were twenty-nine accidents, nineteen of these occurring during the blackout. Advertisements in the papers, "How many will die in the blackout tonight?", enjoined the public to take extra care. Cars, lorries, but not Fire Engines, taxis or buses were required by the Defence Regulations to park with their left, or nearside, against the side of the road during the hours of darkness and the speed limit during those same hours was set at 20 mph .

The Police requested motorists to avoid the Undercliff and Overcliff Drives because, although legally lit, car lights could be seen many miles out to sea. Petrol Rationing Books were issued from the Motor Licensing Department at the Town Hall on September 8th and applications for Food Rationing Books were delivered to each household by the Post Office. These had to be returned, when completed, to the Food Control Office which had been set up in the Popular Restaurant at the Pavilion.

At the declaration of war all cinemas, theatres and other places of entertainment were closed. No bands performed on the bandstands, the circus at the Winter Gardens was cancelled and the Concert Party on Boscombe Pier disbanded. Pictures were removed for safety from the Russell Cotes Art Gallery and stored in many places in the country around Bournemouth. The bus service was drastically curtailed, no buses operating after lighting up time. Later on this was extended to 8 o'clock, but with a restricted service. However within a fortnight the Pavilion and cinemas were open again until 10 o'clock, and by the end of November audiences were nearly up to prewar levels. With the reopening of the places of entertainment the Corporation Transport operated a skeleton service over all their routes during the blackout from 16th September, with the last buses leaving the Square at 10.30 pm The bus shelter in the middle of the Square was remodelled in November to include a waiting room where passengers could shelter on wet days and in the blackout. The canteen for drivers and conductors was enlarged as well. These alterations did not change the appearance of the shelter.

To help the motorist and the pedestrian white lines were painted on the kerbstones at road junctions, with lines across the road at pedestrian crossings, while lines were painted on lamp posts, trolley bus standards and trees on the pavements. Two bands of white were painted, one at eye level and the other about a foot from the ground and later a third band was added. Some residents painted

their garden gates white and also the edges of the paths which went to their front doors.

Under Home Office Regulations the interior lights in buses had to be obscured. To begin with the windows of the Bournemouth Corporation buses were painted blue, but this was unpopular as it cut out daylight. Some buses at first were kept only for use during the day and did not have their windows obscured. This, however, cut the number available during the evenings and early mornings so this was abandoned. Eventually the paint was removed and blinds were fitted to all buses. Hants and Dorset buses used interior bulbs which were opaque on the bottom but which threw light on to the ceiling. These provided enough light for the conductor and passengers.

Amongst those using the buses in early September as transport to their new homes were the evacuees. Bournemouth was considered to be a safe area and had been designated as a reception area for children from Southampton which was regarded as a prime target for German bombers. The first to come were pupils of St. Anne's Girls' Secondary School, Southampton. They arrived on September lst and were taken by 30 petrol buses from the Central Station to Talbot Heath School, where they were to remain for five years, until December 1944. Only then was it deemed safe for them to return to their own school buildings at Southampton. During this time the Talbot Heath pupils used the classrooms in the morning and those of St. Anne's in the afternoon.

More children arrived on Saturday 2nd. They had been told to report to their schools in the early morning, then taken by train to Bournemouth. At the stations Girl Guides helps in the reception of the evacuees by meeting the trains and showing parties to their transport. Buses took them initially to schools which were used as reception centres. From there the children were transported to the prearranged billets. Earlier, lists of houses with vacant rooms and families willing to take in the evacuees had been compiled by local teachers, and it was to these that the children were taken. The last ones were placed in the early hours of Sunday morning. Taunton's School, consisting of approximately 600 boys and their masters, came by train complete with identity labels attached to their coats, one suitcase and gas mask. Taunton's was the largest secondary school to be evacuated in England. Included was a Master, Dr. H.M. King, who later became an MP, then Speaker of the House of Commons, and eventually Lord Maybray King. The TV comedian Benny Hill and his sister also came with Taunton's. He remembers how nice and kind everybody was to the evacuees. Bournemouth School played host to Taunton's, the two schools sharing the new buildings just opened in East Way; whilst Southampton Grammar School for Girls shared with Bournemouth School for Girls at the Lansdowne until 1942 when they transferred to the Wentworth School site at Southbourne (now Wentworth Milton Mount School).

Two hundred and fifty boys from Portsmouth Grammar arrived to occupy Cliff House, Clifton Road, at Southbourne as a school, and later in October two hundred and fifty more followed. Carbery Preparatory School for Boys at 126 Southbourne Road was also taken over by Portsmouth Grammar. Other schools came as well, junior and senior. They came as complete schools and arrangements were made for them to continue their education sharing premises with local schools, sometimes on a shift basis, or full-time in rented halls. As well as classrooms rented Church, temperance and Mission Halls were also used to provide recreational facilities for the evacuees in their spare time. The Salvation Army Hall in Norwood Place, Pokesdown, was one of the first to open in the evenings for the children to go to play games and enjoy themselves. This Hall was originally the YMCA Kennedy Hut which had been set up in the Upper Pleasure Gardens in World War 1. It was transferred to Pokesdown in 1920. In October it was announced that secondary schools would open six days a week with alternate mornings and afternoons for the Bournemouth and evacuated pupils. The National Society Training College of Domestic Subjects was also evacuated to Bournemouth from London at the start of the war. They took over Princes Hotel on the corner of Knyveton and Vale Roads. Now the building is part of the College of Further Education.

On 29th September 1939 a national register of the population was taken. This applied to the civilian population only, excluding Members of the Forces. Through this register every man, woman and child in the country received their identity card. The result showed the population of Bournemouth to be 144,457, a rise of 27,654 over the 1931 Census figure of 116,803, and 22,357 over the 1938

Registrar General's estimate. It is likely that a good proportion of these "new" residents were evacuees. lt was estimated that from Southampton alone there were 7,724 official evacuees, 5,104 unaccompanied children, 859 mothers, 1,038 under-fives, 42 expectant mothers, 340 teachers, 12 helpers and 327 blind people. No figures were given for those from Portsmouth, nor for the Londoners who arrived taking houses and flats for the duration. Estate Agents reported a great demand for rented accommodation. However by the beginning of December the evacuees were going back home because the expected onslaught had not materialised. An average of seventy were leaving each week. Later on in the month special trains were laid on to take some home for Christmas. Special trains were also provided to bring the parents of London children for a visit on 17th December. Buses were laid on to take the visitors to see the children at their billets.

Some of the parents went to the Evacuees Club at 109 Holdenhurst Road (now the site of offices). This was set up to provide a place for parents to see their children. It was formally opened on 10th December by the Mayor, Alderman P.W.T. Hayward. Dr. H.M. King, Senior English Master of Taunton's School, and his wife, Mrs. V.F. King, a Councillor for Southampton Borough Council for ten years, who were in charge of the Club worked very hard for it. "Falaise", 14 West Overcliff Drive, a large house, was converted into a hospital of forty beds for the evacuees early in 1940. Later it became the Headquarters of the local Home Guard and of an Anti-Aircraft Company. After the war Sir Alan and Lady Cobham made "Falaise" their home. Another house, 16 Stourwood Avenue, was also turned into a sick bay for the evacuees by the County Borough. The children and staff of the National Sunday School Union Children's Convalescent Home were forced to move from Clacton-on-sea because of the war. As there was no spare room at the Bournemouth Home, "House Beautiful", Derby Road, they took over "Beardwood" 19 Stourwood Avenue, as a temporary home. By February 1940 the number of evacuees had fallen to 4000, less than half than at the beginning of the war, and by April this had fallen even more to 3,700, 500 from Portsmouth, 400 from London and 2,800 from Southampton. But as Bournemouth would be expected to provide accommodation for at least 21,000 evacuees from danger areas the Evacuee Department of the Town Hall prepared a fresh register of those willing to take in evacuees in case of heavy bombing.

During the first wartime months several organisations were set up to provide comforts for the troops, help the evacuees and make dressings, bandages and other hospital necessaries. To co-ordinate the war work of some of these various organisations the Bournemouth War Services Organisation came into being. lt had its Headquarters at "Cren Dahr" chamber, 159 Old Christchurch Road (now the offices of the Registrar of Births, Marriages and Deaths) and was made up of several Committees. The General Supplies Committee's task was to collect, sort and despatch periodicals, books, magazines, and other material, such as cards and games, for the recreation of Bournemouth men and women in the Forces. At Christmas 3000 parcels were despatched to those serving away from their home town of Bournemouth. The benevolent Committee dealt with cases of distress caused by the war and also included hospital visiting. The Evacuation Committee confined itself to the problems relating to evacuees, whilst the Entertainment Committee organised concerts and other types of entertainment for the members of the Forces stationed in the district.

The Central Hospital Supply Service Scheme, which opened on 23rd October, had its central depot at 15 Wellington Road. The Service was run by the London Joint Committee of the Red Cross and St. John Ambulance, and was to provide clothing and other items for both civilian and military hospitals. There were sub-depots spread around the town, including "Crag Head" which had been a hospital in World War 1. The main depot received the material from the cutting out depot in "Old Library House" in Dean Park Road, then passed it on to the depots for making up, and stored the finished articles before sending them onto the hospitals which needed them. There were in October over 500 helpers on its books. The Women's Voluntary Service co-ordinated the work done by the knitting groups for the Forces which were to be found all over the Borough.

At the beginning of December the blackout was relaxed with a system of modified lighting in shop windows. This did not give a very effective display but it did show some of the gilds available. Many shops, and private houses, were now pasting strips of strong brown paper in a crisscross pattern on

to the window glass to lessen the effects of bomb blasts. Later on the use of net which was pasted onto the glass was recommended as a better method of stopping the glass from shattering.

In October an Order in Council changed the closing hours of shops to 6 pm, with one late shopping night to 7.30 pm. However the local authority had the power to make local changes, so Bournemouth Corporation made it 8 pm on Saturdays and 7 pm on other nights. At the same time food retailers had to apply for a licence to trade, and the Ministry of Food fixed retail prices for certain commodities. In November 145,000 ration books were sent out from the Bournemouth Food Control Office, who advised the public that it was the responsibility of the householder that when they received the ration books they had to register with retailers for:

A Butchers meat
B Bacon and ham
C Butter and margarine
D Cooking fats, including lard and dripping
E Sugar

The freedom of shopping around for these commodities was no longer possible. The housewife had to purchase them from the retailer with whom she was registered. To change a retailer a visit had to be made to the Food Office in order to do so. When purchasing any of the rationed goods the shopper had to take the ration book to the shop where the requisite number of coupons would be removed for the items supplied.

Friday 13th October saw the "Battle of Poole Bay" when walkers on the cliffs heard gunfire in the Bay. For an hour six destroyers raced at full speed in all directions dropping about sixty depth charges and firing an estimated 200 rounds. To the onlookers it appeared that there was a hunt for, and attack on, a German U-boat. Local fishermen were ordered back into Poole Harbour, there the crew of one of them reported seeing a large oil slick and assumed that a submarine had been sunk. On Saturday rumour had it that three U-boats had been destroyed. However Coastguards said that it had only been an exercise. The guns had been firing at a target towed off Durleston Head. The "Battle of Poole Bay" never actually happened.

Rumours were circulating that U-boats regularly surfaced at night to recharge their batteries between Hengistbury Head and Hurst Castle. The World War I story of a German submarine aground off Hengistbury Head whose Officers rowed ashore and had dinner at the Royal Bath was resurrected.

Although the town had not yet been touched by enemy action the sadness of war had already been felt by some of the population. The local papers had carried the news of the sinking of the "Royal Oak" at Scapa Flow on October 14th by a German submarine, U 47, when several Bournemouth men had been killed. However the town was able to celebrate the "Battle of the River Plate"

This action between the heavy cruiser "Exeter" the light cruisers "Ajax" and "Achilles" and the German basket battleship "Graf Spee" ended in the scuttling of the German raider. During the fight the cruiser "Ajax" was commanded by Captain C.H.L. Woodhouse the son of Mrs. Woodhouse and the late Rev. A.P. Woodhouse of Littledown Road. On the "Exeter" the Chaplain, Rev. C. Grove, and three other seamen, also came from the town. Petty Officer Fred Knight of Boscombe received the Distinguished Service Medal for his part in shoring up damaged parts of the "Exeter" and for helping the wounded. Unfortunately he was lost when the "Prince of Wales" was sunk on December 10th 1941.

In December the Imperial War Graves Commission (now the Commonwealth War Graves Commission) wrote to the Town Clerk asking if the Council would provide space for war graves. As there were only twelve grave spaces remaining from the allocation in the First World War plot in the East Cemetery the Council agreed to provide one hundred more spaces in the North Cemetery. The first Service burial was that of Pilot Officer G.F.A.Barwell who died as a result of a flying accident on Friday 3rd November 1939. His funeral was held with full military honours at the East Cemetery.

The War Graves Plot in the North Cemetery lies to the right of the main entrance. It is enclosed by a a yew hedge with the Cross of Sacrifice at the far end flanked by silver birch trees. “The total

number of burials is 111, and this figure is made up by 9 sailors, 47 soldiers and 23 airmen (one of whom is not identified) belonging to the forces of the United Kingdom; 1 man of the Home Guard; 21 airmen of the Royal Canadian Air Force; 8 airmen of the Royal Australian Air Force; 1 sailor of the Royal Indian Navy and 1 seaman of the Dutch Merchant Navy.

Seventy five of the graves are in the War Graves Plot and the remainder are spread through the cemetery in positions chosen by those responsible for the internments. The Plot was used for the burial of airmen from various RAF stations prior to the opening of RAF Regional Cemeteries and 23 of the 41 airmen who rest in the War Graves Plot were killed during an air raid on 23rd May 1943".

Close by is the Cremation Memorial which has engraved on it the names of the men and women of the Forces who were cremated. "During the 1939-1945 war 33 men of the forces of the United Kingdom were cremated at the Bournemouth Crematorium. This figure is made up by 2 sailors, 20 soldiers, 9 airmen, 1 Merchant Navy man and 1 man of the Home Guard. All are commemorated by name on a memorial standing in the War Graves Plot... This takes the form of a screen wall of Portland stone, upon which the names are carved. It bears an appropriate inscription, recording the fact that these men died in the service of their country during the war years and were cremated. There is one woman named, an ATS Corporal"

Bournemouth East Cemetery contains the War Graves Plot which is enclosed by a dwarf euonymus hedge with the Cross of Sacrifice on the Western side. "The 1939-1945 burials total 69, and this figure is made up by 6 sailors, 32 soldiers and 27 airmen ... 1 man of the Merchant Navy, 2 men of the Home Guard and 1 French airman. Seven of the graves are in the War Graves Plot and the remainder are distributed throughout the Cemetery, in positions chosen by those responsible for the internments"

The Kinson Cemetery has four war graves.

A Garden to honour the memory of members of the Forces who lost their lives through the war was laid out in St. Peter's Churchyard. The half oval plot lies between the main gate and the Lych gate with a bush of rosemary for remembrance on each side. This was recognised by the War Graves Commission and now contains four war graves, plus one of an airman killed during the Berlin airlift in 1949, and one other service grave of a later date, There are also memorials to servicemen buried overseas.

The local Territorial Army had been mobilised in August. The No.3 Company, Hampshire Fortress Royal Engineers (Territorial), who trained at the Portman Road Drill Hall, were called up on 24th August. Then on the next day they went to the Isle of Wight to man the forts around the Island. On Friday 1st September 218 Battery of the 94th (Dorset and Hants) Field Regiment, Royal Artillery, left their Drill Hall in Lansdowne Road with requisitioned builders' lorries towing their 1914-18 18/25 pounder guns. Having no proper towing equipment the guns were tied to the lorries with rope! On the way to camp at Wilton whilst going through Fordingbridge one gun parted its tow and caused a lot of confusion.

The number of visitors to the town had fallen by approximately 10% immediately after the declaration, the smaller hotels and boarding houses being the worst hit, but with the coming of Christmas hoteliers found that their bookings picked up, approaching normal. Many of the hotels had converted their basements into gas proof air raid shelters which according to one advertisement gave "comparative safety against air raids". The normal train service from London had been cut on Monday 11th September from fourteen to six trains a day, but an improved service was operated over Christmas thus enabling those who had booked hotels for the festive season to travel. War or no war Bournemouth enjoyed a boom holiday. The weather before the holiday period was good and the shops reported excellent business with a great demand for presents suitable for men and women in the Forces.

The entertainments were well patronised. Shows such as "No No Nanette" at the Pavilion played to packed houses which included many men in uniform. The pantomime "Babes in the Wood" which followed was also very popular, so was "Robinson Crusoe" at the Hippodrome, Boscombe (now the Academy). Free film shows were given at the YMCA for soldiers on Sundays and on Christmas Day

three cinemas, the Carlton, the Grand and the Westover, opened reporting good business in the afternoon. However bad weather and no bus service resulted in poor houses in the evening. At the end of November the Ice Rink in the Westover Road, which had closed earlier in the year, reopened as the "Rink" a spacious and luxurious ballroom. There were 700 people at the first tea dance and the afternoon and evening sessions became very popular.

The remaining evacuees who were spending Christmas in Bournemouth were not neglected for they were provided with entertainments. They went to the cinema, the pantomime and on Christmas Day were given a party with games, food and presents. The soldiers billeted in the town were not forgotten either. Amongst others the Congregational, Methodist and Baptist Churches at Westbourne provided a centre for their recreation and relaxation in the lecture hall at the Congregational Church. There were billiards, table tennis, darts, cards and other games. Writing facilities were also provided as was a canteen. This was open 6 - 10 pm during the week and 7 - 10 pm on Sundays. Here on Christmas Day seventy five men were given a festive dinner. The Bournemouthians away in the Forces were also not forgotten for the Mayor sent everyone a Christmas card.

Chapter Two

1940

The year started with bad weather. Like many parts of the county Bournemouth experienced freezing weather with heavy snow in January. The pond in Queen's Park was frozen for three weeks and many people used it as a skating rink. Even parts of Poole and Christchurch Harbours froze. At the Hippodrome, Boscombe, for the week commencing 29th January the play "Dangerous Corner" by J.B. Priestley was performed. Bournemouth Councillor D.E. Richards went to see it on the Monday and wrote on his programme, "3 inches of snow to-day when it seemed we were clear of Arctic conditions. Went to Hippodrome notwithstanding. Had to wear overcoat during performance" As well as the cast list and advertisements the programme also gave the times of the last buses from Bournemouth. The last one was the 10.52 pm which went to Iford via Boscombe.

In July Bournemouth Corporation Transport announced that if an air raid warning should be sounded during the evening and the All Clear had not been given until after public transport would have normally stopped then the buses would wait until after the All Clear so that they could take passengers home whatever the time. Bus drivers were instructed to halt their vehicles when the Alert sounded and the conductors were to show the passengers where the nearest shelter was. However later on in the year under revised regulations the Ministry of Home Security permitted cars and buses to run during an Alert, only stopping if there was a raid actually in progress. Then the buses were to proceed to the nearest air raid shelter on their route. If the first shelter was full the buses would go on to the next and then cease to run. After the All Clear the vehicles had to wait for a reasonable time for the passengers to re-board before continuing their journey. The public were in favour of this arrangement as it did not mean that the traffic came to a standstill causing confusion.

To stop air raid warnings disrupting war production people were encouraged to stay at work until an enemy attack was imminent. When the Alert sounded lookouts, called "Jim Crows", trained in aircraft recognition, were stationed on the roofs of factories and large buildings. If enemy aircraft were spotted the lookouts warned the workforce by blowing whistles or ringing bells so that they could take cover. Silhouettes of both British and German planes were published in the daily papers to help people recognise friend from foe. The watchers were also there to deal with any incendiary bombs which might fall on the roofs.

In October the tops of the double-docker buses were painted dark grey to make them less conspicuous from the air, and single-deckers were painted grey all over. At the same time the trolley buses had their windows covered with netting to stop them splintering in a bomb blast. The Corporation released sixty three of its fleet of one hundred and seventy eight buses for service elsewhere, of these six were lent to the Bournemouth and Poole Fire Brigades, six to the ARP and the War Office had twenty one, these were mostly single-deckers. Amongst others twelve went to Wolverhampton (the last one returning in 1948) and eighteen double-decker trolley buses were sent to London, the Transport Department towing the trolleys to London. A letter in the Echo in December from a resident of Iford where some of the buses were being used, said the Bournemouth trolley buses, still in their distinctive livery with Bournemouth Corporation Transport on their sides, reminded

him of many happy holidays.

The last buses from the Square from November left at the earlier time of 10.15 pm much to the annoyance of the proprietors of cinemas and other places of entertainment. This was a slight compromise as the Council had wanted it to be 10 pm In December the Council very grudgingly allowed women to apply for jobs as conductors as well as men. However there were enough male applicants so none of the women who applied were appointed. But many women were being recruited locally and trained to work in the munitions factories.

An experimental device for waiting passengers to signal buses in the blackout was developed during the Autumn. A coloured light, screened from being seen from above, was attached to the bus stop poles at various parts of the Borough, such as Heron Court Road, St. Leonards Road, Hill View and Namu Roads. The intending passengers pressed a button which switched on the light so that the bus driver would know that someone was waiting. The Echo stated that "Development of the system should lessen the dangerous practice of shining torches in the driver's eyes. However this system was not put into operation. Bournemouth Corporation Transport also conducted experiments with a gas powered bus. A Bedford single-docker bus, EEL 56, had an inflatable bag on its roof to carry the gas. Unfortunately the bus could only travel about fifteen miles on one filling so the trials, which started in July 1940, were soon discontinued.

On January 3rd two new buildings were opened in the town. One was the new Boscombe Senior School in Ashley Road, and the other temporary premises for the new Kinson Catholic Church, St. Teresa of the Little Flowers. This was a wooden building in Millhams Road seating seventy five people. Later on in the month the "Saxon King" Hotel opened on the Broadway at Hengistbury Head. Originally its name was to be either "Hengist" or "Horsa" but a compromise had to be made and the "Saxon King" was decided on. Then on the 10th April the official opening of the new building for the Bournemouth School for Boys in East Way, postponed from the previous September, was performed by Lord Hugh Cecil. Three months later, on 30th July, Dr. E. Fenwick, the first Headmaster of the school, died.

Owing to the blackout a large number of churches cancelled their evening services because of the difficulty in screening the windows and also because many members of the congregations did not like going out after dark. Some held services in church halls which had adequate curtains or during the afternoons. However many Free Churches did curtain their windows and continue to hold evening services albeit to much reduced assemblies. Because of the blackout there were no Midnight Masses at Christmas 1939 at any of the Roman Catholic Churches, but five Anglican Churches managed to hold one. However in 1940 only two, Holdenhurst and Holy Epiphany, were able to continue the practice.

Rationing of bacon, ham, sugar and butter commenced on Monday 8th January. These were followed in March by meat, then in July tea and cooking fats, plus margarine. Other items were rationed later on, such as cheese, sweets and eggs.

There were a considerable number of refugees of different nationalities in the town, German Jews, Austrians, Czechoslovakians and Poles. The Police and the Home Office Refugee Tribunals had carefully examined their credentials and all were certified as refugees from Nazi oppression, both political and racial, and given permission to remain in England. There were two categories, those whose movements were restricted, who had to obey a curfew and were unable to own a car, bicycle or a radio, and those who had lived in England for at least six years. However many could not speak English and an educational centre for them was set up in the Friends Meeting House in Avenue Road (demolished when the Avenue Centre was built). This prompted several letters in the local press from people querying the "procession of Germans visiting the Quakers in Avenue Road".

The Bournemouth Central Committee for Refugees maintained a Hostel in Surrey Road, and provided training for these "friendly aliens". But in May the Home Office issued an order rounding up the restricted aliens. Originally the Order affected the Eastern half of England which included Hampshire but not Dorset. This created a complicated state of affairs on the Dorset border between the Boroughs for it meant that the Police had to check for aliens crossing from Poole into

Bournemouth. It must be remembered that at this time Bournemouth was part of Hampshire, not Dorset as it is now. Later, on May 16th, the Order was extended to the whole country. So the Bournemouth Police were given the task of finding all the restricted aliens in the town. As well as the residents all hotels and boarding houses had to be visited to see if any such aliens had come for the Whitsun holiday. Approximately one hundred people were taken away in three motor coaches from Bournemouth for internment. On the 10th June Bournemouth became a protected area under the "Aliens (Protected Areas) (No 5) Order 1940". This meant that an alien was not permitted to enter into, or remain, in a protected area without written Police permission. All male aliens between 16 and 60, even these who had lived locally for over six years, were required to leave. However the Bournemouth Central Committee for Refugees did not close down because there were the young and the old who did not come under the Order to look after. Brownsea Island had many refugees from occupied Europe sheltering on it. They had arrived by sea in different kinds of ships. Rumour had it that Mrs. Christie, the owner, and her foreign staff had been questioned about a high powered transmitter found on the island which could send messages to Germany.

At Easter 24th March, in spite of the war, holiday amenities were not severely curtailed. Road and rail travel were as normal and the thousands of visitors found Bournemouth's attractions unchanged both in quality and variety. ne Municipal Orchestra, albeit smaller than prewar, gave performances in the open air as well as at the Pavilion.

The Whitsun Bank Holiday was something and nothing for the Government had cancelled the Holiday, the reason being to keep the factories and workshops running to provide the munitions and equipment required for the war. The announcement was made on the Friday at midday so that many people who had bookings for the weekend disregarded the cancellation and came. Some shops closed on the Monday but others opened, whilst a few office workers went into their place of employment.

In London the Prime Minister, Neville Chamberlain, was attempting to form a National Government. The Labour Leader, Clement Attlee (later Lord Atlee) and Arthur Greenwood were asked if they would join it. Their reply was that although the Labour Party was agreeable to join a coalition government it would not do so under Chamberlain. Chamberlain then asked if they would serve under a different Prime Minister. Attlee replied that he thought so, but would have to consult his colleagues. As the Labour Party was having their annual conference in Bournemouth from the 13th May Atlee and Greenwood travelled down to consult the National Executive Council, which was meeting just prior to the main conference. The NEC'S decision was that they would not agree to Attlee serving under Chamberlain but would under another. Attlee returned to London with this message, and Chamberlain resigned almost immediately. The King then asked Winston Churchill to form a new government. The next day Attlee and Greenwood returned to Bournemouth where the Labour Party Conference endorsed the NEC'S decision overwhelmingly.

Early in the year Bournemouth became a principal training area for RAF recruits. Trains disgorged many men in conspicuously new Air Force blue uniforms with their kitbags to live in boarding houses in Boscombe for a few weeks. After physical training and squad drill they went off to RAF depots all over the country.

The billeting of soldiers and airmen occurred on a large scale all over the town. The Promenades, car parks and any large open spaces became "squares" for new recruits to be initiated into the pleasures of foot drill. The Burlington Hotel was use for Officer training and later the chines and cliff for Commando training. Regiments which came to the town at different times included the Black Watch, Green Howards, Irish Fusiliers and the London Scottish amongst others. The soldiers, English and later American, billeted in the Charminster area had as their mess room the former BBC transmitting station in Bushey Road, its two radio masts having been taken down prewar. Mail was processed at the Post Office sorting office for the British Expeditionary Force in France during the early months of 1940.

The Town Council received in April a letter from Brigadier E.V.H. Tollemache, Commander of the Portsmouth Area , which stated that "he was of the opinion that having regard to the large number of H.M. Forces quartered in, or in the neighbourhood of, Bournemouth that cinemas should be opened

on Sundays". He also, as required under the Sunday Entertainments Act 1932, provided the necessary certificate to that effect. Later in August a letter from Brigadier J.M.L. Grover, Commander of the 11th Infantry Brigade, Home Forces, endorsed the original letter on Sunday cinemas. After a great deal of discussion the required permission was granted by the Magistrates and on Sunday, January 19th 1941, the cinema opened their doors for the first time from 3 pm to 9 pm This proved to be a very popular move. However the Church authorities were unhappy because children were "pouring into them (the cinema) and not attending Sunday Schools".

The Mayors of Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch appealed in April for scrap metal to be collected for munitions, calling for May to be the "Spring cleaning month for scrap". In May the Borough Council set up a special Committee to look into the collection of scrap in all forms. Bournemouth had miles of iron railings outside houses, around public part and churches. There was a great need in the munitions factories for scrap metal and so arrangements were made for their removal and transition to dumps in the town. By the end of the month over 1,000 tons of scrap metal had been collected. Later on in June the Council came under fire for not doing enough. It was claimed that there were still tons of ornamental railings, chains and gates at parks and Council buildings. The Municipal College at the Lansdowne was cited as an example. Not only iron was collected but also housewives were asked to give up their aluminium pots and pans to make Spitfires and Hurricanes.

Several World War I mines which had been washed ashore on the beach, rendered safe, and placed at various points along the cliffs as memorials or collecting boxes for various charities were removed to the Corporation East Yard to be cut up for scrap. However there was an unfortunate accident on 13th October when Mr. F.E. Trim was killed when another First World War mine exploded as he was cutting it up at Powell's Scrap Yard in Victoria Road, Springbourne. The mine, which had been made in 1916, had been washed up at Mudeford in 1917 where it had lain untouched for years until collected during the drive for metal.

The Salvage Committee reported in October that there was still need for householders to collect for salvage, even though the clearance of lofts, attics and garages had been completed. The "Clearance of Lofts Order 1940" had come into force in August. Under this householders had to clear out any attics or lofts not used as living quarters so that if the house was hit by a fire bomb there would not be anything which could catch fire. The need for raw materials required the usual household rubbish to be sorted when put out into piles of paper, rags, bones and bottles. These were then taken to the Council dump and sent off in bulk for recycling. Every month the Salvage Committee reported on the amount of material salvaged from the house refuse collected in the Borough.

The "Dig for Victory" campaign started by the Ministry of Food to help in the production of food saw the Corporation turning the grazing land at the Corporation farms to the growing of vegetables. The restaurants at the Pavilion were supplied with all the potatoes and green vegetables that they needed. In May there were thirty five sites used for allotments on which over six hundred people cultivated carrots, potatoes, etc., whilst in many gardens chickens and rabbits were reared, and the flower beds and lawns dug up for vegetables. The Ministry of Health issued an order in June suspending restrictions against the keeping of livestock in gardens, contained in tenancy agreements, providing that the keeping was not prejudicial to health or a nuisance. Chickens and ducks were from then to be found in many a back garden providing eggs and poultry for the table.

In May the German Army was sweeping through Belgium to the Channel coast. The Government recognised that volunteers would be required to defend Britain alongside the Army against a German invasion. So on the evening of the 14th May Anthony Eden, Secretary of State for War (later Prime Minister 1955-57), appealed on the radio for all men between the ages of seventeen and sixty five, who were reasonably fit and with a knowledge of firearms, to enrol in the volunteer force, the Local Defence Volunteers. Those who volunteered would not be paid nor would they have to live away from home. There was an immediate response, almost as soon as he had stopped speaking willing men were arriving at Police Stations to register, many were veterans of the First World War. Within forty eight hours of the broadcast 1,500 had volunteered.

Major, later Lieutenant Colonel, T.V. Rebbeck was appointed to command the Bournemouth Company. He had been a member of the local Volunteer Battalion of the Hampshire Regiment during the Great War and had served in the Territorial Army. Locally the men were nicknamed "Parashots" as their first duty was to repel parachute troops. However in July Churchill referred to them as the "Home Guard" and this was adopted officially.

The area from Hengistbury Head to the County boundary at Westbourne and as far inland as the River Stour was divided into sections, each having a Section Leader. The Drill Halls in Holdenhurst Road and Portman Road were used as Headquarters. By the end of May cliff patrols and lookouts had been established all around Bournemouth during the hours of darkness, similar to those in the First World War, which were also carried out by Volunteers. However the early LDVS were not issued with any weapons, and they had to appeal for shotguns, binoculars and other equipment. These were quickly forthcoming. Guns used in the Crimean Campaign and elegant opera glasses were amongst the donations. At first no uniforms were available, their only distinguishing mark was a khaki armband with LDV on it. These initials were translated by some as "Look, Duck and Vanish".

August saw weapons and equipment start arriving, eventually the Home Guard was well equipped with rifles, Tommy guns, mortars, grenades and even a 2 pounder anti-tank gun. By the end of 1940 a more formal military organisation had emerged. Proper Companies were formed and in 1941 Commissions were granted to the Officers and ranks were brought into line with the Regular Army. Conscription into the Home Guard was introduced in May 1942 for men waiting to join, or for those over the age for, the Forces.

There was realistic training, sometimes with the Army, using live ammunition. Several members were killed or injured during demonstrations and exercises. One of the worst happened on Salisbury Plain in April 1942.

Over eighty Officers, NCO's and men of the 7th (Boscombe) Battalion were trained to man the coastal guns at Hengistbury Head to relieve the regular crews. Although they never fired the guns in anger they were extremely well trained.

By 1941 the Bournemouth Battalion had been split because it became too unwieldy with over 4,600 men on its strength. So two Battalions were formed 6th (Bournemouth) and 7th (Boscombe) of the Hampshire Home Guard (Bournemouth being in Hampshire then).

The Bournemouth Battalion had seven Companies, including one from the Electricity Supply Company, as well as a platoon from the Hants and Dorset Bus Company, and a strength of 2,050. Initially Lt. Col. T.V. Rebbeck was the Commanding Officer, he was succeeded by Lt. Col. E.C. Seconde in September 1942, then Lt. Col. H.G. Wheeler in November 1943 and finally by Lt. Col. N.F. Gadsdon in June 1944.

The 7th (Boscombe) Battalion was under the command of Lt. Col. F.I. Ford, with a strength of 1,652 men in four Companies. Its area was eastward from Boscombe Pier to RAF Southbourne at Hengistbury Head. The boundary to the North was Muscliffe then along the Stour to the sea, the other half of Bournemouth being the responsibility of the 6th (Bournemouth) Battalion.

In March 1942 Major G.T. Thomas and his Christchurch Company transferred to the 7th Battalion from the 8th (Avon Vale) Battalion. The Boscombe Silver Band, which was in danger of being disbanded owing to the lack of engagements, enrolled en masse in October 1940 and became the Battalion Band. They were given the ordinary Home Guard training as well as that given for the traditional Army role for Bandsmen as stretcher bearers. A social life evolved and a concert party called the "Barricadians" was formed in 1941 giving many performances in Bournemouth and at military camps around the town.

Each Home Guard Company had a "Battle Platoon" and when D-Day approached two mobile Battle Companies were kept ready for action anywhere and at any time in case of raids by the enemy on the troop concentrations along the South Coast. There were also Battalion Signal Sections, Medical Sections and Despatch Riders on motor cycles.

The Southern Railway and the Post Office had their own Battalions. The 21st (Southern Railway) Battalion was formed in 1940 and its members were all employed on the railway. B Company, 21st

Battalion, had its Headquarters at Queen's Hall, Bath Road with Major F.T. Cook in command. The five hundred members of the Company were easily recognisable as their webbing was black not khaki. Their primary role was to protect the railways from sabotage by carrying out guard duties and patrols.

The Bournemouth and Poole Companies of the 22nd (Post Office) Battalion were under the command of Lt. Col. W.R. Tyson, the Bournemouth Area Telephone Manager. One Company was formed from the telephone staff and the other from the postal personnel, with a Headquarters Section comprising Ambulance, Transport and Administration.

The Gas and Water Company was formed in May 1940 under Major W.V Cutler. Its purpose was to patrol and guard at night the local gas and water installations. It was part of the 3rd Dorset (Poole) Battalion and had an average strength of 200. The Bournemouth Electric Company of the 6th Battalion guarded the electricity works and other installations such as the sub-stations at Bourne Valley and Christchurch. This had an average strength of about 120.

As far as the town was concerned until the end of May the war was far distant. Nothing had happened really to change the life style of Bournemouthians, but the "miracle" or "debacle" of Dunkirk brought the horror of war right into their homes. Dunkirk was the first opportunity for the town to play a real part. On Friday, May 31st, the Mayor, Alderman P.W.T. Hayward, received a telephone call warning him that Bournemouth was to be one of the centres to which evacuated soldiers were to be sent. He was to expect a large number of French soldiers, some from the French African colonies, including the turbanned men from Morocco. All schools were closed immediately and preparations were put in hand to turn them into barracks. People flocked in hundreds to the schools to help make up beds and prepare food. This was done in the few short hours allowed for the first trainload arrived at 3 am on the Saturday morning, 1st June. The Mayor and a small crowd of well-wishers were there to welcome them. The first party was taken to Malmesbury Park School, the next to Alma Road Schools and then to six others all over the Borough, plus the Municipal College. Bournemouth School (for boys) had 1,500 soldiers billeted in their class rooms and the Girls School had 800. Even Dean Court Football Ground was used, some of the exhausted and hungry men in their torn, dirty uniforms slept on the pitch.

The members of the local Cercle Francais worked hard as interpreters, whilst the St. John Ambulance Brigade and the Red Cross were at the billets night and day giving first aid treatment. Kitchens were set up overnight by the Gas and Water Company and the Corporation Catering Department provided food using the multi-storey garage in Hilton Road as a dispersal point. Many families invited the men to share their Sunday lunch, as well as offering baths. Gifts of razors, soap, socks, clothing and cigarettes flowed into the temporary billets where, even though blankets and bedding had been provided, many had to sleep on the floor. A local newsagent procured hundreds of French newspapers and magazines which enabled the men to find out what was happening in their own country. Even the barbers gave free shaves and haircuts. Hot baths were also available at the Corporation Baths and some men went for a swim in the sea. Entertainment was put on at the Services Club at the Theatre Royal in Albert Road and the YMCA at Winton and Westover Road threw their doors open to the soldiers. The local Catholic Churches made special arrangements for Mass to be said.

The exact number of men is not known, but it is estimated that there were several thousand for during the time that they were here the Bournemouth War Services Organisation gave out 3000 shirts, socks and other articles of clothing. After four days the soldiers started to be moved to camps set up in other parts of the country and then back to France. Five schools reopened on Monday, 10th June, the remainder on Wednesday, 12th June.

The Commanding Officer, Southern Command, wrote to the Mayor expressing thanks for Boumemouth's hospitality and letters of thanks from the French soldiers themselves were published in the local papers. Even after the war had finished a French Officer sent a postcard to a local family, who had befriended him at the time, saying how much he had appreciated the effort made on his, and his men's, behalf. Later Bournemouth School and other schools were again used as billets from 19th to 26th June. This time it was English soldiers who had been fighting a rearguard action in France and

who had been evacuated from Cherbourg. There were also more French troops, this time from Norway and Dieppe, to be housed. In all fifteen schools were closed to accommodate them before permanent camps could be found. Many parents were worried by what appeared to be a standstill in the education of their children. However the need for the schools did not last long and they were able to revert to their proper function.

Some of the small ships which helped to rescue the 337,000 British and French soldiers from the beaches of Dunkirk were well known by the Bournemouth holiday makers. Skylark VI, an open launch which was part of the large Bolson fleet from Poole on which many had enjoyed trips around the Bay, was found awash in the Channel after the evacuation. She was salvaged and put back into service. However she was lost in Poole Bay after an accident in April 1946. Amongst the paddle steamers which saved hundreds of men were two that had been based at Bournemouth for the Summer seasons. The 'Emperor of India' was requisitioned at the beginning of the war and converted into a minesweeper. She went across the Channel early in the evacuation and returned to Dover with 600 soldiers aboard. The "Princess Elizabeth" was also converted for minesweeping and in the four journeys she made to Dunkirk brought back 1,670 men. She was the first paddle steamer to use Bournemouth Pier in 1946 when the Bournemouth to Swanage service restarted. However the "Emperor of India" did not return until the summer of 1948. Another pleasure steamer which had sometimes been seen at Bournemouth, the "Gracie Fields" was sunk by a bomb off Dunkirk with the loss of one hundred servicemen. The star herself had once sailed on her from Bournemouth to Swanage Pier.

On the 22nd May the Emergency Powers (Defence) Act was passed which put the country under military law. Under this Act civilian rights were suspended for the duration of hostilities, also Orders could be issued so that, for example, "a farmer could be told what to grow, the cinema could be told what to show, and the traveller where he could go!". Defence Regulations prohibited photographs of the sea front and one local man was fined £2 by the local Magistrates for taking one without a permit. By another Order all signposts and direction signs were removed and placed in storage. Their removal was to hinder enemy parachutists or invaders in finding their way or checking their location. The loss of the many-armed signs in the Square, at the Lansdowne and other major road junctions caused much inconvenience to strangers to the town. Estate Agents signs outside houses, business names, in fact any notice which could give any indication of the name of a place had to be removed or obliterated. The large name plates at the local railway stations were removed and replaced by smaller ones which could only be seen by the traveller on the train and not from outside the station.

Traffic lights were switched off, except at Cemetery Junction, Winton Banks, Sea Road, Queen's Road and County Gates, until after May 1945 when "the prewar lighting of traffic control signals became permissible". These remaining traffic lights were reduced to small crosses on each signal light which made them very difficult to see especially in daylight. Masks in the shape of half moons were fitted in 1941 so that the signal lights could be more easily seen. These special masks illuminated the upper part of the circle during daylight and the cross at night. The change over was effected by a switch operated by the Police. In 1942 the lights at Queen's Road and Sea Road were discontinued, and were reinstated in June 1946. Those that remained were turned off at blackout time, then on again at 7 am next morning.

Experimental street lighting, "Starlight", was tried out in the Square and the Lansdowne. The Echo commented, "People must not expect the streets to be brightly illuminated. The lamps are only intended to give a glow to help the pedestrian and motorist. They cannot be seen from the air". Another scheme for modified street lighting was proposed in May when 4,000 electric and 1,600 gas lamps were to be erected at principal road junctions and crossings and at such places as bus stops and outside places of entertainment. In June the lights in the Square which marked the edges of kerbs were considered to be too bright. All these schemes were eventually scrapped in July so that Bournemouthians still had to proceed carefully, aided by their torches, after dark. It was reported to the Lighting and Fire Brigade Committee on the 15th August that "The Air Ministry cannot advise that street lighting should be permitted at Bournemouth".

Bournemouth and the Second World War

In June Bournemouth was declared a military garrison under Col. C.E. Temperly as Garrison Commander. The Garrison covered the area from the West of Poole to the East of Christchurch and had its Headquarters at 7a Wimborne Road at the top of Richmond Hill. Michael A. Hodges in his "Prepared for Battle" gives an excellent description of the Garrison and its objectives to which the reader is referred.

Work began on the coastal defences from Hengistbury Head to Sandbanks in July, the objective being to prevent the enemy landing on the beach. Steel scaffolding was erected along the beach at the low water mark and also further up the beach with barbed wire entangled in it. There were three places where gaps had been left, at Southbourne, near Boscombe Pier and at Alum Chine. These spots were covered by guns along the beach and cliffs.

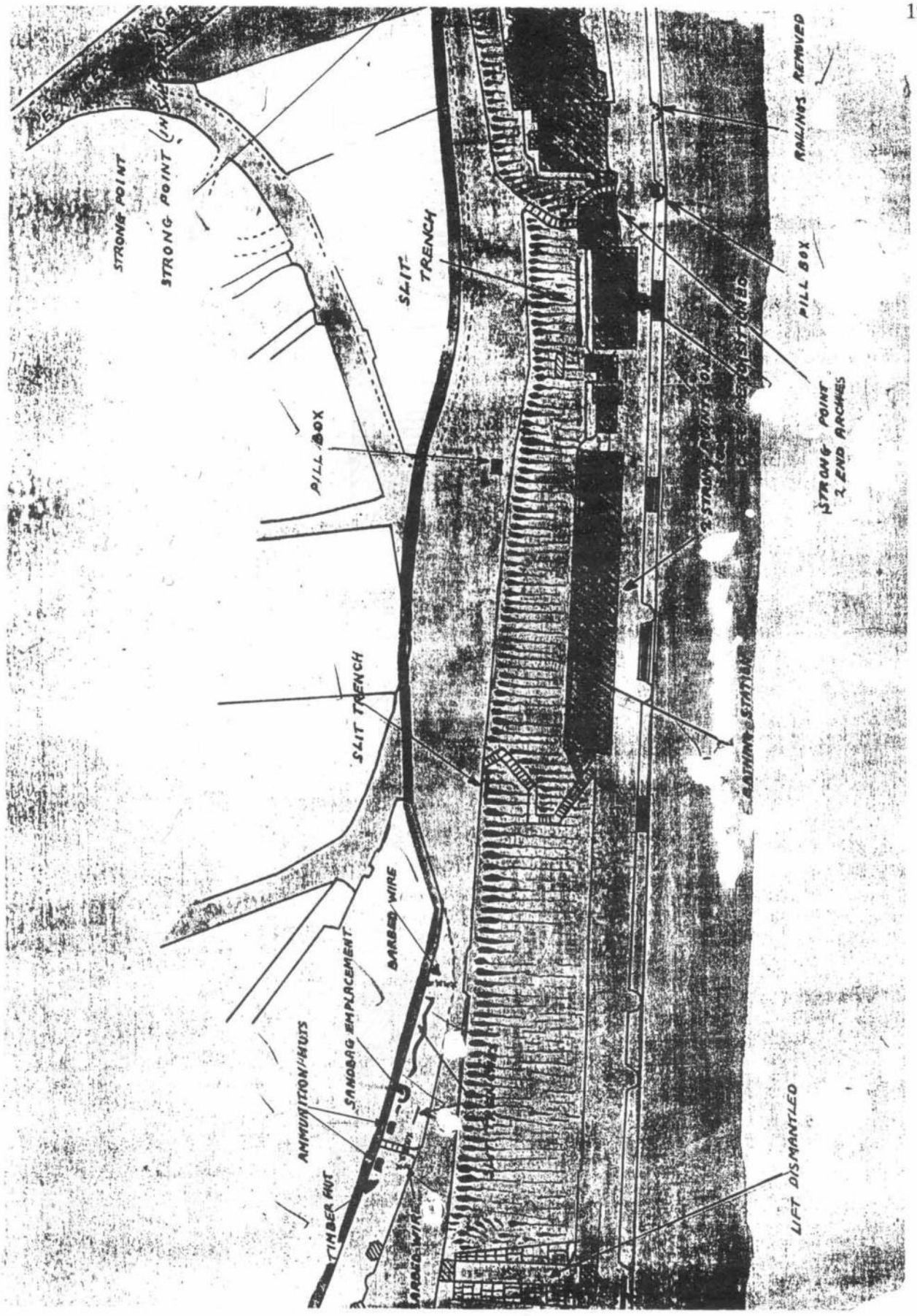
In the Alum, Middle and Durley Chines flame traps, large concrete tanks holding up to 500 gallons of highly inflammable liquid, were placed. The contents would have been drained out through pipe lines and ignited, setting fire to the Chine together with any invading Germans. Pipes were also laid under the promenade which would have fed oil on to the beaches for a similar purpose. The cloisters at Bournemouth and Boscombe were adapted as strong points, whilst the cliffs and the promenade had pillboxes built on them. The Army also constructed blockhouses on the cliffs and dug trenches. Local builders were given the task of constructing "dragon's teeth" in all the Chines and open areas such as the Pier Approach. At the peak period there were thirty firms working together with a total manpower of over one thousand to build these obstacles to the invasion by both men and tanks.

The "dragon's teeth" were cubes made of reinforced concrete with a pyramid top. Most of them have been removed but examples can still be found. Some remain under the railway viaducts at Branksome where there is a pillbox at the side of Gordon Road as well. According to the Echo, 9th June 1945, each obstacle required five to six tons of concrete and that within the first six days at least one line had been built in every Chine and each vulnerable cliff opening. The most difficult project that the builders had was a gun emplacement half way down the steepest part of the sandy cliff at Southbourne. Not only was the construction tricky but the gun itself arrived at night and had to be lowered into position by ropes.

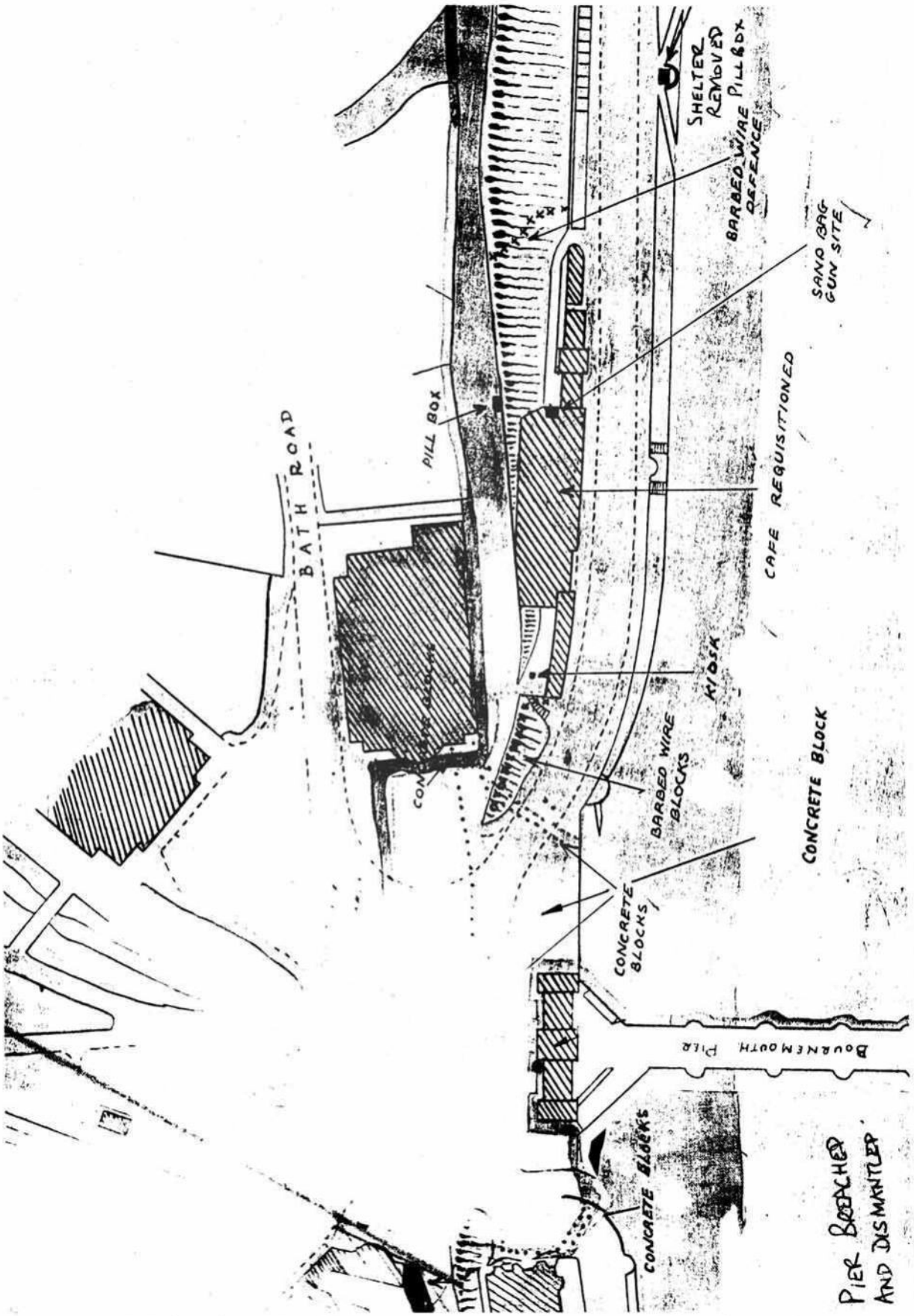
The Alum and Durley Chine Cafes were demolished by order of the military authorities and railings and shelters on the promenade were removed to give a clear field of fire. Beach bungalows were taken away, some being removed to the top of the cliffs and used as accommodation for soldiers on guard. The cliff lifts were dismantled and the buildings at the top of the cliffs used by the Army and also the Home Guard. The Zig-zags had "dragon's teeth" at strategic points to restrict their use. AA guns, 40 mm Bofors, were positioned on the cliffs and on top of the beach cafe at Bournemouth, whilst searchlights were placed at Southbourne near Fisherman's Walk. On one occasion these lights were machine-gunned by an enemy aircraft and several soldier wounded. This caused protests from people living near the site and the lights were eventually moved. There were other searchlight sites, at Throop and Meyrick Park. Ted Hughes in his "Bournemouth firemen at war" tells of an incident when German aircraft machine-gunned the searchlights situated in Meyrick Park and a firecrew had to dodge the bullets when moving from their canteen in the Pavilion to their fire engine. A letter in the Echo on August 11th 1941 stated that the AFS attending an incident in Southbourne were attacked because of the reflection of moonlight on the highly polished appliance.

Light machine guns, such as Lewis guns, were set up on high buildings in the town. Typical sites were San Remo Towers, Beales, Highcliff Hotel, the Town Hall and Whites Furniture depository in Springbourne. John Perks in his "Dorset's anti-aircraft defences" remembers that on one occasion a light machine gun and stand fell over on the roof of San Remo Towers and went off spraying bullets everywhere. Luckily not much damage was done and nobody was hurt.

There are sketch plans in the Local Studies Collection at the Bournemouth Reference Library which show the situation of nearly all the defences along the front from Alum Chine to Southbourne. The part showing Bournemouth Pier Approach is reproduced on pages 19 and 20. A list of the fortifications is given in Appendix A.



Defences from Alum Chine to Southbourne - Bournemouth Pier Approach



Defences from Alum Chine to Southbourne - Bournemouth Pier Approach

Anti-invasion precautions also included the immobilisation of vehicles. The Ministry of War Transport issued a leaflet which described the steps vehicle owners had to take to prevent cars and lorries being used by enemy invaders. These included the removal of the distributor head and leads, removing the carburettor and emptying the petrol tank either by its drain plug or by puncturing the tank with a nail. Those parts which were removed had either to be hidden or in dire emergency smashed. As a normal everyday precaution the rotor arm had to be removed to prevent the car being driven. The local magistrates had a number of cases when owners were summoned for failing to do this. The Courts also heard many prosecutions where householders were lax with their blackout precautions.

Bournemouth Pier - which would have celebrated its diamond jubilee on August11th - and Boscombe Pier were closed for entertainment on 3rd July and all the buildings at the head of the Piers and their deck planking, plus railings, were removed. Then two days later, on 5th July, both Piers had sixty feet of their middle sections blown up by the Royal Engineers so that any invaders would not be able to use them to disembark troops or equipment. These gaps were extended to one hundred and twenty feet on July 11th.

The Green Howards and the 4th Battalion Royal Northumberland Fusiliers also laid minefields along the beaches and helped to extend the coastal defences. It was whilst the soldiers were working on the defences that a German aircraft machine-gunned the beach and the promenade. More pillboxes were constructed at strategic road junctions, at bridges and river crossings. Until recently one was situated in the Blanchard & Burgess Builders Merchants yard guarding the Gloucester Road railway bridge, and two more can be found either side of the North end of the Cleveland Road railway bridge built into the banks along the track.

Possibly the best known pillbox was at Cemetery Junction. This had a wooden peaked roof and was painted to look like a summer house. It survived for many years, losing in roof, before being demolished when road improvements were made. Another pillbox in Southbourne Road by the railway bridge was also camouflaged as a summer house, whilst the "shops" at either end of Iford Bridge were in fact defence posts. But perhaps the cleverest piece of disguise was a strong point actually in the Bournemouth Central Station. This was camouflaged to look like a W.H. Smith's Bookstall, with books and magazines painted on it. Inland large areas which could be used to land troops, either by parachute or glider, had obstacles placed on them. Meyrick and Queen's Park golf courses "grew" telegraph and old lamp posts along the fairways. Moveable road blocks and barricades were constructed and placed at road junctions and railway bridges. They became attractions for children to climb over much to the concern of Councillors and many other people. The Borough Engineer was instructed in December 1941 to "call the attention of the Military Authorities to the unsafe manner in which steel girders for use in road blocks were left by the roadside and the consequent danger for children".

The first aid posts which had been housed in the Pier Approach and Stokewood Road Baths were transferred to "Roseneath", Durley Road, and "The Home of Good Hope", Lowther Road (now the East Dorset Professional Education Centre) in June allowing the Stokewood Road Baths to be reopened to the public.

The first real air raid warning sounded at 12.20 am on 20th June when German aircraft bombed Southampton, the All Clear signalling "Raiders departed" was at 3 am. Bournemouth had its first bombing raid during the night of 2/3rd July, the siren sounding at 11.50 pm, when a high explosive bomb fell at 00.17 am between two houses in Cellars Farm Road, Southbourne. One of the houses caught fire and was completely destroyed, the other was severely damaged, as were seventeen others. Luckily nobody was hurt. Later on that afternoon, 3rd July, the first daylight warning was heard at 2.30 pm. Bombs had already been drops near Stapehill on 27th June and at Three Legged Cross on 2nd July, neither incident causing any casualties.

The Battle of Britain started officially on 10th July and went on until the 31st October. Many dog fights occurred in the sky above the town and the Bay as the Luftwaffe flew over on its bombing raids. After the war a unique memorial dedicated to those who gave their lives during the Battle of

Britain was built in an apple orchard at the rear of the Queen Victoria Hotel, Wimborne Road, Winton.It was a tiny chapel, holding nine people, constructed by Mrs. G.E. George, the wife of the Licensee. Using the base of, and materials from, a demolished 5000 gallon static water tank, she took two years to complete the building. The four pillars and the roof of the entrance porch were covered with seashells, the interior walls and the floor with pottery mosaic and the windows were of stained glass. Effigies of the Virgin Mary came from Dublin and the Bible on the Altar was given by the mother of a Canadian fighter pilot killed in the Battle. The Chapel was demolished when the site of the Queen Victoria was re-developed.

It was on 10th July that the first civilian death in Bournemouth occurred at 6.30 in the morning when an enemy plane dropped five high explosive bombs in the Meon Road area. They fell on common land, on allotments and in the Meon and Hambledon Roads. Mr. Harold E. Vatter was cycling to work as a gardener at Dean's Nursery in Curzon Road when he was fatally injured. He was buried in the churchyard at Throop Congregational Church (now Throop United Reform Church).

The duty of the local authority after a raid was to ascertain the extent of the damage and to carry out first aid repairs. A representative of the Borough Engineer's Department would visit the bombed site and make a survey to see if the building could be repaired or if it had to be demolished. Every effort was made to replace glass in windows and repair roofs so that the damaged properties were made wind and water tight. A panel of local builders was set up to put the repair work required in hand immediately. There was also an organisation consisting of Architects and Builders to deal with the demolition or permanent repairs set up by the Civil Defence Committee. Property owners had to pay for the repairs but could submit a claim for compensation to the District Valuer in Yelverton Road. Bombed out people could be fed and housed for forty eight hours at either of the Public Assistance Centres at the Winton YMCA or the Temperance Hall in Haviland Road, Boscombe, The Borough Council then had powers to billet homeless people in private homes or even requisition houses and let them at a reasonable rent. A centre where information on casualties could be found was set up at the Town Hall. All enquiries had to be made to the centre and not to the Police or Hospitals. After major raids, such as the one on Westbourne, temporary enquiry centres were opened near the bombed area.

By the end of 1941 the WVS had a large mobile kitchen in a converted single deck Corporation bus for feeding rescue parties and other people in blitzed areas. It could serve three hundred meals per hour when used as an emergency feeding centre. A new organisation, run by the WVS, called the Housewives Service, came into being in November. It organised housewives who would give help to people bombed out by offering shelter and refreshment for up to two days if necessary, plus looking after children and the elderly. It was a service of partially trained women who assisted in allaying panic, giving help to neighbours and providing assistance to Wardens during and after raids.

Criticisms of the civil defence measures taken occurred. In July there was a call for Sir Charles Cartwright, Area Group Controller, to resign because of his age and the "general dissatisfaction with his grip on the Borough ARP affairs". The Bournemouth Citizen's Committee for ARP Co-ordination was formed in the same month. At their first crowded meeting on Wednesday 10th July resolutions were passed calling for the Council to speed up and increase the provision of adequate and efficient shelters in the streets, recreation grounds, factories and shops. The slow progress of providing shelters and protection for children at school was deplored too. However this work was progressing in all the Borough's educational establishments. Roofs were reinforced, ceilings shored up to provide protection and six foot high walls were built in front of windows near the rooms in which the children would shelter to minimise the effects of bomb blast. The Committee called upon eligible residents to enrol in one of the Voluntary Services, ARP, AFS or the Home Guard. They also thought that street committees should be organised so that stirrup pump parties and first aid groups could be set up. Over three hundred stirrup pumps had been purchased by the AFS and these were distributed around the town, One to every two or three roads.

Houses in which a stirrup pump was kept had a four inch white square with SP in red on it fixed to the gate post so that if necessary the Fire Guard would know where to find one together with

several buckets for water. The pump sucked water from a bucket, the stirrup referred to being a bracket at the bottom of the steadying leg in which the foot was placed. The water was then pumped on to the fire through a hose attached to the pump.

The Fire Brigade Chief Officer appealed for seven hundred and fifty volunteers to be trained in putting out fires caused by incendiary bombs, but there was an apathetic response, only half the number required coming forward. Those who did had two two-hour training sessions on how to use the pumps. As well as lectures and demonstrations everybody on the course had to go into a smoke-filled shed and extinguish a tray of wood shavings which had been set alight. Lectures on incendiary bombs and how to extinguish them were held at ARP Centres, whilst demonstrations were given at Grafton Road Depot. Also demonstrations on how to put out incendiaries using sand were given in the streets to the local residents. The Council dumped sand at various parts of the Borough, generally at ARP posts, so that people could fill buckets and keep sand at home ready to smother fire bombs. They were also asked to fill their baths with water to provide supplies for fire fighting in case the mains were broken.

The local Area ARP Officer, Mr. H.G.D. Barrett, resigned his post in June having been arrested on a minor driving charge. Subsequently after a search of his flat in which a short wave radio and other incriminating evidence was found he was thought to have been a German spy. Although detained by the Bournemouth Police in August under the Defence Regulations he does not seem to have come to trial and apparently went to America. His replacement, Mr. R.H. Stovey, was appointed in July.

On 5th July Bournemouth found itself part of the South Coast Defence Area. The Order, bringing the Area into being, prohibited people entering the strip of land, roughly twenty miles deep, bounded by the coast on one hand and inland by a line drawn from Petersfield through to Romsey, Wimborne and Dorchester. This barred holiday makers and also anybody else from Bournemouth unless they had good reason for travelling to the town. People were able to travel out, but the Movement Restriction Order allowed entry only to those who were resident, or had business here. Travellers on trains had to produce identity cards to the Police on duty at the stations when leaving. Residents could travel as usual but those people not registered as local had to give convincing proof, or reasons, before they were allowed to stay. Reasons such as visiting the sick, evacuees, members of Government Departments moved to the town, or on business were accepted. Barricades were set up on main roads just inside the limits and buses and cars were stopped. Not even a tramp, or casual wayfarer as the Order called them, was allowed in. The chief object of the Movement Restriction Order was to keep the coastal zone free from visitors who might be enemy agents and who might hinder the defence preparations. Under Regulation 16a of the Defence Regulations from 5th July anybody without a permit from the local naval or military authority was not permitted to have access to beaches in Hampshire and parts of Dorset between sunset and sunrise. This included all tidal estuaries such as Christchurch and Poole Harbours. However this did not prohibit access to the cliffs. Restrictions were placed on travellers to Swanage by bus and car using the floating bridge at Sandbanks. Part of the area between the ferry and Studland Village became a prohibited zone. Therefore nobody could visit this area without a permit. Vehicles had to be escorted through it and pedestrians were no longer allowed to cross over the ferry. It was at this point that many local hoteliers realised that they could no longer carry on their businesses and closed their hotels. Subsequently many buildings were taken over by the Government for those Departments evacuated from London because of the bombing, For example the Home Office Aliens, Immigration and Nationality branches were moved to Bournemouth using the Hawthornes (now part of the Wessex Hotel), Trouville, Hydro (now flats), Meyrick Cliffs (demolished when the Bournemouth International Centre was built), and Rodborough Grange (now Wilton Grange Flats) as offices. Other hotels and boarding houses were used as billets for the staff. Rotherfell Court, Bodorgan Road, was one of them. Unfortunately on the night of 10th/11th April 1941 it received a direct hit, the landlady being fatally injured. The bomb did not explode straight away, but before it was made safe a second bomb dropped in the garden two days later and the resulting explosion set the first one off too, destroying the building.

It appeared to many people that the evacuation of large numbers of Civil Servants to Bournemouth

was the signal for the bombing of the town to start! Later on in November after approximately eighty Alerts since 3rd July, in which there had been twenty five incidents when bombs were dropped, the feeling was that before they had arrived things had been fairly quiet, but since then it had been the opposite! Even though bombs were not dropped every night the enemy bombers could be heard overflying the town. Some people thought that they were using Poole Harbour and Christchurch Harbour as navigational aids, but it was a system of VHF (very high frequency) radio beams, Knickebein, which intersected over the target. The bombers flew along one beam and released their bombs when the intersecting beam was reached. One of these beams was transmitted from the Cherbourg Peninsular and passed over Bournemouth so consequently every night the drone of German aircraft en route to targets in the Midlands and elsewhere could be heard, then several hours later again on their return. This also explained the random dropping of bombs from returning planes which had not reached their main target. In order to monitor the beam the RAF ran a mobile listening van along the sea front from Christchurch to Poole. When a German bomber made a forced landing on the beach near West Bay, Dorset, the secret radio equipment was discovered, and the scientists were able to design jamming equipment to deflect the beams and hamper their use. Unfortunately this did not happen until after the disastrous raid on Coventry, the German bombers coming in over Bournemouth and Christchurch. Later on RAF Southbourne at Hengistbury Head and another station at Worth Matravers, near Swanage, were operational sites for the "bending" equipment.

The German air offensive engendered the desire, by the civilian population, to hit back at the enemy aircraft which daily invaded the sky above Britain. At that time the Spitfire, rightly or wrongly, was being given the credit for being the victor of the Battle of Britain, so it appeared to the public as a symbol of retribution. All over the country, in counties, towns and villages, Spitfire Weeks were held to raise funds to purchase Spitfires for the Royal Air Force at the nominal sum of £5000 per plane. These aircraft were to be named after the county, town or area which collected the necessary amount. Critics of the idea pointed out that the planes would have been built in any case, and that the money collected could have been used to help those bombed out and injured. This may have been correct, but the public morale received a "boost" which was sorely needed.

The Hampshire Spitfire Fund was set up in August 1940. The publicity stated:

Hampshire Spitfire Fund

AIM: To buy a SPITFIRE or SPITFIRES to give to the Nation in honour of our brave airmen.

Towns and village are asked to set up Committees or appeal for Funds in other ways. Large towns are raising a Spitfire on their own - but every bit of Hampshire can take part in this glorious piece of war service and raise funds for one of the Hampshire Spitfires.

Is there a Spitfire Committee in your town or village? lf not find other patriots and get to work at once. We want every spot in Hampshire to take part in the great campaign.

Collecting-sheets, posters and further details may be obtained from:

Hon. Organiser - Dr. H. M. KING
109 Holdenhurst Rd
Bournemouth.

Gifts may be made to your local Committee or direct to the Hon. Organiser.

Help us to put our Hampshire Spitfires in the sky!

In all thirteen Spitfires were purchased by the people of the county. They were: Portsmouth 3, Southampton 3, New Forest 2, Bournemouth 2, Aldershot 1, Gosport 1 and Winchester 1.

Throughout the county, towns, including Bournemouth, and villages set up appeals for money. The Bournemouth Honorary Organiser, and one of the prime movers in the Hampshire Spitfire Fund, was Dr. Horace Maybray King. Dr. King was Head of the English Department of Taunton's School, Southampton, and came to Bournemouth when the School was evacuated at the outbreak of war in September 1939. A Doctor of Philosophy he was also a virtuoso on the piano and piano accordion, composing not only lively ballads, but also at least one Christmas Carol. The Hampshire Spitfire Song, of which he wrote both words and music, caught on and was played by many local bands. It was dedicated to "all British Airmen - especially Frank". This was WO Frank Tizzard of Parkstone, a former pupil of Taunton's School, who passed through the RAF Apprentice School at Holton, and served in Egypt before the war. He then trained as a pilot, flying on numerous raids over enemy territory, and was awarded the Distinguished Flying Medal in November 1940 for a particularly gallant raid on Italy early in the war. Unfortunately he was killed later on.

The song had the facility for towns which were buying a plane to substitute their name in the lyrics for that of Hampshire, e.g. "The Bournemouth planes are here" instead of "The Hampshire planes are here". There was even a Tyneside version which according to the local paper "made great strides". Over 10,000 copies were sold at 6d (2.5p) a copy, all profits going to the fund. It was even recorded by Joe Loss and his Band for HMV in January 1941. Dr. King presented all his royalties to the Bournemouth War Services Organisation. Dr. King also helped to start the V Amateur Concert Party which entertained the local troops in the town as well as on lonely gunsites "somewhere in Hampshire and Dorset". He was largely responsible, together with his wife, for the Evacuees' Club, which was started in Bournemouth in a house, 109 Holdenhurst Road (offices now occupy the site), so that parents and friends of the Southampton evacuees could meet the children in comfort and not have to rely on the people with whom the evacuees were billeted to provide somewhere. The Club was open every Sunday for the visiting parents, and also on Mondays for the Mothers who had been evacuated with their children to meet and chat together.

After the war Dr. King became Labour MP for the Test Division of Southampton. ln 1964 he was elected Deputy Speaker of the House of Commons, then on the death of Sir Harry Hylton Foster in November 1965 he became the Speaker, retiring in 1971. That same year he was made a Life Peer, taking the title Lord Maybray-King. He died on September 3rd 1986.

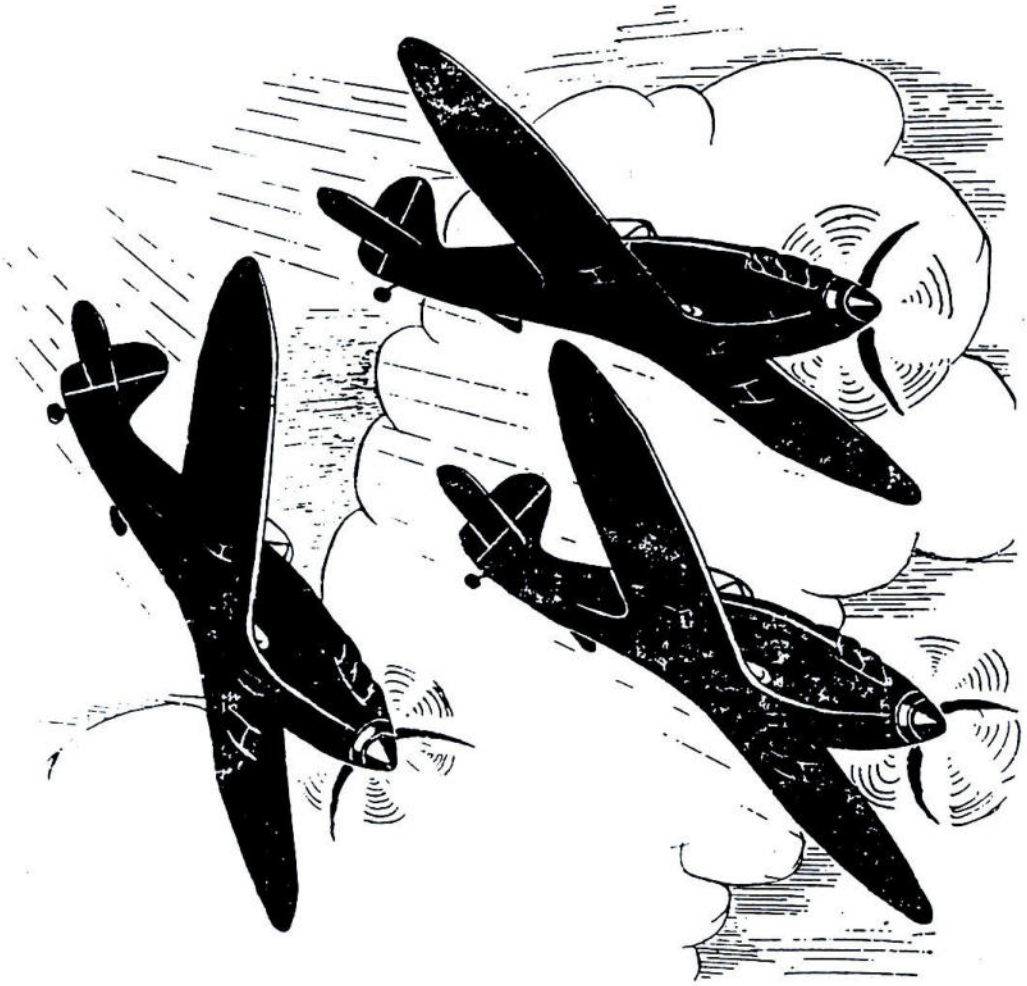
The first meeting in the campaign was held at St. Peter's Hall, Hinton Road, when Dr. King sang his Spitfire Song in public for the first time. The initial idea was to provide part of a Spitfire only. However concerts, dances and other entertainments were put on to raise money for the fund and these proved very popular. In September, for example, the Odeon Cinema (now the Bingo Hall) at the Lansdowne was lent free of all costs for a concert, and later in the month the Rink Ballroom in Westover Road held a Grand Ball and Concert.

Another fund raiser was a little booklet entitled "Two poem's, written by S.J.J. Wise. One poem was called "The Spitfire" and the other "The Immortal Emblem". This sold for 2d or more.

A shot down German plane also came to the aid of the fund. This was a Dornier Do17P bomber which had been on a photo-reconnaissance flight over Plymouth on August 27th. Attacked by fighters it had one engine disabled and was forced to land at Hurdwick Farm, near Tavistock, at 10.30 am. All the crew were captured unhurt. The plane was put on view at Dean Park Cricket Ground in early September, Bournemouth having received "very special treatment" in being allocated the Dornier. lt was brought from Tavistock by a fleet of RAF tenders with a special Police escort. As well as the German plane four Spitfires gave two aerial displays over Dean Park to the delight of the people visiting the exhibition. The Mayor, Alderman P.W.T. Hayward opened the exhibition on Friday, 5th September 1940, and over 2,500 people saw the aircraft on the first day raising £60 for the fund. Over £700 was raised that week. A novel fund raiser was the sale of three superseded Spitfire propellers, one being displayed in the Grand Parade Motor Showrooms at Westbourne.

The £5000 required for a plane was reached fairly quickly and "Bournemouth", a Mark 1 Spitfire

THE HAMPSHIRE SPITFIRE SONG



Words and Music
by
H. M. KING.

Price: SIXPENCE.

All profits on the sale of this song are for the "Hampshire Spitfire" Fund.

Dedicated to all British Airmen—especially Frank.

Cover drawn by
Master G. MEW.

The Hampshire Spitfire Song

(X4911) first flew on 29th December 1940. It went to 8 Maintenance Unit on 2nd January 1941 before joining a newly formed operational unit, 457 Squadron, at Baginton, near Coventry, on 22nd June. X4911 was transferred to 58 Operational Training Unit on 26th October 1941, where it was unfortunately written off in a flying accident on 16th March 1942.

More money was collected and with the help of the Borough of Eastleigh the £5,000 for a second plane was collected by the end of November, and the fund was wound up. However the £700 gift from Eastleigh was returned to enable that Borough to raise £1,000 and to contribute the money to the main Hampshire collection so that it would not be swamped in a much larger town's fund. The Bournemouth fund was then extended for three months. During that time enough money "trickled in" to reach the second £5,000. ln February 1941 Dr. King made the presentation to the Mayor, Alderman A.H. Little. The final figure was £ 10,300 16s 6d.

"Bournemouth Crest 11" a Mark V Spitfire (R7220) made its first flight on 18th March 1941 and survived the war, but only after sustaining damage several times. Starting at 38 Maintenance Unit on 21st March it was issued to 54 Squadron on 26th May, only to be damaged five days later. It was repaired and passed to a Canadian Squadron, 403, on 4th August. On operations on 26th October it was again damaged. Repaired once again the 8th January 1942 saw R7220 with 74 Squadron and then on 27th January with 332, the RAF's 2nd Norwegian Squadron. Passed on yet again to 164 Squadron on 15th April 1942 it collided with another Spitfire (X4238) in the air, and made a forced landing at Skae (Orkneys). Repaired it went on again to 60 Squadron, the United States Army Air Force, who flew it from Northern Ireland. On 7th July 1943 it passed to a Belgian Squadron, then in August to 58 Operartional Training Unit. Another accident occurred on 29th August, and although R7220 was repaired it became a non-flying instructional plane for the French Air Force.

Bournemouth was not the only local town to fund a Spitfire. In Dorset, Poole as well as the Bridport and Beaminster district collected the necessary amounts. "The Brit", a Mark 1 Spitfire (R7062) named after the river at Bridport, only flew for just under a year. Operational in May 1941 it was involved in a flying accident whilst with 57 Operational Training Unit in December 1941 and was written off.

The Poole Spitfire, "Villae de Poole", was also a Mark 1 (R7126) and had a similar length of life. It flew first on 14th February 1941, then went to 9 Maintenance Unit, passing to 57 Operational Training Unit on 14th August. However on 7th December 1941 it crashed during a snowstorm at Park Gate Road, Chester, killing its pilot. The plane was a total loss.

Both the Bournemouth Spitfires bore the Borough's Coat of Arms, transfers being supplied by the Borough Transport Department to Dr. King. He sent them to the Ministry of Aircraft Production, who arranged to have them placed on the aircraft just below the cockpit.

In August 1941 a commemorative plaque from the Ministry of Aircraft Production was presented to the Mayor, Alderman A.H. Little, as recognition of the efforts Bournemouthians had made in providing two Spitfires. The inscription read "In the hour of peril the people of Bournemouth earned the gratitude of the British nation, sustaining the valour of the Royal Air Force, and fortifying the cause of freedom by the gift of Spitfire aircraft" . There was also the quotation "They shall mount up with wings as eagles".

The story of the Spitfire and its designer, R. J. Mitchell, was made into a film, "The First of the Few", with Leslie Howard playing the leading role. Some of the filming was done at the Ibsley fighter station and Leslie Howard visited Bournemouth several times.

Another shot down German plane went on view to the public in November. A Messerschmitt 109 was displayed in premises lent by Boots the Chemist in Post Office Road in aid of the Disabled Soldier and Sailors Workshop at Winton which was in financial difficulties.

A miraculous escape occurred when bombs were dropped on Alyth and Huntley Roads on Saturday 10th August at 11.15 at night. 47 Alyth Road received a direct hit, and Mrs. Thornley, the wife of the owner, was buried in the rubble under an upturned bath. She was trapped for an hour before rescuers could release her. Eleven bombs were dropped, several fell in gardens or on allotments.
Two more houses were badly damaged, and nineteen others slightly.

The next day a Hurricane of 145 Squadron was damaged whilst attacking German bombers south of Swanage, but the pilot managed to make a forced landing near Christchurch. Tuesday 13th August saw Hurricanes shoot down a Messerschmitt Bf 110D, which crashed in the sea two miles west of Bournemouth at 11.50 am. One member of the crew was killed and the other, rescued from the sea, was wounded. Another German airman from a Bf 109E was captured when his fighter was shot down over Bournemouth and crashed into Poole Harbour. A Hurricane pilot had to bale out when his fighter was shot down into Christchurch Bay by a Dornier Do 17 at 7 am on August 14th. He was rescued unhurt.

Two Old Bournemouthians fought in the Battle of Britain. Flight Lieutenant Ivor Henry Cosby flew with 610 and 72 Squadrons, sharing in the destruction of a Bf 109 on 23rd September. He was awarded the DFC in 1944 being credited with shooting down four enemy aircraft. He survived the war, retiring in 1976 as a Wing Commander. Sgt. Pilot William Claude Wills flew with 3 Squadron in July 1940, and then with 73 Squadron in September. ln November he went to North Africa where his Hurricane was shot down by anti-aircraft fire on 12th April 1941 after an attack on a convoy of enemy vehicles. He is buried in Knightsbridge War Cemetery, Acroma, Libya.

Thursday 15th August 1940 was called by the Germans "Der schwarze Donnerstag" (Black Thursday). It has been described as the hardest fought day during the Battle of Britain when the Luftwaffe lost seventy six aircraft and some of their crews.

On that day the sirens sounded the Alert at 5.20 pm as German bombers, heavily escorted by Messerschmitt Bf 109 flew over the town, the All Clear being given at 7.30 pm. It was during this raid that the only Allied airman to die in action over Bournemouth was killed. Pilot Officer Cecil Henry Hight, aged 22, a New Zealander serving with the RAF as a fighter pilot of 234 Squadron from Middle Wallop, Wiltshire, was shot down whilst attacking the large formation of enemy aircraft.

Horrified people watched as his plane nosedived towards the ground from about 5,000 feet. Pilot Officer Hight managed to bail out but he was badly wounded and unable to pull the ripcord of his parachute. His body was found in the garden of "Hambledon", Leven Avenue. The owner, Mr. Alfred K. Hoare, a retired builder, said that he and his wife had taken shelter at the warning and then they had heard a loud noise outside. The Police and rescue workers arrived, and told Mr. Hoare that a plane had crashed at the corner of Leven Avenue and Walsford Road. A search was made for the pilot and he was eventually located under a privet hedge not fifty yards from where his Spitfire R6988 had crashed at 5.46 pm making a large crater and scattering wreckage over the immediate area. Part of the rudder had already broken off during the plane's descent and other wreckage had fallen near the town centre. One wing was found on top of a hedge in Walsford Road, The plane was a complete "write-off". A rumour sprang up that had the pilot stayed with his machine he would have survived because the plane had "landed on a carpet of pine needles". The report in the local paper does say that according to an eyewitness the plane "landed flat", but other accounts state that the plane was very badly damaged and made a large crater. Canon Hedley Burrows, the Vicar of St. Peter's, arrived at Leven Avenue just before the body of Pilot Officer Hight was found. Ian MacQueen in his "Bournemouth St. Peter's" quotes Canon Burrows "A few seconds later the Police located the body of the pilot on the other side of Mr. and Mrs. Hoare's house and I said a prayer for him in the garden where he lay". On that spot the owners of the house planted a memorial garden and tended it with great care. Then on 14th November 1940 at 11.35 pm a bomb landed on "Hambledon" killing Mr. Hoare and trapping his wife in the debris of the wrecked house. However, the garden of remembrance was not damaged, and for sometime afterwards local people continued to care for it.

The funeral of Pilot Officer Hight, with full military honours, took place in the War Graves plot in Boscombe Cemetery on Monday 19th August, Canon Burrows conducting the service. Six RAF Sergeants bore the coffin draped with the Union Jack and the flag of New Zealand. This had been sent to Christchurch from Christchurch, New Zealand, in 1938 when greetings were exchanged between the towns. The RAF also provided a firing party who discharged three volleys over the grave. Amongst the wreaths and flowers was one bunch "From the garden where this hero fell".

A memorial service was held at St. Peter's on April 7th 1943, at which a plaque to his memory

was unveiled in the Church by the High Commissioner for New Zealand. The memorial, Air Force Wings carved in wood from the Kauri, the hardest of all New Zealand trees, was made by pupils of Pilot Officer Hight's old school, Stratford Technical High School, North Island. The service was attended by the Mayor and Mayoress, men from the RAF, and the New Zealand, Australian and Canadian Air Forces, as well as many organisations in the town. The service was broadcast live to New Zealand and was heard by Pilot Officer Hight's mother. Another memorial to Pilot Officer Hight can be found on a housing estate at Kinson. There a road, "Pilot Hight Road" has been named after him.

Bournemouth nurses were able to help Flight Lieutenant J.B. Nicolson, the only Battle of Britain VC, when his Hurricane was shot down on August 16th. Three nursing sisters, together with a doctor, were travelling from “Roseneath", the first aid station, Durley Road, to another in Southampton, when they saw Flight Lieutenant Nicolson parachuting down from his blazing plane. Although badly burnt and wounded he had shot down his adversary only to be fired at by an overzealous Home Guard when he was landing. One of the nurses, seeing how injured he was and also how he had been peppered with shotgun pellets, gave an injection of morphine then went with him to the Royal Southampton Hospital in a makeshift ambulance.

A German communique broadcast on Sunday 18th August boasted that the "harbour works at Bournemouth" had been destroyed. This referred to a raid on Poole on Friday 16th in which a Junkers Ju 87B had been shot down in Poole Harbour.

On the 21st at 10.50 am, Christchurch Road, Madison Avenue and Walpole Road were machine gunned by a lone raider, but only slight damage occurred and there were no casualties. Later on the same day at 4.59 pm seven high explosive bombs were jettisoned by a German bomber which was being attacked by Spitfires. They fell on Keswick Road, Chessel Avenue and Beechwood Avenue. Two houses were demolished and the ARP Headquarters at Shelley Park was extensively damaged. In all one hundred and ten properties were involved. One man died of shock, five were taken to hospital and twelve others received first aid. West Howe was the target on 25th August at 4.32 am when forty five houses were damaged when two bombs fell. The raider then went on to attack Poole. Just after 11 o'clock (11.17 pm) thirty incendiary bombs fell on waste ground at Iford and Tuckton. There were no casualties and only six properties were slightly damaged by fire. Early in the morning of 29th August at 1.30 am a high explosive bomb fractured a water main in the Broadway, Southbourne. Others left craters in the field around Wicklea Road and at Muckleshell Farm. One bomb landed in High Howe Lane where fifty one houses were damaged but nobody was hurt. However the next incident which occurred at 9.55 pm on 2nd September cost three lives and five injured when seven bombs were dropped on Seabourne Road, Southville Road and Christchurch Road at Pokesdown. Three shops were hit, two houses destroyed and in all one hundred and seventy three properties were damaged. This had been a sneak raid, the plane had managed to evade the warning system so no sirens had been sounded.

During September the sirens sounded twenty eight times. On some occasions there were two during one day. In fact on the 15th there were three. However bombs were dropped in only eight. Many Alerts were caused by the German bomber stream passing on their way to attack targets in the Midlands.

The railway line by Surrey Road South was hit by a high explosive bomb at 5.40 am on 4th September. Fitted with a delayed action fuse it did not explode at once, but when it did it caused a crater on the top of an embankment about 200 yards from the West Station. Rails were damaged for about thirty yards and the train service had to be suspended. After repair work had been carried out the service was able to run normally the next day. The gas and water mains were also cut and seven houses had superficial damage. A petrol bomb was dropped as well, and this fell in the back garden of a newsagents shop in Westbourne. Luckily it failed to ignite.

Westbourne was hit again on the 5th September at 00.15 am when five bombs were dropped, 2 and 8 Burnaby Road receiving direct hits. There was damage to seventeen other houses and in Alum Chine one bomb fell on the beach damaging a sewer. The Alert had been sounded at 9.30 pm and

went on until 1.30 am the next morning. Theatre patrons and cinema goers were informed that they could stay until the All Clear and in the largest cinemas extra films were shown. However, many people decided to walk home as the buses had been suspended because of the raid. A dance in aid of the Spitfire fund which was to have finished at 11 o'clock continued for several hours, the majority of the dancers enjoying the unexpected bonus.

The Durley Chine area was attacked at 12.43 am on 6th September when four bombs were dropped but there were no casualties or any damage. Hawkwood Road, Boscombe, was the next target at 1.20 am on 13th September. This time twenty four houses were damaged by a high explosive bomb. The next day, Saturday, at 5.50 pm two bombs fell, one wrecking a house, 40 Crabton Close Road, killing four people. Eleven more were injured and one hundred and forty three homes damaged, especially in Wilfred Road and Chessel Avenue. The ARP Headquarters at Shelley Park was again damaged. This was the second raid on this area, for just over three week before on 21st August Chessel and Beechwood Avenues, plus Keswick Road, had been bombed.

On July 16th Hitler had signed his Directive No 16 Seelowe (Operation Sea Lion) for the invasion of England. The German Navy started preparations along the French Coast collecting barges to transport the German Army across the Channel. These were heavily attacked by RAF bombers, some flown by Bournemouthians. Then on the 7th September the code word "Cromwell" was sent out by the British High Command indicating that the invasion was imminent, probably within twelve hours. All branches of the Forces were put on instant readiness and those units on the South Coast were sent to the defences. Locally the newly prepared pill boxes, trenches and gun positions were manned by the units of the Bournemouth Garrison. 2,600 Home Guards were mobilised and they too occupied the defences along the cliffs and promenades. The plan was to hold the chines and cliffs for an hour against the invaders to give the Canadians stationed on Salisbury Plain time to deploy. The Home Guard had only enough guns and little ammunition to arm one out of three! They remained at their battle stations for three days.

There had been a report that a seven mile long convoy was heading towards the Hampshire and Dorset coasts, but this was just a figment of someone's imagination. There was even a rumour that the invasion had been thwarted and that bodies of German soldiers had been washed up on the beaches. When it was discovered that nothing was happening the troops were stood down. At the time to avoid undue alarm the church bells were not rung nor were loud speaker vans sent round the streets warning the inhabitants. Church bells were only to be rung if more than twenty five parachutists were seen to land. Hitler later postponed the invasion, his intention being to consider it again in the Spring or early Summer of 1941.

172 Battery at Hengistbury Head was completed at about this time. It had two 4 inch guns which dated from the First World War, and some equally ancient searchlights. Its HQ was at 34 Dalmeny Road. These guns were eventually replaced by 5.5 inch ones. This Battery was part of 554 Coast Regiment Royal Artillery, which also included 347 Battery on Brownsea Island,175 at Mudeford and 386 at Swanage. The Headquarters of 554 was at "Conningtower" West Road, Canford Cliffs.

The "City of Benares", the flagship of Ellerman's City Lines, left Liverpool on Friday 13th September carrying a crew of 215 and 191 passengers. Amongst the passengers were ninety children and nine people who were travelling with them as escorts, who were being evacuated to Canada. At about 10 o'clock on the night of September 17th the "City of Benares" was torpedoed by the German submarine U48 under the command of Kapitänleutenant Heinrich Bleichrodt. The ship sank rapidly in rough seas and the crew had difficulty in lowering the lifeboats. Some capsized in the heavy seas and others shipped vast quantities of water. A large number of people succumbed to exposure and in all 248, including seventy seven children and five escorts, died. Many of the survivors were picked up by the destroyer HMS Hurricane, whilst one lifeboat drifted for eight days before being spotted by a Sunderland flying boat of the Royal Australian Air Force. A destroyer, HMS Anthony, was guided to the lifeboat by another Sunderland and rescued the forty six survivors in it. Amongst the adults was Mary Cornish, a music teacher from Sandecotes School, Poole, who kept the children entertained by telling them stories. One of the six children in the lifeboat was Paul Shearing (12½) from

Bournemouth. Unfortunately the other Bournemouth child on the "City of Benares", Jean Forster (10), was lost. Paul arrived back home on Friday 18th October and on Wednesday 6th November at the Odeon Cinema the Mayor, Alderman P.W.T. Hayward, presented him with a copy of the newsreel showing the rescued children arriving back on HMS Anthony.

Holdenhurst Village received a visit from the Luftwaffe just before 1 am on Sunday 22nd September. Considerable damage was done to the Vicarage when two bombs fell in the field next to the house. Fortunately none of the eight people inside were hurt. Six more bombs were dropped in Holdenhurst and Throop. One man was killed by a bomb splinter and twenty two houses were damaged as well as the Vicarage and Holdenhurst School.

At midday on Wednesday 25th September watchers on the ground saw a Heinkel He 111H, one of about twenty which were returning from a raid on the Bristol Aero Works at Filton chased at low level over Bournemouth to Poole. The plane had already been hit in the port engine and was attacked again by Spitfires of 609 Squadron. All but one member of the crew abandoned the burning aircraft which crashed at 12.09 pm in the garden of "Underwood", Westminster Road, Branksome Park, where it set the house alight and burnt itself out. One crewman parachuted into the sea off Branksome Chine and was captured unhurt. The Echo reported "A short, ugly, broad-chested Nazi airman ... was being hoisted by the military into a truck to be taken away". The others who bailed out were found to be dead, whilst the airman who stayed with the plane was killed in the crash. The following morning at Westminster Road collectors for the local Spitfire Fund charged those who came to view the damage one penny a look. "Underwood" was damaged again, this time by a bomb on 12th August 1943. After the war it was demolished and "Chatsworth", a block of flats, was built on the site.

At 11.30 am on September 30th a Hurricane (P3655) of 56 Squadron crashed following a dog fight with Bf 109 and Bf 110s over the town, the pilot being severely wounded. Another RAF fighter, a Spitfire, made a forced landing on Parley Common on October 5th. The pilot of this aircraft escaped unhurt.

October started quietly for it was not until 5.50 am on the 12th that a high explosive bomb fell on Bath Road. There were no casualties, but three houses were hit. The previous day the Cornelia Hospital and other properties in Poole had been attacked and the Bournemouth Fire Brigade had been sent to provide support for the Poole Brigade.

Earlier on the morning of Wednesday October 9th a soldier on patrol along the Southbourne Undercliff Drive near the Gordon Steps saw a body floating in the sea about thirty yards from the beach. It was brought ashore and found to be that of a sailor. Later on he was identified as Francis W.G. Jeffries, a Royal Navy Stoker from HMS Recoil, an armed trawler, lost on patrol in Lyme Bay presumably by hitting a mine on either the 27th or 28th September with the loss of all hands. The headstone on his grave in the War Plot at the East Cemetery gives his date of death as 27th September, whilst records state that the Recoil was sunk on the 28th.

The West Station was the German target at 3 pm of 14th October. The West Station Garage was completely demolished and seventy three other buildings damaged by the blast from four bombs. Parts of a car were hurled into the air and a large dynamo used in the garage landed in a garden near the Royal Victoria Hospital in Poole Road. One report suggested that it was in fact a large fan which had fallen so that the blades looked like the tail fins of a bomb protruding from the earth. A Policeman checking the area thought it was a bomb and the Hospital and the adjoining houses were evacuated. The Poole Road was also closed until the Bomb Disposal Unit had checked it. Four people were injured.

The next day a man was taken to hospital after being hit by machine gun bullets while standing in his front garden watching a dog fight over the town between twelve enemy planes and several RAF fighters. This dangerous practice was called "goofing" but it was done by many, the cliffs being a favourite place to stand and watch the aerial fights over the sea. On the same day two aircraft came down in the Bay and the Poole lifeboat was launched to rescue the crews, whilst a Me 110 was reported to have crashed near Bournemouth, shot down by Spitfires of 609 Squadron from Warmwell.

A week later on the 21st at 4.39 pm without any warning being sounded the Springbourne and

Queen's Park area were attacked in a hit and run raid. The plane dropped a stick of ten high explosive bombs, one of which fell on the House of Bethany Orphanage next to St. Clement's Church. Two Sisters of Bethany, the Religious Order running the children's home, were seriously injured and taken to hospital, one dying the next day. A number of girls, all between fourteen and eighteen escaped unhurt. The damage was not repaired for ten years, the shattered roof and walls having tarpaulins over them to keep out the weather. However the restoration was carried out in 1950.

Houses in Shaftesbury, Avon, Spencer and Moorland Roads, and Queen's Park Gardens were also damaged, 24 and 26 Shaftesbury Road being completely destroyed. In all five people were seriously injured, five slightly and two hundred and twelve properties damaged. After this raid there was a lull in the bombing for nearly three weeks, but this did not mean that the daily wail of the siren was absent. Nearly every day and sometimes twice, especially after dark the engines of the enemy planes on their way to, and returning from, attacking targets inland could be heard.

Tired and exhausted firemen arrived in October from blitzed London for a well earned rest, their places being taken by forty Bournemouth firemen. These London firemen were the first of several parties who came for rest and recuperation. Whilst they were here the Londoners were given hospitality by many people including the Mayor. He received the following letter dated 18th October from the Chief Fire Officer, London Fire Brigade Headquarters:-

> "My Dear Mayor,
>
> I write to express my thanks to you for the kindness shown by Bournemouth to the AFS men from London. They had a most enjoyable time and are very grateful for this rest afforded them and for the general hospitality with which they were treated during their stay. We were very pleased to have the men from Bournemouth as our guests and hope that they found their short stay interesting and instructive. I feel sure that the arrangements made will be of the utmost value to both parties".

Other parties were exchanged in November.

November's first raid occurred on Saturday 9th. At 10.15 pm ten high explosive bombs were dropped on Knyveton and Vale Roads killing four people, one a five month old baby. Incendiary bombs fell on the East Cliff around the Meyrick and Gervis Road junction. Most landed in the road or in gardens and were dealt with by the ARP. Only slight damage was done to an unoccupied hotel. However one hundred and nine houses were damaged and four people injured. It was reported that the plane which dropped the bombs had been flying to and fro over the town for some time and as its engines had not sounded in the usual way associated with German aircraft nobody had taken much notice of it. No Alert had been sounded so it was assumed to be friendly. Afterwards the Italian Air Force was thought to be responsible.

The next night, 10th November, at 9.01 pm, there was another incendiary raid, this time on Southbourne. Again many of the bombs fell on open ground, roads and gardens so that only slight damage to ten properties was caused and there were no casualties. The ARP Headquarters at Shelley Park suffered slightly again. Douglas House, the British Legion convalescent home, now demolished, in which the one hundred and thirty patients had just gone to bed had seven incendiaries in in grounds. On 14th November at 11.35 pm the Terrace Road area was hit, and so was Leven Avenue, by twelve high explosive bombs. Three hundred and seventy two houses were damaged, eight people injured and five killed, four from one family. Also killed was Mr. Alfred J. Hoare when his house "Hambledon", in Leven Avenue, was destroyed. It was in the garden of "Hambledon" that Pilot Officer Hight's body was found after his Spitfire was shot down on August 15th. Earlier in the day a Junkers 88A-5 bomber flying over West Howe had been attacked by Spitfires of 152 Squadron. The plane crashed at the rear of Moor's Garage on the corner of Herbert Avenue and Ringwood Road, Poole. It exploded as it hit the ground and all the crew aboard were killed. One member, who had managed to bail out, was found in the Kinson Pottery works in Ringwood Road after plunging through the corrugated iron roof and two floors of the building. Several people in nearby houses were hurt but nobody was killed.

The Echo, 16th November, had as its headline "Raid devastation in South Coast town. Vicious attack in the early hours". This was the worst raid on Bournemouth so far. At 3.30 am enemy bombers circled the town dropping flares, then six parachute mines and a large number of incendiaries. These fell in three separate areas causing damage to 2,321 properties, including two churches, a chapel and three schools. Many of the houses were so badly damaged that they had to be demolished. At Westbourne six houses were destroyed and six required demolition. In the St. Leonards Road area sixteen were destroyed and twenty nine had to be pulled down, whilst around Alma Road ten needed demolition. There were fifty three people killed and over one hundred and fifty injured.

The Alma Road Elementary School, formally opened on 26th March 1908 received a direct hit from a land mine. It consisted of two buildings, the Boys and Girls Department being two storeys and the Infants a separate one storey block. The two storey block was completely destroyed whilst the Infants School was so badly damaged that it could not the used again. Also seven houses in King's Road were damaged beyond repair and demolished.

When the rubble of the Infants School was cleared away the exterior walls, where sound, were left at a height of four feet. On these the new School was erected after the war, whilst the empty sites in King's Road became a small sports ground. On the other side of Alma Road the new Senior Girls School, which had only just been opened was also damaged.

The Avenue Methodist Church in Fitzharris Avenue was hit by the blast, its windows blown out as well as losing most of the roof tiles. Whilst repairs were carried out the Services and Sunday School were held in St. Luke's Church Hall through the kindness of the Vicar and Parishioners. The blast also turned the weather vane on top of the Plaza Cinema (now demolished) on the corner of Alma Road and Wimborne Road so that the indicators pointed to the opposite points of the compass.

The Council School in R.L. Stevenson Avenue suffered damage to its roof and St. Andrew's Church of England School, Malmesbury Park, received some slight damage, but St. Andrew's Church, Bennett Road, had some of its windows blown out and damage to its roof. Christ Church, Westbourne lost its East window of stained glass as well as the North one and several smaller panes. However it was the residential areas which suffered most. Many people found themselves homeless and without clothes and had to take refuge in centres set up for air raid victims . One rest centre was opened at the YMCA in Jameson Road, Winton, and hot drink, food, clothing and money were made available to those people who had been bombed out. Then temporary accommodation was provided. Those houses which could be made habitable quickly had builders working on them the next day. The Town Council, after the Chairman of the Air Raid Precautions Committee had presented a report to them on the incident, "expressed their most cordial thanks to all the services concerned for the manner in which they carried out their respective duties".

St. Leonards Road and Malmesbury Park Road were devastated and so were parts of Westbourne. There a row of apartment houses in R.L. Stevenson Avenue was hit, some being completely destroyed and rescue workers had to dig survivors out of the rubble. Twelve people were killed in one house and nine in another. Eleven servicemen of the lst Battalion East Surrey Regiment were killed when their billet at 4 Denewood Road was demolished. In Alum Chine Road "Skerryvore" the home of R.L.Stevenson from 1885 to 1887, was very badly damaged. After inspection by a panel of Architects from the Ministry of Works, who decided that its restoration and preservation as a house of national interest was not warranted, it was demolished in November 1941. The plot was not redeveloped and was bought by the Borough Council on 27th August 1954. Later a memorial garden was created and opened in April 1957, the footings of the house being marked out and a model of Skerryvore Lighthouse erected. The original suggestion that the site should be made Bournemouth's memorial to the famous author came from Mr. Clive Holland, son of Mr. T.J. Hankinson, Bournemouth's first Mayor, who was a frequent visitor to "Skerryvore".

As well as the mines many incendiary bombs were dropped. Aid from Poole and Christchurch Fire Services was provided, as well as rescue and first aid teams. In all thirteen Rescue Parties, four Mobile Units, fifteen First Aid Parties and nineteen Ambulances attended. Windows of many houses in the area were broken and the glass roof of Westbourne Arcade was extensively damaged. Shop windows

were blown out and their displays scattered in the road. Offices for enquiries regarding casualties were set up in Rumsey and Rumsey's premises in Poole Road and also at Dr. Postlethwaite's in St. Leonards Road.

This raid was also attributed to the Italian Air Force. A Home Guard on duty at the Moordown Bus Depot reported that, as it was a clear moonlight night, he had seen a low flying plane with Italian markings and had opened fire on it with his rifle just before the land mine had fallen on the Alma Road Schools. Lord Haw Haw later apologised for the land mines saying that they were dropped on the wrong town by mistake!

At the funerals of those killed the Union Flag was draped over the coffins in accordance with a Government directive. Later Circular 35 from the Ministry of Health, dated 19th March 1948, authorised local authorities to erect permanent headstones to replace the wooden crosses originally put on the graves of civilians killed by enemy action who had been buried by the local authority. The Town Clerk wrote to the relatives of twenty four of the twenty nine civilians buried in the town's cemeteries giving them the choice between two designs of headstone. The relatives were also able to suggest an inscription to be carved on the stone. The other five graves had already been permanently marked by private memorials erected by relatives. All the other casualties had been buried privately by relatives at their own expense. With three schools being out of use arrangements were made for the pupils at Westbourne Council school to attend St. Michael's Church of England School, whilst Alma Road Infants shared Malmesbury Park Infants with alternate sessions. Alma Road Senior Girls shared with Portchester Road Senior Boys and Alma Road Juniors with Malmesbury Park Juniors.

The Anglo-Swiss Hotel, Gervis Road, was accused of being anti-semitic in November. A question was asked in the House of Commons regarding hotels which had issued advertisements announcing that they did not cater for members of the Semitic race, and naming the Anglo-Swiss. The Managing Director said that the notice was intended to inform visitors that Kosher cooking was not available. It was not to prevent Jewish guests staying at the hotel, in fact there were several in residence.

On Tuesday 19th November the Echo reported that an unexploded bomb had been found in the garden of a house in Ashley Road. Probably it had been jettisoned by a returning German bomber in the early hours of the morning. Some of the wards in Boscombe Hospital were evacuated as a precaution before the Bomb Disposal Squad dealt with it. Later at 8.12 pm the same day two high explosive bombs were dropped in Montague and Southern Roads, damaging seventeen properties but with no casualties. Several others fell in the sea.

After a heavy raid at Southampton on 23rd November the Bournemouth Fire Brigade, plus rescue teams, went to the assistance of the local hard pressed teams, joining a convoy of similar crews from Poole. Paradoxically though Bournemouth was part of the defence area and visitors were banned it was still a reception centre. So towards the end of the month one hundred and fifty people from bombed areas arrived and were found billets. The Mayor also arranged the collection of clothes and household goods for those bombed out in the major cities. Then in December one hundred and forty survivors from Southampton came to be housed. Most were provided with transport supplied by volunteers, however before it arrived some started walking the thirty miles, covering half the distance on foot and reaching Lymington before being picked up by cars which brought them to Bournemouth. Most were found beds at the reception centres for the homeless before they were billeted in more permanent accommodation.

The new airfield at Hurn was attacked on 3rd December at 6 pm with five high explosive bombs and incendiaries. These were dealt with by the RAF fire crews. During December the only incident in which damage was done in Bournemouth happened on the 21st. Bombs were dropped in the Iford Bridge area of Christchurch causing blast damage in Old Bridge Road and Castle Lane. Most of the damage was on the Christchurch side of the river, Jumpers House being partly demolished and properties in Oak and Cedar Avenues hit. Twenty one houses on the Bournemouth side were damaged, one person was seriously injured and eighteen slightly injured.

The next day craters were discovered on either side of the Bridge and were thought to contain unexploded bombs. Iford Bridge was closed and the Bomb Disposal Team called in. By lunch time

the area was declared safe and the Bridge re-opened to traffic. The Luftwaffe did not have it all its own way as anti-aircraft gunners on the cliffs claimed two planes, one of which crashed in the sea off Hengistbury Head on lst December.

On Thursday, 5th December, the United Churches' National Services Club was established at the Queen Hotel at the Lansdowne, now Jacey House. It was made possible by Sir Alexander MacLean and promoted by forty one local churches. Originally the idea had been to build a club at the rear of the Hants and Dorset bus station in Exeter Road, but the conversion of an existing building was thought to be a better idea. First of all the Queen's Hall, Bath Road, was suggested; however this was considered to be too small, and so the Queen Hotel was taken over. The Club occupied the whole of the building, and had a canteen plus rest rooms for the men and women of the Forces. There were also writing and recreation rooms, whilst for the ATS, WRAF and WRENS a workroom was provided where they could sew or knit. Space was also provided for a Chapel dedicated to St. George of England. A weekly programme of entertainments was provided to stave off the boredom felt by a great many Servicemen. Sir James Marchant originally thought of the Club and Sir Alexander promised the money, the running of the Club being managed by a Committee representing all the Churches. Money was also provided to purchase ten mobile canteens for the Forces, two to be operated in Bournemouth. These canteens were also used to supply refreshments to Civil Defence workers engaged on long hours of rescue, fire, first aid, warden or demolition work, and were run and maintained by the WVS on behalf of the Corporation. They were handed over on Thursday 13th March at a ceremony outside the Town Hall. The Church Army also provided a mobile canteen for the troops in the local area as did the YMCA and the Catholic Women's League. The British Red Cross organised a number of mobile parties trained in first aid and equipped with a vehicle, rations and first aid supplies to supplement the ARP parties.

Other Forces Clubs opened all over the town. The Theatre Royal in Albert Road had been converted into a Servicemen's Club with a canteen and opened on 29th March. Originally only the entrance hall lounge and several other rooms were used, but these were extended to include the stage where the first entertainment for the troops was put on in early June. At first there were ten WVS members to staff the canteen, however by March 1941 no fewer than three hundred and twenty worked shifts in two canteens, the Library and offering help to the Servicemen. Other Clubs were at the Richmond Hill Congregational Church House, St. Stephen's Road; Wesley Church, Holdenhurst Road; Punshon Memorial Church, Richmond Hill and a number of other Church Halls. The Church Army opened a canteen and Institute for the Forces at the Wilberforce Hall, Holdenhurst Road, in January 1941.

With Christmas approaching the news that the ban on visitors to the town and Poole and Christchurch had been unofficially lifted early in December was received by the hotels and boarding houses still open with great relief. Even though the Christmas holiday was a quiet restful time the hotels were well filled. Closing times for shops were fixed at 6 pm Monday to Friday and 7.30 pm on Saturdays during the month. Gifts for Christmas tended towards the practical. Comforts for the troops on active service and shelter gifts for those at home. Sleeping bags, cards and games to while away the long winter evenings, Thermos flasks and cups and saucers and plates made of unbreakable bakelite were extremely popular.

Three thousand Christmas parcels were despatched by the Bournemouth War Services Organisation to local men and women in the Services. Local people invited members of the Forces stationed locally and away from home into their homes treating them as family. Many Canadians from camps in Hampshire and Dorset were put up for the two days of Christmas under these arrangements. Christmas meals were provided in many of the Services Clubs in the town and on Christmas Day itself nearly two thousand visited the Theatre Royal Club. The evacuees were given parties and entertainments. Soldiers stationed in the town provided a Christmas party at the Westbrook Hotel, Boscombe, for eighty poor children. Dick Whittington was the panto at the Pavilion and on Christmas Day the Regent, Westover, Carlton, Grand and Odeon cinemas opened. The church bells were silent as their ringing was to be the warning of an invasion by parachutists. People in the news included

Bournemouth's M.P. Sir Henry Page Croft, who was elevated to the Peerage in May taking the title Lord Croft of Bournemouth. He was succeeded by Sir Leonard Lyle who was the local M.P. until 1945 when he was made a Baron, being replaced by Brendan Bracken.

Richard Austin resigned as Musical Director to the Corporation in April because of his disagreement with them over the further reduction of the Municipal Orchestra to twenty four musicians and no summer symphony concerts. The Orchestra had already been cut from sixty one to thirty five when the war broke. Montague Birch was appointed Musical Director in his place. He was also the composer of "The Carabiniers: the Home Guard March". This was performed for the first time at the Home Guard Social Club Concert held at the Pavilion on Monday 11th November. It was played by the Home Guard Band consisting mainly of members of the Municipal Orchestra serving in the Home Guard and augmented by other members of the Orchestra.

The first Victoria Cross of the war to be won in Africa was awarded during the year to Lieutenant (Acting Captain) Eric Charles Twelves Wilson who had been educated at Gorsecliff School and whose father, the Rev. C.C. Wilson, had lived at "West Haye", St. Anthony's Road when he was Assistant Curate at Holy Trinity from 1906 to 1909. Captain Wilson, The East Surrey Regiment, attached to the Somali Mounted Infantry, although suffering from malaria and the effects of a wound, fought in the battle of Observation Hill in Somaliland from 11th to 15th August 1940 in which he kept a machine-gun post in action holding off the enemy's advance despite several of his guns being destroyed by artillery fire. Initially he was reported killed and the award was made posthumously, but eventually he was found to be a prisoner of war in Italian hands, being freed when Eritrea was conquered in 1941.

Chapter Three

1941

The siren wailed for the one hundred and seventy fifth time on 3rd January, the first Alert for 1941 which lasted from 6.40 pm to 0.41 am the next morning, but the bombers did not visit the town until March. However, on Saturday 22nd February a Heinkel He 111H of 4KG 27 was brought down by fighters near Avonmouth. Painted on the nose was a list of towns to which it had been flown on bombing raids, the last name being "Bournemouth" with a bomb symbol next to it. No bombs had fallen on the town for some time, but there is a possibility that this referred to a severe raid on Poole on 9th January when Bournemouth had been the alternative target for the Heinkels of 4KG 27.

The threat of incendiary bomb raids became greater after the experiences of London and other large towns, so to combat the danger a plan for fire-watchers was made for the centre of the town by the Bournemouth Chamber of Trade. Beales had already made their own arrangements for the nineteen male members of staff to take turns in keeping watch at night at the store since June 1940. These watchers did the job voluntarily having time off in lieu, generally given during the day after a night duty. Two people were on duty every night including Sundays, on a rota of four hours on and four hours off, patrolling the roof and floors of the building.

Under the Chamber's plan the shopping districts were divided into twenty three areas, each having a representative who acted as a link between themselves and the Fire Brigade. Small firms got together to either pay a fire-watcher or to arrange a rota amongst themselves.

Then in January the Ministry of Home Security made the Fire Precaution (Business Premises) Order. Under this the Bournemouth Corporation was required to make arrangements for fighting fires in business and industrial areas, so men between sixteen and sixty living in such an area had to register for up to forty eight hours per month part-time fire prevention duty. Women and boys were encouraged to volunteer as well. Members of the Home Guard and the Civil Defence were not subject to this Order at that time.

For residential areas there was a scheme in which the occupants of the houses in a road were brought together to fight small fires. Leaders were appointed in every street, in a long road there would have been one for every thirty houses. Their duties were to see that access could be obtained to the houses in their area at any time by the Civil Defence, and to see that fire fighting equipment was available at strategic places.

The Borough Engineer's Department had, by using the dustcarts, delivered forty three thousand sandbags to the houses in the town, dumped three hundred and sixty five piles of sand at Wardens Posts, and another one hundred and sixty in the streets. Sandbags were also placed at the base of lamp posts in the roads. However by the beginning of 1942 nearly all these had disappeared. Some had rotted away, and some had been moved to other locations, so it was decided not to renew them. There were six hundred stirrup pumps available through the Wardens as well as scoops, buckets and rakes.

Observation posts were established by the Fire Brigade on the roofs of San Remo Towers, Sea Road, Boscombe; Talbot Court, Wimborne Road, Moordown; Moderne Cinema, Wimborne Road, Moordown; Harvey Nichols Furniture Depot, Alum Chine Road, Westbourne and the Palace Court

Hotel, Westover Road. From these Fire Guards could direct the appliances to those areas which had been bombed and required assistance.

At St. Peter's Church ladders with platforms were fixed to the walls at the South and East ends of the building. These provided access to the space between the outside roof and the interior "barrel" roof over the Chancel, the Keble Chapel, the organ transept and the choir vestry, so that if firebombs fell through the outer roof, landing on the inner, fire fighters would be able to put them out.

At the beginning of the year nearly ten thousand places in shelters were available and many people spent their nights in them, sleeping in deck chairs or in sleeping bags on the floor. Bunks were eventually supplied in some shelters. These were constructed in three tiers with the middle one hinged so that it could be folded back allowing the lower bunk to be used as seating. Heating, lighting and some form of sanitation were also provided. At first the lavatories were only buckets hidden behind a curtain, later on proper flush toilets were installed. In July the Ministry of Food extended the Shelter Food Order SRO 1940 No 1964 to cover Bournemouth. This authorised the Council to provide refreshments in public air raid shelters in its area and at the same time laid down the conditions under which they could do so. Appendix B lists the majority of the shelters, gives the number of people who could be accommodated in each one, indicates if they were dormitory shelters, and if they had canteens; the Corporation having provided electric boilers and food storage cupboards in these.

The Bournemouth Times and Directory ran a series of articles in January interviewing the people sheltering in them. The shelter at Wallisdown, constructed under a garage, held seventy people, but on some nights up to ninety slept there. The Grand Parade shelter in Westbourne held a New Year's Party with decorations, lights, streamers and entertainment. Eight shelters for nine hundred people built of brick with un-gauged lime mortar were closed by the Ministry of Home Security because they were not strong enough to withstand a bomb blast. Later they were reinforced and reopened.

Work started in March on providing illuminated directional and location signs for public shelters. Arrows pointing to the nearest one and screened lights at each entrance, worked by automatic time switches, were put up.

A dispute arose over the shelters built in the grounds of hotels and other properties taken over by Government Departments. These were locked when the offices were closed and there were no Civil Servants to use them. It was thought by many residents that they should be left open so that anybody caught out in the open when there was an enemy attack could seek refuge in them. Eventually it was decided to put a key in a glass fronted box on the door so that when necessary the glass could be broken, the key removed and the door unlocked. This was similar to the arrangements for the public shelters in the town.

Portsmouth suffered a heavy raid on the night of 10th/11th January, and a convoy of fire fighting vehicles, ambulances and rescue parties under the leadership of the Chief Officer of the Bournemouth Fire Brigade went to give assistance. The Chief Constable and the Chief Officer of the Portsmouth Fire Brigade wrote to Mr. Barker thanking him for "the administrative and organising skills displayed by you at the scenes of the various major fires... and finally bringing the situation under control".

The dams in the Upper Pleasure Gardens to provide water for fire fighting had been built early in the year. These were put to good use in fighting the fire at Woolworths and helping to save the buildings either side of the store. The pool next to the Square, known as "Paradise", was enlarged to the delight of the resident ducks, whilst the dams further up the Bourne Stream flooded the lawns on either side. The trees and shrubs in the beds alongside were not removed and considerable damage was done to them.

The Transport Committee of the Council in February discussed the case of the trolley bus driver who halted his bus during an Alert because of the frosty conditions which caused the trolley arms connected to the overhead trolley wires to make "terrific and continuous flashing of the overhead Wires". This had caused many people to ask him to stop because the flashes were thought to be visible to enemy aircraft. The Councillors were told that when icy conditions prevailed a special petrol bus with an overhead arm fitted with special steel cutters was used to disperse the ice around the wire when necessary. They were also informed that the flashes could not be seen, and that "the wheels of

public transport must be kept turning".

Shaded lights with circular shades were fitted to the trolley buses during the year. Three were downstairs and three upstairs, plus three more on each deck which were only used when there was no Alert. On the bus platform there was a shaded light which acted as a spotlight illuminating both the platform and the road enabling passengers to board and alight safely. To help the bus driver and the motorist in the blackout oil lamps were placed at night on traffic islands to light the traffic signs. These were screened so that they were not visible from the air.

Shops were allowed a dimly illuminated sign which had not to be visible more than one hundred feet away. Such a sign was only allowed at each door when the shop was open for business and the entrance had to be curtained in such a way that no light showed when customers went in or came out. Particular care was needed by people leaving cinemas and other places of entertainment. Some of these employed Scouts to man the doors at night so that the blackout would not be breached. Once outside torches had to be used with care. The lens had not to exceed one inch and was dimmed by a piece of white paper and even then the torch had always to be pointed downwards. Batteries had to be conserved as they became extremely difficult to obtain.

The National Savings Campaign to provide money for the war effort had started in 1939. Savings groups by February 1941 numbered five hundred and twenty five, two hundred and sixty two were at places of employment, one hundred and fifty five were street groups and there were others at schools. By September £90,000 per week was being saved, and the authorities were asking this to be raised to £150,000. They pointed out that the money was not a gift to the Government, but an investment at 3% free of income tax. The Bournemouth War Weapons Week, organised by the Bournemouth War Savings Campaign Committee, was held from the 15th to 22nd February. It was designed to encourage the residents of the town to lend their money, through War Savings, to provide the arms and munitions required to fight the war. The target was to be £1,000,000, and on the first day £250,000, a quarter of the total aimed at, was collected, Bournemouth Corporation itself lending £100,000. The large savings indicator, scaled like a thermometer surmounted with a crown having a lion and unicorn as supporters, erected by the War Savings Committee in 1940 on the bus shelter in the centre of the Square, was used to record how much had been lent. The Mayor, Alderman A.H. Little, placed the figures for the first day, Saturday 15th February, on it.

Every day the cumulative amount saved in the Borough was displayed, the Mayor hoisting the latest figures on the indicator at noon. On the Wednesday the Mayor rode to the Square on the top of a tank, which paraded through the town daily, to record the latest amount. Troops were lined up in front as the Mayor addressed the gathering after Buglers on the top of the shelter had sounded a fanfare. After Alderman Little finished speaking, expressing his satisfaction with the amount lent, three Spitfires gave a display of formation flying and aerobatics, then Lysander aircraft showered thousands of leaflets over the centre of the town. The leaflet read:

> "A message to Bournemouth from the Royal Air Force. To the citizens of Bournemouth. The Royal Air Force is watching with great interest your War Weapons Week. Lend your money to the utmost as we are lending our full support to you. We're banking on Bournemouth, too!"

A tragic accident happened on Friday 21st February at about 6 pm when three Hurricanes flew over the town giving a demonstration. One, flown by a 22 year old Czech Sergeant Pilot of 32 Squadron stationed at Ibsley, performed a Victory Roll but failed to pull out of it, crashing on the backs of 36 and 38 St. Clement's Road. Unfortunately the pilot was killed, but the only occupant of 38 St. Clement's Road was rescued unhurt from the rubble by firemen from the Central Fire Station in Holdenhurst Road, The inquest found that the crash was caused by an error of judgement when the plane was flying upside down.

During War Weapons Week a Civic Service was held on the Sunday and a Grand Ball at the Pavilion. Bands of the Royal Army Service Corps and the King's Royal Rifle Corps gave concerts and played for dancing. Every day the Buglers sounded a fanfare of trumpets in the Square at the alteration of the figures on the savings indicator and the public were able to watch the ceremonial Changing of

the Guard for the Exhibition Hall on the Pavilion forecourt. The Beating of Retreat was also performed in the Central Gardens in the evenings. The Exhibition Hall, the old Westover Cinema (now Fortes), had on display a captured German gun, a shot down Messerschmitt 109, and a selection of other war trophies. Included was an engine from the Heinkel which had crashed on "Underwood" Westminster Road, Branksome Park on 25th September 1940.

There were also demonstrations of first aid given daily and the Bournemouth War Services Organisation had a stall with posters illustrating its work as well as a display on how to make old clothes into new! Posters designed by local school children for War Weapons Week were on show. There were so many of them that an overflow exhibition was held in a shop in Post Office Arcade, now the Criterion Arcade. Over seventeen thousand maple visited the exhibition, and the week's total savings amounted to £ 1,629,102 which was more than any other town in Hampshire.

Just before the War Weapons Week a display of munitions work was held in a window of J.J.Allen's. A lathe was displayed as well as examples of the work turned out on such machines. Considerable interest was shown, and one hundred and fifty four applications were received from people who wished to be considered for work in making munitions. Training courses for munitions workers were run at the Municipal College and at three factories in the town. At the beginning of the year one hundred and fifty people were being trained locally. The College also provided classes in the renovation and remodelling of dresses and clothes.

RAF Southbourne came into being early in 1941 at Hengistbury Head. The land between the sea in the South and Christchurch Harbour to the North, from the Saxon King Public House (now demolished) in the Broadway to the West and beyond Double Dykes to the East was taken over for a Chain Home Radar Station, one of the Radar Stations which were placed along the coast from Lands End to Scotland. These were set up to detect and then track enemy aircraft approaching and flying over Britain so that Fighter Command could direct fighter aircraft to intercept.

There were four 250-foot high metal masts used for transmitting the radar beams. Two were situated between Southbourne Coast Road and the Broadway (21 and 22 on the sketch plan), and two more nearer the Broadway (19 and 20). There were also two wooden receiving towers (16 and 17), one each side of Double Dykes at the end by the sea. The buildings which housed the equipment for plotting the enemy aircraft were situated, it is thought, in semi-underground shelters at the foot of the first pair of masts (19 and 20) and in the enclosure at Rowberries Hill (28). By Double Dykes was a building (18) which had the stand-by equipment in case of damage or failure of the main radar sets. The sketch map of Hengistbury Head can be found on page 42. It is based on a plan of RAF Southbourne, its defences and those on the Hengistbury Head, held in the Bournemouth Reference Library. The majority of the buildings and defence measures are numbered and these can be identified from a schedule prepared for the Contractors who were demolishing unwanted buildings and pillboxes, etc. and restoring the area. The plan was drawn by the Air Ministry and is dated 12th April 1948.

A flat at Sea Mansions, 7 Southbourne Overcliff Drive, was used as a listening post on the Luftwaffe. There, between 1942 and 1944, RAF personnel and WAAFs listened in on the German transmissions gathering information on the bombers' destinations. Most were fluent German speakers and it has been suggested that enemy pilots were fed false information diverting them from their targets, thus making the German bombing less effective.

RAF Southbourne closed down in September 1945 and most of its personnel dispersed to other sites or demobilised. However there were sentries posted to stop the public going on to the Head because of the minefields. In April 1946 concern was expressed that the RAF had withdrawn their sentries even though the area had not been de-requisitioned and that the Air Ministry had not declared the area safe from explosives. Hengistbury Head was at last declared clear of mines and unexploded ammunition on the training ground in July 1947.

Along the coast were pillboxes, dragon's, teeth, trenches and weapons pits for its defence against a seaborne raid such as the British Commando raid on Bruneval. Double Dykes were protected by more dragon's teeth, weapon pits and pillboxes. Mine fields were also laid along the coast and beaches.

The two gun emplacements of 172 Battery (1 and 2), situated near the western pair of masts, had subterranean rooms. A searchlight emplacement (4) and the fire control building (3) were nearby. Around the whole area barbed wire defences were erected, especially around the radar buildings. At the entrance to the site by the Saxon King (36) was the guard room (32) and in the woods on the other side of Double Dykes were the living quarters for the troops manning the guns (13). These were Nissen huts and there was a NAAFI building. The coastal battery was in action against German E-Boats in March 1943 and April 1944 when the Germans were engaged in laying mines off the Isle of Wight. Its personnel was comprised of three Officers, one hundred other ranks with ATS girls as clerks and cooks, plus Royal Navy personnel for identifying shipping.

Just by Double Dykes were several buildings described as the PLUTO base (23). Operation PLUTO (Pipeline Under the Ocean) was to provide fuel for the Allied Armies in Normandy after D-Day. A pipeline was laid from Shanklin, Isle of Wight, to France. This eventually pumped 56,000 gallons per day under the Channel. However local rumour had it that the pipeline operated from Hengistbury Head. This may refer to tests carried out during March to June 1944 when the floating "Cotton Reels" were to be seen in Poole Bay laying an incremental pipeline. This experimental pipeline consisted of eleven miles of piping laid in a loop. The loop was connected to a pumping station (in one of these huts'?) and the petrol was sent through the pipe under the sea successfully proving that the project would work. These buildings might have been part of these trials.

RAF Southbourne and Defence Measures on Hengistbury Head

Key to sketch plan on page 42

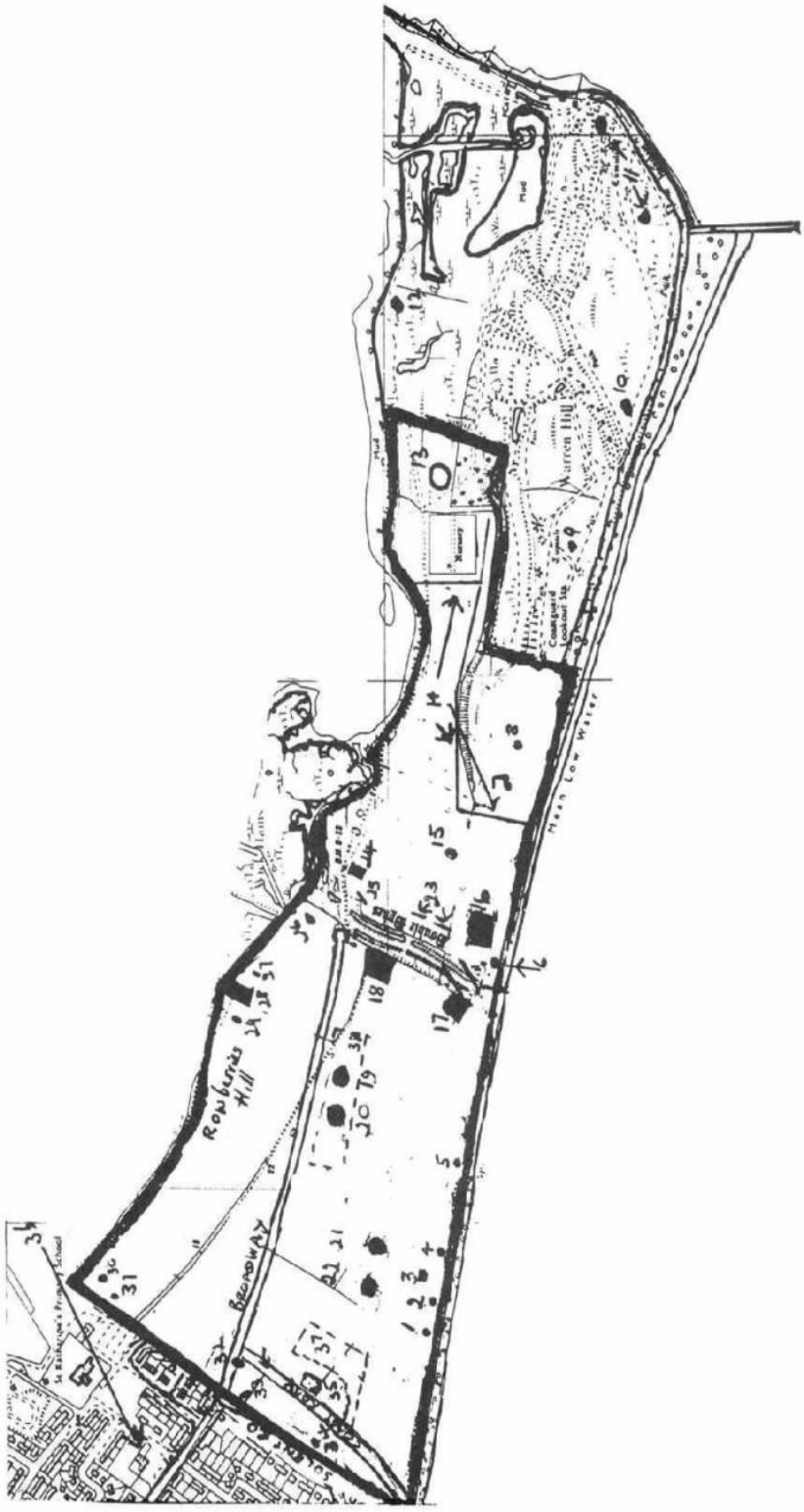
1 5.5" gun emplacement
2 5.5" gun emplacement
3 Fire Control building
4 Searchlight site
5 Pillbox
6 Pillbox and Dragon's teeth Double Dykes
7 Vickers gun site
8 Vickers gun site
9 Gun pit
10 Bofors guns
11 Weapons pits and benches
12 Pillbox
13 Camp
14 Anti-tank ditch
15 Wireless mast
16 Wood tower
17 Wood tower
18 Stand-by set
19 Metal mast
20 Metal mast
21 Metal mast
22 Metal mast
23 PLUTO base
24 "The Barn"
25 Nissen hut
26 Gun emplacement
27 Vickers gun site
28 Radar enclosure
29 Vickers gun site
30 Gun emplacement
31 Pillbox
32 Guard room
33 Pillbox
34 Pillbox
35 Signals enclosure
36 "Saxon King" site

The following were constructed post war:

37 Car park
38 Car park
39 Southbourne Coast Road

There were a number of other gun pits, strong points and trenches all over the Head, plus a firing range and a training area. Also there were barbed wire barriers or entanglements and mined areas.

The first bombs of the year fell on 11th March when at eight minutes past nine in the evening a stick of four high explosive bombs caused some damage to six houses in the Throop and Littledown areas, but there were no casualties. At 10.15 pm the same night four more bombs were dropped in the



RAF Southbourne and Defence Measures on Hengistbury Head

The dark wide lines show the approximate area of RAF Southbourne. The Southbourne Coast Road and the two car parks constructed post war have been added to help locate the approximate positions of the masts, enclosures and gun emplacements etc. The identifying numbers are listed on the previous page.

Broadway, Yeomans, Mill and Valley Roads, again damaging property but not causing any casualties. The next night, 12th March, at 8.45 pm the Five Ways area was the target. The junction of Portland and Murley Roads, plus Ripon Road, received two bombs which damaged one hundred and twenty three houses. Several properties were completely wrecked and rescuers had to tunnel into the rubble to release two women, one of whom was found to be dead. Seventeen other people were injured, one so severely that he subsequently died. The Royal Blue Coach garage in Rutland Road was one of the buildings hit and quickly caught fire. The Fire Brigade had difficulty in fighting the flames because of a ruptured water main.

During the following three days, 14th, 15th, and 16th March six incidents occurred. Hillcrest Road was the first target at 11.50 pm on the 14th when one high explosive bomb and several incendiaries damaged twenty eight houses. Then in the early hours of the next morning 2.05 am, three bombs wrecked and damaged ten houses in Gerald, Grafton and Iddesleigh Roads, injuring three people. Nine minutes later, at 2.14 am, a high explosive bomb damaged seven houses when it was dropped in Queens Road, Westbourne. In the evening three houses in Surrey Road were hit at 8.17 pm, followed by two bombs at Cemetery Junction at ten minutes past two in the morning of the 16th. One bomb exploded in the Cemetery itself uprooting headstones, the other near 43 Wimborne Road damaged the Wardens Post there. The last bombs, five in all, landed yet again in Leven Avenue and on Meyrick Park Golf links. Happily in the last four incidents nobody was hurt. It was rumoured that at some time during these three days a German airman had bailed out of his stricken plane which blew up off Boscombe Pier, landed on the trolley bus wires, and stopped the service for nearly an hour!

By now the network of Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres was being built up for the benefit of the bombed out and homeless, who were suffering mostly from shock and minor injuries. The more seriously injured were taken straight to hospital by ambulance. These Centres were placed in various halls all over the Borough and were opened only after a serious raid. The Wardens took the homeless there first where they were given food and drink, their injuries attended to, and clothing supplied if necessary. Then after giving their names and addresses to the Wardens they were taken to temporary billets before being sent on to more permanent ones, or to relatives or friends. The Centres were largely staffed by the WVS and the Housewives Service. A list of the Centres was published in the Echo, 6th April 1942, and this is reproduced in Appendix C.

Stokewood Road Baths, one of the Rest Centres, used the upstairs part of the building for those bombed out, but the swimming pool itself had to be kept filled with water as an emergency supply. For those unable to find accomodation with family or friends there were several houses which had been taken over by the local authority for this purpose, such as "Braemar" and "Bryn Tyrion" in St Michael's Road, 5 Wellington Road and 22, Knole Road.

The Times and Directory reported on a "realistic demonstration" at the East Cliff Congregational Church Rest Centre in its issue dated 8th May 1942. The helpers who staffed the Centre were summoned by messenger after the raid and came bringing a bottle of water in case there was no main supply. They placed hurricane lamps at various parts of the hall as a precaution if the electricity should fail. Then they set out mattresses and blankets, also preparing hot drinks and food. Directly the bombed out people arrived they were wrapped in warm blankets and given a hot drink. First aid was given when needed and clothing provided where necessary. Temporary billets were then arranged for the homeless either short stay of up to forty eight hours or more permanent ones of up to two weeks. Those who could be housed by friends or relatives at a distance were provided with a free travel voucher.

At Selwyn Hall St. John's Church, Boscombe, a Central Depot was set up for bombed out people to go to for assistance. There their immediate needs were assessed. They were issued with any necessary documents which needed replacing, such as identity cards, ration books, as well as new gas masks. Financial help was provided and also information on their bomb damaged house how to claim for its repair and the removal, plus storage, of their furniture. Billeting and rehousing were also dealt with.

A Rest Centre for bombed out babies and their mothers, as well as families, from the hardest hit

parts of Bristol was set up at the Cintra Hotel, Florence Road. There they stayed to rest and recuperate for a fortnight, the first party of forty arriving at the beginning of November. In June 1942 this holiday centre was transferred to the Studland Dene Hotel, Alum Chine.

It was on the 21st March that the "Glamour Puffer", the train taking women workers to the Royal Naval Cordite Factory at Holton Heath, near Wareham, was attacked. This special train ran to the factory in the morning from Christchurch, Bournemouth and Poole Stations, and then returned in the evening. On its return journey the train had crossed Rockley Bridge at 5.50 pm when a sneak German raider dropped a stick of bombs which exploded on both sides of the train, breaking all the windows, but not doing any major damage. The engine driver stopped the train, then discovering that the damage was only slight drove it into a cutting to escape more attacks. On finding that the enemy aircraft had flown away he then proceeded slowly into Hamworthy Station. There the ARP and rescue workers were able to provide first aid for the minor injuries suffered.

There was a short lull in the bombing until 27th March when at 12.20 pm three high explosive bombs were dropped in Lowther and Methuen Roads, injuring three people and damaging one hundred and one houses as well as a water main. A few moments later two unexploded bombs were discovered in Alma Road causing the area to be evacuated. Just after that the worst incident for casualties so far in the Poole/Bournemouth area occurred at the Bourne Valley Gas Works.

At lunch time the work force was just starting their meal in the staff canteen, even though the Alert had sounded, whilst on the roof the Spotter watched for enemy planes. However there was thick, low cloud which gave poor visibility, so that when the German plane appeared the Spotter was unable to give very much warning. Two bombs fell apparently aimed at the railway viaduct by the Gas Works. They both missed, but hit the Gas Works instead. One completely destroyed a store and the other struck the canteen, plunging through the roof of the two storey building and ending up caught by its tail fins in the ceiling of the mess room. It hung there for a few seconds before exploding killing thirty four men and seriously injuring sixteen, plus seven others with minor wounds. Of the thirty four killed fifteen were from Bournemouth. Rescue parties from the ARP and from a Royal Artillery Unit close by brought out the dead and wounded from the debris. Only slight damage was caused to the viaduct by machine gun bullets.

It seemed that during the past month most of the raids had been directed towards the railways. West Station, Branksome viaduct, Cemetery Junction and a train had all been targets, but none of them hit.

The Germans were well acquainted with the geography of the town for they printed a street plan with all the military targets noted on it. Based on the Ordnance Survey Six Inch map of 1934 with later amendments the "bombing" or "invasion" map was redrawn to the metric scale of 1:10,000 and dated lst August 1941. Amongst the targets the railway bridges, the electricity works, the gas works, and main buildings such as the Pavilion and the Barracks at Christchurch were highlighted. The boating lake in Queen's Park Golf Course was shown as a "wasserreservoire" and the area known as Townsend as "feldflugplatz", a landing ground for aircraft or parachutists. This plan can be seen in the Bournemouth Reference Library. After the war copies of the local One Inch Ordnance Survey maps printed in Germany were discovered by workmen repairing a building in Old Christchurch Road. They were concealed under the floorboards and were thought to have been hidden by a German spy.

In the Bournemouth Advertiser, 18th November 1993, it was revealed that by the vigilance of a local woman, Mrs. M. Jones, two German spies were caught in 1944. The spies, a married couple with two sons, had a house on the cliff top in which there was a room with transmitting equipment. Mrs. Jones saw the radio when visiting the house about six months after D-Day and, through a friend, alerted the Police. The house was raided by Scotland Yard and the couple arrested.

The Echo on lst April played an April Fool's Joke on their readers. Whether they appreciated it is not known but it concerned poison gas. "A coat of white paint on the tops of pillar boxes may have led the observer to believe that in spite of war economy Bournemouth Corporation was going in for decorative effect. The white paint is the first coat on which special poison gas detection paint will be applied. This will be green and it denotes the presence of gas by turning brown. Another gas detection

device is an armlet of red paper, the wearing of which may have been noted".

Easter 1941 was different to former years. On Good Friday Banks, Post Offices and some businesses remained open. Most of the shops and places of entertainment closed however, and there were no road or rail excursions. Factory workers were only allowed a few hours off because of the crisis, so visitors were mostly from the adjacent counties who could reach the seaside easily through the normal train or bus services. There were very few holiday-makers, and little holiday atmosphere. However there were some very unwelcome "visitors" who came by air.

At three minutes to midnight on Maundy Thursday, 10th April, a stick of bombs fell around the Square. In this raid Woolworths (the site is now occupied by Boots) was gutted by fire after two direct hits. Fire-watchers had a lucky escape, just managing to vacate the building before it became engulfed by flames.

A bomb fell on Hampshire Court in Bourne Avenue wrecking three flats, followed by another in the road which cracked the water main. The Richmond Hill Congregational Church had the east wing of its Hall demolished and slight damage to the Church itself. The Church held many functions to raise money to pay for the repairs, which cost nearly £ 2,000. Over £ 1,600 had been found by April 1942. The Easter Sunday Morning Service had to be held in the Pavilion Theatre and it was not until lst June that services were resumed in the Church.

The local author Cumberland Clark was killed when his flat in "Fernbank", St. Stephen's Road, received a direct hit. He was a prolific writer, particularly on Shakespeare and the British Empire. Much of what he wrote was in verse. He had written six books of patriotic poems since the beginning of the war, with some of them being printed in the local papers. In the same building a woman was trapped in the wreckage for several hours, Rescue Party 4 having to dig a tunnel through the debris to save her. This difficult and dangerous task was carried out by three men who laboured for nearly six hours at great risk to themselves. One of the rescuers, Mr. T. Davies, was awarded the British Empire Medal, Civil Section, for bravery and the other two, Messrs. F. Gardiner and L. Maidment, who helped him, were given certificates and their actions highly commended. One hundred and twelve properties were damaged, eight people killed and five injured. Earlier at 10.14 pm a bomb had dropped in Westminster Road, Branksome Park, again.

More bombs were dropped in the area around the Square at 10.30 pm on Saturday night, 12th April. One bomb actually fell in the Square itself, nearly outside W.H. Smith, another made a crater on the bank of the Bourne in the Lower Gardens, whilst there was one in gardens near the Royal Exeter Hotel. Two landed in Bodorgan Road breaking the water main and a sixth in the garden of "Rotherfell Court", which when it exploded set off an unexploded bomb buried in the garden, dropped on the previous Thursday, completely demolishing the building. A Nurses' Hostel in Clarendon Road had its windows blown in but there were no casualties. In all forty two properties were damaged. Earlier in the day a German plane had machine gunned houses breaking windows and damaging several roofs.

On Easter Monday a large number of Servicemen and women enjoyed a day's freedom strolling along the promenade and in the Pleasure Gardens, together with the few holiday-makers. The hotels still trading had not expected a considerable influx of long stay guests, but had kept open in case of sudden demand. It was on the seafront that the visitors who did come experienced the greatest changes. Only a few beach bungalows were available for use and the beach itself was not accessible because of the barbed wire defences. However there were deck chairs on the promenade for sun bathing and lounging. Chairs were also available in the Gardens but there was no music from the bandstand, instead there were afternoon and evening orchestral concerts at the Pavilion. Apart from Good Friday the cinemas and dance halls were open and packed. One of the problems for cinema and theatre managers was how to notify the patrons that there was an Alert. At the cinemas a slide was shown over the film being screened which said that there was an Alert or that the All Clear had sounded. At the Palace Court Theatre and the Pavilion on either side of the stage there were Alert and All Clear signs which were illuminated when necessary.

There had been some disquiet voiced about the number of people on the promenade and in the

Gardens because it was thought that if there had been an air raid many might have been killed or injured as there were no shelters in the immediate vicinity.

The bomb in the Square on the Saturday night which damaged the road at the corner of Gervis Place and Old Christchurch Road disrupted the trolley bus service and the Transport Department put into operation a shuttle service of petrol buses between Boscombe and Westbourne. They were unable to travel through the Square and had to be routed via Exeter Road, the Pier Approach and Bath Road. Because of the large crowds who made heavy demands on the transport system over the weekend, and especially Easter Monday, the last buses from the Square were run an hour later than usual to enable everybody who had been to the theatre, cinema or dancing to get home.

Changes in the Square area started in May with an important experiment designed to relieve the traffic congestion. The stops for loading and unloading five Corporation Bus services were moved from the Square itself to Gervis Place alongside the Pleasure Gardens, and in order to provide greater safety for pedestrians a long island was constructed from Rebbeck's Corner, the junction of Gervis Place and Old Christchurch Road, nearly to the foot of Richmond Hill, replacing a line of small white posts.

Later on in November bus shelters were constructed in Gervis Place to shelter the waiting passengers from wind and rain when queuing. The shelters were made of corrugated iron having a back and roof, but no sides, so that people would not walk into them during the blackout. To some the shelters were unsightly and shut off the view of the Gardens. To others they were a blessing on wet and windy days.

The behaviour of people waiting to board buses had given cause for concern earlier in the year. With the growing number of Servicemen in the town, they, and the town's people, were not getting on in an orderly manner. Much pushing and shoving was occurring. The Town Council attempted to introduce voluntary queuing for the buses in July. They placed notice boards at the stops which said "Don't push your way through but keep in the Queue. Play the game please". At the Lansdowne to check some of the congestion which happened especially at the rush hour, barrier rails were erected at the kerb and along the pavement at the bus stops, so that the passengers were penned in and had to move forward taking their turn properly.

Kinson was bombed at 12.35 am on the 16th April when five high explosive bombs damaged eighty three properties in the Millhams Road, Glendon Avenue, Bramley Road and Weymans Avenue. The bomb which fell in Millhams Road caused some damage to shops, The Royal Oak and the Oddfellows Hall. A Civil Defence report stated that anti-personnel bombs attached to parachutes were dropped during the night of 9th/10th May. They were found in Westbourne, Branksome Park and Moordown. Designed to kill or maim people, they were not meant to damage or destroy property.

The next raid occurred when high explosive and incendiary bombs fell on fields at the back of Northbourne and Leybourne Avenues during the early hours of 12th May at 3.32 am There were no casualties even though thirty five houses were damaged. The incendiaries were quickly dealt with by the local street fire parties who smothered the flames with sandbags. This was their first experience of extinguishing fire bombs.

Clothes rationing came into force on June lst 1941, sixty six coupons having to last for a year. At first the margarine coupons in the Food Ration Book were used, the coupons being cut out when the clothes were purchased, but later in September a new clothing card was issued, the number of coupons required for each article of clothing being regularly advertised in the local press so that people were able to plan their wardrobe. For example, a coat was thirteen, trousers eight, a dress eleven and a shirt seven.

Saturday May 30th was a record Saturday for business in the clothing shops. At first this was thought to be because it was the Whitsun weekend, but it was reported that there had been a shopping spree by many people employed in the Government Departments transferred to the town. This made many locals wonder if they had prior notice of the rationing, giving them an unfair advantage.

Knitting parties had been set up to provide comforts, such as socks, scarves and woollies, for the troops at the beginning of the war. When wool could no longer be bought without coupons many

changed to mending parties. They met at various places such as the YMCA in Westover Road and the Services Clubs. There, in the evenings and most afternoons, a group would meet with needles, thread, buttons and darning wool, repairing, altering and sewing on stripes.

Stores and shops were closed on Whit Monday, 2nd June. With the sea-front amenities restricted many went into the country for the day. There were a good many, however, who went for a stroll along the promenade and then sat in the sun in the Lower Pleasure Gardens. Children, although not allowed on the beach, had enough sand which had been blown on to the Undercliff Drive for them to build sandcastles. Again the question arose regarding the safety of people in the Gardens and on the promenade.

In the issue of 21st June 1941, Picture Post, a popular weekly illustrated magazine, published an article by J.B. Priestley entitled "1 look at Bournemouth" in which he recounts his impressions of the town during a stay at the Royal Bath Hotel. Amongst the points he made was that "Nobody could call it a bad war in Bournemouth". He went on to say that there were plenty of amusements available, plenty of food in the shops, a choice of many comfortable hotels and that there were "some evacuees in the town". He did admit that "it has been bombed a little, and air raid warnings are frequent".

There were only a few letters in the press complaining about the article, and the Echo report on it said "It made everybody laugh". The flowers Priestley mentioned were artificial, the wedding cake at Beales imitation, and there were only a few hotels open because the majority had been requisitioned. The picture of the writer asleep in a chair in the gardens of the Royal Bath, which headed the article, was captioned "Solitude and safety. J.B. Priestley relaxes in the grounds of a Bournemouth hotel", and caused one letter writer to point out that he needed to live in the town not just for two days or even two weeks in a luxury hotel to find out about the town and its people.

However, it must be pointed out that the Echo in August stated "Shopping activity in Bournemouth continues at practically prewar level. There is not the variety available, but the necessary goods are available". The report also mentions the "excellence of window and counter displays in the shops". Perhaps J.B. Priestley's article had been more truthful than people would allow!

Just after that the Royal Bath had a Royal visitor, King Peter II of Yugoslavia. He had fled his country in late April, arriving in England on 21st June when he was met by HRH The Duke of Kent. They were photographed together walking the Hotel's gardens.

In 1941 Bournemouth became a Personnel Reception Centre for Air Force personnel from Canada, Australia, New Zealand and other Colonies (as they were then). The advance party arrived early in the year with the first intake coming in July. They had all received their flying training in other countries and were waiting postings to their operational units for active service. Later the Royal Canadian Air Force set up No 3 Personnel Reception and Training Centre with up to twelve thousand airmen at any one time. Here they were instructed in navigation, naval and aircraft recognition and other aspects of aerial warfare. The Pier Approach Baths were used to teach aircrew how to launch inflatable dinghies when they "ditched" in the sea and how to survive until they were rescued. Glider pilots training at Hurn also used this facility.

W. Morrison writes in "Horsa Squadron" about the training the glider pilots received at the Baths. There the training for "ditching" consisted of jumping into the deep end of the pool whilst wearing full flying gear, then clambering into an inflatable dinghy. He thought that "for discomfort there's nothing like putting on a soggy wet flying suit".

One Canadian posted to No 3 PR & T Centre recollected that he landed at Greenock and was "immediately loaded on a train heading South. The next day (18th March 1943) we were unloaded and transported to lodgings. Our question "Where are we?" was answered, "Bournemouth - a real posh place!" We braced ourselves for terrible times in Wartime England, but here we were living in comparative luxury accommodation (Bath Hill Court) after almost a year of quonset huts and hastily erected buildings for the Empire Training Plan. A pleasant walk across a beautiful park took us to the Winter Gardens or Bowling Green as our mess hall was called.

"The parks were beautiful, the city was so clean, and the people friendly and understanding. We were amazed by the friendliness despite what must have looked like a takeover by an occupying

"Colonial" military force. I enjoyed walking around the town, but soon learned not to date girls from Poole after twice having to do that long walk after the buses had ceased operation!"

Some members of the RCAF had a dog as their mascot. They decorated it with the three stripes of a Sergeant marked in red on one of its forelegs, whilst the air-gunner's badge and the letters RCAF appeared on its body. Its tail displayed the RAF roundels in colour. This poor animal was seen with its masters all over the town much to the amusement of everybody.

Forty three hotels and other properties were requisitioned to accommodate the RCAF. Amongst them were the Royal Bath, Bath Hill Court, East Cliff Court, Durley Chine, Hawthornes, Hazelwood, Knole Hall, Heathlands, Melford Court, Byng Hall, Byng Mansions, Cottonwood, Carlton, Annersley Court, Vale Royal, Walmer, Osbourne, Burley Court, Highcliff, Bourne Dene, Delamere, Compton House and the Grand. Somerset House in Bath Road was their post office, Earls Court their hospital and the Holdenhurst Road Drill Hall was used for physical training. The Majestic Garage, Westover Road, became a training centre and several other hotels were used as class rooms.

HRH The Duke of Kent paid an informal visit to the Reception and Training Centre on 20th August 1942. He saw classes receiving instruction in Morse Code and wireless operation, lectures on bombs and pilot training on the static "Harwell" trainer. In the grounds of one hotel gun turrets were set up for air gunners to practice on. The Rink Ballroom was converted into a museum of war trophies, including German and British equipment, engines, bombs and photographs. The Duke was killed on 25th August 1942 when the Sunderland flying boat in which he was travelling crashed in the north of Scotland.

Sea bathing was allowed from 12th July between 6 am and 10 pm. Three gaps were cut in the obstructions along the promenade providing access to the beach at Bournemouth Pier, opposite the East Cliff lift cafe and near Boscombe Pier by the large platform erected just off shore for the Fire Brigade to place pumps to suck up sea water for fire fighting. The whole stretch of beach between the Piers was available to the public and hundreds took advantage of the relaxation. Three notices were displayed which said "Notice is hereby given that persons using this promenade or bathing from this beach do so at their own risk. Access to the beach is restricted to the gaps in the barbed wire. Cameras are not allowed, and any persons using one will be prosecuted. Some confusion was caused by an old notice which stated that no one was allowed on the beach and that everybody had to quit the Undercliff Drive, which was open from the West Cliff Zigzag past the Piers to the eastern end, by 9 pm.

A row occurred between the military authorities and the Borough Council when in July the Pavilion Ballroom was put out of bounds to Army Officers. Southern Command issued an Order stating that no Officers were permitted to use the Ballroom. There was resentment locally over the Council not being consulted or notified, the Pavilion management being left to find out. There was a statement from Southern Command which said, "Never for one moment did we think that what we were doing would receive such publicity. We did not think it was big enough to do so. There was not the slightest intention of showing any disrespect to Bournemouth". The reasons given were limited seating, congestion, and it could have meant Other Ranks and Officers "requiring the same chair". lt would not have been fair to expect ORs to give up seats to Officers as there were more ORs using the Ballroom. There had been no incidents or friction but the Order was intended to make sure that this did not happen. A compromise was arrived at so that as far as the Southern Command was concerned the Ballroom would be available for all ranks except on Friday and Saturday evenings when it was reserved for Warrant Officers, NCOs and men. The Order was therefore cancelled and all ranks informed. The Council and the Pavilion management accepted these new arrangements.

Statutory Instrument No 103 1941 the "Local Authorities (Community Kitchens and Sale of Food in Public Air Raid Shelters) Order" required local authorities to set up community feeding centres or what came to be called British Restaurants.

The first British Restaurant in Bournemouth was opened on lst August by the Mayor of Bournemouth, Alderman A.H. Little, at Alma Road, using the repaired Senior Girls' School, which had been damaged by the land mine in November 1940. British Restaurants, run by the local

authorities, were not emergency feeding centres but were intended to provide food for the public at the lowest possible price everyday. The food was good, cheap, one shilling (5p) for a three course meal, and there was plenty of it. They were self-service and their main object was to cut down on food, electricity and gas. "200 people eating together need much less food than would be required to prepare separate meals", the Ministry of Food stated. The diners liked it because the food consumed did not come from their precious rations.

The Alma Road Restaurant originally seated two hundred people, but it proved so popular that it had to be enlarged by taking over more of the school, eventually serving five hundred lunches a day. The second British Restaurant opened in the Wesley Church Hall in Holdenhurst Road on 13th September, catering for up to four hundred people. There was no formal ceremony, nor was there one for the third at the Co-operative Hall, Latimer Road, Winton when it came into operation the following week on the 20th September. Later on two more were started, one in The Popular Restaurant at the Pavilion and the other in a building specially erected in Seabourne Road at Pokesdown. Another purpose built hall was erected as a replacement for the Wesley Church Hall just after the war.

Restaurants and cafes since March had not been allowed to serve more than one course of fish, meat, poultry, game or eggs and the maximum charge had not to exceed five shillings (25p), however this was relaxed for Christmas meals.

In March the meat ration was reduced from one shilling and twopence to one shilling only (5p), also milk was cut to six-sevenths of the quantity used in the week ended 8th March. Hotels found this very difficult as during that period they had done very little business. Next came the registration, on 14th June, for eggs with a retailer, and milk followed soon after. There was even registration for onions at the greengrocers. Office tea clubs had to register for milk and the Food Office received one thousand applications for the forms. However a club had to have a membership of six or more to be eligible. Special arrangements were made for schools, hotels and boarding houses. The cheese ration though was raised to three ounces a head. In October the fat ration was up by 25% and sugar by 50% from 17th November, and at the end of the month onions were available at 1lb for each ration book. During the same month new amounts of milk came into force. Adults could have two pints a week, children over six but under eighteen had three and a half pints whilst those under six were allowed one pint a day.

The Echo reported in August that the presence of so many visitors meant a big strain on the retailers who had to meet their demands for rationed and unrationed foods. Also there was more work for the staff of the Food Office in issuing emergency food cards. Visitors had been told before leaving home not to forget their ration cards for without them no emergency ration cards would be issued as these were necessary for purchasing rationed goods during their holiday. From opening time on Monday mornings long queues of visitors waited patiently for the cards. A Food Officer stated in July, "I expect we shall deal with at least five hundred applications during the morning!".

People who changed the retailer from whom they purchased rationed food when they moved house had to register the alteration with the Food Office and their change of address with the National Registration Office at the Town Hall. People returning to the town after an absence had to do the same.

Food became the main topic of conversation. The news was passed amongst families and friends where "treasures" such as biscuits, onions, sweets and chocolate could be obtained. Shopping consisted of what could be found rather than what was desired. Prices, too, tended to rise because of the scarcity of vegetables, fruit and other staple items. ln March cucumbers were fetching four shillings and sixpence (22.5p), a very high price.

The arrival of oranges, which were in very short supply, was mentioned in the Echo in April. The number which went on sale in the shops was enough for one between six people. A large consignment, three thousand three hundred cases from South Africa, came in the middle of September. As this was prior to their rationing measures were taken to ensure a fair distribution. Rationing of oranges came into force on September 29th. From then all deliveries were made available first, for seven days, to children up to six years of age who were entitled to two pounds each, then to young people up to

eighteen and after that any left were for the general public.

The Government had decided early in the year that a week's holiday would not hinder the war effort, so during August the hotels and boarding houses still open welcomed the workers from the munitions factories, and Civil Defence personnel from other parts of the country, for a well-earned rest. Some hotels introduced high teas instead of dinners to conserve food.

Just before August Bank Holiday, then the first Monday in August, the Ministry of War Transport issued the following statement, "Before you make up your mind to travel on the Bank Holiday remember that you are asked not to do so. There will be no special trains, or bus excursions, and no extra food available. Walking, cycling, gardening and resting are much more restful and patriotic ways of spending the day". But this appeal fell on deaf ears for many people arrived in the town on the regular train and coach services. On the Bank Holiday Saturday there was an invasion by day trippers, many coming by bicycle and others by the ordinary service bus. Hundreds were to be found on the cliffs, on the promenade and the beach. On the Monday it was estimated that there were forty nine thousand visitors. The number of deck chair sessions paid for over the three days was twelve thousand, ten times that of 1940, but nothing like the eighty three thousand in 1939. The concert by the Municipal Orchestra at the Pavilion was packed out, the cinemas were busy and the holiday-makers and the servicemen in the town had to queue for nearly everything from buses to beer in the public houses, as did the residents. However there was little beer to be had, while spirits, cigarettes and chocolates were also in short supply.

Little Audrey, Marjorie and Lucy, three heavy cruiser Canadian tanks arrived in Bournemouth at the end of August, and went on display on the forecourt at the Pavilion where they were of extreme interest to schoolboys, residents and visitors alike. The tanks stayed for three days noisily touring the streets all over the town. They demonstrated their powers by demolishing two bomb-damaged houses in Malmesbury Park Road by pulling them down with ropes. The Mayor appealed for £10,000 to be collected to build a tank.

Surplus railings were still required for salvage. The Ministry of Supply estimated that the railings left in the Borough amounted to five hundred and fifty two tons which would be enough to build a destroyer. The salvage of food scraps started in October. Over six hundred bins for collecting kitchen waste to be made into pig food were placed around the town in private gardens and other unobtrusive sites. Some were also put on the pavements where they would not cause an obstruction.

Wild fruits, blackberries, bilberries, elderberries, loganberries, sloes and crab apples were collected by Scouts, Guides and local school children. These were taken to the Food Office for preservation and jam making at two depots, one in Ashley Road, Parkstone, and the other at the Canford Cliffs Cafe. The Ministry of Food authorised the payment of threepence (1p) a pound to the collectors. Guides also collected nettle leaves, which they dried and sent to manufacturing chemists, as well as foxglove leaves for heart medicine.

The Daily Express reported in August that three men in German Army uniforms had been seen in the centre of the town. Nobody recognised the field grey uniform at first, perhaps because of the many Allied soldiers in unfamiliar uniforms who passed through. However a member of the Home Guard called the Police who stopped the trio, only to discover that they were British soldiers taking part in a military exercise.

Several exercises were held in the area during the year. One in February involved one thousand men from the Bournemouth and Christchurch Civil Defence Units and Home Guards, plus the local military garrison. The "enemy", the garrison troops, had landed cutting road and rail connections to the town, and the Town Hall had been dive-bombed as well as other military targets. All branches of the Civil Defence were involved, the Home Guard being credited with successfully mopping up the invaders.

In March the Bournemouth Battalion of the Home Guard held a realistic battle in Meyrick Park. They were the defence against an attack from the North over the railway line, Another exercise was the Home Guard against seven thousand servicemen for the beaches. This time the defenders did not do so well.

Sunday morning at Meyrick Park was the time for the Home Guard to practice throwing hand grenades at the bombing range set up there. They also learned fieldcraft skills and camouflage in the woods around the golf links. Dean Court Football Ground was used for several displays by the armed forces stationed in the town. A gymnastic gymkhana was held on Wednesday 18th June, in aid of the RAF Benevolent Fund, by two hundred and fifty RAF recruits who were being trained "somewhere in England". This phrase was used to conceal the actual name of the place, which was, in this case, hotels and boarding houses in Boscombe!

The 7th (Boscombe) Battalion, Hampshire Home Guard, organised a military display and gymkhana on the August Bank Holiday Monday. There were sporting events, displays of drill and guard mounting, plus a display of firefighting and drill by the AFS. The entrance fee was cut by half for those who were carrying their gasmasks.

The public after the first flush of enthusiasm at the beginning of the war had grown lazy and forgetful about their gasmasks and did not carry them everywhere. So the Borough Councillors were asked to set an example by having theirs with them at all times. There were regular reminders in the press plus novel ways of jogging the public's memory such as a reduction in entrance charges. The idea was also used by a local dance hall which had regular nights when those seeking admission were charged a lower price if they had their gas masks. In 1943 the public were excused carrying gas masks but were told that they must have them examined periodically.

Security Circular No 40 issued by the Home Office emphasised the necessity of the ARP holding regular inspections of civilian respirators. This was done at halls all over the town, the venues and the times being advertised in the local newspapers.

The Air Training Corps staged a display at Dean Court on 16th August when there was a flypast and show of aerobatics by Spitfires. The recruiting for the Air Training Corps had started on lst February. The primary purpose of the ATC was, and still is, to provide basic training for boys wishing to join the RAF. The local units of the Air Defence Cadet Corps became the basis of the new Squadrons, 130 (Bournemouth), 149 (Poole) and 171 (Christchurch). The ADCC had been formed by the Air League of the British Empire in 1938, but it was taken over by the Air Ministry at the beginning of 1941. One member of the Christchurch Squadron, Cadet Ray W. Clarke, was presented with a medal for gallantry in November 1940, awarded by the Air League, in recognition of his bravery whilst on ARP duty at New Milton when it was badly bombed in August 1940.

The colours of the ADCC were laid up by the 130 (Bournemouth) Squadron at St. Andrew's, Bennett Road. The ceremony was taken by the Rev. J.P. Hodges, Padre to the 130th, on Sunday September 18th.

The Fire Brigade and the Auxiliary Fire Service were nationalised in August 1941. The Home Office had decided in April to rationalise the Fire Service, and, by combining the two, to provide a more effective fire protection based on Regions. They called the new organisation the National Fire Service. Mr. Barker left to take charge of the Region covering Berkshire, Oxfordshire and Buckinghamshire. Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch became Area 16C of Region No 6, which covered Hampshire and also part of Dorset, with Divisional Officer Stanley Fairbrass in charge.

The Ambulances, which were kept at the Central Fire Service Depot, were handed over to the Civil Defence when the Fire Service was nationalised. They were transferred to the ARP Depot in Portchester Road. During the same month a mobile X-ray unit was presented to Boscombe Hospital by the people of New Hampshire USA.

Also in August the Fire Guards, the new name for fire-watchers, were merged with the ARP. The Civil Defence Committee's minutes of the 18th November recorded that the amalgamation of the Fire Guard Organisation into the Wardens Service went smoothly and with less difficulty than had been originally anticipated!

The Registration for Fire Guard duties under the "Civil Defence Duties (Compulsory Enrolment) Order 1941" happened in September. The unofficial estimate of the number of men between eighteen and sixty who were required to register was twenty five thousand. Approximately fourteen thousand claimed exemption for reasons of Civil Defence duties and about six hundred on medical and hardship

grounds. Those who were not exempt received a compulsory enrolment notice with directions as to where to report for duty. Everybody who performed fire prevention duties wore an amulet with "Fire Guard" written in yellow on a dark blue background.

Very few projects were carried out by the Corporation owing to the war, but extensions to the Stourfield School in Cranleigh Road were opened in September. The School had started in October 1912 when the infants and older children's block was opened. Other blocks came into use in 1927 and 1935. Now the three departments were enlarged by providing a babies section, two large classrooms, a needlework room, an art studio and a changing room for physical training.

The funeral with full military honours of the first Commonwealth airman stationed in Bournemouth to die was held in the North Cemetery on Wednesday 8th October. Leading Aircraftman F. W. Bidgood from New South Wales died in Boscombe Hospital after a short illness.

On November 27th the body of a soldier was washed up at Double Dykes, Hengistbury Head. It was identified as Sergeant James Croft who had been washed off some rocks on the Dorset coast when trying to retrieve a lost army bucket from the sea. Another body was found in April 1942, but sadly this man was never named.

At the end of October, on the 28th the Dowager Marchioness of Reading inspected and addressed the WVS at the Pavilion. She went to see a Group Clearing Post at Immanuel Church Hall at Southbourne and then on to a depot where camouflage coverings were made. The ballroom at the Town Hall was used at that time for this purpose. There three wooden "airing horses" had 35 ft. by 35 ft. nets slung over them. These nets were then "garnished", that is strips of fawn, brown or green material were either threaded or tied to the netting to make the camouflage nets. Thirty nets were completed every week. The majority of those working on them were members of the WVS.

The Echo, 8th October 1941, reported a communique from the Air Ministry which stated "Last night a few aircraft flew overland, mainly over parts of South-West England and South Wales. Bombs were dropped at several points. Some damage was caused and there was a small number of casualties". One of the "several points" was Bournemouth's Pier Approach and East Beach, where at 9.20 pm a single German bomber dropped two parachute mines, one falling into the sea. Some reports state that two fell on land and another into the water. The blast from the mine which exploded on land was partially deflected by the cliffs, however many windows were broken over a wide area.

The Russell Cotes Art Gallery suffered badly: it had nearly every window shattered. Luckily the exhibits were not damaged, with the exception of two or three watercolours. At the Pavilion the dance band played without missing a beat, the dancers continued as if nothing had happened and the shows at the theatres and cinemas carried on with their programmes. Sea water and sand were deposited at some distance and owing to the unpredictable blast waves shop windows half a mile away were broken, whilst others close to the Pier Approach were undamaged. Nobody was killed but twelve people sustained cuts and shock. First aid parties were quickly on the scene for they were carrying out an exercise at the Pier Approach Baths ARP Station. Over two hundred and thirty five properties were affected including the Royal Bath Hotel, the East Beach Cafe and houses in Bath Road.

The first visit by the reigning monarch to Bournemouth was on Thursday 23rd October when King George VI and Queen Elizabeth inspected airmen from the Canadian, Australian, New Zealand and other Allied Air Forces who were stationed in the town at the Personnel Reception Centre.

The men were paraded in Westover Road outside the Pavilion and the King and Queen passed along the ranks having a brief word with some of them. Amongst those on parade were the skilled civilian craftsmen from the American Civilian Technical Corps who had volunteered for service in England. The Royal Couple had tea with the Dominion and Allied Serviced Hospitality Committee which catered for the welfare of personnel from overseas. Although the visit was supposed to be secret many people knew about it and crowds packed the pavements near Westover Road. The road from the station was lined with people and windows and balconies of nearby hotels were also crowded.

There had been another parade a few weeks before when on Sunday 28th September the Civil Defence held a church parade at the Regent Cinema (now the Odeon). The column of three thousand men and women marched down Bath Hill, along Westover Road, round the Pavilion forecourt and into

the Regent. All sections of the Civil Defence were represented and the Mayor, Alderman A.H. Little, reviewed them from the outside balcony of the Cinema.

Westover Road saw yet another parade, this time in November, when tanks, Bren gun carriers, and other military vehicles together with detachments of ATS, WAAF, WRNS, Land Army, AFS, Red Cross, St. John's Ambulance, women munition workers, bus conductors and railway porters combined to start "Women's Recruiting Week" on Sunday 30th with a rally in the Pavilion. The aim was to get a substantial number of local women who were not doing anything for the war effort to join one of the Women's Services, especially the ATS, or do some type of war work.

The Grand Hall at the Town Hall housed an exhibition called "Adventure Through Service" which provided information about the life in the ATS. Demonstrations were given of signals communication, radio location of enemy planes, cooking and transport. There were also exhibitions and demonstrations of work that was being performed by the munition worker, such as sheet metal work, welding, using lathes and instrument making. During the week six celebrities called for women to help in any way they could. Amongst them were familiar names, even to-day, such as Gert and Daisy (Elsie and Doris Waters), Mabel Constanduros and Freddy Grisewood.

The first Labour Mayor for Bournemouth, Alderman J.J.Empson, was elected on November 10th. A rumour suggested that his election was only because the Germans had said that they would shoot all Mayors when they invaded England! However he had been selected because of the great respect and esteem in which he was held by his fellow Councillors. At Christmas he sent a letter to all Bournemouth men who were Prisoners of War.

November also saw the proposal to stop the buses at 9.30 pm The Pavilion Ballroom and Concert Hall planned to close at 9 o'clock. Other entertainments made arrangements for the shows to finish earlier so that patrons and staff could catch the last bus home. This measure was to save petrol but it also applied to the trolley buses. However the time for the trolleys was extended to 10.15 pm, the reason given "to save hardship and inconvenience for many, especially HM Forces".

The Ministry of Health announced in November that more evacuees were to be sent to Bournemouth. To find accommodation for them a house-to-house canvass was made. This unfortunately did not prove successful so notices were placed in the local press asking for volunteers to house the children.

The Society of Friends (Quakers) proposed to the Council that they would like to send a Warden, his wife and two junior workers to help with the evacuees, especially those in hostels. They asked for a house to use as a social centre and somewhere that the evacuees could do dressmaking and their laundry, so 5 Wellington Road was provided to house the Friends' Relief Service Headquarters.

A club for boys and girls was run at the Headquarters and also women's meetings and other social activities were held there. A house in Hawkwood Road was used for forty elderly people from Portsmouth and Southampton.

Hostels available for evacuees at that time were:

11 Marlborough Road	ages 2-5	51 beds
53 Wellington Road	ages 2-5	25 beds
4 Milton Road	under 2	20 beds
12 Suffolk Road	Boys	28 beds
11 Argyll Road	Girls	25 beds

123 Redhill Drive was used as a receiving home with twelve beds and 16 Stourwood Avenue as a sick bay with thirty beds. 179 Belle Vue Road was requisitioned for the Hampshire Medical Officer of Health to use as a hostel for girl evacuees classed as difficult. Castlemain Children's Home, at 7 Castlemain Avenue, was acquired as a residential home for joint use by local children and unaccompanied evacuees under five, and 31 Wellington Road was also used as a day nursery.

The number of evacuees during the year had fallen from four thousand seven hundred and nine in February to one thousand nine hundred in December; nine hundred and seven from Southampton,

two hundred and fifty three from Portsmouth, four hundred and sixty eight from London and three hundred and forty two from other towns. Parties were arranged for them at Christmas in schools and also trips to the Theatre to see the Pantomime. The American Technical Corps held a party for thirty at Annerley Court, Christchuch Road. This year only a few children returned to their home towns for the festive season.

The third wartime Christmas started with a message from the Mayor, who asked everybody to shop early in the day "during the hours of daylight", because the Government had requested that the utmost economy should be exercised in the use of electricity and fuel. Shops were asked to reduce the amount of lighting used.

Toys had almost disappeared, there were few dolls or cuddly toys and stocking fillers were nonexistent. No pretty be-ribboned boxes of chocolates were to be found and under a Government Order wrapping paper was not available. Even the programmes for the Pavilion and other theatres were cut in size and no more town guide books were to be printed. Crackers, too, were not plentiful and the shops that did have them rationed their sales. Because of the clothes rationing any such gifts purchased still needed coupons and people did not want to give up their precious allocation to others. It is not to be wondered at that gift tokens were very popular!

For the first time thirty sixteen-year-old schoolboys volunteered to help the Post Office deliver the Christmas post. With the possibility that Christmas cards might be few and far between for the next year local people sent extra ones. Shopkeepers found that even though there wasn't the same variety as usual the demand was still as great. Turkeys and Christmas trees were also in short supply and bakers were not allowed to sell iced Christmas cakes, only plain ones.

The Government appealed to the public not to travel over the holiday period, but on the 23rd December the local newspapers reported that the trains to London from Bournemouth were full although most of the passengers were troops going home on leave.

For the residents having a stay-at-home holiday and the few visitors who had come the entertainments provided by the theatres and other places were generous. At the Pavilion the pantomime was Robinson Crusoe, whilst in the Ballroom tea and evening dances were held. The Municipal Orchestra gave concerts in the theatre in the mornings and the cinemas were open playing to full houses. The Hippodrome also staged a pantomime, Red Riding Hood.

The BWSO'S Hospitality Committee arranged for servicemen and women billeted locally to be entertained by local people over the festive season and sent over four thousand parcels to Bournemouthians serving in the Forces. There were many letters of appreciation from those who received them. ln fact the Hospitality Committee had been kept busy throughout the year. A report in November stated that in the previous month eight hundred and thirty servicemen and twelve ATS girls were entertained; six hundred and sixty seven in private houses, seventy three by the Overseas League and forty at a Pavilion dance. Since May 1940 fourteen thousand three hundred and seventeen men and women had enjoyed visiting and relaxing in someone's home, a welcome change from a dreary billet. A club for the Canadians and Australians was opened at the White Hermitage Hotel (now the Hermitage), Exeter Road, and the Bournemouth Imperial and Allied Services Social Club was at the Melville Hotel, Upper Terrace Road.

The "Bournemouth Queen", a familiar paddle steamer between the wars, which had been converted into a minesweeper, was adopted by the BWSO who provided the crew with parcels of games and books as well as a football and twenty two jerseys. St. George's Methodist Church at Boscombe sent one hundred and forty parcels containing eleven thousand articles of clothing to London, Bristol, Birmingham and Other towns for those people who had been bombed out and had lost all their belongings.

People in the news during 1941 included A.G. Hawkins, son of Bournemouth Doctor C.T.Hawkins, serving in the Merchant Navy. He was Second Officer on the "San Demetrio", a tanker which was part of a convoy attacked by the German pocket battleship "Admiral Scheer" on November 5th 1940. Although she was not hit then it was after the convoy had scattered that she became a target and set on fire. The crew abandoned ship, but two days later one of the lifeboats, under Second Officer

Hawkins, found the tanker and boarded it even though fires still burned. The sixteen men got the fires under control and restarted the engines. Hawkins, by skilful seamanship with no charts and no navigational instruments, brought the damaged ship back to the Clyde with the majority of its valuable cargo of petrol intact.

After repairs the "San Demetrio" returned to sea but was torpedoed and sunk on March 17th 1942. Second Officer Hawkins was awarded the OBE for gallantry. In 1943 a film was made of the incident entitled "San Demetrio - London". It was shown at local cinemas in January 1944.

A Bournemouth man, Bombardier Rosslin Young, Royal Artillery, was awarded the George Medal for saving eleven people from a burning house during an air raid on Belfast on 16th April 1941. The last person he rescued was a young girl, just two minutes before the roof collapsed into the building.

A member of the Bournemouth Battalion of the Home Guard was also awarded the George Medal for his gallantry during the London Blitz in September 1940. John Allan Stephenson, aged 19, was an ARP Warden in Holborn when a heavy bomb set fire to buildings and a burst water main flooded the streets. He rescued several people from the burning buildings. He moved to Bournemouth in November 1940 to work, staying at the YMCA in Westover Road.

Two more George Medals were awarded for acts of gallantry which occurred locally. It was reported in the town's newspapers that on 28th April Second Lieutenant Andrew Page Watson, The Lancashire Fusiliers, made a brave attempt to save an RAF pilot who bailed out of his Fairey Battle aircraft of the Special Duty Flight at Christchurch when it crashed into the sea some three hundred yards off Hengistbury Head. Lieutenant Watson was on duty on the Head and seeing the crash swam out to help the airman. However he was not able to free the unconscious pilot from his flying gear and parachute so, because of exhaustion, he had to abandon the rescue attempt. Unfortunately Pilot Officer James was drowned. On his way back Lieutenant Watson got into difficulties because of the rough, cold sea and the dangerously strong current. Second Lieutenant K.F Morrill and Lance Corporal L. Masterman went to his aid bringing him safely to shore. Lieutenant Watson was awarded the George Medal for his action and his two rescuers were mentioned in dispatches. Although badly wounded in the arm whilst serving in Burma he survived the war and now lives in Hampshire.

The other George Medal was awarded to Lieutenant Charles Ernest Davies, Royal Engineers, in October 1941 for "Conspicuous gallantry in carrying out hazardous work in a very brave manner".
This understatement covered his work in Bomb Disposal when, from 8th August 1940, he dealt with over four hundred unexploded bombs of all sizes. Some of these were local, twelve being dropped on the Airspeed factory at Somerford, Christchurch, on 10th May 1941. Sixteen bombs actually fell, four exploding. The other twelve, ten 50-kilogram and two 250-kilogram bombs, failed to go off and were made safe by Lieutenant Davies. The recommendation for the award concludes, "The Director of Bomb Disposal states that Lieutenant Davies has an outstanding record of courageous action and fine leadership during which his own safety has been completely disregarded".

Chapter Four

1942

The New Year started quietly for the traditional festivities were curtailed. Because of the blackout all Watchnight services were cancelled, as had been many Midnight Masses on Christmas Eve. Only the Church of the Epiphany and St. Clement's, Boscombe, held one. Many churches had switched back to afternoon, instead of evening, services at the beginning of October. The majority of New Year gatherings were held in the home, families having their own parties, and being careful when "first footing" not to break the blackout. Even the Bournemouth Caledonian Society did not have their usual Hogmanay celebration.

A nationwide Waste Paper Campaign came into force in January. Waste paper of every description, cardboard, newspaper, Christmas cards, wrapping, etc. was taken to reception centres set up at newsagents' shops. At the Town Hall the staff turned out old records, files and out of date byelaws. Some of these were stored in the attics and were thick with dust. The staff made good, if unofficial, use of their gas masks whilst moving the salvage! The Mayor was presented with a cheque for £500 13s ld on 30th January, the proceeds of the sale of all the waste paper collected during the month long campaign. This was sent to Mrs. Churchill's Red Cross Aid to Russia Fund.

Two months later in March a new Salvage Order came into force making it a punishable offence to "burn or destroy paper or cardboard, to throw it away, to dispose of it otherwise than to a collector or buyer, to put it in a refuse bin or to mix it with refuse". lt had to be bundled up and put next to the dustbin for collection.

Nearly fifty tons of books and paper were collected in another waste paper drive in June. A "novel" way was used when six lines of books along the pavement were started from different parts of the Borough ending at the Town Hall, twenty miles in all. The sorting points were Tuckton Bridge, lford Bridge, Ashley Road, Howard Road, the Hollies Pub in Wimborne Road and Bournemouth Pier.
All the books were taken to the Borough Engineer's Depot at Grafton Road where they were sorted through, some to go to replenish bomb damaged public libraries, some to the Forces, and the remainder baled up for pulping as waste paper.

Soap went on ration in February. There was no need to register so it could be purchased against coupons from any shop stocking the kind required. In March the clothing ration was cut from sixty six coupons to fifty one. At the same time the making of double-breasted suits for men and putting turn-ups on trousers was prohibited, saving thousands of yards of material.

No coupons were required, however, for dried eggs. These were obtained from the grocer with whom the housewife was registered for eggs. They could be used for almost any purpose for which ordinary eggs were suitable, except boiling. The allocation was one tin per ration book every four weeks. On the tin was a notice "This can is steel. Save for salvage".

The first case of food wasting was heard in May at the Magistrates Court. The defendant threw away whole loaves, parts of loaves and buns. Some of the bread was nearly fresh and only about a day old, the evidence being found by the Dustmen. The case was found to be proved and a fine of £3 imposed.

The Food Control Office moved in January to an empty Hotel, Pine Court, Gervis Road, vacating the Popular Restaurant at the Pavilion. The fourth British Restaurant was opened in its place on June 6th by the Mayor, Alderman J.J. Empson. A week later it was reported that two thousand five hundred luncheons and teas per day were being served there. lt had been designed to serve one thousand five hundred customers a day. Experience in other British Restaurants showed that diners took between seventeen and twenty minutes for their meals. The original plan for building a British Restaurant in the grounds of the Winter Gardens had been found impractical owing to the time and cost factor. Pine Court now houses the local offices of the Property Services Agency, Department of the Environment.

The Transport Committee in February authorised the General Manager of the Corporation Transport to apply to the Ministry of War Transport for permission to purchase four double-docker Guy-Gardner wartime motor buses and six 32-seater single-docker Bedford motor buses, which had wooden slat seats instead of upholstered ones, saving rubber, moquette and other materials. The first austerity bus was delivered in September. The Echo reported in July 1943 that the passengers "enjoyed the experience of sitting on garden seats in the utility buses because of the compensation of having large clear windows to view the passing scene". Because of the shortage of motor buses in the town arrangements were made to hire a number of London-type double-decker buses. These were painted red and had an outside staircase to the upper deck at the rear. Later the War Department released six Thornycroft motor buses and the Corporation purchased these as well as two Bedford 32-seater buses for which they had already applied. The Transport Committee also approved the transfer of nine Bournemouth trolley buses from London to Newcastle to meet their urgent needs.

Regular bus passengers, men and women, who were willing to assist the conductor during rush hours, were recruited early in the year. They stood on the rear platform regulating the number of passengers boarding the bus and making sure that they got off safely, ringing the bell to signal the driver when to start and stop, and announcing the names of the bus stops, very necessary in the blackout, whilst the conductor collected the fares. They had to wear an official blue and gold armlet when on duty, but travelled free. However when not on duty they had to pay full fare.

With the increased use of the buses during the rush hours many people at the stops in Old Christchurch Road and the Lansdowne were not able to get on the crowded trolleys from the Square. So to give them a chance a turning circle was constructed at Horseshoe Common in April. Some of the trolley buses cut short their journey to the Square during the day by using the turning circle and starting their journey back to the outskirts of the town from there. For safety reasons the circle was not in operation during the blackout.

The voluntary queuing which had started in 1941 was mainly ignored by the majority of passengers who still made a dash to board the buses. At the Fisherman's Walk bus stop although there was a notice asking people to "Form a queue this side", this was not complied with until someone stretched a piece of string from the bus stop pole to the next lamp standard. From then the Echo reported "the queue position has been a tremendous success".

So the Ministry of War Transport issued the "Regulation of Traffic (Formation of Queues) Order 1942, which came into force in April, to make queuing compulsory. This required people to form a two-deep queue "when six or more are waiting" and then "to board the bus in an orderly way". This was to happen even if there was not an official sign. At first these arrangements were not an outstanding success, but by the third day the habit was beginning to form.

In November an advertisement in the local papers told the travelling public that the last buses from the Square on weekdays and Sundays, trolley or petrol, would leave the Square at 9 pm from Sunday 6th December. Also on Sundays there would be no service before 1 pm except for Sunday workers holding yellow identification cards.

The Royal Blue Express Service to London, the Midlands, South Wales and the West Country no longer operated from October and the rest of the services closed down in November. However some services to Southampton, Exeter, Yeovil and Trowbridge were still run. The Hants and Dorset bus station and the railway station displayed posters enquiring "ls your journey really necessary?"

Easter was a quiet holiday, with no Hot Cross Buns available on Good Friday again. The

Government's pleas not to travel were heeded making it a stay-at-home holiday. There were, as usual, some strollers on the promenade and in the pleasure gardens, but there were no holiday crowds. A few shops were open on the Good Friday, April 3rd, whilst the British Restaurants seemed to be the only restaurants available. However the cinemas were open, and well patronised. Easter Sunday and Monday were the same, local residents spending their time in their gardens or resting. There were few private cars to be seen on the roads and in the car parks. Motorists were saving up petrol because of the restrictions to come. Earlier in the year there had been a drastic reduction in van deliveries from shops within two miles of the Square to save petrol and tyres and to release man power. Laundries were restricted to one collection from houses each week and the baker to three deliveries, except to catering establishments.

The basic petrol ration for private motor cars ceased to exist on June 30th. From then vehicles were not to be used for pleasure and only under exceptional circumstances was petrol allocated for domestic use. Having a car did not entitle the owner to have petrol to run it. The absolute limit for essential shopping journeys was enough petrol for two trips each week to the nearest shopping centre for those who lived on the outskirts or in the country. If public transport was available then no ration was allowed. Many people offered their vehicles to the Civil Defence for the duration of the war or laid them up in their garages.

The Town Clerk reported to the Beach and Pavilion Committee in April that the Garrison Commander proposed to recommend to the military authorities that the whole of the seafront, including the promenades, should be closed to the public; however this was not proceeded with. Notices on the Undercliff prohibited entry to the beach and one pointed out that there were no air raid shelters along the promenade, and those "strolling along the beach drive do so at their own risk". Another read, "Access to the beach and foreshore, promenades, cliffs and piers are prohibited, except that between sunrise and sunset only access is permitted to the promenades the limits of which are indicated by notice boards". Several people were fined at different times for disregarding these instructions and going into prohibited areas.

The Times and Directory, 24th July, related that four secondary school evacuees from Southampton ignored the warning notices and got through the barbed wire of the beach defences. One, disregarding the advice given in schools not to touch anything strange, picked up an object and threw it against the sea wall. It exploded and two of the boys were injured, needing hospitalisation. Exactly where this tragedy took place was not revealed.

After an action on 18th June in the Channel against a German convoy HMS Albrighton anchored off Bournemouth Pier to make temporary repairs before sailing on to Portland.

Visitors and residents were disappointed that there was no possibility of sea bathing during the summer. A surprisingly large number of visitors came with their bathing costumes thinking that they could bathe as they had prewar. Although the swimming baths were open no other provision was made to cater for the bather. There had been requests for river bathing to be provided, such as had been enjoyed by the Boys' Brigade at Grove Farm, Iford, but this did not materialise.

The first raid of the year occurred at Whitsun. A local resident recorded in his diary that on the Sunday night the five hundred and fifth Alert sounded. He wrote, "From fifteen minutes before midnight until 1.55 am the most persistent and realistic incident so far experienced. Very lights and other effects, bombs and heavy gunfire. It seemed as if we were in for a Blitz, but the local damage was mainly in and around Poole, but included several bombs in the Upper Pleasure Grounds and sports grounds on West Cliff. Two of the bombs fell between ARP Centre and Town Hall (One delayed action). Betty and Jane were glad to be able to use the Morrison Shelter which had only been completed the previous day".

In the early hours of Whit Monday 25th May, the centre of the town was the target. A high explosive bomb fell in the Upper Pleasure Gardens between the rear of Bealesons (now the Avenue Centre) and the War Memorial at fifteen minutes past midnight, making a crater fifty five feet across and fifteen feet deep. The blast and the flying debris caused damage to the properties in the vicinity, Fairlight Glen, the ARP Offices, and other buildings in Avenue Road were amongst these. The Town

Hall lost many windows whilst the Richmond Hill Congregational Church had its War Memorial Window broken and also sustained damage to the Manse. In all one hundred and forty one properties suffered some sort of damage.

When the bomb site was examined an unexploded bomb was found close by. The area was cordoned off and the Bomb Disposal Team sent for. Luckily there was only one casualty, a fire-watcher, who was only slightly hurt. Forty five minutes later, at 1 o'clock, the West Cliff was attacked. Twenty two houses suffered minor damage when two bombs hit the tennis courts and the bowling green in Argyll Gardens, whilst two more exploded on the cliff itself. Were these destined for "Falaise", West Overcliff Drive, which was then being used as the HQ for 126 Light Anti-Aircraft Regiment?

It was reported in the Echo the next day that a policeman had been asked by a lady where she could get a bus which would take her on a tour of the bomb damage! Then on the 28th May, seventy two hours after it had fallen, the unexploded bomb in the Upper Pleasure Gardens went off. It had landed on the bank of the Bourne Stream which had flowed into the crater so that when it exploded mud and water were showered over the whole area. The War Memorial was covered with mud and slime needing the Fire Brigade to clean it with the help of one of their pumps. Mud and earth were also scattered over Bourne Avenue and the Town Hall drive. Council workmen were called in to clean up the area. Avenue Road and Bourne Avenue were closed to traffic until 11 am on the 29th May because more UXBs were suspected, but none were found. Buses which normally used Bourne Avenue to the Square went via St. Stephen's Road and Richmond Hill, and to avoid Avenue Road the Hants and Dorset buses went along West Hill Road, then down Priory Hill to the Exeter Road Bus Station.

The following is a copy of the official report on this incident by the ARP Controller to the Civil Defence Committee:

From: The A.R.P. Controller, Bournemouth
To : The Members of the Civil Defence Cornmittee (For Information)

Air Raid Incident 25.5.1942

At 00.08 hours on the 25th May, 1942, flares were reported at West Howe, Kinson. At 00.25 hours bomb in Upper Pleasure Gardens causing damage to gardens and properties in Avenue Road, Bourne Avenue, Town Hall, Congregational Church and St. Stephen's Road. One casualty was reported.

All roads in the vicinity were blocked with debris. Storm Sewer was broken. Bourne Avenue and Avenue Road were closed to pedestrians and traffic. There was damage to gas and water mains.

At 00.50 report was received that a man had collapsed in shelter at Old Christchurch Road, and was later found to be dead; body was taken to Mortuary.

At 01.14 hours H.E. bombs were reported in Argyle Gardens, Westcliff, found to be in Corporation Bowling Green, water mains damaged, roads were covered with debris. There were no casualties.

Reports were received from several areas that UXBs were suspected, all their reports were unfounded.

The A.R.P. Headquarters in Avenue Road has suffered severe damage to roof and windows. First Aid repairs are in hand. A shop opposite Fairlight Glen has been requisitioned for the stores.

The Town Hall had most of its windows broken. The majority have now been replaced.

At 00.05 on the 28th May an unreported U.X.B. exploded in the Pleasure Gardens near crater

made during raid on 25.5.42. Slight damage only was caused. Bourne Avenue and Avenue Road were closed to traffic from the time of the incident until 11 am on the 29th May on account of a further suspected U.X.B. There were no casualties during this incident.

Casualties (25.5.42)	1 man died in shelter from a heart attack
	5 casualties (slightlv wounded)

Damage to properties - There were 26 houses, 40 flats and 5 hotels and Boarding Houses slightly damaged.

On Saturday 6th June at 5.15 pm, before the Alert had sounded, three high explosive bombs fell in Gervis, Parsonage and Southcote Roads. A large number of people in the town centre heard the roar of aircraft engines and the rattle of machine gun fire, then the whistle of the bombs. One hit Hill Lodge in Parsonage Road where three people were having tea in the garden, one woman was killed when a tree fell on her. Two other people were seriously hurt by flying glass from windows in the town. Another casualty died the next day in hospital from injuries.

The Anglo-Swiss Hotel in Gervis Road received a direct hit from a bomb dropped by a ME 109 on the games room and some of the bedrooms. Several Of the Canadian airmen billeted there, because of the lack of a warning, had not gone to the trenches dug at the back of the Municipal College and were trapped in the rubble. One RCAF airman was rescued only after his leg, trapped by a steel beam, had been amputated by a doctor. Unfortunately Pilot Officer Bailey died on his way to hospital. Two other Canadians were also killed. All three are buried in the War Graves Plot in the North Cemetery.
It was also reported that several American airmen had been killed, but this was never confirmed.

The third bomb damaged the railway sidings at the back of Southcote Road. In all four hundred and fifty four properties were damaged and two civilians killed, plus nine injured. A number of German planes were involved in this raid, at least one being shot down. Although eye witnesses watched a plane crash into the sea the "kill" by a Spitfire pilot was not confirmed.

One Canadian remembers that William Joyce, Lord Haw Haw, had warned the RCAF staying in the town that the Luftwaffe would be paying them a visit. Lord Haw Haw went on to say that if those airmen in the Anglo-Swiss looked at the clock in the Hotel they would see that it was ten minutes slow ! lt appears that he wasn't far out. However this remark was supposed to have been made about clocks in towns all over the country.

No bombs fell after that incident for the rest of the year, but the siren still sounded frequently. The following gives some idea of how often it was heard:

July	18 Alerts	13 days free
August	56 Alerts	6 days free
September	39 Alerts	12 days free
October	37 Alerts	not known
November	10 Alerts	not known
December	3 Alerts	not known

Displays, parades and exhibitions were held at various times during the year to provide information on different aspects of the war and service life and also to raise money for the war effort.

The first was the Civil Defence Parade on Sunday, 22nd February. Two thousand members of the Armed Services marched along Bath Road into Westover Road with the Home Guard and NFS bands providing the music. The Home Guard, NFS, Wardens, Fire Guards, Police and Special Constables were also represented. After the march Sir Harry Haig, the Regional Commissioner addressed them in the Westover Cinema.

Warship Week ran from Saturday, 28th February to Sunday, March 8th. Bournemouth residents were asked to lend the Government £1,250,000, the cost of the hull of a cruiser. The week started with

"an imposing parade" of the three Services with the salute taken outside the Pavilion by Admiral of the Fleet Lord Chatfield. ln the parade as well as the Royal Marines, WAAF, Canadian and Australian airmen, there was a model of HMS Warrior, AA guns, Pom Pom guns mounted on a lorry, Bren gun carriers, a tank, an armoured car and five military bands. Whilst above the crowds lining the route a Sunderland flying boat flew at roof top level.

The Home Guard had Church Parades at St. Peter's and St. John's, Boscombe, on the Sunday; and during the week concerts were held at the Pavilion and the Hippodrome. The National Fire Service Concert Party, "Colours and Bells" performed at the Central Fire Station in Holdenhurst Road and the Royal Army Service Corps Unit, stationed in the town, put on an amateur production of "French Leave", a comedy.

Everyday at 12 o 'clock the crowd gathered at the savings indicator on the bus shelter in the Square to see the latest figure displayed. This was heralded by a fanfare of trumpets and the final figure of £2,059,013 was greeted with delight! This enabled Bournemouth to "adopt" HMS Phoebe, a "Dido" class cruiser, named after one of the daughters of the god Uranus and the goddess Gaia. She was one of ten ships in this class and had been launched in 1939. The seventh vessel to carry the name, HMS Phoebe had already been in action in the Mediterranean. Her battle honours included Greece, Crete, the Malta Convoys, Sabang and Burma. She survived the war and was broken up in 1956. A replica of her badge was presented in July 1943 for permanent exhibition in the Town Hall. It can be seen in the Hall of Remembrance and there is also a plaque marking the adoption in the corridor opposite. At the same ceremony a Bournemouth coat of arms was given to Phoebe to hang in the wardroom. Also Alderman J.J. Empson presented "The Phoebe March" written by Percy Whitlock, the Borough Organist.

Lord Kindersley, President of the National Savings Committee, wrote to the Mayor, Alderman J.J. Empson, expressing thanks for the collection. He said "This fine effort resulting in the adoption of HMS Phoebe will forge a close link between the people of Bournemouth and the Royal Navy". These links continued after the war and HMS Phoebe, and her successor, paid several visits to the town.

The Comforts for the Forces Committee of the BWSO supplied the crew, with games, books and other things to make their lives aboard easier. The "Bournemouth Queen" was not forgotten, and gifts were sent again to her crew. The Committee also sent comforts to the crews of the five tanks purchased with money collected in the "Tanks for Attack campaign" for which the National Savings Committee received a Certificate of Honour signed by Sir James Grigg, the Old Bournemouthian, who was Secretary of State for War. Each tank had "Bournemouth" inscribed on it together with the names of two districts of the town. The districts were named after the ten main Savings Groups: Boscombe, Charminster, lford, Kinson, Malmesbury Park, Moordown, Queen's Park, Southbourne, Westbourne and Winton.

At Christmas 1941 over five thousand parcels had been sent to Bournemouthians serving in the Forces and thirty big parcels to individual Army Units. The parishioners at St. John's, Moordown, despatched twenty parcels every week to church members all over the world.

The BWSO organised Christmas parcels for the third year running in 1942, except that they were only sent to those serving abroad, estimated at one thousand. However the Committee continued to do as much as possible to brighten the lives of those stationed in the district and far from home over the festive season.

At Marks and Spencer in Commercial Road (now Orchard Walk), the Ministry of Information held an exhibition in April which showed the tank from a heap of scrap through the factory to the front line. Then on Saturday, 22nd August, at Dean Court football ground there was a display in aid of the RAF Benevolent Fund which raised over £400. The chief attraction was the 1931 Schneider Trophy winner S6b, designed by R.J. Mitchell, the forerunner of the Spitfire. Also on show were RAF and German equipment, an aircraft gun turret and a mobile RAF canteen. There were numerous side shows, the Moordown Flight of the ATC gave a drill display and as usual there was a fly past by a Spitfire. The RAF Benevolent Fund also benefited from a Boxing Tournament, £121, and a Cricket Tournament, £38.



CERTIFICATE OF HONOUR

IN RECOGNITION OF THE SPECIAL EFFORT IN THE "TANKS FOR ATTACK" CAMPAIGN 1942 WHICH EARNED FOR *Bournemouth Savings Committee* THE PRIVILEGE OF NAMING *Five* TANKS UPON WHICH APPROPRIATELY INSCRIBED PLATES HAVE BEEN PLACED

I EXTEND SINCERE THANKS FOR THIS VALUABLE CONTRIBUTION TO THE WAR EFFORT, AND ASK YOUR ACCEPTANCE OF THIS CERTIFICATE OF HONOUR AS A PERMANENT RECORD OF YOUR ACHIEVEMENT

P. J. Grigg

SECRETARY OF STATE FOR WAR

'ANKS FOR ATTACK" CAMPAIGN • 1942

This Certificate was presented to the town for funding the cost of five tanks.

The United Women's Services Recruiting Campaign started on 21st November. Its aim was to encourage women to join one of the three Services. It was held in Hartwell's Car Showrooms in Bourne Avenue. There the ATS and the WAAF demonstrated their work on anti-aircraft tracking, on barrage balloons (using a miniature one), on the maintenance of aero engines and of meteorological instruments. Displays of physical training and exercises were given during the five days by the ATS Demonstration Team. They also gave several shows during the summer at different venues, such as the United Services Sports Day in August in front of five thousand spectators. They also gave demonstrations of drill and physical training at Kings' Park, Winton Recreational Ground and in the Lower Pleasure Gardens. There was also a Church Parade at St. Peter's on Sunday, 22nd November, with an all women procession of one hundred WAAF, one hundred ATS and fifty WRNS, marching to the Band of the Royal Canadian Air Force. At the Hippodrome, Boscombe, a pageant by the members of the Forces was the highlight of a Concert.

There was controversy over the hospitality that the people of Bournemouth were offering to the Commonwealth Forces stationed in the town. Several letters were published in the local papers comparing what was being given to RAF men in Canada on pilot training with that provided here. Letters in reply pointed out that rationing made it difficult to serve up substantial meals. However the BWSO reported that seven thousand men and women from the Forces, including several Americans, had been received into people's homes during the year. In all over twenty thousand visits had been arranged since 1940. The Echo reported in September, under the headline "Britons are swell say the Canadians", that tribute was paid to the residents of Bournemouth for their hospitality. A newly arrived Canadian airman said he could "walk down the street and say Good Morning to quite a few people".

American servicemen were now being billeted in the town, and on Thanksgiving Day, 26th November, they celebrated with a dance at the Pavilion, where "jitterbugging replaced waltzes and slow foxtrots". The Director of the American Red Cross Clubs in an interview in the Echo, 14th November, stated that "The Red Cross has just opened a first-class club at Miramar, Grove Road, and this is to be followed by the opening of clubs at Granville Court (now part of the Heathlands Hotel, Grove Road) and Trouville (Priory Road); and in a few months these will be merged into one club at Marsham Court (East Cliff). These clubs are to serve American soldiers on leave from distant points and will give the American soldier as near a home atmosphere as possible. He will be able to sleep in the clubs, have meals, entertainment and dances - everything will be done to make a break from Army life and discipline as complete as possible". The staff of the clubs were primarily British, some were paid, others were volunteers.

A new hostel and canteen were opened by the Church Army at 18 Tower Road for use by HM Forces. There they could have bed, breakfast and a bath for 2s 6d (12½p), cubicles being provided for both men and women. The Church Army also opened a Services canteen at the Wilberforce Hotel, Holdenhurst Road, and the Black Cat hut at the West Railway Station.

The Hahnemann Convalescent Home on the West Cliff was used as an auxiliary hospital for the care of members of the Forces who had been discharged from military hospitals but were not fit enough to go to a convalescent camp. It had fifty beds and was opened on Saturday August 22nd by Lady Louis Mountbatten. It was staffed mainly by the Officers and Members of the Order of St. John.

The wounded and convalescent soldiers from both Fairmile and Hahnemann Hospitals were supplied with free passes for the cinemas and theatres. They were invited to tea at private houses and in cafes they found that people insisted on paying their bill. The Corporation Transport Committee arranged for members of the Forces in hospital blue to receive free passes for the town's buses.

The residents of Bath Hill Court had to move out in February when it was needed to house Sergeants of the RCAF posted to No.3 RCAF Personnel Reception Centre. The Winter Gardens Indoor Bowling Green, closed since the outbreak of war, and used as a furniture store, was taken over as a Mess Hall and the RAF were also allowed the use of the empty East Beach cafe.

The Children's Welfare and Evacuees Committee distributed ten thousand three hundred and one garments during 1941 to needy children. However from January 1942 the difficulties the Committee had in obtaining clothes were lessened by the Government Clothing Scheme by which children

evacuated without their parents were supplied with their clothing needs by the Government.

A residential nursery was established at "The Knole", Knyveton Road, the home of Henry Page Croft, first Baron Croft, Bournemouth's MP from 1918 to 1940, after it was no longer required as Headquarters for the 11th Infantry Brigade. This was managed by the Red Cross and St. John Ambulance, and housed delicate evacuees from London and Portsmouth.

At Easter Southampton Grammar School for Girls, which had been sharing with the Bournemouth School for Girls at the Lansdowne, and also using the Temperance Hall at Boscombe as well as St. Peter's Hall, moved to the Wentworth School building at Southbourne. This allowed BSG to return to full-time education. The Wentworth building had originally been the marine residence of Lord Portman and was one of the first mansions to be built of concrete. Much of the gravel used was dug up in the grounds and large quantities of pebbles were brought from the sea shore. Later additions were of brick but rendered to match. The Borough Council had in January 1942 considered whether Wentworth could be used as alternative office accommodation if the Town Hall had been damaged or destroyed by enemy action. However this idea was not proceeded with.

The Bournemouth and District Committee for Refugees, which had been disbanded when the majority of local aliens had been either interned or ordered out of the coastal area, was reconstituted as the Bournemouth Refugee Committee in January. Funded by donations and a subsidy from the Home Office it had three main tasks:-

1. To care for the sixty or so refugees under the age of sixteen who had been allowed to stay
2. To help the sixty adult refugees, mainly elderly Czechs and Poles, still living in the district
3. To keep in touch with former refugees who had been residents and now were elsewhere and who had left property in the town.

It also arranged employment in shops and offices for those requiring work, especially the boys and girls. One alien was fined £2 in April for breaching the regulations which prohibited an alien entering a protected area without permission.

The music scene improved during the year. At the beginning of the war the Municipal Orchestra had been cut in size to thirty five musicians. Then in the following April it was reduced even further to twenty four. Now the Corporation decided to restore it to symphonic strength again by augmenting it to thirty five. The Council held a special meeting on 16th March 1942 to discuss this enlargement, but the resolution which was tabled against the proposal was defeated. The Echo published a letter on the same day by Sir Dan Godfrey's daughter praising the move and pointing out that the music played gave pleasure and relaxation to the members of the Forces as well as to civilians.

Bournemouth staged the first seaside wartime music festival in the country in March when the Bournemouth Music Festival opened with Sir Henry Wood conducting the London Philharmonic Orchestra. A festival of Chamber music of the Allied Nations was held in April and May, this received widespread attention and acclaim.

The Army Cadet Force came into being in April. It's aim was to provide basic army training for boys aged 14 to 16, then at the age of 17 they could transfer to the Home Guard. The Headquarters was established at 6 Wellington Road in May where boys could go to enrol. At the start there were platoons at the Pokesdown Boys' Club and St. Walburga's, Charminster Road, later others were formed in different parts of the town. Members of the Army Cadet Force and the Air Training Corps aged sixteen could volunteer for part-time messenger duty with the ARP, NFS and the Police Auxiliary Messenger Service. The Cadets wore the uniform of their Corps with a Civil Defence armlet when on duty. They were needed during and immediately after an incident.

Girls 16 to 18 who wanted to receive preliminary training for the Women's Royal Naval Service (WRNS) could join the local unit of the Girls' Naval Training Corps. Later on in the year a Girls' Training Corps Unit was formed in the town. This gave pre-service training which was applicable to all the women's services and also for Nursing and the Land Army. For those in reserved occupations, who might not be called up at all, this training provided an insight into the services and helped them gain confidence. Girls could prepare for the Women's Auxiliary Air Force (WAAF) through the

Bournemouth Cadette Squad, British League of Aviation Ladies Cadette Corps.

The Home Guard saw changes during the year. In January the Home Secretary announced that the right of members of the Home Guard to resign had been withdrawn. Later compulsory enlistment came into force for men from eighteen up to forty one, with those between eighteen and twenty five being called first. On lst May the local National Service Department began to send out forms to all the six hundred men between eighteen and forty one who were registered for military service. On this form they were to record any objections that they had to joining the Home Guard. So by its second birthday the Home Guard had ceased to be a voluntary force and its members had been split into two categories. The first contained those men who had to be available immediately at any emergency, and the second was composed of those who, owing to the essential nature of their work, would be required to continue carrying out their normal duties until the last possible moment.

During a combined Army and RAF demonstration of an air attack held at Imber Down on Salisbury Plain, on April 13th, a Hurricane of 175 Squadron from Warmwell accidentally fired at a spectators' enclosure instead of dummy vehicles and troops, killing twenty five officers and injuring sixty. Amongst the injured was Major W.J. Calderwood of B Company, 7th Hants Home Guard Boscombe. Several other officers from Bournemouth and Poole were also wounded. The Hurricane pilot, William McLaclan, an American serving with the RCAF was found guilty of an error of judgement by a Board of Enquiry. Unfortunately he was killed in action in June when making an attack on enemy shipping in the Channel. An article on the incident, entitled "Friendly fire", written by Major Calderwood's son, was published in the Saga Magazine July/August 1992.

Another Home Guard, Sergeant F.W.J. Butt, E Company, 6th Bournemouth Battalion, died of his injuries sustained during another exercise and demonstration on Sunday 26th July. In all seven members of the Home Guard are named in the Bournemouth list of war dead at the Town Hall.

At Christchurch the Airspeed factory constructed Horsa gliders to carry airborne troops, whilst the training of the pilots for them was being carried out at Hurn where eighteen gliders arrived in September 1942 to form a Glider Pilot Regiment flight.

In his "The skies over Throop 1940-1950 and beyond..." Fred Mayne remembers seeing Horsa gliders in trouble, casting off from the towing aircraft and having to land in the field along the side of the Stour which still had posts to prevent invading enemy aircraft landing.

Vera Brittain, the author of "Testament of Youth" and other well-known books and pamphlets, visited Bournemouth on Saturday 4th July to speak at a meeting of the local Peace Pledge Union on "The Shape of the future".

In her "Diary 1939-1945: Wartime Chronicle" she records that she stayed with a friend and her husband. He worked at an ice cream factory which was to close in the October. Her friend was a typist in the Board of Trade offices which had been moved down from London. From her Vera Brittain learned of the rumours that all the Government offices were to return because of the "second front" and that all Bournemouth was to be evacuated. The town would have then been taken over by the Army, but exactly what for nobody knew!

Changes occurred in the Civil Defence for the Joint Committee of the three local authorities, Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch, set up just before the beginning of the war, was dissolved in February, the Joint Committee being seen to sense no useful purpose and appearing to be interfering with the affairs of the Boroughs. From then each Borough became responsible for the organisation of the Civil Defence, its administration and operation, in its own town with its own Controller. However the three Boroughs remained as a Group for the purpose of mutual help and support. There was a Group Co-ordinating Officer for the three towns, Councillor Harry Mears, the Bournemouth Controller, being appointed to this post. As well as his Bournemouth duties he exercised some very important functions such as sending reinforcements from one area to another, liaising with the Police, the National Fire Service and the local military authorities. These operations were directed from the Bournemouth Town Hall basement. The Bournemouth Centre still received from the Regional Centre at Reading the Regional Controller's messages regarding operational matters for transmission to Christchurch and Poole. All reports of attacks and requests for help from the conurbation and the

Region were directed there, the Group Co-ordinator having to deploy the rescue services to the best advantage.

When an incident was reported to the Bournemouth Centre the necessary services, Fire, Ambulance, Rescue, etc., were sent to the scene and an Incident Post set up nearby. Here all reports on damage, casualties and other matters were co-ordinated before being sent to the Centre, so as to prevent confusion. The Centre then only received accurate information and not a lot of conflicting reports. The local First Aid Posts were manned by Doctors, Nurses and trained First Aiders, and the Rest Centres would then be opened for the bombed out or those made temporarily homeless because of a delayed action bomb.

A Census of the whole-time members of the Civil Defence was made in March. All Air Raid Wardens, Police War Reservists and all other full-time paid personnel had to register. "The object of the industrial registration is to ascertain to what extent the services contain men and women who would be able to give more effective service to the war effort by being released permanently, or temporarily, for other employment" . Not included in the registration were two hundred Special Constables. When war broke out they were mobilised and in its early weeks were on duty every day performing regular police work in all weathers. Later this became every third day. As well as being Policemen the Specials continued to perform their usual jobs.

At the end of March Fire Guard Street Leaders were instructed to check whether householders in their areas were filling their baths with water when the Alert sounded and if the water buckets kept Outside the house ready for emergencies were full and checked regularly. Many Leaders discovered that the buckets had disappeared. The explanation was found to be that a large number of housewives had been using their buckets to help in their spring cleaning!

The Fire Guard was expanded to include women between twenty and forty five on a compulsory basis in the Autumn. Fire protection duty had been obligatory in business premises for men only, but now it was extended to women both for business premises and in residential areas, together with compulsory training. In order to identify Head and Senior Fire Guards and their deputies their steel helmets had the letters FG painted on them.

The Fire Brigade erected more static water tanks in many parts of the town to provide emergency water supplies to fight fires. Some held as much as one hundred thousand gallons, such as the one in Meyrick Road where the College car park is now, whilst others were much smaller; for example the tank on Peter's Hill, Winton, which held forty three thousand gallons. The danger of children playing on the tanks and using them to sail toy boats was recognised and paling fences were erected around each one. Wire netting was used to cover the top as well. However later on this was thought to be more dangerous than leaving the tanks open as the children climbed up and walked on the mesh. So angle irons leaning outwards were fitted to the paling fences and surmounted with barbed wire to prevent the children scaling the fence and getting on the mesh. Unfortunately these precautions did not stop one lady from committing suicide in a SWS tank in September 1943. Chemicals were added to the water, which could become stagnant, to prevent the breeding of mosquitoes, and the Medical Officer of Health reported at intervals on the hygiene of the basins. One tank placed in the garden of a large house used as an Army billet became a pond for the ducks and geese kept for their eggs!

In August 1943 it was revealed that when the SWS tanks had been cleaned out by the NFS, dead dogs, chickens, cats, pots and pans, bricks, parts of bicycles, a bath and a head of a swordfish complete with sword had been found. In one tank four pounds of sausages, which could have blocked the pumps, were discovered!

The NFS proposed in January to place six inch steel pipes in the road gutters to provide water in sufficient quantities to fight fires and to refill the static water basins in case of emergency. The Roads Committee requested that the pipes be painted white at intervals, and at bus stops, to help people see them in the blackout and that where they crossed roads they be placed underground. To feed these pipes platforms were constructed at various points so that heavy pumping units could be used, either on the river banks or on the seafront. These sites were established on the Stour at Redhill and at Iford Bridge, on the Bourne in the Lower Pleasure Gardens and on the western side of Boscombe Pier. The

pipeline from Redhill fed the SWS basins beside the library at Winton and St. Luke's Church Hall.

In order to safeguard the family in the home from air raids individual shelters were provided. There were two types, the Anderson, an outdoor shelter, and the Morrison for use indoors, The Anderson, named after Sir John Anderson, Parliamentary Under Secretary of State for the Home Office, was made of corrugated steel, six feet high, four and a half feet wide and six and a half feet long. lt had to be buried in the ground with at least fifteen inches of soil on its curved roof. Steps, or a slope, had to be constructed to the entrance. Inside it was cold, damp and cramped. However many people made the inside as comfortable as they could with seats and even bunk beds. When the weather was bad water lay on the floor and had to be bailed out. As the Anderson was in the garden, when the Alert was sounded the occupants of the house had to rush out for safety. Not too difficult during the day, but at night clothes had to be found before going out into the dark and cold, especially during the winter months. Some of the shelters built in the garden still exist, appearing in Estate Agents' details as "interesting features" when the property is put up for sale.

During 1940 Herbert Morrison, the Home Secretary, was the instigator of a new design of shelter, inevitably named the "Morrison", which was to be erected inside the house. lt was a massive steel structure rather like a table, designed to be placed on the bottom floor of the house. There were two models. One, a single tier, measuring six and a half feet by four feet and two feet five inches high, was for two adults and up to two children. The other one, a double tier, was for the larger family. The sides were made of wire mesh and the bottom of slatted lathes which provided a fairly comfortable base to support a mattress. The two tier model had another base halfway up so a family of four or more could sleep in reasonable comfort. To build one from its component parts took two people approximately two hours. The Home Guard and the Wardens were called upon to erect them for elderly people. ln order to show the public what the Morrison looked like a display of the two models was held at the Gas and Water Showrooms at Horseshoe Common and at Boscombe. Many cases occurred of houses being wrecked but the occupants were found to be safe in their Morrison.

Originally not many Morrison shelters were sent to Bournemouth, and the applications for them exceeded the allocation, but in 1942 there was a change of policy and the Civil Defence Committee minutes reported that three thousand indoor shelters would be available, preferential treatment being given first to householders who had not been provided with a shelter nearby, and then to those who had been provided with a blast wall only. Both types of shelter, Anderson and Morrison, were supplied free to families whose income was below £350. The cost to others was £7 for the Anderson and single tier Morrison, and £9 15s for the double. Morrisons were also placed in schools and some Wardens Posts.

A full scale mock invasion, and Civil Defence exercise, was held on Saturday 16th and Sunday 17th May. The simulated attack started on the Saturday with an air raid which covered the town from one end to the other. Fleet Air Arm planes "bombed" the town destroying the Westbourne Hospital and the Queen's Hotel. "Bombs" also fell at Winton, Boscombe and Kinson to which the Fire and Rescue Services were called. Military vehicles drove through the roads with soldiers throwing thunder flashes from them. One scored a direct hit on a trolley bus but failed to stop it! Many people were caught without their respirators when tear gas was discharged in thick clouds from canisters placed on the pavements. A large number rushed away from the Square, which was described as a "minor inferno", and into the gardens to escape the fumes. Passengers on the buses looked peculiar sitting there with their masks on. In Holdenhurst Road buses were held up by tanks and "fighting troops". A few people who inhaled the gas failed to report for work on the Monday and Tuesday.

Loudspeaker vans toured the town requesting people not to leave home during the hours of 9 am and 1 pm on the Sunday. However though they were asked not to, and also to disperse, crowds watched the exercise. At 9 am loud explosions were heard from the beach where the "enemy" had established a bridgehead. The invasion force captured the Town Hall only to be driven out by the Home Guard and the Bournemouth Garrison troops. Some two dozen incidents in various parts of the town were used to build up particular aspects of enemy action, such as bombing, fires caused by incendiaries, street fighting and people trapped, stretching the local military and Civil Defence

personnel. ATS girls and Canadian airmen acted as casualties. There were even mock "graves" dug in the parks.

1942 saw the first Land Girl being employed in the Corporation Nurseries in King's Park. Several were already working in the Corporation Farms at Strouden, Wick and Holdenhurst.

When the war started the Council appointed a Committee to "discover ways of utilising the land at the farms". By Summer 1941 one hundred extra acres were producing corn and root vegetables. Now in 1942 more grassland was to be put to the plough. This included thirty acres of the old racecourse at Ensbury Park, fifty acres of land earmarked for building at Southbourne and part of the playing fiends at Kinson. One hundred and thirty boys from Bournemouth School volunteered to assist in picking fruit at Wisbech during the summer holidays.

The third anniversary of the war was marked by a National Day of Prayer. Shops and offices, backed by the Chamber of Trade, closed until 10.15 am to enable staff to attend the services. A Civic Service was held at St. Peter's and the Chamber of Trade had theirs at St. Andrew's Presbyterian Church in Exeter Road. The staffs of Beales, J.J. Allens, Maples and Harvey Nichols joined together in a service conducted actually in Beales itself. Just as the Civic Service in St. Peter's commenced the siren sounded but no attack occurred, the enemy aircraft only passed over the town.

Three Alerts were heard in December, on the 12th, 14th and 16th. The first was the seven hundred and forty seventh sounding of the sirens, whilst the second occured at midnight, the first late disturbance for three months.

In November on Armistice Day the Mayor laid a wreath of poppies on the War Memorial but there was no official ceremony. Then on Sunday 15th November the church bells rang out to celebrate the victory over Rommel's Afrika Korps at El Alamein by the 8th Army and the Middle East Air Force. This was the first time they had been heard since the Control of Noise Order of June 1940 as the sounding of church bells was to signal the German invasion. The bells of St. Peter's were also heard at Christmas.

Over four thousand people attended a combined Civic Service and Civil Defence Church Parade on Sunday 22nd November. The Councillors robed in St. Peter's Hall then processed into the Church. The members of the Civil Defence marched down Bath Road into Westover Road past the Saluting Base outside the Pavilion where the Mayor, Alderman F.B. Summerbee, accompanied by the Controller, Councillor H. Mears, and other officers, took the salute. The parade with three bands then marched via the Square and Hinton Road into the Westover Cinema by the back door. The service held in St. Peter's was relayed to the Cinema. This was the first time such a link-up had been made in Bournemouth.

A double murder occurred on August 7th at 17 Wimborne Road, a house used by the Army. Corporal Robert George Jackson, Royal Fusiliers, and Lance Corporal Walter Edward Thompson, Royal Fusiliers, both Regimental Policemen, were shot and killed by Private Leslie Goodall, 12 (City of London) Battalion, Royal Fusiliers. Goodall, under arrest for being absent without leave, broke out of detention, seized a rifle and ammunition, then shot the two NCOs when they entered the loft in which he was hiding. Sergeant Percy Pick, Royal Fusiliers, disarmed him with complete disregard for his own safety, being subsequently awarded the George Medal for bravery. Tribute was paid to his courage by the Judge and the Counsels for both the Prosecution and the Defence. Goodall was tried at the Old Bailey, found guilty but insane, and was sentenced to be detained during His Majesty's Pleasure.

Sir Percy James Grigg, who had been educated at the Bournemouth School for Boys and at St. John's College, Cambridge, was appointed Permanent Under Secretary of State for War in March 1939. In 1942 he became the Secretary of State for War, continuing until 1945. He also became in 1942 the Member of Parliament for East Cardiff. Sir James had been created a Knight Commander, Order of the Bath (KCB) in 1932 and then in 1936, to honour his work as Finance Member of the Government of India from 1934, he was created a Knight Commander of the Most Exalted Order of the Star of India (KCSI). After the war he held directorships in several commercial enterprises, dying 5th May 1964, aged 73.

Three notable Bournemouthians died during the year. The first was Dr. J.D. Jones on 19th April at Bala, North Wales. For nearly forty years, 1898 to 1937, he was Pastor of the Richmond Hill Congregational Church. He was for many years a member of the Education Committee and was awarded the Freedom of the Borough in March 1938. This was conferred upon him in recognition of the devoted service which he had given to both the religious and civic life of the town.

Colonel T.V. Rebbeck, who had been Mayor of Bournemouth 1936-37, died on 28th September. A member of the well known Estate Agent family he was an Alderman, having been elected to the Council in 1927. He had been appointed to command the local Home Guard at its start in 1940. Colonel Rebbeck was given a military funeral with the Home Guard providing the Guard of Honour. The coffin was carried on a gun carriage and after cremation his ashes were placed in the family vault in St. Peter's Churchyard. He was succeeded as the Commanding Officer of the 6th (Bournemouth) Home Guard by Lt. Colonel E.C. Seconde.

The Town Clerk, Mr. A.R. Eaton, died on 6th December. He had been the Deputy from 1930 until he became Town Clerk in 1939. His Deputy, Lindsay Clegg, was appointed temporarily until the end of the war when he was then confirmed in the post.

Chapter Five

1943

The Alert was heard right from the beginning of January. There were eighteen warnings during the month, but no bombs were dropped. However on the 22nd January the siren sounded at 8.45 pm followed at 9 pm with a heavy anti-aircraft barrage from the guns positioned in and around the town. This was said to be the first of its kind in Bournemouth. The enemy aircraft were driven off, apparently transferring their attentions and bombs to New Milton. During this Alert the Fire Brigade were called to a fire in Portland Road which destroyed a garage and a car. The cause was thought to be a shell fired by an AA gun, perhaps the one sited in the Winton Recreation Ground. The Civil Defence Controller issued a warning to the members of the public that, unless they were on duty for Civil Defence, they must keep under cover when the AA barrage was in action because of the danger of falling shrapnel. lt was a common occurrence to find large chunks of jagged metal in the road and in the garden after such a barrage. Many people thought that enemy aircraft had been machine gunning their houses when what they heard hitting their roofs was in fact shrapnel.

Alerts continued during February and March, then in April on the 23rd there were two during the night when enemy aircraft were heard droning their way to and from the West Midlands. Their passing was marked by heavy gunfire and it was reported that a bomber was brought down near Christchurch.

The funeral service for Sybil Laura Young, a Bournemouth girl who had been a member of the Winchester NFS, was held at St. Katherine's Church on Friday 12th February. On Tuesday 9th February she had been waiting in Winchester for a bus to go on duty when she was killed by a bomb. There was a guard of honour of Firewomen and her coffin, covered with a Union Jack, was born by four Firemen when she was buried in the North Cemetery . The next day a male torso was found washed up on the beach. The body had been in the water for several months and was never identified.

Some everyday necessities were now in short supply. Razor blades and torch batteries were highlighted in January. Bicycle lamps were available but no batteries to go in them. Several cyclists in court for having no lights on their machines pleaded the shortage in mitigation but were still fined. Later on during the year retailers were expressing their delight in being able to obtain some batteries, especially the elusive No 8s for small hand torches. Trunk telephone calls were restricted to a maximum of six minutes each between 9 am and 11 pm from January. This affected Servicemen stationed away from home when keeping in touch with their families.

The Board of Trade stated in March that "no coupons can be issued to hotels, boarding houses, clubs, hostels, hairdressers etc., for the purchase of towels. You must be prepared to take your towel with you to the office, to the hairdresser, or if you have to go away to stay. Also you must contribute coupons where you are living when new towels or tea towels have to be bought". One wonders how the local hotels, etc. managed!

Retailers were having difficulty in continuing deliveries by van because of the small petrol ration available to them. Consequently a number discontinued this service. One, James & Co., Wine Merchants of Boscombe, wrote to their customers explaining that "this step has been taken through circumstances beyond their control. We hope to be able to call and clear the empties in a month's

time". The letter then hoped that the customer would still patronise the shop. Spirits and beer were now in short supply and the quota allocated to each retailer was soon sold out, especially when the American Servicemen could afford to pay over the odds.

To save petrol gas-producer buses were now seen in the town and the immediate neighbourhood. The Echo in March printed a photograph of a Hants & Dorset bus towing the producer unit. This was a two-wheeled trailer carrying a furnace which burned treated anthracite coal, four hundred pounds making enough gas to fuel the bus for one hundred miles. The Bournemouth to Salisbury, New Milton, Lymington and Southampton routes were the main ones on which the gas-fuelled vehicles were used.

Bourncmouth Corporation received two wartime utility double-decker motor buses in March. These had only one staircase at the rear instead of the usual two, one at the front and one at the rear. However the seats were upholstered making them more comfortable than the "austerity" single-deckers with the wooden seats. Two London Passenger Transport buses were then returned. The special service of motor buses leaving the Pavilion forecourt at the end of the evening performance was suspended from 1st February. The last buses for all destinations from then left the Square at 9 pm. The Pavilion's performances were finished at such a time that its patrons were able to catch the last buses from the Square. In April 1944 it was decided to demolish the wall along Westover Road on the gardens side from the Pavilion to the Information Bureau to provide more room on the pavement. This safety measure was taken because many cinema and theatre goers were rushing along the Westover Road at night in the blackout to reach the last buses regardless of the traffic.

A part of old Bournemouth made a move during the Summer when the Bath Chairmen's Shelter in Gervis Road, which opened on 20th May 1901, was transferred to Meyrick Road to replace the Taxi-Drivers' Hut. This had become dilapidated and was falling down. The one remaining Bath Chairman continued to ply his trade from Meyrick Road.

Another change was suggested earlier in the year. This time that of a street name in Moordown. The residents of Lindbergh Road, after Colonel Charles Lindbergh the American aviator, requested that because of its Germanic origins it should be renamed. It was decided to call it Franklin Road, one of the Christian names of President Roosevelt. However it was not until sometime after the war had ended that the change occurred, the Echo, October 11th 1946, stating "but the change has not yet been made". The Kelly's Directory for 1947 records the new name for the first time.

Sunday May 23rd was a fine Spring day. Just before 1 o'clock pre-lunch strollers on the cliffs at Southbourne suddenly saw twenty four aircraft roar overhead. According to contemporary newspapers the Royal Observer Corps identified them as twelve Focke-Wulf 190 fighter bombers and twelve Messerschmitt 109s. However other sources say they were all Focke-Wulfs of SKG 10. A table in B. Collier's "Defence of the UK" entitled "Notable day attacks by German fighter bombers, 1943" states that on May 23rd twenty six FW 190s were sent to Bournemouth. Two were lost, twenty five bombs were aimed with twenty two on target, an 88% success rate. German radio described the raid as a "surprise low-level attack against the port of Bournemouth".

The German aircraft came in at fifty feet above sea level trying to miss the radar and then climbed steeply over the cliffs. However on St. Boniface Down, Isle of Wight, the Naval radar had picked them up and had alerted Fighter Command. From the cliffs, still flying low, they fanned out towards the centre of the town. The German planes raced in before the sirens could be sounded so that the people in the centre of the town were not able to reach the safety of the shelters. The bars and public houses were packed with customers enjoying a drink before lunch. During the next four minutes twenty one bombs exploded in ten areas completely destroying fifty nine buildings and damaging three thousand four hundred and twenty two. Later on several unexploded bombs were also found. St. Paul's School was not able to open on the Monday morning because of one of the UXBS.

A Canadian pilot of 3 PRC remembers that "The Gardens were full of relaxing Canadian airmen, strolling about or laying on the grass and basking in the sun. I had already made my way up to our hotel [The Bath Hotel?] and was shining my buttons. Suddenly there was a lowpitched hum in the East and this began going around to the North and then West. Twenty-two Focke Wulf Fw 190s had crossed the coast, came around behind us and made a perfect line of stern attack on the city centre,

particularly the Gardens. They were so low, as they passed my window on the third floor I could look down and see the pilot's eyes in each plane. Two 500 HEs were dropped by each of the twenty two marauders and as they were pointed out to sea when they attacked it was all over within 60 seconds! A piece of shrapnel hit me on the top of the head, small but powerful. Then I passed out for a few seconds, or minutes, and when I came to there was blood streaming all down my face. He also recalls that "As the twenty two FW 190s swept low over the gardens, they raked the airmen there with machine-gun fire for the total period".

Another Canadian, a bomb aimer, states "On 23rd May 1943 1 had a latish lunch at the Bowling Green (The Winter Gardens), and was strolling across the park on a beautiful Sunday afternoon. I don't recall any warning sirens but I do remember looking up at the roar of engines to see my first enemy aircraft - Focke Wulf 190s. I was very exposed so ran across the park to the built-up area where I took shelter in the entrance to a shop (shoes). (This could have been Dolcis on the corner of Gervis and Old Christchurch Roads). On my way I saw an airman (Australian, I believe, since he had a darker uniform) hit and spun round with a leg missing. I spent the next few minutes (seemed like hours) cursing myself for having picked such a poor shelter since I was surrounded on three sides by plate glass. Back to Bath Hill Court to confirm my survival and then I volunteered to help at the Hotel (Metropole?) which had been hit".

The Central Hotel on Richmond Hill, built in 1886, and the Punshon Memorial Church next to it, opened 30th June 1886, received direct hits. The Hotel was completely destroyed whilst the Church was extensively damaged and its organ wrecked.

The Punshon Memorial Church site on Richmond Hill was sold in March 1944 for £18,300. Two houses in Exeter Road were purchased, the sites to be used for a new church after the war. One of the houses was used as a temporary church. The new church, designed by local architect Ronald Sims, was dedicated by the Rev. Leslie Weatherhead on 17th December 1958.

At the Central Hotel the bar was crowded with pre-lunch drinkers and in the restaurant lunch was being served. Diners and drinkers were buried under the rubble, but luckily there was no fire, and passers-by immediately started to dig them out. The Chef and several members of the kitchen staff were able to escape through a gap in the rubble. Amongst the twenty seven people killed was H.L.Sikes, Senior Regional Technical Adviser, Ministry of Home Security, who was in town to confer with Town Hall officials about the provision of shelters in schools.

Beales received a direct hit from a 500lb bomb and a ruptured gas main in the building caught fire. Some reports say that it was an incendiary, not a high explosive bomb. The blaze was finally contained at about 5 o'clock, taking fifteen pumps to do so. However, by then the building had collapsed. In the store were only the duty fire-watchers who escaped injury. But on the flat roof there was an anti-aircraft machine gun post manned by Lance-Bombadier Norman Lawrence and Lance-Bombadier John Howard of the 87th Light AA Regiment, Royal Artillery, who were billeted in Poole. They continued to engage the enemy aircraft, which were flying low and fast, with their triple Lewis guns (three barrels linked together) whilst the store burned beneath them, shooting down one FW 190 which crashed in the Bay. One gun received a direct hit with a cannon shell wounding two of the soldiers manning it. They were evacuated first and then, carrying the guns, the two NCOs led their gun crews down the stairs through the smoke and flames to safety. They were both awarded the British Empire Medal for Bravery, being invested by King George V1 on lst November.

The citation for the award states that "The shooting of this site was excellent. One aircraft was seen to be hit and disappeared towards the sea, losing height". It went on to say that the behaviour of these NCOs was a tonic to the battery; "They kept their heads and did all that was possible to kill Germans". This exploit was featured in two magazines called "Tip Top" and "War Heros".

The Echo reported that another Focke-Wulf 190 was shot down over the town by a Spitfire, the pilot's first "kill" which crashed at St. Ives Hotel, 34 Grove Road, with its bomb still attached. The German pilot, Unter Officier F.K. Schmidt, was killed. The crash also killed two people in the next hotel. The plane caught fire, gutting the Hotel. Luckily the bomb failed to explode and was removed by the Bomb Disposal Squad.

Uffz Schmidt was buried initially in the North Cemetery as an unknown German airman. However he was identified and re-interred in the German War Cemetery at Cannock Chase, Staffordshire in 1947. Subsequently it was claimed that Uffz Schmidt had been shot down by a Bofors gun near the Pier, not by the Spitfire.

The Metropole Hotel at the Lansdowne, opened in August 1893, was a billet for Canadian, Australian and American airmen. One 500lb bomb struck it on the Holdenhurst Road side in the centre of the building causing the walls and floors to collapse. Here, too, the bar was full with airmen and civilians, twelve of the latter being killed. The Fire Brigade were quickly on the scene as their station was only yards away in Holdenhurst Road. Using their turnable ladders they released many of the airmen trapped on the upper floors. The Echo related, "it was believed that the occasion constituted a record in the number of people rescued at one time from a bomb-damaged building", but did not say how many that was! Ted Hughes in his "Bournemouth Firemen at War" quotes a Fire Officer as saying, "Fortunately there was no fire, but many airmen (thirty five in fact) had to be rescued, some from the upper floors, where the new 100 feet Turntable Ladders were put to good use".

One of the airmen billeted at the Metropole, an Australian, had on that morning taken a bus to Christchurch and returned for lunch just after the raid. The side of the building opposite the College looked relatively undamaged, but he was shocked on going round the corner into Holdenhurst Road to see the damage caused by the bomb. He immediately joined the rescue parties bringing out the dead and injured. Rumour has it that a body was blown into the Clock Tower of the College and not found for over a week!

The stoker at the Metropole, Mr. David Gear, was in the boiler room when the bomb struck. Although bruised, cut about the head, and not being able to see because of the clouds of dust and all the wreckage he managed to turn off the electric power switches and damp down the fires, thus stopping the risk of the boilers exploding and causing fires. When the steam gauge indicated that the pressure had fallen, and only then, he used a fire axe to break down a door in order to escape. He then joined the rescuers in bringing out the casualties. Mr. Gear, aged 76, was awarded the Commendation for Civilian Gallantry by the King for "gallantry worthy of all praise". The citation was published in the London Gazette of the 19th December 1944. He was also presented with the award of the "Three Silver Oak Leaves" by the Commander of the Canadian Air Force in Bournemouth.

Assistance was requested from the Christchurch and Poole rescue squads and the local garrison. One contemporary picture of the damaged Metropole shows a Borough of Poole lorry being used to remove debris and also the troops and Civil Defence workers clearing the damage. In another photograph soldiers of the United States Army can be seen working on the site. Both these can be found in "After the Battle: the Blitz then and now", Vol.3. After demolition two sections of the Metropole were left standing, part of the bar in Holdenhurst Road and part of the lounge opposite the College.The bar was eventually opened in September and the other section was used as a furniture store.

The fire at Beales also damaged J.J. Allen and St. Peter's Church was threatened by the flames. The louvres of the belfry in the church tower caught fire and the Verger, Mr. Arthur Davis, organised the fire fighting operations to put the flames out. Altogether three stirrup pumps were used, amongst the pumping parties were two RCAF Sergeants. Other Servicemen and women, plus members of the congregation, made a chain passing buckets of water to the pumps. For over two hours these volunteers worked to put out the fire. As soon as the NFS had contained the fire at Beales they ran a hose into the tower and saturated the louvres to completely extinguish the fire. The water for the fire hoses was pumped from the Bourne Stream and also from the pipe system laid in the gutters. The concrete platform alongside the Stream was brought into use to stand the pumps on to supply the hoses which snaked their way up the grass banks to fight the fires.

As well as Beales being hit West's Cinema and Cairns House in St. Peter's Road were also bombed. West's Cinema was originally the Shaftesbury Hall, built to commemorate the work done for the poor and needy by Lord Shaftesbury. For many years it was Bournemouth's most commodious hall and the place where the earliest films were screened in the town. It was almost completely

destroyed, the only parts of the building left being the shops fronting Old Christchurch Road. Next door, Cairns House was also badly damaged, having to be pulled down. It was built as the Cairns Memorial Hall, named after Earl Cairns, Lord Chancellor of England, who lived in Bournemouth at "Lindisfarne", Gervis Road, now called "Earls Court". During its existence Cairns House had been used by the YMCA, for County Court Judges' Sitting, then lastly for the Bournemouth Chamber of Trade offices, with flats above. The site of West's Cinema and Cairns House is now occupied by the Burlington Arcade.

For some time after the raid vehicles were prevented from using several roads because of dangerous buildings, For instance only buses were permitted to proceed up Old Christchurch Road. By the end of August the traffic in the Square had been restored almost to its normal amount prior to the changes which had been introduced to cope with the damage.

Until Cairns House was demolished the trolley buses could not use their normal route via Fir Vale Road, St. Peter's Road and Gervis Place to the Square; they had to be turned around at the Horseshoe Common. However they were able to resume their usual route on 29th July. Trolleys travelling from Holdenhurst Road to Boscombe which turned at the Lansdowne could no longer do so until the Metropole was made safe and they, too, used the Horseshoe Common roundabout.

The main roads closed for safety reasons were reopened in May and from Saturday 29th May trolley buses were able to use Richmond Hill. Beales' corner reopened on the 20th September to traffic, pedestrians had been allowed to use it a few days before. Beales itself had reopened in the premises previously occupied by Messrs. Woodhouse, the house furnishers, at 163-171 Old Christchurch Road just above Lorne Park Road. As a safety measure chestnut paling was erected around the bomb site, then in 1944 this was replaced by a stone wall, the stone coming from the ruins of the Punshon Memorial Church. During the demolition of Beales the plaque presented by the staff in December 1928 as a tribute to the founder, John Elmes Beale, and his wife, was found amongst the debris. This can be seen in a display case, together with a portrait of Mr. and Mrs. Beale, on the landing between the fourth and fifth floors of Beales.

The Shamrock and Rambler Coach garage in Holdenhurst Road was hit. There two employees were killed and fifteen buses destroyed. Bobbys (now Debenhams) was struck by a high explosive bomb which plunged through the building from the second floor exploding in the basement which was used as a shelter. Fortunately nobody was there at the time. A Canadian airman surveying the damage said, "Bobbys Department Store, on the circle (sic), was standing but the whole face of three storeys had fallen away". The store reopened for business on 26th July. A letter to the Echo, May 25th 1993, from a former RAF Sergeant, recalled that he was stationed in Bournemouth on that fateful day and was returning to the Station HQ from the Osborne Hotel in Exeter Road. Outside a shoe shop, near Bright's, which had been damaged, he was accosted by an elderly lady who started belabouring him with her stick shouting "Why weren't you up there stopping them?" He went on to say that "one confused old lady unknowingly inflicted more damage on my person than Hitler had been unsuccessfully attempting over the past four years".

Bombs fell in Upper Terrace Road and Exeter Road behind the Hants and Dorset Bus Station (the site is now a car park), where many buses had their windows blown out. Lansdowne Road, Queen's Park South Drive, Richmond Wood, Howard, Bethia, Drummond, Manor, Vale, Spring, Holdenhurst (the shops opposite Lowther Road), Cleveland, Cotlands and Dean Park Roads were all bombed. The bomb in Vale Road damaged 38 Carlton Road which was being used as a children's hostel: the Matron losing her life in saving the evacuees. 'Unfortunately one four-year-old boy was also killed there. Two civilian deaths are recorded as happening in the Central Pleasure Gardens which were heavily machine gunned. At the Lansdowne the Policeman on point duty escaped injury, but several other people in the vicinity were hit by machine gun bullets from the enemy aircraft.

The bombs around Queen's Park could have been aimed at the military equipment concealed in the woods along the trotting track around the edge of the golf links. Here were guns and their tractors and on the opposite side of the road were houses taken over for billets. Several of these were to be bombed later on in the year.

In all seventy seven civilians were killed and one hundred and ninety six injured, plus many who received first aid on the spot and who did not go to hospital. Military casualties were not announced then, but later on the Civil Defence Controller, Cllr. Harry Mears, wrote in a letter to the Echo in April 1986 that "The number of military casualties was kept secret at the time for reasons of national security... The final figure for that day of all nationalities including American came to one hundred and thirty one" So the total deaths owing to enemy action was two hundred and eight. Another death, that of a demolition worker, occurred on lst June at Beales' corner when part of a building fell. At the same time another man was seriously injured.

Cllr. Mears went on, "It being Sunday, more people were in their homes than on a working day, and in the hotels packed with members of the armed forces, dinner was being served. Casualty reports came in so fast from the Warden Service that our fire, ambulance and heavy rescue teams were stretched to the limit. Help was willingly given by members of the armed forces and civilians. I cannot praise the morale and courage of all too highly". Cllr. Mears was awarded the OBE in July 1943 for services to Civil Defence.

Morrison shelters saved several lives although the one in the flats in Vale Road which were hit was badly crushed and another at 54-56 Drummond Road had its top caved in. All the occupants were rescued alive and not badly hurt.

In addition to the Punshon Memorial, St. Andrew's Presbyterian Church in Exeter Road, and the Lansdowne Baptist Church were also damaged. The spire at St. Andrew's had eventually to be removed in September 1947 because of the damage to it. It was never rebuilt. The Lansdowne Baptist Church lost the window commemorating a previous Pastor, Rev. Howell Rees, which was blown out, amongst other damage. The Church reopened on 24th September, five months after the raid.

A piece of old Bournemouth was revealed by the destruction of the Central Hotel. This was the outline of a Gothic window in the wall of the National Westminster Bank at the bottom of Richmond Hill which was originally part of the first, stone built, St. Andrew's Church (1872-1886). Rest centres were opened, mobile and static canteens were also provided by the WVS and other organisations. An administrative centre was set up at the Town Hall to deal with the many enquiries about casualties and to help those bombed out.

The Bournemouth traders' salvage scheme went into action quickly. This was an arrangement that as soon as possible after a raid the stocks of damaged shops would be salvaged and stored safely. There were twelve hundred volunteers who rendered such assistance. The Police regarded the scheme with favour as it was a protection against looting. "We have saved the complete stocks of some shops that would have been destroyed by fire and water", claimed one of the organisers. Shoes and menswear, as well as cases of wine and spirits from the cellars of the Central Hotel, were rescued this way.

The bodies of those killed were taken to the Borough Mortuary in the Corporation's East Yard in Holdenhurst Road (demolished when the road changes were made and the Travel Interchange was built), and to the temporary mortuary in the old stabling next to the Sheepwash Cottages in Castle Lane at Iford. There the task of identifying the dead took place, The service casualties were then dealt with by the military authorities.

A number of bodies of people from other towns were sent to their homes for burial. Some of the airmen, RAF, RCAF and RAAF, were buried in the War Plot at the North Cemetery. The others were sent to military cemeteries in other parts of the country.

Amongst those killed were four Air Raid Wardens, four Home Guards and a Swiss national. The injured were treated at local hospitals initially. The servicemen were later removed to military hospitals.

On this disastrous day the Municipal Orchestra celebrated its Golden Jubilee, having played its very first concert to five thousand people at the old Winter Gardens with Dan Godfrey, Junior, (later Sir Dan Godfrey) as conductor on May 22nd 1893. There were two anniversary concerts that day, one in the afternoon and the other in the evening, with altogether two thousand people attending. G. Miller in his "Bournemouth Symphony Orchestra" sites that the atmosphere was "chill and dreary". Sir

Adrian Boult, who shared the rostrum with Montague Birch for the afternoon, uttered a few well chosen words of sympathy and then conducted "Nimrod" from Elgar's Enigma Variations as a tribute to those who had been killed. This poignant orchestral piece is always played during the Remembrance Day Service at the Cenotaph.

Three days after the raid Cllr. Mears said in a press statement that "When I visited the scenes of the incidents I found everything proceeding with utmost precision. There was no confusion or waiting about for orders; everybody knew just what to do and got on with it ...".

At the Borough Council meeting on the lst June the Mayor paid a tribute to the Civil Defence and to the coolness displayed by the public during the raid on 23rd May. The Council expressed their deep sympathy with those who suffered as the result of the air raid.

At the same meeting the Mayor reported that he had received a letter from the local Commanding Officer of the Royal New Zealand Air Force expressing the thanks of all the Officers and Sergeants posted to the town for the hospitality and friendliness shown to them. The RNZAF left Bournemouth at the end of May.

In all the property damaged was twenty two buildings destroyed, thirty seven requiring demolition, two hundred and sixty eight seriously damaged but repairable and three thousand One hundred and fifty four slightly damaged. A total of three thousand four hundred and eighty one properties. One householder in the Richmond Wood Road area claimed that the work of repairing the damage was not carried out soon enough. The Borough Engineer reported that over seven hundred houses in that area were damaged, eight of these were demolished and fifteen seriously damaged. By Monday evening approximately four hundred properties had been covered with tarpaulins and had windows re-glazed or boarded up thus making the houses weatherproof. "In view of the amount of damage caused to the buildings in the town in this incident, it would appear that the work was commenced and carried out very expeditiously, and the residents in the neighbourhood have expressed their satisfaction with the speed at which repairs were effected".

To mark the 45th anniversary of the raid a ceremony took place outside the Norfolk Royale Hotel, Richmond Hill, on 23rd May 1988, when a Canadian flag was raised at 1 o'clock to pay tribute to the Canadian airmen who died that day. In 1993 Canadians who came for the 50th anniversary looked in vain for three stained glass windows which, it is claimed, were installed in the Royal Bath Hotel in 1944. Paid for by North American and Canadian servicemen they represented the Royal Canadian Air Force, the United States Air Force and the United States Army. The Canadian window was in memory of those killed when the Metropole was bombed. According to one veteran he saw and photographed them in 1985, but his pictures were destroyed in a fire. When he returned six years later the windows were no longer there and nobody could help him trace them. No evidence exists at the Royal Bath Hotel that any such windows were there, and nobody came forward when the story was published in the local newspapers.

According to the newspapers hotels were doing "pretty good this summer", with many visitors to the town. Large audiences listened to the music of the Municipal Orchestra playing on the bandstand in the Pine Walk, whilst children splashed and sailed boats in the Bourne Stream which had been widened and "canalised" by having the banks built up. At weekends parties of residents and holidaymakers could be found in the fields at Muscliffe picnicking and paddling in the shallow parts of the river.

The Beach Committee in May had been of the opinion that the public should still be allowed to continue to have access to the promenade but not to the beach. No application to the Garrison Commander was made, therefore, for the beaches to be opened up for bathing but it was possible for anglers to receive permits to fish between Fisherman's Walk and Southbourne rocks. Entry had to be made at the old Coast Guard Station at Southbourne. There a notice stated that only holders of fishing permits were allowed entry to the beach.

It was stated in July that during the peak period in 1942 over six thousand emergency ration cards a week for visitors had been issued, but so far in 1943 the weekly total did not exceed three thousand. The Food Office in Pine Court, Gervis Road, now shared the building with the Milk Office and the

National Registration Office, which had been transferred from the Town Hall.

On August Bank Holiday the 7th (Boscombe) Battalion Home Guard held a military display at Dean Court, General Sir Richard Haking taking the salute as the Battalion marched past. The Battalion had collected £100 on August Monday 1941 to endow a bed named after it at Boscombe Hospital, and the 1943 event raised a further £130 towards the £400 needed to make the endowment perpetual. Also at the display a cheque for £450, contributed by all ranks during July, was presented to the Hampshire Regiment for the Regimental Prisoner of War Fund.

The Bank Holiday attractions did good business, the cinemas and theatres were crowded, nearly a prewar scene of big crowds of visitors. Some holiday makers were left behind at Waterloo on the Friday night and had to wait until the early morning train next day.

The Swiss Restaurant in Bourne Avenue beneath the Hampshire Court flats was as busy as ever, a focal point for the men of the Forces and their partners. Dinner there cost five shillings (25p), and the charge for dancing and entertainment one shilling and sixpence (7½p).

Military displays and march pasts continued to attract crowds whenever they happened. The massed bands of the Black Watch, London Scottish and Royal Irish Fusiliers visited Dean Park Cricket Ground again on Wednesday March 17th. There a large number of people enjoyed the spectacle of marching and countermarching to the skirl of the pipes and the beating of the drums as the Bands "Beat Retreat". Scottish soldiers in their kilts were a common sight in Boscombe, the Black Watch being billeted in the Burlington Hotel, Owls Road; whilst in Sea Road the Broughty Ferry Hotel (now demolished and replaced with a block of flats) was the Headquarters of No 5 Commando, the men being billeted in Boscombe. At East Howe in October were soldiers from the Canadian French speaking Regiment "Le Regiment de la Chaudiere" when they were training for Combined Operations. The Regiment took part in Exercise "Pirate" which took place around Arne and Studland on the battle training ground.

In January one thousand Army, ATC and Sea Cadets from Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch marched past the Director of the ATC, Mr. W.W. Wakefield MP, who took the salute at the Pavilion; with him on the saluting base were the Mayors of the three Boroughs.

A parade to mark the fifth birthday of the ATS in September was held with the salute being taken in Westover Road. The Mayor, Alderman F.B. Summerbee, represented the town on the saluting base. Later a combined parade of the Bournemouth, Parkstone and Poole Units of the Sea Cadet Corps was also held at the Pavilion, marching past Vice Admiral L. Mackinnon.

The sea theme continued with the Merchant Navy Week which started on 18th September. The object was to raise £10,000 for welfare work amongst seamen. There was an exhibition connected with ships and the sea at the Regent Cinema (now the Odeon). Social events such as concerts, football matches between the Services, plus a swimming and diving gala at the Pier Approach Baths were organised. Dr. H.M. King published a new song entitled "When the convoy comes to port" which he dedicated to the men of the Merchant Navy. He hoped that it would encourage people to be generous. Although the desired sum was not raised, four cheques of £2000 were presented to four societies working in the interests of merchant seamen.

Exhibitions were also held to publicise the endeavours of the Forces and the war workers. At Beales in January was one on the British Army and in August the RAF exhibition at Plummers showed photographs of the damage inflicted on Germany and Italy. This was of great interest to the people of the town who remembered very clearly the destruction and death of the raid in May. The "Wings for Victory" campaign in May included an exhibition in what had been prewar the Westover Ice Rink where a Hurricane fighter and a Miles Master trainer were on show.

Although the Alert still sounded regularly Bournemouth did not suffer any more raids between May 23rd and the middle of August. Then on the 12th at 10 minutes past 1 in the morning, fifteen minutes after the siren, according to the newspapers "Bombs fell during the night on the suburbs of a South Coast town, doing considerable damage to property and causing a number of casualties".

The raiders flew in at about twelve thousand feet dropping three flares over Talbot Village. Then the two enemy aircraft hung over the town dropping eight bombs at intervals, the areas hit being the

corner of Firs Glen and Woods View Roads, Strouden Avenue, and Boundary, Spring, Shelbourne, Wilton and Gloucester Roads. Malmesbury Park Junior School, the Wesley Chapel, Springbourne Library and the Holdenhurst Road British Restaurant were all damaged. However damage was heaviest in the Wilton and Gloucester Road area where two bombs caused ten deaths including an Air Raid Warden, two Fire Guards and a mother and her new baby. Five people and a dog were saved by their Morrison shelter when tons of rubble fell on it. The electricity cables, telephone wires and the water and gas mains were all cut, the gas main catching fire.

The Civil Defence (ARP) Committee on the 30th August heard from the Controller that he had received from the Hampshire Police a communication regarding the fine work put in by Senior Warden A. Friend. Although the Wardens Post was damaged, and one of his colleagues killed outright by the bomb, Warden Friend had taken command of the situation. His devotion to duty and his untiring efforts had helped in every way in locating people trapped in the various bombed houses and in reporting damage.

Two Fire Guards, a mother and her daughter, were also killed in Woods View Road when a high explosive bomb fell. In all thirteen people died and twenty one were injured through this raid. Altogether one thousand four hundred and forty properties were damaged, four were destroyed and eleven more had to be demolished.

More air raid sirens were provided in the Autumn. Complaints had been received again that sirens could not always be heard, so eight more were erected on tubular steel towers at Meyrick Park Crescent, the junction of Holdenhurst Avenue and Christchurch Road, Harland Road, Throop Mill, Cox Avenue, Kinson Grove, Roundhayes and Francis Roads. The Echo, March 4th 1944, reported that "Residents have noted the greater volume and better distribution of sound".

More protection for school children was provided during the school holidays. At St. Paul's School Anderson shelters were erected on the surface, not buried, but were then encased in bricks and concrete. They were positioned around the school grounds to disperse the children. At the other schools Morrison shelters were placed inside in rooms protected with blast wails. Students at the Municipal College were allowed to use the trenches dug for the RAF at the rear of the Bournemouth School for Girls. Instructions were issued that all pupils must proceed immediately to the protected parts of the school when the Alert sounded during school time. Pupils on the upper floors, such as at the College, had to move "at the double".

School children worked in the summer holidays picking fruit and carrying out other kinds of work at farms. Parties from Bournemouth School for Girls went to Harvest Camp near Wareham in 1943 where they dug potatoes, thinned out turnips and even cleared reeds from the River Frome. This was so successful that the camps were held twice more, during the summer of 1944 and 1945. In December, for the second year running, the older school children helped deliver the Christmas mail.

The 3rd September saw the Eighth Army landing at Reggio, Gallico and Catona on the Straits of Messina at the toe of Italy, whilst at home it was a National Day of Prayer. Services were held at Churches all over the Borough, including the bomb-damaged Baptist Church at the Lansdowne as well as in shops, store restaurants and a furniture warehouse. Then when the Allies and Italy announced an armistice on 8th September St. Peter's bells rang out a victory peal.

On Thursday September 30th the efforts of the Fire Guard Service and the National Fire Service were co-ordinated in fighting fires to a greater degree, the Fire Guard and Warden Services having been separated in the July. Small sign boards with red lettering on white background indicating Fire Guard sectors and assembly points were erected around the town to mark the places where a fully trained Fire Guard could be found in the event of enemy action or an Alert during the hours of darkness. The plan operated from half an hour before blackout to half an hour after the official blackout time when an Alert was in operation. Members of the public had to report fires to the nearest point. Fire Guards were then sent to the incident. If the fire was small they dealt with it, only alerting the Fire Brigade if it was a big one beyond their capabilities. The main advantage of this arrangement was that the Brigade was not inundated with calls from all and sundry. They only received notification of those fires with which the Fire Guard could not deal. All other times fires of whatever origin were

reported through the usual channels, i.e. direct to the NFS or through the Police.

There were three main categories of Fire Guards:

1. Those who performed duties under the Business Premises Order
2. Those who did voluntary duty or were enrolled in their street party
3. Those who were in the first category and were still willing to give another night of duty in the road in which they lived.

Their main duty was detecting, putting out fires and summoning any necessary assistance. In October the age requirement was lowered to eighteen for men but for women it remained at twenty.

The Theatre Royal, opened in 1882, was gutted by fire at the end of October. lt was being used as a Services Club run by the BWSO and at the time nine hundred people were in the auditorium enjoying the entertainment.

The evacuation of all nine hundred, plus those in the Club, was effected without injury. The NFS contained the fire but the roof was completely destroyed. Luckily the Club was undamaged so that the canteen, lounge and games room, where every week Councillor F.I. MacInnes and Claude Falkiner the local billiards professional, played exhibition games of billiards and snooker, could still be used. Strangely enough there had been a fire during the 1914-18 War at the Theatre when a matinee for wounded soldiers had been in progress. This time a flash light used to take a photograph of the audience set fire to scenery and stage fittings. The safety curtain was immediately lowered and the fire quickly extinguished. Nobody was hurt. The theatre was officially reopened on Saturday 8th April 1944 by Lord Croft, Under Secretary of State for War.

A new centre for members of the Services was opened at Digby Chambers in Post Office Road mainly to provide entertainment and cultural facilities in the mornings only and a Forces Rest Room was made available at 493 Christchurch Road. Digby House in Suffolk Road, taken over by the YWCA in 1937 as a holiday hostel, housed at the beginning of the war its Headquarters evacuated from London. It became a hostel for Servicewomen with accommodation for some residents later.

The American Red Cross held dances at the Officers' Club in the Ambassador Hotel, Meyrick Road. "Young lady residents" of Bournemouth were invited by the Club Dance Director to be "among our guests ... to entertain the American Officers". Before these young ladies could be included on the dance rota they had to fill in a questionnaire to show that they were "suitable".

A new way of raising money, this time for the Bishop of Winchester's War Damaged Churches Fund, was to be found at St. Mary's Church, Springbourne, where a collecting box was placed near the door of the Church. On entering on Sundays many members of the congregation placed in the box a penny for every time the siren sounded during the previous week. This method raised £17 during the period 1941-42.

Two bananas, seldom seen since the beginning of the war, were sold for charity in October. One fetched thirty shillings (£1.50) for the Red Cross Prisoners of War Fund and the other also thirty shillings for the Victoria Home for Crippled Children in Westbourne. The person who purchased the second one auctioned it for £4 the proceeds again going to the Children's Home.

On November lst two JU 88s flew in over the Purbeck Hills and attacked the town dropping twenty four high explosive bombs, eleven of which failed to explode. Three areas were affected: the first, Queen's Park Avenue, Howard Road and Cecil Avenue; the second, Wimborne Rd Road Cemetery and the roads around; and third, Palmerston Road plus roads adjoining. In Queen's Park Avenue two of the houses hit, 89 where a French Canadian Major was killed, and No.111, were occupied by the Army. 135 was also wrecked, the occupants being saved by their Morrison shelter.

Avon, Bennett, Chatsworth and Shaftesbury Roads escaped major damage because all the bombs dropped there did not explode. However the Avon Road laundry and Hayden's Engineering Works on the opposite side of the road had to be closed for twenty four hours because of the UXBs.

This was dubbed as an "Enemy nuisance raid" by the local newspapers, the raid occurring at 5.20 pm, the bombs falling at 5.45 pm, just as office workers were leaving to return home. There was a mad dash for the shelters by those caught in the streets. The 500lb bomb which fell at the junction of

Heron Court and Gerald Roads shook the Stokewood Road Baths, where there were twelve people in the swimming pool. Four bombs fell harmlessly on the golf links and one actually in the Wimborne Rd Road Cemetery, damaging tombstones and graves again. The speculation was that the incineration chimneys in Grafton Road had been the target.

One man was killed, ten seriously injured, plus one Serviceman, and seventeen slightly injured. Eight houses had to be demolished, twenty four were repairable and six hundred and ninety one had slight damage, seven hundred and twenty three properties in all. Revised figures published later brought the number of those damaged up to one thousand and seventy two, plus two hundred and four requiring new glass only. On the following day loudspeaker vans toured the affected area giving the addresses of the aid depots where assistance and advice could be obtained by those who had suffered damage to their houses. The official report on this raid is as follows:-

Air Raid - Bournemouth
November 1st 1943.

An air raid warning was received at 17.20 hours, bombs were dropped at 17.45 hours. White received 18.29 hours.

Believed two planes J.U.88 came in over Purbeck Hills, and flew over and out South to sea.

Bombs were dropped at the following points:-

Junctions of Heron Court & Gerald Road	1 H.E.	-	500 k.g.
Cemetery	1 H.E.	-	500 k.g.
Cecil Avenue	1 H.E.	-	50 k.g.
Howard Road	1 H.E.	-	50 k.g.
Queens Park Avenue	3 H.E.s	-	50 k.g.
Campbell Road	1 H.E.	-	500 k.g.
Borthwick Road	1 H.E.	-	500 k.g.
Queens Park Golf Links	4 H.E.s	-	50 k.g.
Avon Road	4 U.X.B.s	-	50 k.g.s
Bennett Road	2 U.X.B.s	-	50 k.g.s
Chatsworth Road	1 U.X.B.	-	50 k.g.
Orchestron Road	1 U.X.B.	-	50 k.g.
Shaftesbury Road	1 U.X.B.	-	50 k.g.
Shelbourne Road	1 U.X.B.	-	50 k.g.
Allotment St.George's Avenue	1 U.X.B.	-	50 k.g.

Damage all in residential areas. One Laundry, and Haydens Engineering Works out of action for 24 hours owing to U.X.B.

Only one gas main was fractured in Gerald Road. Owing to heavy rain there was a shortage of tarpaulins, further supplies were obtained from Dorset.

6 Rest Centres were opened soon after the raid. 112 people slept in Rest Centres during the night. They were all billeted the following morning. By 1800 hours November 2nd the first 8 U.X.B.S that had been discovered were cleared, and people evacuated were able to return to their homes. On the 3rd November a further U.X.B. was discovered which was cleared the same day, and on the 5th November another one was discovered which was also cleared the same day.

The morning following the raid the Public Information Service at the Town Hall and Billeting Officers were available.

All Incidents were closed the same evening as raid, except the areas with U.X.B.S.

No mutual assistance was required. Public Morale was unaffected.

Morrison Table Shelters were the means of saving a number of people from serious injury.

The casualties were as follows:-

Killed			Seriously Injured			Slightly Injured		
M	F	C	M	F	C	M	F	C
1	-	-	3	6	1	9	8	-

There was also one Serviceman killed and one seriously injured.

Housing Damage

Demolition	Necessary for Demolition	Repairable	Slight Damage
-	8	24	691

Post Warden T. Dunn deserves special mention, in that, although his home was badly damaged he carried on with his duties and was an inspiration to all Wardens at the Post.

Four 50-person shelters were erected in Westover Gardens after the Admiralty took over the shelter under the Westover Garage. As the area was thought to be "one of the hubs of Bournemouth life" they were considered to be necessary. Queries were received from the public as why the shelters could not be placed in the Pavilion car park because the site chosen would destroy some of the rhododendron bushes. The Echo commented "They should be the first temporary buildings to go when the war ends". This suggestion was unfulfilled because the shelters were not demolished after hostilities ended but still exist today.

The first local memorial "to those who have made the supreme sacrifice" since 1939, a scarlet oak, was planted by the Mayor, Alderman I. Richards, on Armistice Day 11th November 1943. The tree, a gift from the Men of the Trees Society, was grown locally and was planted on the South side of the War Memorial in the Upper Pleasure Gardens approximately where the bomb fell in May the previous year.

A flu epidemic struck in late November, the worst for six years. Doctors were rushed off their feet, hospitals were inundated with patients and at one point the Royal Army Medical Corps offered to help; however locally this was not needed. At the Borough schools a large number of teachers and pupils were off, whilst shops and the buses were also hard hit. By December 13th the hard pressed medical services were able to state that the worst of the epidemic was over. The Medical Officer of Health for Bournemouth said in his annual report that eighty seven people died from influenza during the year, a large increase over previous years.

A Civic Welcome at the Pavilion was given to local repatriated Prisoners of War at the end of November. They attended a reception and a tea party when they were presented with, as souvenirs of the occasion, a coloured Bournemouth guide and a fountain pen.

A different kind of hospitality was given to troops living under canvas at lford. During bad weather the residents of nearby houses provided hot baths, meals, dry clothes and a warm place to sit when off duty.

At the Town Hall on the 17th December a ceremony was held to present a plaque and certificate of merit to the town for collecting £2,033,894 in the "Wings for Victory" National Savings Campaign from 8th to 15th May. The number of planes which were purchased with the two million pounds were:

A flight of six Sunderland flying boats; three Squadrons of twelve four-engine bombers; three two-engine bombers; three Squadrons of fifteen single-engine fighters. Lord Brabazon was the principal speaker and Group Captain Hutchinson RCAF made the presentation of the plaque with the words "in commemoration of the wonderful efforts your town made on the occasion of the Wings for Victory week". Then a certificate of merit was presented to the Chairman of the Savings Committee who handed in his turn ten blank log books from the Savings Committee to the Group Captain. These were to be used to record the history and operational flights of ten of the aircraft purchased with the money collected. Later these log books were handed to the Mayor by Mr. S. Bell, Chairman of the Bournemouth National Savings Committee on August 15th 1946 with operational details filled in.

Sadly in all cases the planes either "failed to return" or crashed. The log books are now in safe keeping at the Town Hall.

The fifth wartime Christmas was celebrated in good spirits. Housewives performed miracles providing Christmas fare with great ingenuity. Cakes, puddings and other goodies were conjured up from the families' rations. Some even provided enough to invite a member of the Forces billeted in the town to share their festivities. The children's enjoyment was paramount, the war austerities were not allowed to overshadow the season's goodwill too much.

Canadian and American Servicemen gave parties for local children, evacuees and those in institutions such as the Cottage Home at Fairmile and the House Beautiful in Bournemouth. At the House Beautiful an American Officer gave every child a present. These had been donated by his family and flown over from the United States by the US Air Force.

The Echo commented about the Canadians and Americans, "They seem to have a special knack of quickly making friends with children". The Education Committee's Elementary Schools Sub-committee "placed on record its sincere appreciation of the generous action of the Canadian and USA contingents and others in organising Christmas festivities for children who would otherwise have been without entertainment, and in giving large numbersof toys for distribution among the children, and express its cordial thanks to the numerous workers who have voluntarily given their time and service to this cause".

Regulations banned the sale of toys which had more than 10% of metal in them and cost more than twenty five shillings (£1.25). The result was the majority of those available were either wooden or stuffed. At the Pokesdown Fire Station children's party the toys distributed there were all made by the firemen from scrap material.

The town as usual provided entertainment and accommodation for many Servicemen in both clubs and private residents' homes. Bournemouth's adopted cruiser HMS Phoebe sent a message to the Mayor, "All on board Phoebe send their best wishes to you and to the citizens of Bournemouth for a happy Xmas and a Victorious New Year". The Mayor replied sending good wishes from the town. Also sent were Christmas parcels from the BWSO to the sailors aboard. Three thousand parcels were sent to those serving overseas as well as gifts to the lonely units stationed in Hampshire and Dorset.

This year because subdued lighting was permitted by a relaxation of the lighting restrictions for the Festival in churches which were not blacked out, Midnight Mass was celebrated in several lit by flickering candles. Christmas Day was not, however, a holiday for all. Workers in munitions and other essential war work had to carry on and special buses were laid on to take them. There was no ordinary bus service but the cinemas opened from 3 pm to 10 pm, reporting good business.

Cinemas, theatres, dances and other entertainments over the year were seen to have provided ample diversions and relaxation for the war workers, the members of the Forces and the public in general. Sometimes the Forces were providers of shows. At the Pavilion in December for a week the RCAF presented "Victory Roll" in aid of the RAF and RCAF Benevolent Funds with a cast of one hundred and twenty five performers, the majority from the RCAF, including LAC Ted Hockridge who became a well known show business personality after the war. The RCAF also took over the Regent Cinema on several occasions, after the films had been screened, and gave impromptu variety shows. These were very much enjoyed by both the Servicemen and their guests.

Firsts during the year were a new trolley bus service from the Square to Christchurch via lford Bridge and Barrack Road which commenced on Thursday 22nd July. A new restaurant called "The Princes" opened at 58 Old Christchurch Road in September. This must have been difficult with food rationing and shortages of many things required to run such an establishment such as crockery and linen. Whilst at the Central Railway Station the first woman railway guard commenced work on Monday 27th September. Then Tuckton Bridge became completely toll free on the lst October. The Bridge had been built in 1882-3 and was taken over by the Corporation in 1904. It was rebuilt and reopened in October 1905. ln those thirty eight years the tolls brought in an average of £1,052 per year. From December lst 1942 pedestrians and cyclists no longer had to pay, but now motorists, buses,

THIS

LOG BOOK

which will record the operational activities

of an Aircraft

is a tribute to the success achieved by

Bournemouth

SAVINGS COMMITTEE

in the

WINGS FOR VICTORY

NATIONAL SAVINGS CAMPAIGN • 1943

Target :- £ 2.100. 000.

Achievement :- £2.033.894.

REPRESENTING One Flight of 6. Sunderland
THE COST OF Four Engine Flying Boats

Three Squadrons of 12. Four Engine Bombers	Three Two Engine Bombers	Three Squadrons of 15. Single Engine Fighters.

WM/2056

Cover of one of the logbooks presented to mark Bournemouth's achievement in collecting £2,033,894 for the Wings for Victory National Savings Campaign in 1943

cyclists and pedestrians could cross free of the halfpenny toll. The passengers on the buses were no longer charged the toll to pay for the levy on the bus using the Bridge.

In the Autumn Lt.Col. C.E.Temperley left his post as Bournemouth Garrison Commander and at the Emergency Committee (Air Raids) meeting on 2nd November the Mayor, Alderman F.B. Summerbee, reported that he had expressed to Col. Temperley the appreciation of the Council for his co-operation and assistance whilst he had been Garrison Commander.

Mrs. Bertha E. Butler, 31, of Redbreast Road in Moordown was found guilty but insane at the Dorset Assizes in June of murdering her five year old son, Roger. She was sentenced to be detained during His Majesty's Pleasure. Then in October Gordon Douglas Tucker, an eighteen year old gardener, went on trial at the Dorset Assizes charged with murdering his father, Victor Tucker, on July 9th at Howeth Road, Ensbury Park. During a domestic argument while Mr. Tucker was assaulting his wife his son knifed him. The jury returned a verdict of "Not guilty of murder, but guilty of man-slaughter" with a strong recommendation for mercy. Gordon Tucker was bound over for two years as he was waiting to join the Services. The Judge said that if he misbehaved himself during that time he would be sent to prison, however if he behaved himself he would never hear any more of the case.

Two members of the Home Guard died whilst on duty during the year. The first was Private G. Jeffreys, 22nd (Post Office) Battalion Home Guard who was found shot in the chest whilst on guard at the main Bournemouth Post Office. He died at the Boscombe Hospital on 18th March. The verdict reached at the inquest was suicide. Then Private Percival Candler, B Company, 7th (Boscombe) Battalion Home Guard was fatally injured by a bullet from a Sten gun during a class of instruction held on 20th June. Death by misadventure was the verdict this time.

Temporary Lieutenant Colonel Derek Anthony Seagrim, born in Bournemouth on 24th September 1903, became the 3rd Bournemouthian to be awarded the Victoria Cross. His father, the Rev. C.P.C. Seagrim, was a Curate at St Peter's Church. In 1904 he became the Rector of Ashmansworth, Hampshire.

Lt.Col. Seagrim won his VC on the night of 20/21st March 1943, when he led an attack by the Green Howards on an important enemy position in the Mareth Line in Tunisia. The attack was successful although there were heavy casualties. Derek Seagrim led from the front and personally accounted for 20 of the enemy. The enemy counterattack was repulsed mainly due to Lt.Col. Seagrim's organisation of the defence. Unfortunately he died of wounds in hospital on 6th April 1943 and is buried in Sfax War Cemetery, Tunisia.

He is commemorated, along with Cpl. C.R. Noble VC and Sgt. F.C. Riggs VC MM, on the statue of Tregonwell and Creeke outside the Bournemouth International Centre. Also Seagrim Rd, Charminster, is named after him.

Chapter Six

1944

The New Year was rung in by St. Peter's bells, the first time since the ban on the ringing of church bells came into force in 1940. The half-muffled bells tolled the dying year out and an "open" peal heralded 1944 with the hope of a better year. To many people the coming year appeared as if it was to be just another wartime one. However others were more optimistic and looked forward to better things.

A step forward did occur in February. Work started on replacing the road signs, which directed the traveller to other towns and gave the mileage, removed in the invasion scare of 1940. The job took time, but Bournemouth's reputation as a town of signs was eventually restored. Unfortunately there were several instances of signs being put back in the wrong places. These mistakes, however, were soon rectified. Signs such as "To the gardens" or "To the cliff lift" had to wait until after the hostilities had finished.

The ban on the town's name on notice boards, shop signs and business premises was also relaxed later in the year, so Churches could again display the name of the town or suburb as well as the Saint's name or denomination. Delivery vans could now show the address of the firm which owned them, and the full telephone number instead of just the figures.

Another restriction which was removed was on the design of men's suits. The austerity suit which came into being in March 1942 was no longer compulsory, style was now allowed again. To sell their existing stocks men's shops had to cut the price.

But to replace that relaxation another restriction arose, that of the laundry service. An advertisement in the Echo on 5th February stated that "Laundries in Bournemouth are having heavy demands made upon their services by the Forces which have to take first place. Owing to the shortage of labour they cannot accept covers, sofa, chair or cushion, and all fancy articles having frills or flounces, excluding personal clothing". Later in June another announcement gave the priority to hospitals first, then the Forces, schools, hotels and institutions, the family wash came last!

The fifth British Restaurant in Seabourne Road was officially opened by the Mayor, Alderman J. Richards, on Wednesday 12th January. The prefabricated building seated one hundred and thirty people and provided the same food as the Lucullus Room at the Pavilion, the only difference was at the Pavilion there was silver service and a higher charge! This building still stands and is now used as a Day Centre for elderly people run by the Dorset County Council Social Services Department, as is the Springbourne British Restaurant, erected next to the Springbourne Library in Holdenhurst Road in 1946.

In March a roundabout for trolley buses was constructed at the top of Richmond Hill. This was considered necessary after the May raid the year before. Buses had to be turned around at the top because they were unable to use the road down the hill through bomb damage. At the time the bus crews had to manipulate long whippy poles in switching the trolley arms by hand from one set of wires to the other.

Bones were in the news in the early months of the year. Not enough were being collected for

salvage, and they were urgently needed for the production of glycerine. To increase the amount bins were attached to lamp standards in the roads so that housewives would not forget to give them for salvage.

A concentrator plant for the treatment of kitchen waste to make pig food was constructed in the Corporation Yard at Grafton Road. It commenced operating on 8th May, dealing with waste from Poole and Christchurch as well as Bournemouth. The waste food was sterilised and compressed into a pudding so reducing the chance of the pigs contracting diseases.

The weather was dry and cold for the first three months but April was a fairly wet one. The maximum allowance of coal per house for domestic purposes was 4cwt per month, so the coming of warmer weather was looked forward to. Many people had not been having fires except in the evenings. In previous years householders were able to purchase their allowance every month and stockpile it for really cold weather. Then the local Fuel Office announced that those whose store of fuel exceeded 5cwt would not be allowed to buy any more until that had been considerably reduced.

Oranges and lemons arrived in larger quantities. They now had to be displayed in the shop windows for everybody to see together with a notice "Not to be sold until - ". There was no official ration but most shops restricted the amount sold to 1lb per person .

Just after midnight of 20th/21st March the Fire Brigade received a warning from the RAF at Hurn Aerodrome that one of their bombers, Halifax JP137 from 1658 Conversion Unit, on a routine flight to North Africa, was in difficulties. Minutes later at 12.35 am it crashed at Moordown. The plane, full of fuel and fully armed, came in low over Malvern Road just clearing the rooftops, but its lowered undercarriage struck one roof leaving a large hole. It then plunged into the cottages, 1025, 1027, 1029 and 1031 Wimborne Road where it exploded setting fire to them and "Meadow Court", a block of flats almost opposite the Hollies Public House. One wing struck a cottage, causing the plane to crash upside down. Then an explosion threw one engine into nearby allotments. The aircraft was engulfed in flames, the eight man crew, plus two people, one man in the cottages and a lady in "Meadow Court", were killed. In a long letter in the Echo, 29th January 1985, an eye witness stated that ammunition on board the aircraft was exploding with bullets flying everywhere. It was reported that the fire could be seen for miles around.

This crash was due to mechanical failure and not enemy action. It was thought that the plane was already on fire and that the pilot was trying to land on some vacant land behind the flats and not crash on houses. Because of the warning the NFS were at the scene in minutes. It is ironic that the crash site had been used shortly before for an NFS exercise. The homeless were taken to the Moordown Bus Depot (now demolished) to be looked after by the WVS. The site was redeveloped after the war as "Meadow Court Close".

Three stories evolved from this incident. One was that it had been a "secret" flight, the plane carrying important passengers, perhaps dropping supplies for the Underground in France. The second that the landlord of the Hollies, who was amongst the first on the scene, was so affected by the cries of the men trapped in the blazing plane that he was eventually admitted to a mental home. The third was that German markings were painted on the remains of the aircraft after it had crashed to disguise the fact that it was British. Earlier, on January 26th, another Halifax, this time from Hurn's Overseas Aircraft Delivery Unit, crashed into the sea off Bournemouth Pier.

Later on the same day as the Halifax disaster Flight Lieutenant N.E. Pollock, a Canadian of 439 (RCAF) Squadron, was practising dog fighting with American Thunderbolts near Hurn when his Hurricane was in collision with one of them. Losing part of its starboard wing the Hurricane went into a spin and crashed, killing the pilot. Flight Lieutenant Pollock was buried in the North Cemetery with full military honours.

Prior to the invasion of Europe in June Hurn received many fighter squadrons and several crashes occurred. One pilot lost his life when two Typhoons of 247 Squadron collided on 8th May north of Hurn and then on 27th May another was killed when his plane crashed near Bransgore.

On 14th July 418 (City of Edinburgh) Squadron RCAF flew their Mosquito Vls into Hurn. From there they went on night intruder sorties to catch the Luftwaffe bombers returning to their

airfields in France. 418 also flew patrols to shoot down the flying bombs aimed at London. Nine days after their arrival a Mosquito was seen flying away from Hurn across North Bournemouth at about 7 o'clock in the evening. As it reached Wallisdown an eye witness saw it explode in a ball of flame and watched the aircraft fall out of the sky. He eventually found the remains on undeveloped land opposite the Alder Road Drill Hall (now the Royal Mail Alder Hills Sorting Office), still on fire. The pilot and navigator were both killed.

Patricia M.Wilnecker in her "Upper Parkstone in the Second World War" says the crash was caused by a wing touching the roof of a house in Mossley Avenue. The Mosquito then seemed to break up in mid air and crashed two hundred yards west of the Drill Hall. A resident of Talbot Village wrote a letter, published in the Echo 29th July, praising the pilot for his gallant effort in keeping the plane from crashing into houses.

418 left for Middle Wallop on lst August. They were the last British fighter squadron to be based at Hurn. The US Army Air Force took over on 3rd August with B26 Marauders of 596, 597 and 598 Squadrons of the 97th Bombardment Group, 9th Air Force. The B26s left for France on 20th August with Hurn formally returned to the RAF on 18th October. On lst November Hurn closed down as a military airfield as BOAC moved in making it a civil aerodrome.

A crash which killed and injured civilians as well as a Fireman and a Warden occurred on 29th June at Christchurch. A Thunderbolt of 509 Squadron, 405 Fighter Bomber Group, USAF, crashed on take off from Christchurch airfield ploughing into a bungalow in Foxwood Avenue. The subsequent explosion brought down another Thunderbolt which had just become airborne. The final death toll was sixteen with eighteen injured.

The last raid on the town occurred in the early hours Of 24th April, just after 2 o'clock. lt was described as a "very noisy raid". Aircraft, estimated at thirty, were heard to zoom and dive, the anti-aircraft guns putting up a massive barrage and brilliant searchlights swept the sky, but there was only minor damage. Several sources state that this raid took place on 27th May. However this was the date of the Echo in which the full details of the incident were published.

Phosphorous and incendiary bombs fell in Charminster and Springbourne. Stour, Avon, Strouden, Beatty, Portland, Gresham, Shelbourne, Holdenhurst Roads and Channinster Avenue were all showered. Fire destroyed the auditorium of the Roxy Cinema in Holdenhurst Road; this had been bought by the owners of the bombed West's Cinema in the town as a replacement. It was advertised in the local papers as "West's (late Roxy's)". Rebuilt after the war it is now the Roxy Bingo Hall. One person, a Fire Guard, was killed and another casualty died later in hospital. One hundred and fifty six properties were damaged, four houses and a shop were gutted by fires caused by incendiaries.

This raid was the first and only incident in which the new Fire Guard plan came into action. There was some criticism especially over what was thought to be a delay in requesting assistance from the Fire Brigade. This was denied and it was pointed out that the rest centres at St. Andrew's Church Hall and Lowther Road School were opened, food provided and officials were soon at the scene to save those bombed out having to go to the Town Hall for information and help.

At the end of March a ban on visitors to the South Coast, from the Wash to Lands End, was announced. From lst April restrictions on travel in the ten mile deep coastal belt came into force.
There were no restrictions on travel between Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch for Hampshire and Dorset were regarded as one area. The Chief Superintendent of the Bournemouth Police notified all hotels and boarding house keepers that they were advised to cancel all bookings for visitors who were not exempt, and to ask those in residence to leave by April lst if they did not come in the exempt categories. Those who had to leave were philosophical and many went before the deadline. Many hotels and boarding houses did not lose guests as they were occupied, principally the larger ones, by residents there for the duration. One hotel, the Norfolk (now Norfolk Royale), placed an advertisement in the local papers offering residents of Bournemouth a wonderful opportunity to stay at a really first class hotel as visitors were unable to come.

Various categories of visitors were allowed into the banned parts. Those travelling for business, illness, education, Servicemen on leave and children visiting their parents were allowed to

come into the town. Residents and visitors alike had to carry their identity cards at all times and could move around as long as they did not "poke their noses into things that did not concern them". No cameras, binoculars or telescopes were allowed.

The few visitors who came for Easter were checked at the railway stations by the Police and the Military Police, who inspected their identity cards and asked for a reason for their visit. Only a handful were refused permission to stay and had to return to their homes by the next suitable train.
The Police also had to check up at the hotels and boarding houses still open to make sure that the guests were all exempt.

The reason for the ban was the build up of troops and equipment for the invasion of Europe. The town, the surrounding countryside and the New Forest were all crowded with men, tanks, lorries and the stores needed for the offensive. The Civil Defence and the NFS were held in readiness for the enemy attacks which were expected but did not materialise.

More hotels and private houses, especially the larger ones, were requisitioned to house the soldiers. Houses in Marlborough and Portarlington Roads were used by Messrs. Harvey Nichols to store the furniture from the requisitioned buildings. Many of the tree-lined roads concealed military equipment, whilst on the trotting track around Queens Park Golf Links, and in the wooded parts, guns and lorries were parked nose to tail. One Royal Artillery Warrant Officer remembers being billeted in a large house in East Avenue backing on to the railway line, and using the then undeveloped ground beyond Glenferness Avenue for exercising the gun crews. The Carlton was one of the many hotels taken over and part of it housed the crews of self-propelled guns which were parked along the cliff top. General Eisenhower, Supreme Commander of the Allied Forces Western Europe, and General Montgomery had also stayed there when watching the invasion rehearsals in Poole and Studland Bays.

The 78th Infantry Division US Army came to Bournemouth for three weeks in the Autumn before going off to advance into Germany. In September 1945 the Mayor received a letter from the 2nd Battalion 311th Infantry, 78th Division, thanking the townspeople for their hospitality. They returned in November 1945 to spend their leave here.

The town was host to more and more troops, being used as a recreation centre for them. American airmen on leave at rest and recreation centres many miles away would come to visit the clubs and the local places of entertainment. One pilot remembers thinking nothing of taking a Jeep and driving from Walhampton House at Boldre, near Lymington, where he was resting between bombing tours, to spend a few hours at the BWSO Club at the Theatre Royal. Walhampton House is now a co-educational Church of England School. Bournemouth, too, had a "Rest home for bomber crews".

June 6th was D-Day. On the previous day people on the cliffs saw the Bay full of craft of all descriptions on their way to the invasion beaches, A plaque on the Quay at Poole states that on 5th June three hundred boats left there for Normandy. Later, planes roared over to France to attack the German positions or to defend the invading troops against the Luftwaffe. All these had the distinguishing markings of black and white strips round the fuselage and wings so they were easily identifiable. Many sorties were flown from Hurn and it was also used as a refuelling base. The Civil Defence and the AA gunners were on the alert against reprisal raids by the German Air Force.

The old airfield at Wallisdown, where the Bournemouth University now stands, was used by Piper Cubs of the US Army Liaison Unit until after the Invasion. The RCAF moved out completely from the town during the build-up to D-Day, the billets they vacated being used by the US Army. However the RCAF returned a few weeks later.

Two ambulance trains were stationed at Bournemouth West Station and these were soon in use transferring the wounded to military hospitals in the immediate neighbourhood. They were equipped with hammocks, hot and cold water, kitchens, a surgical ward and even a padded room. St. Leonards Hospital had been built during the Winter and Spring and was ready to receive the American wounded who arrived by train and by sea to Poole. The Hospital complete with operating theatres, X-ray department and a chapel was handed over after the war to the Health Service providing nearly one thousand extra beds for the area. It is now used as a geriatric hospital.

Amongst the ships in the Bay on D-Day were the Post Office cable layers "Iris" and "Alert".

They sailed on D+2 laying one hundred and five nautical miles of telephone cable from Southbourne to Normandy. This was, at that time, the longest cable of its type, and through it on D+3 at midnight went the first signal for four years from France to England by submarine cable.

In 1942 Bournemouth and the Purbeck coast were chosen as termination points for submarine cables to the invasion coast. A telephone land/sea line repeater station linking the Allied armies with Supreme Headquarters Allied Expeditionary Force at Southwick House just outside Portsmouth was constructed at Tuckton. The Royal Engineers built an underground chamber at the corner of Belle Vue and Tuckton Roads to house the repeater station and by June 1943 the equipment had been installed. All the installation work was carried out by local telephone engineers. The station magnified many times the signals sent along the cable which carried three speech and six teleprinter circuits, all of these could be used simultaneously. Two cables were also laid across the Bay to more equipment in Swanage. A second cable to France was laid five weeks later. By the end of 1945 these cables were no longer necessary and they were recovered. Churchill, Eisenhower, Montgomery and other famous leaders made use of these lines. Another method of communication between Normandy and RAF Hurn was the use of pigeons. Many came from the lofts of pigeon owners in the Bournemouth area.

A new exodus of Londoners to Bournemouth reminiscent of the early days of the war, started after the commencement of the V1 offensive on the night 12th/13th June. The flying bombs, or buzzbombs or doodlebugs as they were nicknamed, were pilotless planes launched from sites in France and aimed at the capital. Some deviated from the planned flight path, one being so much off course that it crashed and blew up at Ferndown near Church Road and Victoria Road. Another fell on the churchyard at Boldre in the New Forest. Luckily in both instances nobody was hurt. Later on in the year eighty builders went to London to help repair the damage caused by the Vls.

On 6th July the Town Clerk received a letter from Lt.Co1. P.J.W. Gatehouse, Commander Bournemouth Garrison, which stated that it was proposed to allow the public access to the beaches from the West Cliff lift to approximately one hundred yards west of Fisherman's Walk and from one hundred yards east of Fisherman's Walk to Sea Road, Southbourne. Access was to be provided by gaps in the barbed wire at West Cliff Lift, west and east of the Bournemouth Pier, East Cliff Lift, Toft Steps, Boscombe Pier, Manor Steps, Portman Ravine and Gordon Steps. Civilians would have to be clear of the beaches by 9.15 pm as Coast Watchers and Beach Patrols commenced their duties at 9.30 pm.

The work of removing some of the wire commenced on 25th July and the Borough Engineer undertook to remove some of the dragon's teeth. There were still mined areas at Durley, Middle and Alum Chines. These were enclosed with barbed wire and nearly all were cleared by August Bank Holiday. Notice boards warned "Danger Mines. It is forbidden and dangerous to proceed beyond this line", and at each opening to the beach "The public may use and bathe from this part of the beach but at their own risk. Beware of barbed wire and other obstructions. Do not touch any suspicious objects. By order Garrison Commander". The local newspapers also carried warnings of the danger of going into the mined areas. Children at school were also warned. Some people ignored the warning signs and in some cases actually removed them. Bomb disposal experts made a reconnaissance along the beach to investigate any articles which might have been dangerous before the beaches were declared free of explosives.

The scaffolding both in and out of the water was to be removed by civilian firms under contract with the military authorities. At the Beach and Pavilion Committee 18th August, it was reported that the Garrison Commander was now authorised to remove all the barbed wire with labour from the Civil Defence Reserve. After the mines were cleared from the chines and the wire moved the whole of the West beach was open to the public.

The St. John Ambulance First Aid Hut on the West promenade was reopened on 5th August, followed by the Boscombe Hut a week later. Many of the privately owned huts along the promenade which were not removed at the outbreak of war suffered badly from the enforced neglect. Their owners were now able to repair them and make them habitable again, if they were able to find the wood and paint to do so!

The ban on visitors was lifted on 12 July and the August Bank Holiday weekend saw the town flooded with people. On the Saturday over nine thousand left Waterloo for Bournemouth, extra trains being put on. Many found it difficult to obtain accommodation for the hotels and boarding houses open were fully booked. None of the four hundred requisitioned properties were released by the Authorities, nor were there any plans to do so.

The opening of the beaches proved very popular, even with the barbed wire and other obstacles still in place. There was a heavy demand for bathing costumes even though three clothing coupons had to be surrendered for one. The shops, both large and small, soon ran out. Another shortage was that of buckets and spades for the children. One paint shop reported that paint kettles were being purchased instead, whilst ironmongers were selling the small shovels designed to remove ash from the fire as a substitute for the spade. There was also a shortage of toothbrushes and hairbrushes, as well as razor blades.

Since the ban was lifted bus passengers, residents and visitors, found that they had to queue for long periods. So over twenty thousand bus priority passes were issued to war workers, office and shop staff, pink for men and buff for women. They were for use from 12.30 pm to 2.15 pm and 5.15 pm to 6.30 pm Monday to Friday, and 12 pm to 1.30 pm on Saturdays, so that the holders could take priority over the crowds of holiday makers at rush hours. The pass holders had to form a queue facing the ordinary one and when the bus arrived they were let on first. The bus stop signs indicated which side the priority holder had to stand. Identity cards, or bus passes, were also issued to enable war workers on late shifts to use the 10.15 pm bus service, which was restricted to Fire Guards and others going on night duty during the week, and Sunday morning workers the Sunday buses before 1 pm.

At the beginning of September the public were surprised to see Corporation workmen servicing the street lights in the main roads. From 17th September the Ministry of Home Security circular 97/1944 allowed the restrictions on street lighting to be relaxed from blackout to dimout. Albert and Post Oftice Roads, Richmond Hill and the Square were used to try out modified lamps on Saturday, September 23rd. Servicemen leaving the BWSO Club in Albert Road danced around the lamp standards and parents brought their children to see the streets lit up. The subdued lighting came into use on main roads radiating from the Square at first. Although not brilliant the lights were a relief from the hated blackout.

Dimout was also allowed for private houses from the middle of September. The Police placed posters in the town confirming the relaxation because many householders were not sure that they did not have to put up the shutters or draw the blackout curtains at night. The complete "obscuration" of light issuing from buildings was no longer required. There was no objection to light showing through windows if it was "diffused" by curtains so that no direct light could be seen. Skylights, however, still had to be covered completely. If an Alert occurred then the full blackout was to be observed. This was discontinued from 7th December.

Later on in October many people removed blast walls from in front of windows to let more light into their houses. This was not really allowed but the local authority turned a blind eye, but they did refuse permission to those who wished to dismantle their Morrison shelters just in case of any enemy air attack. However blast walls were officially allowed to be knocked down in July 1945.

Some districts had to wait as the modifications to the street lights were done in stages, but by the beginning of October over eight hundred lights were in use. This number rose to fifteen hundred by the middle of the month. There was a toll of approximately seven thousand lamps, one thousand electric and six thousand gas, in the town.

The main roads, road junctions and other places where the lighting was essential were lit first. More people were now out and about at night because of the return of the street lighting. The lamps described in the Echo as "moonlight" proved to be adequate, but the motorist still had to be careful and keep a lookout for pedestrians. The Central and West Railway Stations, plus the Square Bus Station, also improved their lighting to the delight of their passengers. Churches which, during the past years, had held afternoon instead of evening services on Sundays in the Winter no longer did so.

From Christmas Eve cars no longer needed to mask their lights and public clocks could be

illuminated at night. The clock at the Municipal College was lit early in the New Year. It was dim compared with prewar but the time could easily be read.

On Monday 11th September Lt.Co1. H.G. Wheeler, former Commanding Officer 6th (Bournemouth) Battalion Home Guard from November 1943 to June 1944, died. On the same day compulsory drills and training for the Home Guard were discontinued. Then on Sunday lst November the Home Guard was stood down.

The 6th (Bournemouth), together with the 7th (Boscombe) and the 21st (Southern Railway), Battalions Home Guard presented a pageant at the Pavilion on Friday 10th November. Entitled "Salute the Home Guard" it illustrated the history of the Home Guard from its start in May 1940 to the stand down on lst November 1944: The bands of the Hampshire Regiment and of the Boscombe Home Guard also entertained the packed theatre.

Later on Sunday 3rd December the Home Guard paraded for the last time in Meyrick Park. There was a march-past in Braidley Road of 6th (Bournemouth), 7th (Boscombe), 21st (Southern Railway) and 22nd (Post Office) Battalions when Brigadier K.F.D. Gattie, Commanding the Hampshire Sub-Division, took the salute. On the same day a national stand down parade was held in London. The 6th and 7th Battalions each sent an NCO and three men to represent them. The Home Guard was finally disbanded on 31st December 1945.

The eleven thousand residential and six thousand five hundred business premises Fire Guards were relieved of their duties by a Regulation which came into force in September, the night of September 11th/12th being the last one on which they had to be on duty. There was also a substantial reduction in the Civil Defence organisation, both in full time and part time personnel.

From 27th November the staff of the control centre in the Town Hall basement was cut from eighteen to eight, one hundred and fourteen Wardens Posts reduced to thirty, the rescue teams from eighty eight men to three parties of seven, and First Aid Posts from seven to one. Formal training for the Civil Defence ended on 31st December. However, Bournemouth remained a "proscribed" area and the Civil Defence, plus Fire Guards, needed to maintain a basic service so that they could be activated if required.

The Civil Defence had a farewell party on 20th December at which the Mayor, Cllr. Harry Brown, paid tribute to the personnel. He said "The people of Bournemouth owe a debt of gratitude to the unceasing vigilance of the Civil Defence service who were prepared at all times and in all circumstances to give of their best for their fellow men".

The Rest Centre service was also reduced towards the end of the year. All the Auxiliary Rest Centres were closed and only eight of the first line centres retained. The Maxwell Road Fire Station was closed, followed by the Nortoft Road Station in January. The number of full-time firemen was reduced meaning that until the peacetime manning levels came into force the part-time firemen were needed even more.

The Government decided that more information could be released about air raids without endangering security, so in November the ARP Controller, Cllr Mears, prepared a report for the members of the Corporation giving basic details of all the incidents. This report was eventually released to the Press (see Appendix D). However certain information could not be made known, such as damage to military objectives, size and type of bombs, and the number of unexploded bombs.

The fifty one raids, or incidents, are listed with brief details of the bombs dropped and the roads in which they landed. The number of casualties, killed and injured, are given and also the number of properties destroyed or damaged. Fuller details had been compiled by the Controller and circulated to the members of the Civil Defence Committee but these were classified as "Secret". Copies of two of these have been included in this pamphlet.

A summary of the incidents stated that two thousand two hundred and seventy one bombs, forty six tons, were dropped killing one hundred and sixty eight civilians, plus fifty one Service personnel, and injuring five hundred and seven. The number of Servicemen killed did not include those who died on 23rd May 1943 as at that time this was classified information.

The damage to property amounted to seventy five totally destroyed, one hundred and seventy

one so badly damaged that demolition was necessary, and ten thousand and eighty eight damaged but repairable, plus three thousand two hundred and fifty six which had glass broken only. Two out of every three bombs did not kill or injure anybody, but every bomb damaged in some way six buildings.

There were nine hundred and fifty eight Alerts, sixteen which sounded after bombs were dropped, and fifty nine bombs which arrived without any warning at all.

In September the News Chronicle related that plans for a German invasion in Spring 1942 had been found in Brussels. Landings were to be made around Lulworth Cove. The invading forces would have advanced to Blandford, Salisbury and Andover then swung round to London.
Bournemouth and Poole would have been cut off at first then when the enemy had reached London the town would have been attacked from the country and not from the sea. Local people remembered the many occasions when enemy aircraft had flown over the coast and beaches presumably photographing the defences and suitable places for a landing.

In the Echo of 13th October there was a letter from a Londoner complaining about the lack of hotel accommodation in the town. He was unable to book a hotel for the dates he required. Bournemouth was enjoying a record wartime season, the demand being nearly ten times as heavy as previous years. The pressure on accommodation meant that hotels and boarding houses were completely booked for October and there were few vacancies for November.

The Americans celebrated Thanksgiving Day in November with turkey dinners at the Marsham Court and the Trouville. Their Red Cross girls and Officers visited schools explaining Thanksgiving Day to the children, its history, its significance and what it meant to Americans.

Exhibitions had been held in different places during the year. The majority were on the Services and their activities such as the one at Bealesons (the site is now the Avenue Centre) in December on the Air Sea Rescue Service. However earlier in October an exhibition at Bobbys (now Debenhams) in aid of the Henry Wood Promenade Jubilee Fund emphasised the close links the town had with the late Sir Henry. Salute the Soldier Week had been held from May 27th to the day before D-Day, June 5th. It commenced with a ceremonial parade with Sir James Grigg, Secretary of State for War, speaking from the Regent Cinema balcony. There were displays by the ATS and the NFS, a drumhead service in Meyrick Park, and an exhibition of war material at the Town Hall. No target for the collection was announced but the final total was £ 1,759,064.

A new Toc H Women's Services Club officially opened at St. Cuthbert's, 19 Christchurch Road, on Saturday 29th December. Already in use for five weeks it became known for its cheerful and friendly atmosphere. It had accommodation for nineteen girls at two shillings and sixpence (121/ip) per night.

There was a campaign in Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch to provide replacement household articles for the people of Woolwich, who had lost their homes through the V weapon attacks, as a thanksgiving for not being bombed.

During the war years municipal progress was at a standstill, but the Council was having thoughts on the post war development and reconstruction of the town, especially the seafront. The Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch Councils together commissioned Professor (later Sir) Patrick Abercrombie, Professor of Town Planning at University College London, to make a survey and produce a report on possible development in the three towns. Sir Patrick commenced his survey in 1944, then produced in 1946 "A Plan for Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch" which did not come to fruition.

Bournemouth had been the only town in Britain to keep its Municipal Orchestra during the war. They played twice at the Pavilion every Sunday to full houses. The afternoon was the time for the symphony concerts and the evening for light music. Many Servicemen were regular concert goers.

At St. Peter's Hall, Hinton Road (now the Palace Nightclub), on Monday lunchtimes and in the evenings the Wessex Philharmonic played for war workers and the staffs of local shops and offices. The Corporation objected to the names used by the Wessex Philharmonic Orchestra which had been formed by redundant musicians from the Municipal Orchestra with help from local amateurs. An action was heard in the Chancery Division when Bournemouth Corporation applied to the Court to

stop them using the title Bournemouth Philharmonic, or Bournemouth Symphony Orchestra because of the confusion that could arise between them and the Municipal Orchestra. The defendants gave an undertaking not to use these names.

The first party of evacuees left for their homes in Southampton and Portsmouth in the middle of December from West Station. They were followed by the girls of St. Anne's Catholic School, who had been sharing with Talbot Heath, on 20th December. Other evacuees were collected by their parents as soon as clearance to do so had been announced.

During the year there were fifty awards for bravery to Bournemouth men in the Forces. Twenty one DFCs, plus three Bars to existing awards, five DSOs, one DSM, four MMs, nine DFMS, one DSC, two OBES and one MBE. A Victoria Cross and a George Medal were awarded to two men with local connections.

A member of Bournemouth Sports Club was awarded the Victoria Cross in September. Flying Officer J.A. Cruikshank played in many of the Club's Rugby games in 1943 when he was stationed locally. He was the pilot Of a Catalina flying boat of 210 Squadron, Coastal Command, which attacked a U Boat on the 17th July. Even though he received seventy two wounds caused by "flak" he succeeded in sinking the German submarine, releasing the depth charges himself.

The George Medal was awarded to Private Thomas Orr Thorburn, Pioneer Corps, whose next of kin lived in Bournemouth. In September 1943 a dump of petrol in Salerno was hit. Private Thorburn, even though he had been wounded in the back by shrapnel, started to salvage the petrol.
Although the dump was on fire and petrol cans were exploding around him he was able to organise a working party when others arrived. Private Thorburn is credited with saving some thousands of gallons which were vital to the Army.

HMS Phoebe sent Christmas greetings "To lovely Bournemouth from lovely Phoebe" by airgraph to the Echo. A picture of the message was published in the paper on December 14th. The Captain telegraphed a message to the people of Bournemouth via the Mayor, "Very many thanks for all you have done for your adopted cruiser. Wishing you a happy and prosperous New Year from all on board" . The Mayor also received several messages from America thanking the town for the hospitality extended to the US Servicemen.

Two thousand Bournemouthians in the Services received an illustrated airgraph as a Christmas greeting from the BWSO. A local artist, Eustace Nash, drew three pictures, the Pavilion, St. Peter's Church, and the Bay, to remind them of their home town.

A similar airgraph was sent at Easter 1945. This had a picture of a corner of the Pleasure Gardens with an inset view of the Undercliff Drive at Boscombe, both drawn by Eustace Nash.

Chapter Seven

1945

The winter of 1944-45 was bitterly cold and fuel was short, but the end of the war was in sight. Even so the outlook was dreary, Bournemouth itself looking sad, shabby and knocked about. Organisations were disbanding, the spirit of comradeship of fighting the war and the shortages was declining.

The Civil Defence Service closed down completely in May. All the personnel were disbanded, the control room in the Town Hall shut down and the national air raid warning system discontinued from mid-day on 2nd May. The Civil Defence Offices in Fairlight Glen closed and reverted to Council Offices in June.

The ARP Controller related to the Civil Defence (ARP) Committee on 23rd April that Sir Alexander MacLean who had presented two trailer canteens for use by Civil Defence personnel, had agreed that they should be sent overseas in response to the request of the Government for mobile canteens for the troops and for feeding the civilian population in liberated countries.

Then at the ARP Committee meeting on 22nd October the Town Clerk reported that the Council had decided to record their appreciation of the work of the ARP Controller, Cllr. H.P.E. Mears. This took the form of an Illuminated Address on vellum which was presented to Cllr. Mears at the Council Meeting on lst January 1946. The Chief Warden, Lt. Col. R.J. Malet, was given a Testimonial under the Seal of the Council for his "devoted and valuable services to the Civil Defence since 1938".

The Fire Guard Orders for the town were rescinded by the Regional Commissioner on 28th February, the Fire Guards having been stood down since September 1944. The Fire Guard plan was then cancelled and the ordinary peace time methods of calling the Fire Brigade reinstated.

Part-time members of the National Fire Service held what was virtually a stand down church parade on Sunday 15th April. The four hundred members of the Red Cross and St. John Ambulance Brigade attended a special service at St. Peter's on Sunday 22nd April followed by a march-past in Westover Road where the Mayor took the salute. On Sunday 27th May fifty members of the Central Division of the Civil Defence attended Evensong at St. Peter's Church. After the service the Vicar, Prebendary N.R. Boyd, blessed their Colours which were then handed into the Church's keeping. The Colours now hang, with others, in the West end of the Church. One of these, the standard of the RAF Association was dedicated and laid up in the November. The Colours of the 7th Battalion the Hampshire Regiment were also laid up in St. Peter's on Saturday July 20th 1946, the Battalion having ceased to exist on 30th June.

At the end of March Taunton's School returned to Southampton and Bournemouth School had the East Way building to itself. Dr. H.M. King, referred to as Bournemouth's best known evacuee, went with them. The City of Southampton gave a reception and lunch in May to say an official thank you to Bournemouth for the welcome and hospitality provided for their evacuees. The Mayor, Cllr. H.C. Brown, and a Civic party attended. The return of evacuees to London began on 4th May, but some hundreds were not able to go home as their houses had been destroyed in the bombing or by the Vls or V2s. The National Society Training College of Domestic Subjects vacated the Princes Hotel

to return to the Capital.

With the departure of Dr. King the V Amateur Concert Party closed down. Registered under the War Charities Act 1940 it gave five hundred and seventy six shows to over one hundred thousand members of the Forces stationed in and around Bournemouth. Its first concert was in August 1941 and the last one in March to a Naval Unit. The members paid their own expenses and raised over £5,000 for war charities. The story of the V Concert Party was told by Dr. King in "Music, magic and dancing", a pamphlet published in 1944.

There were also other concert parties made up of amateur artists who provided shows for the troops and were greatly appreciated. Amongst them were the Piccadors, Spot on Variety, Black Dominoes, Tip Top Variety, Nonstop, and one made up of Civil Servants from the Home Office Departments evacuated to the town.

One artist who gave the Servicemen much pleasure was the comedian Tony Hancock, whose parents ran the Durlston Court Hotel, Gervis Road, which was not requisitioned; Tony Hancock being employed as a temporary clerk at the Board of Trade. He died in Sydney, Australia, in June 1968. The Mayor, Cllr. Margaret Hogarth, unveiled a plaque on the Hotel to his memory on Saturday 3rd April 1993. The inscription reads "Durlston Court Hotel was the childhood home of comedian Tony Hancock. The family moved here from the Railway Hotel, Holdenhurst Road. Tony's first engagement was entertaining the troops at the Sacred Heart Church on Richmond Hill".

A new Forces Centre opened in March at 30 Dean Park Road. This one was not just recreational but also provided organised lectures and educational classes every evening. There were facilities to learn woodworking and a room which had maps and information on the war and its progress. Other events included gramophone record concerts, choral singing and chess competitions. However later in the year services clubs were closing down. The Westbourne Free Church Forces Canteen in the Congregational Church Hall closed just before Christmas, six years after it started in December 1939. During that time it had served one million, two hundred and five thousand, eight hundred and forty four sandwiches and six hundred and fifteen thousand, two hundred and two cups of tea! In September the American Red Cross Club at the Hawthornes Hotel held its farewell party and St. Cuthbert's Toc H Club, which in its eighteen months had provided accommodation for eight thousand Servicewomen, closed on the 29th.

The Winton YMCA celebrated its 25th Anniversary in April. Its first building had been a First World War ex-Army wooden hut from the convalescent camp at Barton on Sea. This was erected on land in Jameson Road, which had been used for visiting circuses, and was even then in a comparatively undeveloped area of Bournemouth. The hut was formally owned by Lady Malmesbury in April 1920. The present brick building, which is on the same site, replaced the hut in 1928. Since the beginning of the war it had been used as a rest centre for air raid victims, billets for French soldiers after Dunkirk and for English soldiers later on. As well as providing a club for Servicemen it carried on with normal activities for its members.

"From Monday evening until well into yesterday morning Bournemouth let itself go in celebrating the end of the war with Germany. Although Mr. Churchill did not broadcast till Tuesday afternoon the announcement that the war would end at one minute past midnight, it was known the previous day that the Germans were capitulating, so that Monday night became pre-VE day" so reported the Bournemouth Times and Directory on Friday May 11th.

On VE (Victory in Europe) Day, Tuesday 8th May, thousands gathered in the Square, which was hung with bunting and flags, to rejoice at the war in Europe ending. They sang and danced causing congestion and halting the traffic, then at 3 o'clock five thousand people in Meyrick Park listened to the Prime Minister, Winston Churchill, making the historic announcement over the radio. In the morning the Mayor and members of the Council attended the Thanksgiving Service at St. Peter's Church. Afterwards the Mayor, Cllr. H.C. Brown, and the Councillors processed to the Upper Pleasure Gardens where the Mayor planted a Mexican Swamp Cypress tree near to the War Memorial to commemorate Victory in Europe, The tree was a symbol of "Anglo-American relations and was chosen to commemorate the Allies who fought together against a common foe".

In the evening crowds went to the Pavilion where the fountain was switched on at 9.45 pm and jets of multi-coloured water shot twenty feet into the air, the first time for almost six years. The RCAF added to the festivities by giving a gala dance at the Winter Gardens with a free buffet and beer.

Even though the dimout was still in force several buildings were floodlit including Bobbys, the Palace Court Hotel, and the Norfolk. There were street parties in many parts of the town with tables groaning with food hoarded for such an occasion. The largest Victory party was held at Wallisdown for one thousand children. On Sunday May 13th the VE (Victory in Europe) Parade marched down Bath Hill and into Westover Road where the Mayor, Cllr. H.C. Brown, took the salute outside the Pavilion. The parade consisted of six thousand members of the Forces, Civil Defence, Home Guard, Red Cross, St. John Ambulance, Scouts, Guides and other organisations. Then it proceeded to Meyrick Park where a Drumhead Service was held with over twenty thousand people attending. The event was described as "One of the greatest, if not the greatest" parades seen in the town.

The dimout came to an end on Friday May 11th. That evening Bobbys, the Echo building on Richmond Hill and several other establishments legally switched on their floodlights. Buses, both Corporation and Hants & Dorset, were soon able to restore their inside lighting to peacetime levels. Full electric, and partial gas, street lighting was switched on at the beginning of August just in time for the August Bank Holiday.

The Japanese Government surrendered on 14th August after the Atomic Bombs dropped on Hiroshima on 6th August and Nagasaki on 9th August, the announcement being made by the Prime Minister, Clement Attlee, at midnight on Tuesday 14th August. An American band, the US Air Transport Command Contact Caravan, which was staying at the Carlton, were roused from their beds and led a cheering crowd to the Square. They climbed to the top of the shelter in the centre and played so that several thousand people could dance. During the day bands played in the gardens and on the Undercliff Drive. The King's speech was broadcast to a crowd of about fifteen thousand gathered in Westover Road at 9 pm and afterwards there was community singing around the Pavilion fountain. The celebrations continued over the next two days with the Pleasure Gardens floodlit and illuminations in the Square.

The first general election since the war started was held on 5th July and Sir Leonard Lyle was re-elected with a majority of 20,312. However in Winston Churchill's Resignation Honours List in August Sir Leonard was elevated to the Peerage, taking the title Lord Lyle of Westbourne, of Canford Cliffs, in the County of Dorset, and a bye-election was held on November 15th. Brendan Bracken was then elected as Member of Parliament for Bournemouth in his stead, but with a much smaller majority, 6,454. At this time there was only one MP for the town.

Earlier in the same month, November, local elections had been held, the first for six years, the last being in November 1938. During the war, when elections were suspended, twenty Councillors had been co-opted to fill vacancies on the Council. For those Councillors who were standing in the election, in some cases, it was the first one they had to fight.

At their December meeting the Council approved the General Purposes and Parliamentary Committee minute which placed on record their deep appreciation of the splendid work done by the women of Bournemouth in caring for the evacuees, They had taken into their homes nine thousand six hundred unaccompanied school children and treated them as their own, rendering a service to their country the value of which could not be disputed. There were also four thousand six hundred mothers with six thousand three hundred children of school age or below, together with four thousand nine hundred other adults, mostly aged and infirm, making approximately twenty five thousand four hundred evacuees who sought safety and accommodation in the town. The Council also acknowledged "with gratitude and thanks the kindness and willingness of all owners and occupiers who gave up their premises for the purposes of air raid shelters, wardens' posts etc."

The demolition of the public shelters was begun and the Wardens' Posts returned to their original uses as garages, stores, etc, However, not all the shelters were demolished. The one in

Holdenhurst Road by the Central Station survived until April 1991 when it was demolished to make way for a filling station. Another at Cemetery Junction was converted into the Public Conveniences to replace those which had been closed at the beginning of the war, whilst approval was sought by the Housing Committee from the Ministry of Health to convert the four shelters in Westover Gardens, and also the Iford Lane shelter, into bungalows; but the Ministry did not think they were suitable. The buildings in Westover Gardens were used as stores for a number of years. They now stand with their doors bricked up a few yards from the busy road along which people walk not knowing that these relics of the war still exist. The domestic shelters provided free had to be returned to the local authority or paid for. Scouts helped dismantle Morrison shelters for the aged or infirm.

In May the NFS released the water stored by the dams in the Upper Gardens. This was done slowly in order that the Lower Gardens would not be flooded. They also started removing the steel static water tanks. Tenders were invited by the Council for the emptying, removal and disposal of the concrete and brick tanks. When they were being emptied, amongst the rubbish in one basin in Charminster two unexploded incendiary bombs were found! During the same month a start was made in removing the steel pipelines laid in the streets to provide water for fighting fires. There was an estimated fifteen miles in Bournemouth and Poole. The dismantling commenced at the Poole end, at Iford and in the Square. Even though the pipeline was painted with white bands at intervals it was a danger to the pedestrian, especially at night. It had proved its worth, however, when the water it provided helped to save the town centre from fire on Sunday 23rd May 1943.

There was a big improvement in the appearance of the seafront in April following the removal of barbed wire and stakes from the former flower beds, the dragon's teeth and anti-invasion obstacles from the Pier Approach and the filling in of the slit trenches on the cliffs. The scaffolding in the water, which was rusty and sunk deep in the sand, had been cleared for 400 yards east of the Bournemouth Pier and 200 yards beyond Alum Chine. The removal of these beach defences could only be done when the low Spring tides were favourable, and then only for a restricted period. German Prisoners of War were employed to operate the winches dragging sections out of the water and up the beach.

The rifle ranges in Middle Chine were also closed plus the grenade throwing range on the West Cliff. A use was found for the barbed wire removed from the cliffs and promenade in the foundations for the widening and straightening of part of Wimborne Road at Redhill.

A scheme for providing hospitality in local homes for the wounded from American hospitals situated close to Bournemouth in Dorset and Hampshire was started early in the year. The soldiers arrived, complete with their rations, on Saturday and returned to their hospitals on Monday afternoon. This proved to be very successful and much appreciated. One hundred convalescent soldiers were able to sample English home life every week.

Bournemouth, known to the Gls as "The Miami of Britain", was also chosen as a leave centre for battle weary American soldiers from Europe. From the middle of May until the end of September three thousand five hundred arrived each week to spend their seven days leave before being posted elsewhere. The American Red Cross arranged many social events for them. American sports such as volleyball, pitching horseshoes and baseball were also organised. Advertisements in the local papers called for staff to work in the clubs to help cope with the influx. In March the American Red Cross presented certificates at a ceremony at the Ambassador to seventy local ladies in recognition of the work they had put in at the Club.

The Carlton was taken over by the American Red Cross as another club. This was decided on lst May and the club opened in fifteen days. The building was redecorated by German Prisoners of War, the material being provided by the US Army, but furnished by the Ministry of Works. The Carlton housed five hundred and forty six men whilst the Hawthornes Hotel slept six hundred. The Miramar, Gresham Court and Granville Court were used as accommodation for Nurses and WAC Officers. Granville Court, Gervis Road, was returned to its owner on 10th December, opening on December 20th for Christmas with a full complement of guests. It had been used as a rest centre for bomber crews.

In November the Americans vacated ten requisitioned hotels: Hawthornes, Highcliff, Tollard

Royal, Southcliffe, Royal Exeter, East Cliff Mansions. Trouville, Priory, Granville Court and 105 St. Michael's Road. As these were all used by the Red Cross not too much work would have been needed to restore them to their former use as hotels. However those which had been billets were not treated as well. The number of hotels and boarding houses occupied by the War Department at the end of September was ninety. This dropped to seventy six in December, then to twenty by the end of February 1946. There were others requisitioned by the Ministry of Works and the Air Ministry in addition. The Tralee, St. Michael's Road, was requisitioned in 1940 for Cox & King's, the Army bankers.

Released Australian, New Zealand and Canadian Prisoners of War arrived in the town to recuperate before returning to their own countries. Although they were not wounded they were kept under medical supervision and given special diets to build them up. When they were considered fit they were allowed to go home. In July four special trains left the West Station with one thousand repatriated RCAF Prisoners of War and five hundred RCAF personnel on the start of their long journey home. While they waited for transport several RCAF men helped at Dean Park Cricket Ground in preparing it for the season, the Hampshire County Cricket Team playing there for the first time since 1939 against the RAF at the end of August. One or two helped a coal merchant and two tried their hand at window dressing for several shops! American soldiers also waiting to return home served in shops, and one even went to a chemist in Winton to see how English pharmacists worked. There were refresher courses for the occupations the servicemen had before they were called up and also on promoting good relations between the English and the Americans.

British soldiers also came on leave from the Army Trade Schools at Tidworth. There those waiting for demobilisation took refresher courses in their craft or trade, They were brought by three trains which carried up to one thousand men at a time.

At a Special Meeting of the Council, 4th September, it was resolved that "in recognition of the very long and close association existing between the Borough and the Regiment the Council should confer upon the Hampshire Regiment the privilege, honour and distinction of marching through the streets of Bournemouth on all ceremonial occasions with colours flying, drums beating and bayonets fixed".

On Wednesday, 12th September, the Mayor, Cllr. H.C. Brown, presented the Scroll and its Casket to the Colonel of the Regiment, Major General Sir George Jeffreys, in a ceremony outside the Town Hall by the Braidley Road steps. Then the four hundred men, drawn from all the Battalions, marched through the town, the Mayor taking the salute outside the Pavilion. At the head of the parade was the Regimental Band and Fritz, the mascot of the lst Battalion. Fritz was a large brown and white St. Bernard dog taken from a German Officer captured near Arromanches, then sent to England as a POW, eventually being adopted by the lst Battalion as their mascot.

Another presentation took place outside the Town Hall on Tuesday, 25th September, when Group Captain H.G. Richards, RCAF, Commanding Officer No.3 PRC, handed to the Mayor a plaque made of bronze with the RCAF badge in colour on it. The plaque was inscribed "in commemoration of the many thousands of air crew and ground crew of the RCAF who were stationed in Bournemouth during the second Great War, and as a memorial to the undying courage and valour of those who made the supreme sacrifice in the course of daily duty in the struggle for freedom". This plaque can be seen on the wall of the Hall of Remembrance in the Town Hall.

Earlier in the year, in March, the Mayor, Cllr. H.C. Brown, received a plaque from the War Office to mark the part Bournemouth played in the Salute the Soldier Week in 1944. It is now on display in the Hall of Remembrance also. A smaller trophy was handed to Cllr. S. Bell, Chairman of the local Savings Committee for the Committee's efforts. Lord Kindersley, President of the National Savings Committee, was present when the Mayor unveiled a new indicator on the bus shelter in the Square. This replaced the one installed in 1940, the ceremony taking place on Wednesday, 7th March.

Thanksgiving Week ran from Saturday 13th to Saturday 20th October, and was opened by Lord Lyle of Westbourne. The week was to express the thanks of the townspeople for victory. The town was festooned with flags and bunting and there was the usual military parade. On display in the

Pavilion forecourt was a one-man midget submarine which caused a great deal of interest. Then on the second Saturday the Royal Artillery gave a display in Meyrick Park with 25-pounders and Bofors anti-aircraft guns. The target for National Savings for the week was £1,000,000 which was exceeded; the final total being £1,336,419. The Mayor announced the totals collected each day at the Savings Indicator in the Square.

Many members of the Forces having travelled from overseas and arriving by train after the last buses had gone were grateful for the "Get you home service" operating in Bournemouth, Poole and Christchurch. Each night of the week the Rotary Club ran the scheme up to midnight and the Round Table after that. Volunteer drivers waited at the stations to transport the men to their homes, sometimes undertaking long journeys to villages outside the town. Notices were displayed so that the men arriving knew of the service.

Easter 1945 was the busiest one since the beginning of the war. All the trains arriving on the Thursday, Friday and Saturday at the Central and West Stations were packed. Queues were everywhere, the restaurants, cafes and pubs were full, and the cinemas and theatres reported bumper business. Accommodation was at a premium and service hostels, the YMCA and the Church Army, were booked solid.

Earlier in the year pleasure sailing and fishing were allowed in the Bay. The ban was also relaxed in Poole and Christchurch Harbours as well. Motor boat trips around the Bay by Bolson's Skylark 8, the first to be released by the Admiralty, went from the landing stage on the West side of Bournemouth Pier where there was a large gap in the anti-invasion obstacles. A steel jetty on wheels with a double gangway for passengers going out to the boat and returning was used to bridge the gap between the beach and the landing stage. The first trips went on Sunday 5th August.

Even though there was still scaffolding along the waters edge big crowds enjoyed the beach. Punch and Judy were back and the Bournemouth Military Band played on the sea front. The first refreshment kiosk on the promenade opened in July to be followed by several others. The East Cliff lift was oprating and repairs were being made on the Fisherman's Walk lift. This opened on Saturday 4th August in time for the August Bank Holiday. The Pier Approach Baths were refurbished and opened to the public from 9 am to 8 pm daily, the first time they had done so since September 1939. Also on 11th August the West Beach Bathing Station reopened.

Whitsun was not very sunny, but nineteen thousand visitors arrived by train. Weather forecasts were now available so the public were able to plan their outings. Day trippers who did not want to queue for cafes and restaurants brought their own food. Day trips were easier from June for the basic petrol ration became available again, so many motorists put their cars back on the road. The town was now being invaded by motorists with each weekend being busier than the one before, Coach trips to the countryside, the New Forest and the Purbecks and Swanage were now available to the holiday maker.

Motor Torpedo Boats paid courtesy visits in July. Rough seas at the first visit made it impossible for the public to go on board the three boats, but the second, of six MTBS, was in better weather, allowing them to be open for inspection. Thirteen LCIs (Landing Craft infantry) anchored in line off the West beach in early October. Rowing boats and the Skylark on its half-an-hour cruise around the Bay took people out to view them.

Four anti-submarine mines were washed ashore at Southbourne in October. They were dealt with by the Bomb Disposal Squad from HMS Turtle, the Naval Base at Hamworthy. One mine exploded at Highcliffe, when it hit the beach defences, causing damage to Highcliffe Castle.

Towards the end of the year information was being released on the "Hush-hush" industries in the town. The first Of Bournemouth's wartime factories started in September 1939. This was in the Westover Garage in Westover Road. There over a million shells were made for the Army and the Navy. The machine shops made a third of a million parts for Hurricanes, Spitfires and Seafires, and one hundred and thirty thousand parts for tanks, Bren gun carriers, plus thousands for guns, gliders and torpedoes. In 1940 several hundred soldiers attended courses in mechanical engineering and vehicle repair. Vehicles for the essential services were still serviced and repaired in the Westover

workshops. The Majestic Garage, also in Westover Road, was taken over by the Admiralty as workshops too.

Messrs. John E. Clarke & Co. of Windham Road, coach and motor vehicle upholsterers, produced four hundred and eight thousand five hundred parachutes, plus a large quantity of other equipment. They received their first contract to supply targets to be towed behind a plane for anti-aircraft gun practice in January 1940. They also manufactured targets for training radar operators. Sixty four thousand of these targets were produced as well as forty four thousand three hundred canvas packs for the parachutes. Twice the factory was damaged by bomb blast, but this only held up production for a short time.

A new factory had been constructed at West Howe for the Telecommunications Research Establishment, where radar was being researched, at Swanage and Worth Matravers. On a site between the Bournemouth Gas and Water Co. and the Northbourne Golf Course building was started in October 1941. Then in March 1942 a small civilian staff moved in and started the Research Project Unit. There H2S (Home Sweet Home) was produced. This was a self-contained radar set in the aircraft which "read" the territory over which it was passing. This allowed the navigator to "see" the land, sea, lakes, towns under the aircraft and then direct it accurately to the target. By the end of January 1943 the first aircraft equipped with H2S were carrying out bombing missions on Germany.

As the device proved so successful the workforce was expanded to seven hundred and the building extended to enable the unit to manufacture hundreds of the sets for Bomber Command. Girls were recruited from local shops and offices and were trained as Radar Wireless Mechanics at the Municipal College so that they could wire the complicated apparatus. At the Higher Education Sub-Committee on 5th November it was reported that the Air Ministry had expressed their "appreciation of the admirable work done by the Technical College in the training of Radar/Wireless Mechanics" . The Unit also produced equipment, ASV, to help Coastal Command aircraft locate U-boats on the surface at night. In all RPU designed and produced ninety seven different types of radar equipment. The building was taken over by Max Factor to manufacture cosmetics in September 1946.

There were numerous small factories making parts all over the town, such as a radio workshop over the News Theatre in Albert Road (now Bath Travel). The British Telecommunications building in Ringwood Road was used to make torpedoes and part of the Echo building was, for a short time, used for weaving aircraft wiring looms. A letter in the Bournemouth Advertiser, 7th May 1992, states that about fifty women engaged on this vital piece of war work were transferred to the basement at Beales after the damaged building had been demolished.

Basic details were also released about Bournemouth's own "Underground". The members of the Special Duties Organisation, a Publican, a Councillor, a Butcher, a Doctor and a Garage Proprietor, and a Barmaid, who was the Section Leader, were to provide information in time of invasion to the Army on enemy troops and supplies. They were to spy only and were not armed, nor were they "guerillas". There was a secret camouflaged underground hideout near the cliffs, and at the St. Leonards Hotel, near Ringwood, where the Barmaid worked, there was a bunker in the woods with a radio, its aerial hidden in the trees. These precautions were taken because the town was considered a very vulnerable place.

Armistice Day, Sunday 11th November, saw the first Armistice Service to be held at the War Memorial since the beginning of the war. Many ex-servicemen attended as well as contingents from the Armed Services stationed in the town. Afterwards the Mayor and Council proceeded to St. Peter's Church where the annual Civic Service took place.

A Resettlement Advice Office was opened in Post Office Arcade (now the Criterion Arcade) to deal with the problems of the men and women from the Services and war factories in getting restarted in "civvy street". The Bureau aimed to help with the wide variety of subjects asked about, such as setting up in business, getting a job, receiving training for an occupation and obtaining somewhere to live.

The first peacetime Christmas was enjoyed by everybody even though it was still an austerity

one. The RCAF gave local children a party at the Royal Bath Hotel, flying in two planes full of toys from the Continent because they could not find them in England.

There were two murders during the year. The first was by Astralder Brynjolfsson, a twenty year old Icelandic Seaman employed in a civilian capacity by the American Forces. As he was subject to American military law he was handed over to the US Army. Brynjolfsson was sentenced to life imprisonment by a US Court-martial at Southampton for the manslaughter and rape of military records clerk Lance Corporal Enid Marion Simpson, ATS, twenty two years old. They met at a Pavilion dance on March 14th, then whilst taking her home to 47 Norton Road, Winton, he assaulted her in the grounds of the Anglo-swiss Hotel in Gervis Road. Several people heard her screams and called the police. They found her body in a store room in the basement of the Hotel together with Brynjolfsson. L/Cpl. Simpson was buried with full military honours in the North Cemetery on Monday, 19th March.

The second was a double murder followed by a suicide. Arthur Hervey, a discharged soldier and prewar Beach Inspector, shot and killed Mrs. Kate Barnes and her son, Derek, at the Warnford and Christchurch Road cross roads at midnight on August 17th. He then turned the gun on himself.

At the end of the year the Bournemouth Times announced that thirty one DFCs, twenty MCs, four DSOs, three DSCS, three DSMS, one DFM and one Conspicuous Gallantry Medal had been awarded to local Servicemen.

A different decoration was awarded in September to Private Wilfred Ellis, 2nd Bournemouth Company, Boys' Brigade. The Mayor presented him with the Boys' Brigade Cross of Heroism for saving a twelve year old boy from drowning at the Company's swimming pool at Grove Farm, Iford. The boy had been pushed into the river, but could not swim. Private Ellis jumped in and brought him safely to the bank. This was only the second such medal to be won in Bournemouth. The first one had been awarded thirty years previously.

Chapter Eight

1946 and afterwards

War Memorials were being unveiled in many churches and chapels. The following are examples of the different ways that were used to commemorate those who lost their lives.

At the end of 1945 a unique War Memorial was dedicated at St. John's Church, Moordown. This was to commemorate the five members of the 30th Bournemouth Sea Scouts who gave their lives. The Memorial was a weather-vane in the shape of a four masted barque mounted on the top of a flag pole. In April 1946 the Mayor, Cllr. R.H. Old, unveiled a plaque in the Pavilion at the Winton Recreation Ground to the memory of the members of the Bournemouth Parks Department who died, Then in June the Boscombe Baptist Church installed a window to the memory of those from the Church killed in the Second World War, and on 10th November, the day before Armistice Day, an oak reredos in memory of the fifteen men of the district who gave their lives during the war was unveiled at the Church of the Holy Epiphany, Castle Lane.

After much discussion it was decided that Bournemouth's Memorial should be the provision of houses for disabled ex-servicemen. Such a scheme had been suggested at the end of the First World War, but the amount of money raised was not enough and the Memorial in the Upper Pleasure Gardens was built instead.

In 1944 the idea was brought forward again and the sum of £50,000 to build specially designed homes for disabled ex-members of the Forces, with a central block to serve as a Community Hall, was targeted. The site, approximately six acres on the North side Of Castle Lane on the Longbarrow Estate, was given by the well known Bournemouth landowners, the Misses Ellen Anne and Alice Elizabeth Cooper-Dean and their nieces, Alice Ellen and Edith Bethia. £80,000 was raised initially, the final sum being £100,000. This was to pay for the houses and flats. The cost of the Memorial Hall, which opened On 16th May 1953, was the gift of the Queen Services Club, However, because of the lack of use the Hall was converted in 1959 into two flats.

On Monday 28th October Lord and Lady Louis Mountbatten visited the town for the ceremony of laying the foundation stone. The inscription on it reads: "This stone was laid by Admiral the Viscount Mountbatten of Burma GCVO KCB DSO ADC LLD DCL on October 28th 1946. The land for these War Memorial Homes was the generous gift of the Misses Cooper-Dean. Robert H. Old, Mayor". The first of the forty six self-contained homes was occupied in 1948, and the whole project was completed in 1949. Now there are sixteen houses, three maisonettes, three chalet bungalows, ten bungalows and two flats; fifty one homes in all.

The Borough Council decided to fix a plaque commemorating the fallen to the town's War Memorial in the Upper Pleasure Gardens. It also arranged to compile a list of all those killed during the war and to have a Book of Remembrance similar to that of the First World War. At the end of the year the Town Clerk advertised in the local papers for the names of Bournemouthians, men and women, who had died whilst serving their country. The Book can now be seen, together with that for the 1914-18 War, in the glass case in the Hall of Remembrance at the Town Hall. There is a copy on the shelf below so that members of the public can consult it.

The Roll of Honour of the civilian dead, one hundred and sixty eight local air raid victims, was handed by the Duke of Gloucester to the Dean and Chapter of Westminster for custody in the Abbey in 1956.

Several years after the war ended a new housing estate was developed at Kinson where roads were named after Bournemouthians who had been killed, and also wartime leaders. Here, too, can be found "Pilot Hight Road" commemorating the New Zealand pilot shot down over Bournemouth in 1940.

On the 5th April the Mayor received from the Bournemouth War Services Organisation a panel made of oak bearing the Borough Coat of Arms with the following inscription:

> "This panel places on record the work of the BWSO carried out by thousands of voluntary helpers. Service was rendered to millions of the Allied Forces through the comforts depot, Services club, hospitality scheme and entertainments section and to the thousands of civilians through the children's welfare and aid and advice sections".

The panel is on display at the Town Hall in the Hall of Remembrance.

The BWSO's Club at the Theatre Royal closed with a party on 31st January. It had been a haven for Servicemen and women since it opened. Twelve thousand meals were prepared every week and countless cups of tea and coffee sold from the canteen staffed by the WVS. Attendance had dropped off since November 1945 with demobilisation and the removal of troops and airmen. The Queen at the Lansdowne closed at the end of April. There since December 1940 over four million members of the Forces made use of its facilities. It had been staffed by hundreds of volunteers from fifty local churches.

The Richmond Hill Congregational Church Forces Club also closed. A favourite place for the RCAF who used the Church for their services and who presented an illuminated address expressing their gratitude for the generosity and hospitality extended to them by the members of the Church.

The WVS had expanded rapidly to cope with the demands made on it. In March 1940 its membership was six hundred and thirty, and four thousand three hundred when the war ended. The Services Club in Albert Road was staffed by its members. They had the responsibility for the feeding of the evacuated troops from Dunkirk at the schools used as temporary billets. Two thousand members were trained in first aid and in 1940 the Housewives Section was started. As well as looking after bombed out people they also manned in the daytime the telephones in the Wardens Posts.

The biggest part was their work in the canteens. Their responsibility covered the Civil Defence canteens, two being open twenty four hours a day. They fed the Rescue Services, first aid parties, Royal Observer Corps and munitions workers as well as staffing two mobile canteen units. These mobile units were sent to Portsmouth, Plymouth and Southampton to help in the Blitz. The WVS also ran stores and depots to provide clothing for the bombed out. Their mending service was greatly appreciated by the men and women of the Services.

A boon to mothers with growing children and few clothing coupons was the shop on Poole Hill, set up by the WVS, at which they could exchange children's clothing in good condition. Bazaars and dances to raise money and boost morale were organised too, as well as knitting comforts for the Forces.

The Girl Guides had been busy all through the war. Their activities included sending twenty one thousand three hundred Christmas parcels to local members of the Forces, acting as interpreters with the foreign troops after Dunkirk, working at service canteens at the railway stations and with the mobile YMCA canteen, and helping with the evacuees. The thirty six local Guide Companies collected waste paper, horse chestnuts, nettles, silver paper, acorns and rose hips, all needed to produce materials or medicines for the war effort.

The Carlton became a US Army Post in January when it was taken over from the US Red Cross to house "GI Brides" and their children before travelling to America. The first ones, two hundred and thirteen wives and two hundred and twenty four children, arrived on the 27th, staying a few days before leaving at the beginning of February on the Queen Mary from Southampton. Lavish

American food and special entertainments were provided and outside the Hotel "Old Glory", the US flag, flew. Requisitioned in 1940 the Carlton was used first by the Board of Trade staff from London, then by the Army, followed by the Air Force and finally by the Americans. It reopened with a dinner on 29th November, the Royal Bath having preceded it by three months on 4th September.

Many buildings were now being de-requisitioned. One hundred and fifty hotels had been handed back to their owners by Easter. Many were in bad condition however. One owner found that the rooms in his hotel used to train night fighter pilots had had the ceilings and the wails painted black with tar. The RCAF vacated Bath Hill Court on March 2nd and Durley Chine Court, flats used by the US Army and the Air Ministry as local Headquarters, followed almost immediately. The Winter Gardens was handed back on March lst. At the outbreak of war it had been taken over by the Board of Trade as a store for the furniture removed from the hotels requisitioned by the War Office and other Government Departments. Then it was transformed into the mess hall for the RAF and later in 1941 the RCAF, with field kitchens in the grounds. The stored furniture was moved to several large empty houses in Marlborough and Portarlington Roads.

The Winter Gardens was found to be in a sorry state on release, requiring a great deal of work to restore it to its prewar condition. Other properties released were Glen Fern Car Park, which had been used as a fuel dump, the car park at the east end of Exeter Road and the East Beach Cafe.

Priory Mansions in Bath Road was used by the Trustee Department of the Westminster Bank (now the National Westminster) as offices. The staff returned to London in June 1946. Avon Court, also in Bath Road, housed the Trustee Department of Lloyds Bank. The Hahnemann Convalescent Home and Dispensary was released by the military and reopened in early December.

Some hotels were still being used as Army Records Offices. Dunholme Manor, Coolhurst, Toft House, all on the East Cliff, were amongst them. The Cumberland was the wartime home of the Royal Army Pay Corps with the ATS working there billeted at the Picardy Hotel, Meyrick Road.

Early in the year the repatriation of the RCAF started, and No 3 Personnel Reception Centre ceased as an RCAF establishment on 21st February. All the forty three hotels they occupied were vacated by lst March, with the exception of Compton House and the Grand Hotel. A letter from the Commanding Officer, Group Captain H.G. Richards, to the Echo on 25th February expressed the thanks of all the airmen who came to Bournemouth for the hospitality shown to them by the people of the town. "Despite the stringent rationing and other periods of trial you gave us a home from home", he wrote. He also thanked the Mayor and Corporation "for their gracious co-operation and assistance in providing so many amenities for Canadian airmen". Group Captain Richards also thanked the voluntary organisations which catered for the social needs of the men.

As many as twelve thousand Canadians were billeted in Bournemouth at any one time, except for a few weeks in 1944. Then they were evacuated to Imswoth in Gloucestershire because of the invasion build-up of troops. Over one hundred thousand airmen passed through the Centre since it had opened on July 5th 1941, many of them flying with famous Squadrons and many being decorated for bravery. Several Canadians married local girls and settled in Bournemouth, cementing even more "the close bonds of friendship formed between our two countries", as Group Captain Richards put it. The Canadians had become part of the town.

There were no celebrations in the town on the official Victory Day, June 8th, but the pre-service organisations, Army Cadets, ATC, etc. held a "Thanksgiving for Victory" Drumhead Service in Meyrick Park.

The 7th Battalion the Hampshire Regiment stood down on 30th June. Their Colours, the Kings Colour and the Regimental Colour, were laid up for the second time in St. Peter's Church on Saturday, 20th July. The Colours were first laid up there in December 1921 when the 7th Battalion was amalgamated with the 5th Battalion (Southampton). In May 1939 the 7th Battalion was reformed, however its Colours remained in St. Peter's until they were required for the ceremonies of conferring the freedom of various Hampshire towns on the Regiment at the end of the war. The Colours were carried in the Victory Parade held in Berlin, and they arrived back in England early on the 20th July. They were paraded through Bournemouth, the parade being led by Fritz, the mascot of the lst

Battalion.

Bournemouth's long coastline had deteriorated, it was claimed, more than any other resort, but by the end of the year a great deal of work had been done to tidy the area around Bournemouth Pier. Shelters, static water tanks, pill boxes and other defence measures had disappeared, whilst in the town lamp posts and trolley standards had received a new coat of paint. Along the Undercliff the cliffs had been stabilised, trees and shrubs planted and cliff railings and seats replaced. East of Boscombe Pier the promenade still looked neglected. The Pier itself was derelict and at Hengistbury Head there was the empty RAF Station, the Army Camp and the disused defence posts.

Along the seafront beach huts which had been removed by the military, the NFS and the Civil Defence were being returned to their former sites. Owners who had transferred their huts to the safety of their back gardens were also replacing them.

Even though great care had been taken to find and dig up the mine fields along the beach one mine had not been detected. On Saturday, 7th September, it exploded smashing windows in the Southbourne Hotel and causing a large cliff fall. The mine had been revealed by rough seas which scoured away the sand around it, but before it could be made safe it was buried again. A Naval Bomb Disposal Squad searched but were not able to find it before it exploded. Luckily there were no casualties.

The first pile in the construction of a 12 foot wide gangway to provide access for steamer passengers across the gap in Bournemouth Pier was driven on Thursday, 30th May. The gangway stretched from the entrance, parallel with the Pier, to the "island" , the head of the Pier. By August 17th this temporary structure was in place. Then on Monday 19th the Red Funnel Steamer "Princess Elizabeth" tied up at the landing stage on the east side at 1 pm. At 2 o'clock she sailed on the first post war pleasure steamer trip to Swanage carrying six hundred passengers, including the Mayor, Cllr. R.H. Old, who had welcomed her to Bournemouth again.

On Monday 2nd September the "Monarch" and "Embassy" started regular sailings to Swanage from Bournemouth Pier. A Skylark service to Swanage was also run, the larger boats operating from the Pier, whilst the smaller ones operated from a temporary stage east of the Pier. Earlier in the year, on Easter Sunday, 21st April, Skylark 6 sank in the Bay off Alum Chine. All the passengers were saved, but one member of the crew drowned. A verdict of accidental death was recorded at the inquest.

The work of reconstructing Bournemouth Pier started at the end of August and by 29th April 1947 the gap had been bridged. The Pier was opened early in the November, but it was not until April 1950 that the work of reconstructing the buildings on the Pier head commenced. The reconstruction of Boscombe Pier started in 1958, with completion in 1960.

In parts of the town blackout conditions were temporarily imposed again during the middle of the year, The Ministry Of Fuel requested that "superfluous lighting" should be extinguished for ten weeks in the Summer to save fuel, so that people living in side roads, especially those with trees along the pavement, found themselves carrying torches once more.

In August the first Regatta since the war was held with fireworks and illuminations in the pleasure gardens. County cricket resumed at Dean Park, which had been released by the Forces who had used it as their sports ground.

The Art Gallery started to collect the pictures which had been removed for safety at the beginning of the war from the manor houses, rectories and churches to which they had been taken.

On the transport side the last buses from the Square reverted to the prewar time of 11.30 pm from Monday May 6th. Cinemas and theatres were then able to go back to their former finishing time of 10.30 pm. The "Bournemouth Belle", the Pullman train, made its first post war trip from Waterloo on October 7th. Met by the Mayor, Cllr. R.H. Old, it carried a party of journalists who were then given a motor coach tour of the town before returning on the "Belle" to London in the evening.

A De Havilland Dove aircraft on a flight from Hurn crashed on Wednesday, 14th August, in a cornfield near the corner of Ringwood Road and Poole Lane at West Howe. One passenger was killed whilst the pilot and two other passengers were injured. One of those hurt died later in hospital.

The demand for houses, especially from demobilised servicemen, grew during the year and

to cope with it the first of two hundred and seventy six aluminium prefabricated bungalows was erected in Craigmoor Avenue in May. The first squatters took over the unused Gospel Hall in Wimborne Road near Redhill. Several families found homes in the former Guardroom at the end of the Broadway at Hengistbury Head and adjacent Nissen huts, plus other sites such as the huts used by the searchlight crews at Throop.

In August the glaziers were hard at work on Westbourne Arcade. The landmines in R.L. Stevenson Avenue had destroyed almost all the panes in the glass roof. From then the Arcade had been practically roofless as the replacement of the glass had not been given a very high priority.

The basement of the bombed Beales building, which had been destroyed in the May 23rd 1943 air raid, was refurbished and opened as a sales floor on November 19th. To reach it customers descended a flight of stairs from Old Christchurch Road. There were also two temporary buildings at street level which also served as showrooms. However, it was not until November 1952 that the first section of the new sales store was opened, the whole building taking several more years to complete.

Woolworths in the Square reopened in a small prefabricated building on the cleared site in 1947. Rebuilt as a modern two storey shop, now occupied by Boots, it was opened on 28th April 1955.

The Metropole Hotel, demolished after being partially destroyed in the May 23rd 1943 raid, was replaced by Royal London House, containing offices, a bank and shops. It was opened by the Mayor on 16th January 1958.

The Punshon Memorial site, and that of the Central Hotel, was redeveloped in the 1950's. A stone let into the side of the building fronting Post Office Road states that:

> "This building was erected in 1958 on the site of the Punshon Memorial Church & Central Hotel destroyed by enemy action May 1943"

In the New Year Honours List the inventor of the Bailey Bridge, Donald Bailey, who then lived at the "Cobbles", St. Catherine's Road, was knighted. The Bailey Bridge was designed at the Experimental Bridging Establishment, Barrack Road, Christchurch, now the Defence Research Agency. Described as one of the most important inventions of the war the Bailey Bridge, made of lightweight steel panels with wooden decking, enabled the troops to cross rivers easily, quickly and safely. Sir Donald, who had been awarded the OBE in June 1943 died in May 1985, aged eighty three. As a tribute to him a section of Bailey bridging has been erected on Christchurch Quay.

Alderman H.A. Benwell was awarded the BEM for distinguished service as a member of the NFS. He took parties of local firemen to London during the 1940 Blitz, enabling London firemen to come to Bournemouth for a much needed rest. Then after D-Day he went to Southampton to take charge of the pumps placed at the Docks to protect the ships loading and unloading.

The Secretary of J. Caslake Ltd., Metalworkers and Engineers, Malmesbury Park Road, Joseph Caslake, was awarded the MBE "for work in connection with the design and development of tank training turrets for the Royal Armoured Corps". At Caslake's one hundred workers manufactured munitions of various types. The training turrets reproduced the movement of the tank in motion so that the trainee gunners would gain experience. There were several models for different size guns, two pounders of which two hundred and thirty six were made; six pounders, fifty made; and Sherman 75, thirty constructed. Also many other articles made of metal for landing craft, destroyers and lorries were produced.

The Bournemouth National Savings Committee reported in January 1946 that £34,616,044 was subscribed from lst October 1939 to 31st December 1945. This meant that the population of the town, 126,480 at September 1945, saved £273.68p per head. Mr. Sidney Bell also received the MBE for his work as Chairman of the local National Savings Committee.

Later on in the year conductress Nelly Shelley, who had been one of the first women conductors, was awarded the BEM "for the efficient manner in which she had carried out her duties in the Transport Undertaking during the War". The Transport Committee 19th July 1946, felt that the "award reflected great credit on the employees of the Undertakings".

A local Officer, Captain Kenneth R. Thresher, Royal Artillery, was honoured with the award of two Belgian decorations, the Chevalier of the Order of Leopold II with Palm and the Croix de Guerre 1940 with Palm.

There was one murder in the town during the year, but another, just over the Borough Boundary in Poole, caused banner headlines in the newspapers and the subsequent trial proceedings to be published as a volume in the Notable British Trials series.

The Bournemouth murder occurred in the April when at 10.50 pm on Sunday 28th April, Mrs. Olive Maud Harman was discovered on the pavement outside 23 Southern Road, Southbournc, with a wound in her left temple. She had been staying in Southern Road with her four year old son. Although rushed to Boscombe Hospital she died early on Monday 29th April.

Her husband, Mr. Charles William Harman, was found by the police on Monday morning in a shelter on the cliff top at the end of Southwood Avenue. He too had a head wound and on the ground by his side was a humane killer used to slaughter animals, He died in hospital later the same day. The verdict at the inquest was that he had killed his wife and then committed suicide.

The second murder victim was found in Branksome Dene Chine on July 8th. The body was that of Miss Doreen Marshall who had been discharged from the WRNS and was holidaying at Bournemouth staying at the Norfolk Hotel (now the Norfolk Royale). She met Neville Heath who was living at the Tollard Royal Hotel, West Cliff (now flats) under the name of Rupert Brooke. Heath was wanted in London for the murder of Margery Gardner in June. Arrested in Bournemouth he was also charged with the murder of Miss Marshall. Heath was found guilty of the first murder and sentenced to death. His execution was carried out at Pentonville Prison on October 16th.

At the end of 1946 the town was slowly coming out of the gloom of the years. It had been a bumper year for visitors who had arrived in large numbers in the Spring as well as the Summer. Over Christmas the town was well patronised. Even though rationing was still in force there was more food available. Toys for the children were plentiful as were presents for the whole family.

Although the bomb sites were not being redeveloped nor the piers rebuilt the town was being cleaned up and the feeling was one of optimism. People were at last anticipating a more prosperous future after the deprivations of the six years of war. With such a promising start to the postwar era Bournemouth looked forward to a thriving and successful future.

County Borough of Bournemouth
Military Defence Measures

Schedule of Defence Works carried out by or for the Military on lands belonging to the Corporation on the Foreshore between Alum Chine and Hengistbury Head.

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
Alum Chine Promenade			
1. Cripple Childrens Hut.		Removed	Military
2. West Extremity Prom.	Pill box with sand bag protection & sand bag parados	Surface destroyed & filling removed	do
3. West Promenade	Tubular trellis defence	Holes cut through surface of Promenade & sea wall	do
4. Stone Concrete shelter	Converted to Pill Box large concrete gun post erected on top of shelter	3 arches bricked up & brick wall built round steps to same height as shelter	do
5. Alum Chine	66 concrete pillars	Road surface & foundations damaged	do
6. Cafe & privately owned huts	-	Removed	do
7. Alumhurst Road, Chine end	Road block	Holes in carriageway & footpath	do
8. Alum Chine Convenience	-	Closed to public	-
9. Telephone Kiosk	Sandbagged protection	-	do
10. Corporation Cafe	-	Demolished	Corporation
11. Stone retaining wall to Zig Zag path	3 concrete pillars	Approx 30 yards of stone wall to Zig Zag path damaged. Footpath surface damaged, railings of concrete posts & rail fencing removed.	Military
12. Alum Chine Zig Zag	Sand bagged trench	Excavation of cliff side garden	Military
13. do	Concrete pill box & trench at rear of pill box	do	do
14. Alum steps to Overcliff Drive	Concrete pill box & trench	Damage to cliff approx half way up	do
15. Alum Chine Zig Zag garden & terrace	Sand bagged trench	Holes made in stone wall	do
16. do	Barbed wire & picket holes	Holes through Zig Zag paths to top of cliffs & damage to steps, gardens & terraces	do
17. On Promenade half way between Alum Chine & Middle Chine	Tubular trellis	Holes made through surface of Promenade & sea wall approx 70 holes	-
18. Entrance to Chine	36 Concrete Pillars	Path, surface & foundations damaged	Military
19. East & West Terrace	Brick traps for trap shooting	Brick huts	do
20. Bastion (Middle Chine)	Pill box	Surface destroyed, filling removed & railings removed	do
21. 100 yds, west of Durley Chine	Tubular trellis	Holes cut through surface of Promenade to sea wall & into cliffs	

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
Durley Chine			
22. West of Durley Chine	Sandbag Trench	Damage to cliffs	Military
23. Promenade	12 concrete pillars	Surface & foundations damaged	do
24. Road in Durley Chine	32 concrete pillars	Surface & foundations damaged	do
25. Road in Durley Chine	Road mined	Damage to carriageway	do
26. Cafe	-	Demolished	Corporation
27. Bathing cubicles	-	do	do
28. Durley Terrace	Brick traps for trap shooting	Brick huts	Military
29. Stone Wall	-	Portion demolished	do
30. Terrace	Concrete pill box	Excavation	do
31. At top of Durley steps to Overcliff	do	Damage to cliffs	do
32. Terrace	7 concrete pillars	Surface & foundations damaged	do
33. Steps in Durley Chine	1 concrete pillar	Steps damaged	do
Little Durley Chine			
34. St Johns Ambulance Shelter	-	Used as Armoury by trap shooting	Military
35. Convenience	-	Ladies section closed Mens opened to troops	-
36. Public bathing shelter & hut	-	Taken over by RAF	-
37. Across Promenade half way between Durley Chine & Joseph steps	Tubular trellis	Holes cut through surface of Promenade & sea wall	do
38. Joseph shelter	-	12 Bungalows demolished from roof of shelter	Corporation
39. Cliff west of shelter	-	Cliff trimmed back	Military
40. Joseph Zig Zag bastion	-	Railings destroyed	-
41. Joseph Zig Zag bastion	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed	do
42. Joseph Zig Zag	do	Excavation & barbed wire through Zig Zag	do
43. Top of Zig Zag	do	Damage to cliffs	do
44. Double bastion shelter west of lift	-	Removed	Corporation
45. West Cliff Lift	-	Dismantling lift	Corporation (see letter dated 13/8/40) from Commander 11th Infantry Brig.
46. West cliff lift toll house on top of cliffs	-	Taken over by military	-
47. Bathing station	-	Railings & copings removed from roof. No 4 holes cut through walls of stores on roof east & west of main entrance & 2 doors cut through stone walls	Requisition recd from O.C. 225 Field Co. R.E. 8/8/40
48. Across Promenade at west end of Convenience	Tubular trellis	Holes cut through surface of Promenade & sea wall	Military
49. West Beach Cafe	-	Used by Colonial Air Force for Pay Office twice weekly	-
50. West Beach Cloister	Pill box	2 bays bricked up	Military

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
51. Top of Cloister shelter	Sandbagged machine gun post & trench in cliff	-	do
52. Bastion opp. West Beach Cloister shelter	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed	do
53. West Promenade adj. to pier approach	30 concrete pillars 24 socket holes	Surface & foundation of road damaged	do
Pier Approach			
54. Pier approach carriage-way	96 concrete pillars 20 socket holes	Surface & foundation of road damaged	do
55. West shelter (Taxi drivers mess room)	Gun post	Interior alterations	do
56. Bournemouth Pier	-	Demolition of all structures above deck level & remove decking of Pier & Landing stages & gap of 120' made in neck of Pier	Corporation Military
57. Entrance to Undercliff Drive & East Cliff	57 Concrete pillars 29 Socket holes	Surface & foundation of road & footpath damaged	do
58. East Cliff Promenade	Concrete Pill Box	Surface & foundation of road damaged	do
Undercliff Drive			
59. East Beach Cafe	Sand bag post on roof	-	Requisition No 1623
60. 50ft East of Beach Office	Tubular trellis	Holes through surface of Promenade & sea wall	Military
61. Bastion by beach office	Concrete pill box	Shelter removed surface destroyed	do
62. Bastion shelter West of Zig Zag	-	Shelter removed	Corporation
63. East Cliff Zig Zag	2 concrete pillars 1 concrete pill box 1 trench top of Zig Zag	Damage to footpath cliffs and gardens	Military
64. East Cliff Lift	-	Dismantling lift	Corporation (see letter dated 13/8/40) from Commander 11th Infantry Brigade
65. East Cliff Lift Cafe	-	-	Top floor requisitioned by Military Relinquished possession 18/3/41
66. Roof of East Cliff Lift Cafe	Sand bag parados	-	Military
67. Bathing office & tents	-	Removed	Corporation
68. Bastion East of Lift	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed. Shelter removed Railings removed	Military
69. Bastion shelters opp. No 1 Bay	-	4 shelters removed	Corporation
70. Bastion turning circle	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed. Shelter removed Railings removed	Military
71. Bastion shelter west of Toft Steps	-	Shelter removed	Corporation
72. Bastion opp. steps	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed. Shelter removed Railings removed	Military
73. Foot of Toft Steps	1 concrete pillar	Landing of steps destroyed	do
74. Shelter East of Toft Steps	-	Bricked up & taken over by Military	Military requisition LAP claim 1968

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
75. On cliffs at Toft Steps	1 concrete pill box various trenches	Damage to cliffs	Military
76. 100 yds east of Toft Steps on top cliffs	1 concrete pill box	Damage to surface of cliffs	-
77. Toft Steps plateau	Concrete construction one large gun post	Bungalows demolished & used as camouflage & 4 bungalows in Military occupation	Military
78. Toft Steps plateau	No. 2 concrete base for search lights	-	do
79. Boscombe West Hut Terrace	Various trenches in cliffs	Damage to cliffs	do
80. 200 yds west of Boscombe Pier	Tubular trellis	Holes through surface of promenade & sea wall	do
81. Boscombe Convenience adj Cloister shelter	Pill box built inside	Bricked up entrance & pill box constructed inside convenience. Urinal stalls destroyed, 1 W.C. removed	do
82. Shelter west of Boscombe Pier	Pill-box	4 arches built up	do
83. Chair platform west of Boscombe Pier	-	Removed	Corporation
84. Cliffs above Rotunda	Various trenches	Damage to cliffs	Military
85. Boscombe Pier	-	Demolition of all structures above deck level & remove decking of Pier & Landing stages & gap of 120' made in neck of pier.	Corporation Military
86. Boscombe Pier entrance	-	-	No. 2 Toll Boxes taken over by Military
87. do	-	Concrete surface broken up & left	Military
88. Boscombe Pier Approach	57 concrete pillars 30 socket holes	Surface & foundation of road damaged	do
89. Putting Green west of Sea Road	Concrete pill box & trenches	Damage to putting green	Military
90. Convenience west side of Sea Road	Barbed wire	Closed	do
Overstrand etc			
91. Car park	-	-	Taken over by Military as training ground
92. South west corner of St Georges School grounds	Concrete pill box & trench	Damage to cliff edge of garden	Military
93. St Georges School	-	-	In Military occupation on visiting 11/12/41
94. St Georges School Garden	Numerous trenches	Grass lawn destroyed	Garden used by Military for training ground
Boscombe Promenade			
95. 150 yds East of Pier	Tubular trellis	Holes cut through Promenade and sea wall	Military
96. Honeycomb Chine	Rifle Range	Damage to cliffs	do
97. Honeycomb Chine East	do	do	RAF
98. 2 bastion shelters near Honeycomb Chine	-	2 shelters removed	Corporation
99. Promenade at Manor Bay	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in promenade & sea wall	Military

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
100. Bathing office & tents	-	Removed	Corporation
101. Manor Bay Zig Zag (1st bend)	Concrete pill box & sand bag pill box	Damage to surface of cliffs	Military
102. Zig Zag path	4 concrete pillars	Damage to footpath	do
103. Return in Promenade East of Manor Bay	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed, filling removed, railings removed	do
104. do at foot of cliff	do Trench above on cliffs	Damage to cliff	-
105. Promenade at bottom of Portman Ravine	-	Rails removed from bastion	do
106. Portman Ravine	3 concrete pillars	Surface of footpath destroyed	do
107. do	No 3 sand bagged strong points	Damage to surface of cliffs	
108. Portman Ravine east end of terrace	Various trenches 1 concrete pill box	Railings of terrace removed	do
109. Portman Ravine east end	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in surface of Promenade & sea wall	do
110. do	No 2 sand bagged strong points	Damage to surface of cliffs	do
<u>Fishermans Walk Promenade</u>			
111. West of Fishermans Walk Cafe	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in surface of Promenade & sea wall	do
112. Fishermans Walk Promenade Cafe	East end converted into Pill Box	-	LAP P50/1330
113. Fishermans Walk Promenade near Lift	Concrete pill box	Surface destroyed, filling removed	Military
114. Southbourne Cliff Lift	-	Dismantling lift	Corporation (see letter 13.8.40 from Commander 11th Infantry Brigade)
115. Southbourne Cliff Lift Toll House (top of cliff)	Strong point	Sand bagged interior	Military
116. Fishermans Walk Zig Zag	2 concrete pillars	Damage to surface of foot-path	do
117. First bend of Zig Zag	1 concrete pill box	Surface destroyed & filling removed. Timber shelter part destroyed.	do
118. Fishermans Walk Zig Zag	Various trenches on cliffs	Damage to cliffs	do
119. do (top of cliff)	Concrete gun emplacement top of cliffs	do	do
<u>Southbourne Promenade</u>			
120. Fishermans Walk Kiosk	Vision	Removed	Corporation
121. 30 yards east of Fishermans Walk Zig Zag	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in surface of Promenade & sea wall	Military
122. Southbourne Promenade Convenience	-	Closed	-
123. 20 yards west of Southbourne Zig Zag (Gordon Steps)	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in surface of Promenade & sea wall	do
124. do	4 concrete pillars	Damage to footpath	do
125. do	Concrete pill box	Damage to cliffs. Cliffs cut back for vision & wall rebuilt	do

SITE	Type of Defence	Nature of Damage	By whom works carried out
126. 30 yards east of Southbourne Zig Zag	Tubular trellis	Holes cut in surface of promenade & sea wall	Military
127. Eastern end of Promenade on Terrace	1 concrete pill box	Damage to surface of terrace	do
128. Ellen Steps Southbourne	-	Demolished	do
Hengistbury Head			
129. Broadway	Concrete blocks Socket holes & covers	Surface & foundation of roadway damaged	do
130. Hengistbury Head	Tank trap trench Concrete pillars	Farmlands (damaged crops) Excavation	do
132. Hengistbury Head	14 concrete pill boxes	do	Military
133. Hengistbury Head Works Depot (Cannon Street Station)	-	Old office, Mess hut, Cement store etc	Requisition by Military
134. Groyne (concrete)	-	Iron rails grouted into groyne	
General			
135. Promenade & Undercliff Drive from Alum Chine to Southbourne	Barbed wire entanglements	Picket holes damaging footpaths & asphalt carriageway	Military
136. Cliffs & Chines	Barbed wire entanglements	Damage to cliffs	Military

List of Shelters as at 23rd February 1942

The Borough Engineer presented a complete list of public air raid shelters giving the site, type, accommodation, classification and bunk accommodation, to date, as follows:—

Serial No.	Brief description of site	Type	Accom.	Classification	Bunks provided for
3	Boscombe Library	B	118		30 persons
7a	Yelverton Road	B	200		36 "
7b	Yelverton Road	B	200		36 "
8a	Ivy Glen, Avenue Road	B	118		
8b	Ivy Glen, Avenue Road	B	115		
15a	Maple's Basement	B	107		
15b	Maple's Basement	B	75		
16	Pokesdown Tram Depot	G.F.	163	Dormitory & Canteen	33 "
19	Hartwell's Garage	G.F.	174	Dormitory & Canteen	84 "
21	Andrews' Garage	B	200		45 "
22a	521-523 Christchurch Road	B	180	Dormitory	36 "
22b	523-525 Christchurch Road	B	200	Dormitory & Canteen	30 "
23	Plaza Cinema, Winton	B	125		18 "
24a	Coach Station, Exeter Road	G.F.	146		24 "
24b	Coach Station, Exeter Road	G.F.	148		24 "
25a	Richmond Garage	G.F.	200	Dormitory	24 "
25b	Richmond Garage	G.F.	200	Dormitory & Canteen	9 "
26a	Odeon Cinema, Lansdowne	G.F.	123	Dormitory	24 "
26b	Odeon Cinema, Lansdowne	G.F.	115	Dormitory	27 "
27	Tice's Garage, Moordown	G.F.	200	Dormitory & Canteen	36 "
28c	Majestic Gar., Westover Road	G.F.	200		50 "
29	Co-op Stores, Winton	B	155	Dormitory & Canteen	30 "
30	Five Ways Hotel, Charminster	B	50		9 "
31a	Grand Parade, Westbourne	B	200		30 "
31b	Grand Parade, Westbourne	B	45		
31c	Grand Parade, Westbourne	B	102		12 "
32	Springbourne Libr, Holdenhurst Rd	B	35		9 "
33a	Meakers, 562 Christchurch Road	B	200	Dormitory & Canteen	36 "
33b	Meakers, 562 Christchurch Road	B	134	Dormitory	12 "
34	Conservative Club, Holdenhurst Rd	G.F.	78		27 "
35	Dolphin Hotel, Holdenhurst Road	G.F.	55		12 "
36	127 Seabourne Road, Pokesdn	G.F.	115		18 "
37	144 Seabourne Road, Pokesdn	B	65		12 "
38	21-23 Charminster Road	B	167		24 "
40	190-2-4 Seabourne Rd, Pokesdn	B	154		33 "
41	114 Old Christchurch Road	B	70		12 "
42	107-9 Old Christchurch Road	B	180		12 "
43	8 Queens Rd & West End Cafe	B	169	Dormitory	27 "
44	Doland's Garage, Poole Hill	B	112		12 "
45	Grand Hotel Garage, Glen Fern Gdns	B	150	Dormitory	30 "
46	Talbot Hotel Garage, Winton	G.F.	93		
47	1115 Christchurch Road, Iford	B	84	Dormitory	12 "
48	Kings Park Pavilion	B	154	Dormitory & Canteen	21 "
49	Iford House, Bridle Crescent	B	168		21 "
50	Liberal Club, Wimborne Rd, Kinson	G.F.	107	Dormitory	
51	Kennedy's, Holdenhurst Rd	B	170	Dormitory & Canteen	42 "
52	W & L Garages, High Rd, Wallisdown	B	69		15 "
53	Shops, Columbia Road	G.F.	160	Dormitory & Canteen	27 "
54	775-783 Christchurch Road	B	191		27 "
55	Southbourne Cliffs Hotel	B	123	Dormitory	21 "
56	Willis' Showrooms, 965 Wimborne Rd	G.F.	55		
57	912 Wimborne Road	B	67		15 "

Serial No.	Brief description of site	Type	Accom.	Classification	Bunks provided for
58	Strouden Park Hotel, Castle Lane	B	47		18 persons
59	Wilkins' Bakery, Holdenhurst Rd	G.F.	200	Dormitory & Canteen	42 "
60	Westbourne Court, Westbourne	B	172	Dormitory	36 "
61	21 Queens Road	B	200		
62	16-18 Ashley Road	B	104		18 "
63	Carlton Cinema, Boscombe	G.F.	77		15 "
64	73-79 Southbourne Grove	B	129		21 "
65	Iford Lane, Tuckton	S	109	Dormitory	
66	3 Wonderholme Parade, Kinson Road	G.F.	43		12 "
67	1-3 Crimea Road, Winton	B	173	Dormitory & Canteen	33 "
68	280-288 Charminster Road	B	200	Dormitory & Canteen	36 "
69	130-132 Holdenhurst Road	B	171		27 "
70	Tarrants, 85-93 Commercial Rd	B	200	Dormitory & Canteen	57 "
71	226 Old Christchurch Road	G.F.	63		12 "
72	266 Old Christchurch Road	G.F.	89		12 "
73	Cemetery Junction	S	200		
74	Winton Recreation Ground	S	150		
75	Clarence Park Road, Kings Park	S	150		
83	Regent Cinema Passage, Westover Rd	S	181	Dormitory & Canteen	75 "
	Shelters in Children's Playgrounds not scheduled for public use				
76	Malvern Road, Moordown	S	58		
77	Carbery Allotments	S	45		
78	Redhill Park	S	45		
79	Kinson Road, East Howe	S	58		

B - Basement Shelter G.F.- Ground Floor Shelter S - Surface Shelter

List of Rest Centres as at 6th April 1942

County Borough of Bournemouth

Assistance of Air Raid Victims
Rest Centres

1. Rest Centres have been arranged at the undermentioned places:

Northern Area:

Kinson Council School, Kinson Road
East Howe Junior School, Kinson Road
East Howe Infants School, Hadow Road
St Walburga's R.C. School, Malvern Road
Winton and Moordown Council School, Coronation Avenue
St Alban's Church House, Charminster Road
Charminster Senior School, East Way
Bournemouth School (Boys), East Way

Western Area:

Methodist Church Hall, Landseer Road
St Michaels Church House, Poole Road

Central Area:

Stokewood Road Baths
Lowther Road School
Portchester Road School
Malmesbury Park Junior & Infants School, Shelbourne Road
Girls Own Club, Wootton Mount
East Cliff Congregational Church Hall, nr Central Station, Holdenhurst Rd
St Pauls School, St Pauls Road

Eastern Area:

Herridge Memorial Hall, Curzon Road
Boscombe Senior School, Ashley Road
Boscombe Temperance Hall, Haviland Road
Boscombe Junior and Infants School, Gladstone Road
Pokesdown Council School, Livingstone Road
Stourfield Senior School, Cranleigh Road
Immanuel Church Hall, Southbourne Road
"Slavanka", Belle Vue Road

2. Auxiliary Rest Centres have been arranged at the undermentioned places:

Northern Area:

East Howe Congregational School Room, East Howe Lane, Kinson
Liberal Club, 71 Kinson Road, Wallisdown
Unity Hall, Columbia Road
Masonic Hall, Ferncroft Road, Kinson
Redhill Bowls Pavilion, Redhill Common
Moordown Congregational Hall, Malvern Road
Embassy Hall, Brassey Road
Winton Recreation Ground Bowls Pavilion, Fitzharris Avenue
Charminster Road Congregational Church Hall
Gymnasium, 516 Charminster Road
St Francis of Assisi Church Hall, Charminster Road
Kinson Conservative Club, 5 Grand Parade, Wimborne Road
Throop Schoolroom, Muscliffe Lane
Holdenhurst Parish Hall

Central Area:

St Lukes Parish Hall, St Lukes Road
St Augustines, Nortoft Road
Holy Trinity Church Hall, Lorne Park Road
Natural Science Society's Hall, 39 Christchurch Road

Eastern Area:

Swanmore Bowls Pavilion, Swanmore Road
St Saviour's Hall, Denmead Road
Woodlands Avenue Bowls Pavilion
All Saints Hall, Southbounre Road
Seafield Bowls Pavilion, Seafield Road
Wick Club, Tuckton Road

3. If you have been rendered homeless, and you are not able to go to friends or relatives or make other arrangements, you should go to the nearest Rest Centre or Auxiliary Rest Centre. The Air Raid Wardesn and Police will direct you if you are in doubt where to go.
4. Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres in any locality where an incident takes place will be opened. If the raid should be a heavy and sustained one all Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres will be opened.
5. At Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres you will be able to shelter and rest until other arrangements can be made.
6. At Rest Centres sleeping accommodation and food will be provided.
7. At Auxiliary Rest Centres hot drinks will be provided, but not sleeping accommodation or food.
8. **Clothing:** Supplies of emergency clothing will be available at Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres.
9. **48-hour billets:** Representatives of the Women's Voluntary Services will attend at the Rest Centres and Auxiliary Rest Centres which may be opened with lists of billets to which homelses persons may go for a short period (not exceeding 48 hours). Homeless persons who may be willing to go to such billets will be conducted or taken there by the Women's Voluntary Services representatives.
10. **Official Billetin:** Official billeting officers will attend at the Rest Centres which may be opened (but not at the Auxiliary Rest Centres) to billet homeless persons for whom such accommodation may be required. The payment of billeting allowances is intended to be a temporary measure operating only until the homeless persons are able either to return home, or to obtain accommodation of their own or to make their own financial arrangements with their hosts.

    Except in the cases of persons who are in receipt of an allowance from the Assistance Board or Supplementary Pension, Billeting Notices will in the first place be issued for a period not exceeding two weeks. The question whether a billeting notice should be re-issued after this period will be for the billeting authority to decide according to the circumstances.
11. **Information:** Information Officers will attend at the Rest Centres and Auxiliiary Rest Centres which may be opened to give information and advice.
12. **Travel Vouchers:** If you can make arrangements to go and stay with friends or relatives you will be given a free travel voucher if you cannot get to them without help. Enquire about this at the Rest Centre of Auxiliary Rest Centre to which you may go.

Have your plans ready. If you have not already done so, you should try to make plans now to go and stay with friends or relations in case your house is destroyed. They should also arrange to come to you if their house is destroyed. The usual billeting allowances will be payable in such cases.

A.R. Eaton
Town Clerk

Town Hall, Bournemouth
April 6, 1942

List of Air Raids on Bournemouth 1939 — 1944

Reprinted from "Bournemouth Times." Dec. 8, 1944

FIFTY AIR RAIDS ON BOURNEMOUTH

2,271 Bombs: 219 Deaths: 13,590 Buildings Destroyed or Damaged

The Official Narrative

BETWEEN July 3, 1940, and February 29 last (up to which date details of air raids may now be freely given) there were exactly 50 raids on Bournemouth. In all 2,271 bombs, including incendiaries, were dropped, representing a tonnage of 46.

Last week a detailed report of all these raids was circulated to members of Bournemouth Town Council and to the Press by the Civil Defence Controller, Coun. H. P. E. Mears, O.B.E. Other total figures are:—

CASUALTIES	
Killed	219
Injured and detained in hospital	182
Injured	325
	726
HOMELESS PERSONS dealt with at Rest Centres	401
DAMAGE TO PROPERTY	
Premises in Bournemouth totally destroyed	75
So badly damaged that demolition is necessary	171
Seriously damaged but capable of repair	675
Slightly damaged	9,413
Glass broken only	3,256
	13,590
RED WARNINGS	958

THE INCIDENTS SUMMARISED

1940.

No. 1. The first enemy air raid on Bournemouth occurred on the 3rd July, 1940 (0017 hrs.). One bomb was dropped. Fire totally destroyed one house in Cellars Farm-road and another damaged in the same road. No casualties. 19 properties damaged.

No. 2. 10th July, 1940 (06.30 hrs.). Five bombs dropped in Meon-road area; one civilian cyclist was killed, 38 premises damaged.

No. 3. 10th August, 1940 (23.15 hrs.). Eleven bombs dropped in Alyth-road and Huntley-road; one casualty; No. 47 Alyth-road was demolished; 2 houses badly damaged, several others slightly damaged; gas, water mains and telephone wires were also damaged. 36 premises damaged.

No. 4. 15th August, 1940 (17.46 hrs.). Plane brought down by enemy action in Walsford-road. No casualties or damage to property.

No. 5. 21st August, 1940 (10.50 hrs.). Madison and Walpole-roads. Machine gunning; some damage to house roofs. No casualties.

No. 6. 21st August, 1940 (16.59 hrs.). Seven bombs were dropped. One man killed, twelve civilians injured. Damage in Keswick-road, Cheesel-avenue and Beechwood-avenue. Grovely Manor sustained extensive damage. Total 110 properties were damaged.

No. 7. 25th August, 1940 (04.32 hrs.). Two bombs dropped in West Howe; 45 premises were damaged, also telephone wires. No casualties.

No. 8. 25th-26th August, 1940 (23.17 hrs.). Thirty bombs dropped in the Iford and Tuckton district; all fell in waste ground. No casualties, six properties damaged.

No. 9. 29th August, 1940 (01.30 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Wickles-road area; six craters found in open and one on pavement of Broadway. Fractured water main, no other damage. At Muckle-field Farm two bombs fell on swampy ground, no damage. One bomb fell in High Howe-lane. No casualties. 51 premises damaged.

No. 10. 2nd September, 1940 (21.55 hrs.). Seven bombs dropped in the West Southbourne and Pokesdown areas. 3 civilians killed and 5 injured. Premises in Seabourne-road, Southville-road and Christchurch-road damaged. 173 properties affected.

No. 11. 4th September, 1940 (05.40 hrs.). 2 bombs dropped near Surrey-road South; one person wounded; gas and water supply damaged; seven properties slightly damaged.

No. 12. 5th September, 1940 (00.15 hrs.). Five bombs dropped in Alum Chine district. Direct hits on Nos. 2 and 8 Burnaby road; damage to sewers; telephone wires down. No casualties. 19 properties damaged.

No. 13. 6th September, 1940 (00.43 hrs.). Five bombs dropped in Durley Chine district. No casualties or damage.

No. 14. 13th September, 1940 (01.20 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Hawkwood-road. No casualties, 24 properties damaged.

No. 15. 14th September, 1940 (17.50 hrs.). Two bombs dropped in Crabton Close-road and district. Four people killed, eleven injured. 143 premises were damaged.

No. 16. 22nd September, 1940 (00.58 hrs.). Bombs were dropped at Holdenhurst, Throop; one casualty, 24 properties damaged, including the Vicarage and Holdenhurst School.

No. 17. 25th September, 1940 12.09 hrs.). The north side of one house in Westminster-road demolished by fire. No casualties.

No. 18. 12th October, 1940 (05.50 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Bath-road, three houses damaged. No casualties.

No. 19. 14th October, 1940 (15.00 hrs.). Four bombs dropped in West Station district. Four persons injured; damage to 73 properties.

No. 20. 21st October, 1940 (16.39 hrs.). Ten bombs dropped in Queen's Park area. 5 persons seriously, and 5 slightly injured. Altogether 212 premises damaged.

No. 21. 9th November, 1940 (22.15 hrs.). 10 bombs dropped in Knyveton-road area, four persons killed, two seriously and two slightly injured. 109 premises damaged. Bombs were also dropped at junction of Gervis-road East and Meyrick-road.

No. 22. 10th November, 1940 (21.01 hrs.). Bombs dropped in the Southbourne and Grovely Manor areas causing slight damage to 10 properties. Many bombs fell in open ground. No casualties.

No. 23. 14th November, 1940 (23.36 hrs.). Twelve bombs dropped in Terrace-road, etc., and Leven-avenue. Five civilians killed and eight injured. 372 properties damaged.

No. 24. 16th November, 1940 (03.30 hrs.). Six Parachute Mines dropped in the Alma-road, St. Leonard's-road, Westbourne, Malmesbury Park-road and Turbary Common area. 53 civilians killed and 120 injured (approx). 2,321 properties damaged.. Other bombs in Westbourne area.

No. 25. 19th November, 1940 (20.12 hrs.). Two bombs dropped in Montague and Southern-roads. 17 premises damaged. No casualties.

No. 25a. 21st December, 1940 Bombs dropped in Christchurch area with damage to 21 properties in Bournemouth, viz., Old Bridge-road, Castle-lane.

1941

No. 26. 11th March, 1941 ((22.15 hrs.). Four bombs dropped at Throop-road to Littledown-lane with slight damage. No casualties.

No. 27. 11th March, 1941 (22.15 hrs.). Four bombs dropped from Broadway and Russel Way junction to Mill-road, Yeomans-road and Valley-road, causing slight damage. No casualties

No. 28. 12th March, 1941 (20.45 hrs.). Two bombs dropped in Portland, Murley and Ripon-roads. One woman killed, one man seriously injured, who subsequently died; one woman seriously injured; four men, nine women and two children slightly injured. 723 properties damaged and water-main burst.

No. 29. 14th-15th March, 1941 (23.50 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Hillcrest-road; slight damage to 28 properties. No casualties.

No. 30. 15th March, 1941 (02.05 hrs.). A bomb was dropped affecting Gerald, Grafton and Iddesleigh-roads. One woman was slight-

ly injured, two others treated at a First Aid Post. 19 premises damaged.

No. 31. 15th March, 1941 (02.14 hrs.). A bomb was dropped in Queen's-road damaging 7 premises. No casualties.

No. 32. 15th March, 1941 (20.17 hrs.). Bombs dropped in Surrey-road when three premises were damaged. No casualties.

No. 33. 15th March, 1941 (02.10 hrs.). Two bombs dropped in Wimborne-road area; slight damage to property, one bomb in cemetery damaging headstones, and one between Cemetery and 43 Wimborne-road, causing damage to Warden's Post. No casualties.

No. 34. 15th March, 1941 (02.20 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Leven-avenue, no damage to property. Four bombs dropped on Meyrick Park Golf Links. No casualties.

No. 35. 27th March, 1941 (12.20 hrs.). Three bombs dropped in Lowther-road and Methuen-road. Three persons injured. 101 properties damaged. Water main burst.

No. 36. 27th March, 1941 (12.20 hrs.). Unexploded bombs in Alma-road and the area was evacuated.

No. 37. 10th April, 1941 (22.14 hrs.). One bomb dropped in Westminster-road; no damage to property; damage to telephone wires. No casualties.

No. 38. 10th-11th April, 1941 (23.57 hrs.). Bombs dropped in the Square area; one man and seven women killed, two women severely wounded, 2 men and 1 woman slightly wounded. Properties damaged: Hampshire Court, Woolworths, St. Stephen's-road, Richmond Hill-drive, Rotherfell Court, Bodorgan-road. Two direct hits on Woolworth's store followed by fire which gutted the whole premises. One direct hit on Hampshire Court demolishing 3 flats. One bomb in roadway opposite Hampshire Court smashing two water-mains. One direct hit on Richmond Hill Congregational Church Hall demolishing east wing. One direct hit on Fernbank, St. Stephen's-road, demolishing 4 flats. One bomb in garden of Walton Cottage, Richmond Hill-drive, causing slight damage. Bomb on Rotherfell Court, Bodorgan-road. Direct hit on corner of 20a Richmond Hill-gardens. 2 houses evacuated but repairable. 21 houses slightly damaged. One block of 49 flats slightly damaged. Total of 112 premises damaged.

No. 39. 12th-13th April, 1941 (2230 hrs.). Bombs dropped in Square area and Exeter-road; serious propery damage, one bomb on road in Square, one on bank of Bourne in Lower Gardens, one in gardens near Royal Exeter Hotel, one in garden of Rotherfell Court resulting in complete demolition of building, one in Bodorgan-road, fracturing water-main, one in gardens of 35 Bodorgan-road, partial demolition necessary. 42 properties were damaged. No casualties.

No. 40. 16th April, 1941 (00.35 hrs. Five bombs dropped in Wimborne-road (Kinson area). Roads affected: Millhams-lane, Glendon-avenue, Bramley-road and Weyman's-avenue. No casualties. 83 premises damaged.

No. 41. 9th-10th May, 1941 (00.45-03.35 hrs.). Reports of bombs (parachutes with canisters) were received from R.L. Stevenson-avenue, Fernside-road, The Avenue, Moordown and Strathmore-roads. No damage or casualties.

No. 42. 12th May, 1941 (03.32 hrs.). Bombs dropped in Northbourne-avenue. No casualties., 35 properties damaged.

No. 43. 7th October, 1941 (21.20 hrs.). Two Parachute mines dropped in Pier Approach and East Beach area (one in the sea). 12 people sustained cuts by glass. Extensive damage to windows over fairly large area, including Bath-road, Westover-road, Old Christchurch-road, "Rothesay," Bath-road, East Beach Cafe, Beach Office and huts, Royal Bath Hotel, etc; 934 properties affected.

1942

No. 44. 26th May (0015 hrs). One bomb dropped in Upper Pleasure Gardens; one casualty (Fire Watcher slightly hurt); crater approx. 65ft. x 63ft. x 15ft. deep, smashing 42in. cast-iron sewer. Flying debris damage over large area; surface fracture on Avenue-road; cracks on buildings, damage to Fairlight Glen and Town Hall, shops and flats. 141 properties damaged.

No. 45. 25th May, 1942 (00.10 hrs.). Bombs dropped in Argyll-gardens and West Overcliff-drive; one bomb on tennis court near "Rothwell Dene," Milner-road and Bowling Pavilion, causing slight damage to several properties; crater 35ft. x 15ft. deep. One bomb on Bowling Green near Pavilion and West Overcliff-drive, crater 30ft. x 15ft. deep. One bomb at side of cliff edge adjoining public footpath of West Overcliff-drive, opposite Bowling Pavilion. One bomb on cliff side opposite Pavilion causing slight damage to public shelter. No casualties. Damage to 22 properties.

No. 46. 28th May, 1942 (00.05 hrs.). One delayed action bomb exploded in the Upper Pleasure Gardens near War Memorial. Avenue-road and Bourne-avenue were closed.

No. 47. 6th June, 1942 (17.15 hrs.). Bombs dropped in St. Peter's Church area. Two civilians killed, three civilians seriously injured and six civilians slightly injured. Three bombs dropped, one on Anglo-Swiss Hotel, Gervis-road East, one on Hill House, Parsonage-road, and near Southcote-road. 454 properties damaged.

1943

No. 48. 23rd May, 1943 (13.00 hrs.). Bombs dropped in 10 areas of Bournemouth and estimated that some 25 enemy planes were responsible. Casualties: dead, 77; seriously injured 46; slightly injured, 150; killed when dealing with demolition., 1. Buildings damaged totalled 3,481, of which 22 were totally destroyed and 37 required demolition. There were 10 incident areas, mostly in the centre of the town, and places named as being hit were: Bobbys' Keystone Garage, Exeter-road, Shamrock & Rambler garage, Holdenhurst-road, Metropole and Central Hotels, Wests Cinema and Beales. German plane crashed in Grove-road.

No. 49. 12th August, 1943 (01.10 hrs.). Bombs dropped at junction of Firs Glen and Woods View-roads, Wilton and Gloucester-roads, Boundary and Beswick-roads, Spring-road, Shelbourne - road, Charminster-avenue, Strouden-avenue. Casualties: dead 13; seriously injured, 9; slightly injured, 12. 1,456 buildings damaged of which 15 were destroyed or required demolition.

No. 50. 1st November, 1943 (17.46 hrs.). 23 bombs dropped in following areas: junction of Heron Court and Gerald-roads and cemetery, Ovil-avenue and Howard-road, Queen's Park-avenue, Nos. 135, 85 and 89 and Queen's Park golf links, Campbell-road, Borthwick-road, Avon, Chatsworth, Bennett and Orcheston-road, 59 Shaftesbury-road, 146 Shelbourne-road. Casualties: dead, 1; seriously injured, 10; slightly injured, 17. 1,284 buildings damaged of which 6 required demolition.

There has been one raid since then.

Incident No 51 24th April 1944 0217 hours

Phosphorus and incendiary bombs were dropped in the following areas:—

1. Corner of Stour Road and Avon Road (2 phosphorus bombs)
2. Strouden Road (Incendiary and UXB)
3. Beatty Road and Portland Road (Incendiary and UXB)
4. Gresham Road (Incendiary)
5. Shelbourne and Holdenhurst Roads (UXB)
6. Charminster Avenue at junction of Sutton Road and Malvern Road and West Way (Incendiary and UXB)

Casualties: 2 killed, 5 seriously injured and 2 slightly injured. 156 premises were damaged, all capable of repair, also damage to water main. Roxy Cinema badly damaged by fire.

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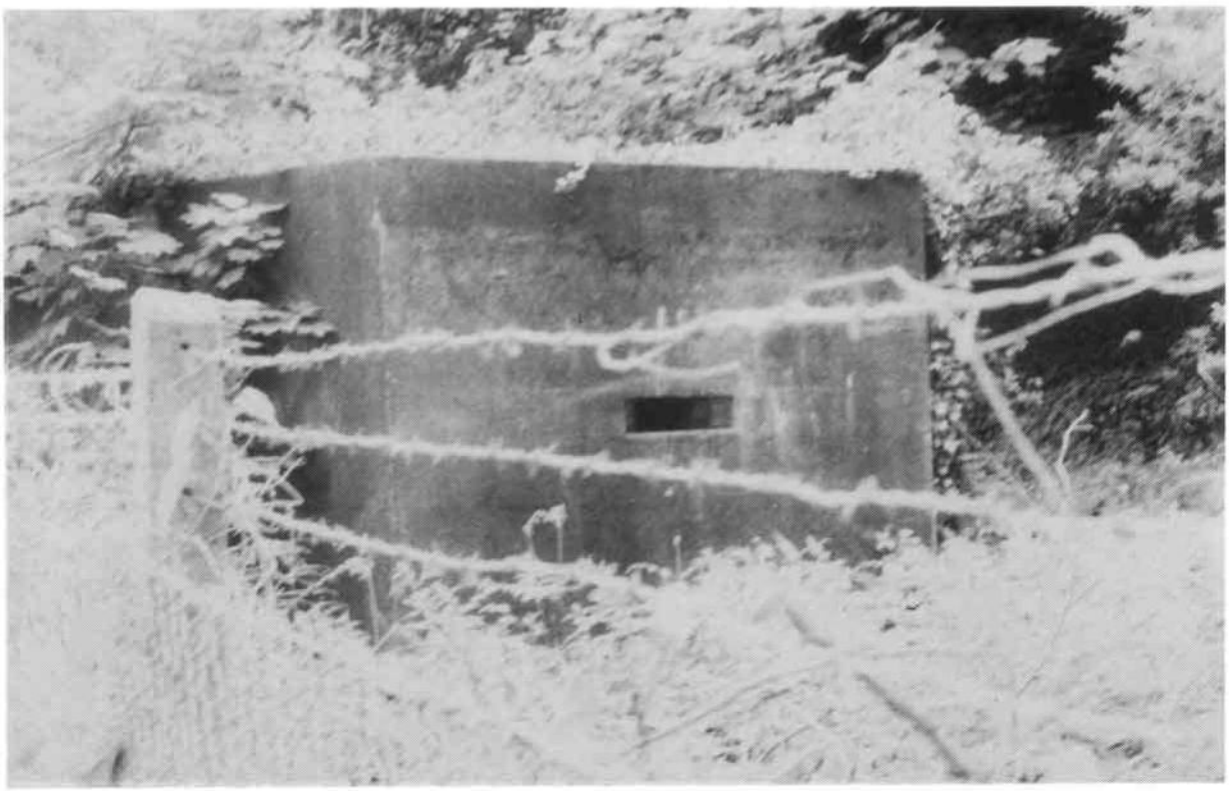
1. Seabourne Road 2nd September 1940.



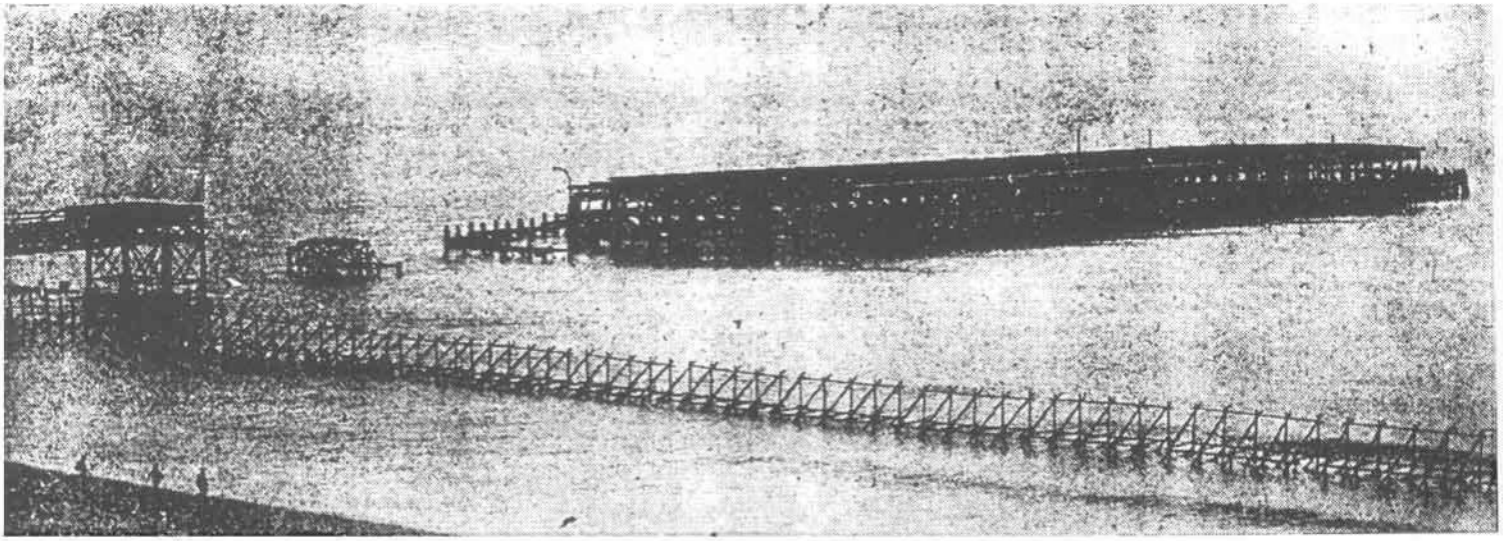
2. Alma Road School after the landmine fell on 16th November 1940.



3. Dragons teeth beneath Branksome viaduct, now demolished.



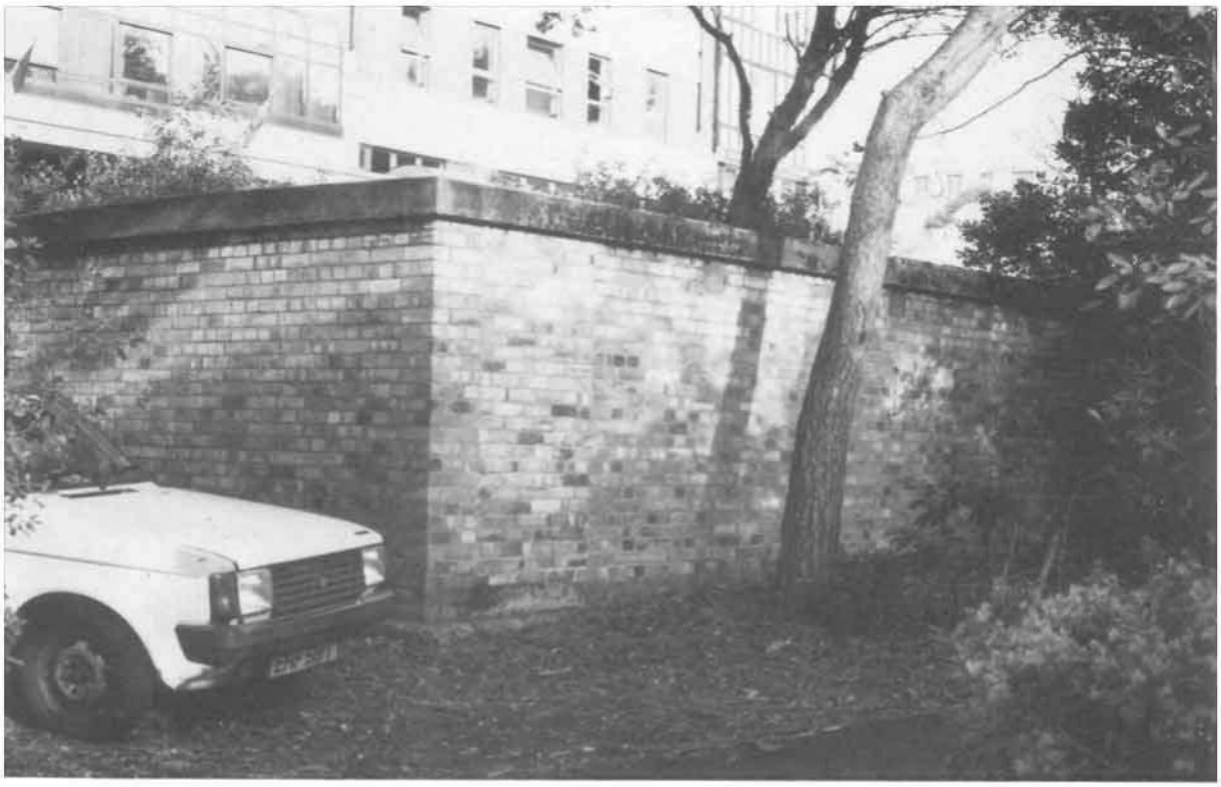
4. Pillbox in Gordon Road, Branksome by the viaduct. Still in existence.



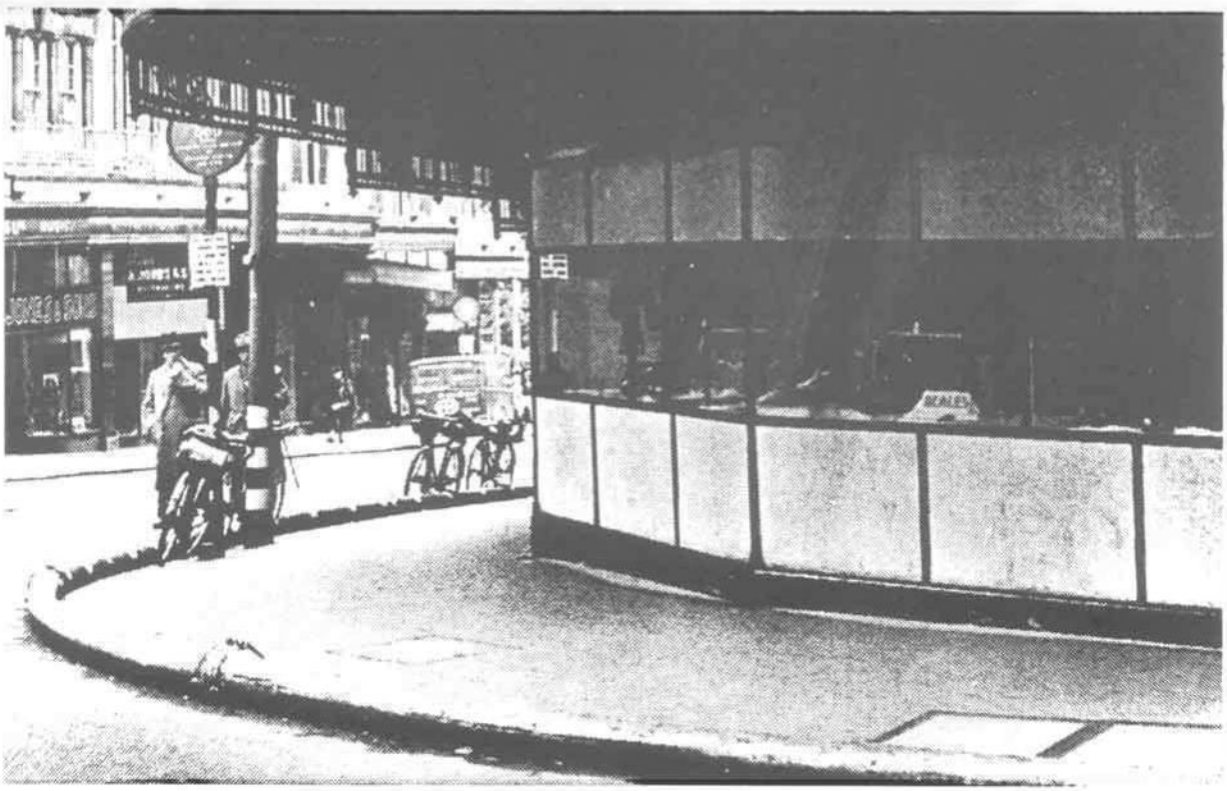
5. Bournemouth Pier showing the gap blown in it and the scaffolding along the beach.



6. The Iford Housing Office, Carlyle Road, which was used as a Wardens Post. The blast wall protecting the entrance still stands.



7. One of the four air raid shelters still standing in Westover Gardens.



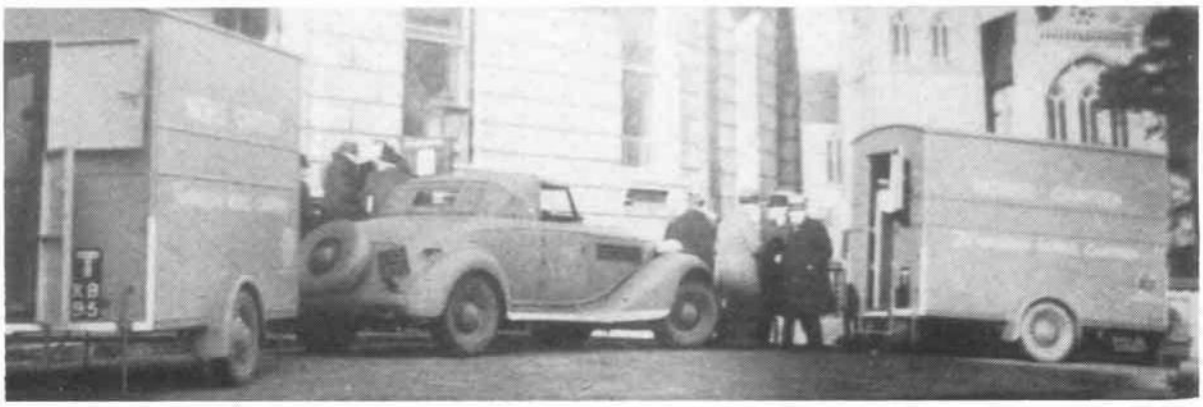
8. Beales corner showing the 6 inch steel piping laid to provide water to fires. Note the white bands to help pedestrians in the blackout.



9. Pilot Officer Cecil Henry Hight who was shot down and killed on 15th August 1940. His plane crashed at the corner of Leven Avenue and Walsford Road.



10. The War Graves headstone of Pilot Officer C. H. Hight in the War Graves plot in the Boscombe Cemetery. The inscription on the bottom obscured by flowers reads "I love them that love me and those that see me early shall find me".



11. The two mobile canteens presented to the Civil Defence Services by Sir Alexander Maclean at the handing over ceremony on 13th March 1941. They bear the inscription "The Maclean Mobile Canteens".



12. Bomb in Central Gardens by the War Memorial. May 24, 1942.



13. Bomb damage in Malmesbury Park Road. The "Brunswick" in the background.



14. No 3 Section No 15 Platoon, "D" Company 6th (Bournemouth) Battalion Hampshire Home Guard 1941 L-R Rear: Cpl Young, Rolfe Treadgold, Jack Beauchamp, Angus Sutherland, - Fisher, - Mules, Cecil Pepin, Harvold Pepin, Cpl Rob Lewis-Manning.
Front: Cpl Jack H C Elliot, Sgt Jim Vigour, Lt K J Fisher, ?, Spencer, Cpl Francis Pepin.



15. Housewives Guild in Grovely Manor (now Shelly Park).



16. Canadian airmen examining German plane shot down during the raid on 23rd May 1943



17. Servicemen and women waiting outside the National Services Club, the Queen Hotel, Lansdowne, now Jacey House.



18. Canadian airmen enjoying a break at the National Services Club.



19. Morning coffee at the Queen.



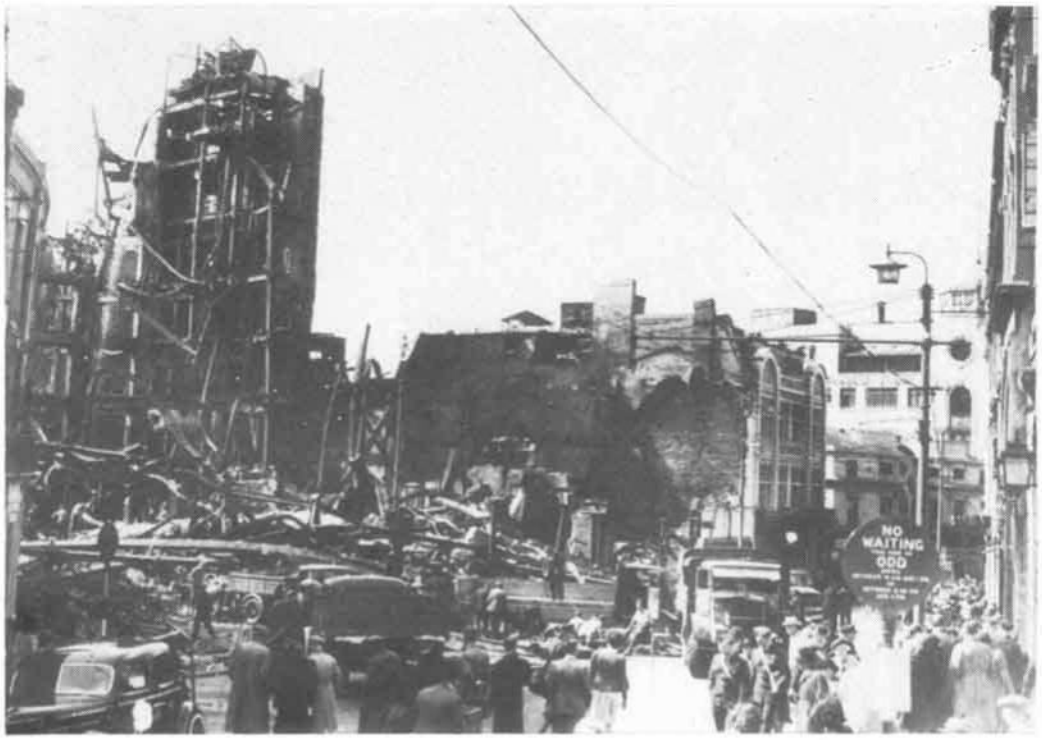
20. 61 year old Mr Harry Powell has been busy cleaning shoes in Bournemouth since he was 13. Now the Americans are here his trade is greatly increased. An American Corporal waits for Mr Powell to finish the shoes of a British Sergeant.



21. G.I. Bandsmen in Bath Road.



22. G.I. Bob DeRoche and Red Cross Hostess Audry Heckford outside the Marsham Court Hotel - an American Red Cross Club.



23. Beales after the raid on 23rd May 1943.



24. The Metropole Hotel after the raid on 23rd May 1943. Note the blotting out of the name of the Hotel by the Censor on the notice on the left of the picture and on the side of the lorry.



25. Fire fighting the blaze at Beales May 23 1943.



26. 246 and 248 Holdenhurst Road after the raid on 23rd May 1943.



27. Shamrock and Rambler Garage between Oxford and Holdenhurst Roads 23rd May 1943.



28. Bobby's Store after the air raid on May 23 1943 (see 20).



29. Sea Cadets parading past the pier September 1943. Vice Admiral L. D. Mackinnon CB CVO taking the salute. The marker is Cadet John Barker.



30. The second national Savings indicator in the Square on the end of the Bus Shelter. The Mayor, Cllr Harry Brown (1944-45), announcing the total saved. Note the American Serviceman in the right foreground.



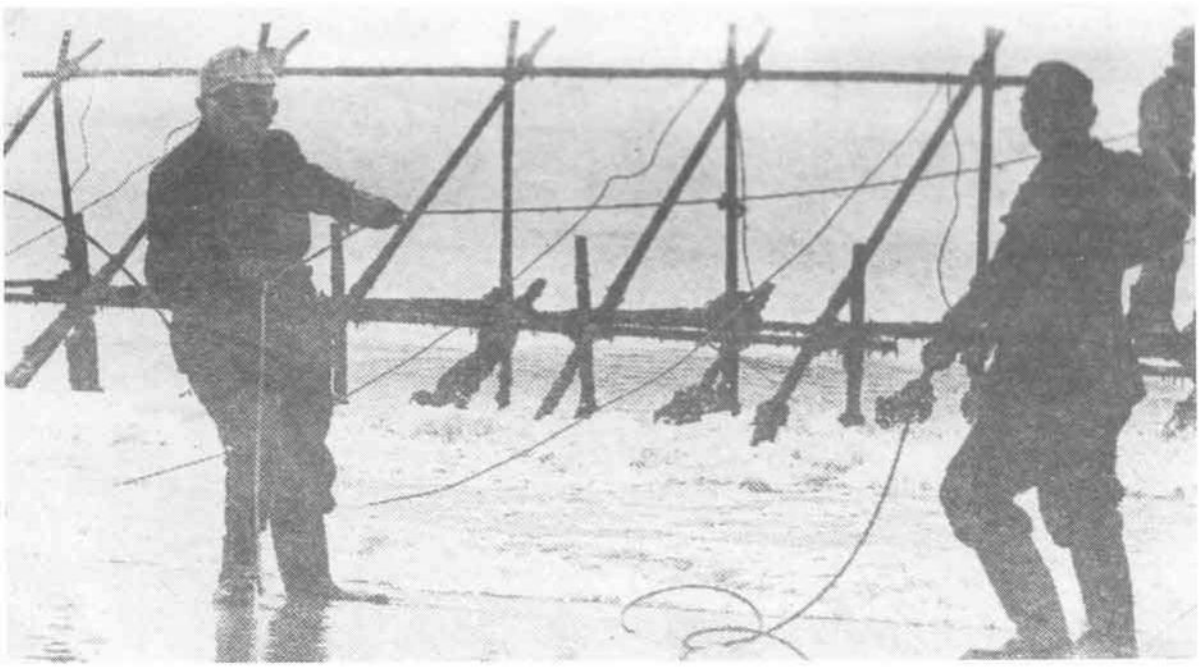
31. The plaque in the wall of Bristol and West House, Post Office Road, commemorating the raid on 23rd May 1943.



32. Victory Parade 1945. Police force passing the Pavilion.



33. The War Graves Plot in Boscombe Cemetery containing the graves of Servicemen of both World Wars. Pilot Officer C.H. Hight is buried here.



34. German Prisoners of War dismantling the scaffolding used as beach defences.